Hegel's Inversion of Philosophy

The Metaphysics of the Made

W. Clark Wolf

HEGEL'S INVERSION OF PHILOSOPHY

Hegel's philosophy is often presented as a reconciliation between thought and the world, and thus logic and metaphysics. But what is the basis of this reconciliation? In this book, W. Clark Wolf argues that the key to Hegel's transformation of philosophy lies in his recognition of the special logical basis of the humanly made world. Human artifacts and institutions are not merely represented by concepts; concepts are necessary for their very existence. For this reason, Hegel sees the human world, the world of spirit or *Geist*, as more central in philosophy than the mind-independent world of nature. Hegel's philosophy is thus a humanism. Wolf argues that this humanistic conception of philosophy is justified in Hegel's *Science of Logic*, since its logical basis is his theory of concepts. Through a detailed interpretation of *The Doctrine of the Concept*, this book sheds new light on Hegelian idealism.

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W. CLARK WOLF

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CAMBRIDGE
UNIVERSITY PRESS

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Shaftesbury Road, Cambridge CB2 8EA, United Kingdom

One Liberty Plaza, 20th Floor, New York, NY 10006, USA

477 Williamstown Road, Port Melbourne, VIC 3207, Australia

314–321, 3rd Floor, Plot 3, Splendor Forum, Jasola District Centre, New Delhi – 110025, India

103 Penang Road, #05–06/07, Visioncrest Commercial, Singapore 238467

Cambridge University Press is part of Cambridge University Press & Assessment,
a department of the University of Cambridge.

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education, learning and research at the highest international levels of excellence.

www.cambridge.org
Information on this title: www.cambridge.org/9781009621458

DOI: 10.1017/9781009621427

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When citing this work, please include a reference to the DOI 10.1017/9781009621427

First published 2026

Cover image: Deconstructed Sphere, 2005 (acrylic) © Lincoln Seligman. All Rights Reserved
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A catalogue record for this publication is available from the British Library

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data
NAMES: Wolf, W. Clark author
TITLE: Hegel's inversion of philosophy : the metaphysics of the made / W. Clark Wolf, St. John's
College, Annapolis.
DESCRIPTION: Cambridge, United Kingdom ; New York, NY, USA : Cambridge University
Press, 2026. | Includes bibliographical references and index.
IDENTIFIERS: LCCN 2025032340 (print) | LCCN 2025032341 (ebook) | ISBN 9781009621458
hardback | ISBN 9781009621465 paperback | ISBN 9781009621427 ebook
SUBJECTS: LCSH: Hegel, Georg Wilhelm Friedrich, 1770–1831. Wissenschaft der Logik.
CLASSIFICATION: LCC B2942.Z7 W65 2026 (print) | LCC B2942.Z7 (ebook)
LC record available at https://lccn.loc.gov/2025032340
LC ebook record available at https://lccn.loc.gov/2025032341

ISBN 978-1-009-62145-8 Hardback

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or email eugpsr@cambridge.org

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Acknowledgments

This book is a substantial development and rewriting of my 2019 dissertation, "The Province of Conceptual Reason: Hegel's Post-Kantian Rationalism," submitted to Marquette University. In that work, I focused on Hegel's theory of conceptual content, gaining an appreciation for the importance of artifacts and social ontology in Hegel's system along the way. Here, I remain interested in Hegel's theory of concepts but I make the significance of artifacts central from the beginning. In the original work, I hoped to show that the German rationalist way of thinking about concepts was alive in Hegel, albeit in a restricted domain. Though I remain interested in the German scholastic tradition, I have not attempted to show its significance for my thesis here.

I am still very indebted to my dissertation committee for their contribution to that earlier work. My advisor, Sebastian Luft, was and remains an invaluable mentor. His interest in the philosophy of culture sparked my exploration of "Vichian" themes and has no doubt left a significant mark on this book as well. Mike Monahan was also a member of my committee and his courses on Hegel at Marquette were very formative; they became an important testing ground for many of the ideas that have remained with me over the years. Yoon Choi was often a valuable conversation partner who has always helped me to sharpen my views. Finally, I was honored also to have Karin de Boer serve on my committee; her work on Kant, Hegel, and Wolff continues to be an important inspiration.

The book builds on other previously published work. Thanks to the publishers for permission to reuse material (with alterations) in Chapter 4 from the following articles: "Metaphysics Supervenes on Logic: The Role of the Logical Forms in Hegel's 'Replacement' of Metaphysics," *Journal of the History of Philosophy* 59:2 (April 2021): 271–98 and "Hegel's Metametaphysical Antirealism," *International Journal of Philosophical Studies* 32:5 (2024): 678–99.

I am very grateful to the three anonymous reviewers for Cambridge University Press who offered invaluable feedback that led to many changes in the manuscript. I would also like to thank Hilary Gaskin at Cambridge University Press for her interest in the project and kind support throughout.

I am indebted to Birgit Sandkaulen for inviting me for a short-term stay at the Hegel-Archiv in Bochum in the summer of 2023, which was a supportive research environment and enabled me to participate in her excellent seminar on Hegel and Jacobi. This was a productive time. While there, I was especially grateful for conversations with Markus Gante, Johannes Schültheis, and Chris Meyers.

I would like to thank especially Mark Alznauer, Bill Bristow, Robb Dunphy, Markus Gante, Florian Ganzinger, Edgar Maraguat, and Jake McNulty for conversation and feedback on specific chapters of this book. Thanks also to Jim Kreines for organizing and participation in a helpful discussion of an earlier version of Chapter 4 in particular. Thanks to Kevin Harrelson, Alex Host, Karen Koch, Daniel LeBlanc, Clinton Tolley, and Andy Werner for their participation in that discussion.

Andy Werner also read the entire manuscript and provided invaluable feedback and many corrections on the whole text. The errors that remain are my own, but I am most grateful.

For conversations on issues related to this book (in addition to those already mentioned), I also thank Brady Bowman, Ardis Collins, Matthew Delhey, Elena Ficara, Luigi Filieri, Giuliano Infantino, Daniel Lindquist, Eliza Starbuck Little, Phil Mack, Tereza Matějčková, Gustav Melichar, Greg Moss, Michael Olson, Yady Oren, Caleb Reidy, Jacob Singer, Pirmin Stekeler-Weithofer, Kevin Thompson, Leonard Weiss, Michael Wolff, Chris Yeomans, and Linhao Zheng.

Some of this work has been presented at Ryerson University, Lehigh University, The Chicago Area Consortium in German Philosophy (DePaul), the Chicago Center for German Philosophy, Paderborn University, the University of Warwick, Ruhr-Universität Bochum, the University of Valencia, Charles University Prague, the Arendt Circle, the Australian Hegel Society, and Marquette University. I thank the audiences at all these events for feedback and discussion.

Last of all, I am grateful for the support of my family: Bill, Jayne, and Angela Wolf, as well as Anatoly Dmitriev and Irina Dmitrieva. The book is dedicated to my wife, Inna Dmitrieva. She read the whole manuscript, providing many helpful suggestions. More importantly, she provided the constant encouragement (and the occasional incredulous stare) that was necessary for me to complete the project.

Abbreviations

Works by Hegel

Hegel's works are cited both in their original German and in available English translations. The German version is cited first, from the readily available Suhrkamp edition (1970), followed by the page number of the translation, which is frequently modified.

Hegel's *Encyclopedia* (as well as the *Philosophy of Right*) is first cited by paragraph number (§), followed by an "R" (for remark, *Anmerkung*) or "Z" (for a "*Zusatz*," an addition from student lectures).

The abbreviations used to refer to Hegel's works are as follows:

W + vol.	*Werke in zwanzig Bänden*. Edited by Eva Moldenhauer and Karl Markus Michel. Frankfurt: Suhrkamp, 1970.
GW + vol.	*Gesammelte Werke*. Edited by the Academy of Sciences of Nordrhein-Westfalia with the cooperation of Deutsche Forschungsgemeinschaft. Hamburg: Meiner, 1968ff.
EL	*Enzyklopädie der philosophischen Wissenschaften I.* W 8. Translation: *The Encyclopaedia Logic: Part I of the* Encyclopaedia of the Philosophical Sciences *with the Zustätze*. Translated by T. F. Geraets, W. A. Suchting, and H. S. Harris. Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing, 1991.
EPG	*Enzyklopädie der philosophischen Wissenschaften III.* W 10. Translation: *Philosophy of Mind*. Translated by W. Wallace and A. V. Miller, revised by Michael Inwood. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007.
EPN	*Enzyklopädie der philosophischen Wissenschaften II.* W 9. Translation: *Philosophy of Nature*. Translated by A. V. Miller. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1970.
GPR	*Grundlinien der Philosophie des Rechts.* W 7. Translation: *Outlines of the Philosophy of Right*. Translated by

T. M. Knox, revised by Stephen Houlgate. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008.

JS I — *Jenaer Systementwürfe I. Das System der speculativen Philosophie*. Edited by Klaus Düsing and Heinz Kimmerle. Hamburg: Felix Meiner, 1986.

JS III — *Jenaer Systementwürfe III. Naturphilosophie und Philosophie des Geistes*. Edited by Rolf-Peter Horstmann. Hamburg: Felix Meiner, 1987.

PhG — *Phänomenologie des Geistes.* W 3. Translation: *The Phenomenology of Spirit*. Translated by Michael Inwood. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018.

VÄ I–III — *Vorlesungen über die Ästhetik I–III.* W 13–15. Translation: *Hegel's Aesthetics: Lectures on Fine Art: Volumes 1 and 2*. Translated by T. M. Knox. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1975.

VGP — *Vorlesungen über die Geschichte der Philosophie I–III*. W 18–20.

VPG — *Vorlesungen über die Philosophie der Geschichte*. W 12. Translation: *Lectures on the Philosophy of World History: Introduction*. Translated by H. B. Nisbet. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1975.

WL I–II — *Wissenschaft der Logik I–II*. W 5–6. Translation: *The Science of Logic*. Translated by George di Giovanni. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010.

Works by Kant

Kant's German is cited from the Akademie Ausgabe. The English follows the *Cambridge Edition of the Works of Immanuel Kant*, which contains cross-references to the Akademie edition. I cite the *Critique of Pure Reason* by standard reference to the A and B editions of that work. The abbreviations used are as follows:

Ak. + vol. — *Kants gesammelte Schriften*. Edited by the Königlich preussischen Akademie der Wissenschaften. Berlin: Reimer, 1900ff.

A/B — *Critique of Pure Reason*. Translated by Paul Guyer and Allen Wood. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998.

CHAPTER 1

Introduction

1.1 The Artifactual Paradigm

For many philosophers, the touchstone of objective reality is *mind-independence*. For something to be real is for it to exist without the contribution of any human mind, and for something to be objectively known, it must be known as it is apart from such a contribution. The initial appeal of such a conception comes perhaps from certain clear cases where mind-*dependence* seems to involve a lack of reality in some relevant sense. One thinks of a hallucination as unreal because dependent on the mind in a special way; fictional characters are thought to be unreal because merely imaginary; colors, tastes, and other "secondary qualities" might be demoted in their reality as well, if they depend for their existence on a relation to the mind. But this initial pairing of the real with the mind-independent and the unreal with the mind-dependent is, perhaps notoriously, hard to maintain with complete generality.[1] If we look around us, almost anywhere we may be, we see a world that is, apart from any sophisticated philosophical thesis, dependent to a great extent on the past and present workings of human minds. The computer in front of me now, the streets outside my window, and the faint music playing from passing cars: these items would not exist apart from the activity of human minds. Nor would the language I am writing in, the legal rights I acknowledge and respect, and the cultural practices I partake in. They would not exist, at least not in their present form, without the contribution of human thought.

While these claims would be, I expect, widely accepted, their overall significance for the shape of philosophical inquiry is, by and large, treated as marginal. One feels perhaps that thought touches reality only on its

[1] For a good contemporary exploration of the general problem, see Khalidi 2013.

surface and in spots; that what really matters for philosophy, and especially metaphysics, is wholly unlike and alien to thought, or at least to ours.[2] The humanly thought and made occupies only a cul-de-sac on the metaphysical landscape. What really is, and so what must be (if it can be) objectively known, is *nature* and the natural. Implicit in the notion of reality as mind-independent, and objective knowledge as knowledge of what is mind-independent, is the metaphysical priority of nature and the natural.

An illuminating way of viewing Hegel's philosophical work, I believe, is as a sustained attempt to challenge this philosophical priority of nature and the natural over the realm of the humanly made and mind-dependent. One of Hegel's most famous contributions to philosophy is of course to introduce *Geist* ("spirit" or "mind") as a central theme. Whatever Hegel means by this term, the result of its high position in his system is that topics like law, art, religion, and history find a nearly unprecedented prominence in Hegelian philosophy compared with the tradition that preceded him. This new prominence to the humanly made is the result of what I call Hegel's *inversion of philosophy*: a transition from a conception of philosophy in which nature sets the standard for truth and knowledge to a conception in which the paradigm case of knowledge is thought's own knowledge of thought's own products. In contrast to nature, in the domain of spirit – the subject matter of what, not coincidentally, would be called the *Geisteswissenschaften*[3] in Hegel's century – the human mind contemplates itself, not, of course, projected on the screen of an inner theater but as expressed in an outer world. Although the products and processes of *Geist*, which make up this outer world, are dependent on nature for their existence, they are no longer simply nature. In their relation to conceptuality, they are sui generis. They thus offer a different kind of object for philosophical knowledge.

That Hegel carries out something like this inversion is evident in a number of places. His concern with revaluing the domain of the "ethical" (which involves spirit in the objective domain) vis-à-vis the natural is especially clear in his *Philosophy of Right*. He writes there,

> As far as nature is concerned, people grant that philosophy must come to know it *as it is*, that the philosopher's stone lies concealed *somewhere*, somewhere *within nature itself*, that nature is inherently rational, and that

[2] For a striking statement of this attitude, see Van Inwagen 1990: 127: "In the last analysis, the labors of Michelangelo and the most skillful watchmaker are . . . devoid of true metaphysical issue . . . All these people are simply shoving the stuff of the world about."

[3] Cf. Stekeler-Weithofer 2018: 806.

> what knowledge has to investigate and grasp in concepts is this actual reason present in it . . . The *ethical world*, on the other hand, the state (i.e., reason as it actualizes itself in the element of self-consciousness), is not allowed to enjoy the good fortune which springs from the fact that reason has come to be a force and power within that element and maintains itself and has its home there. (*GPR* 15/6)

While Hegel does not here deny that nature *is* rational, and that philosophy can grasp its rationality, he also alludes to the fact that the rationality of nature is typically understood as something hidden or opaque. The rationality of the state, however, and the humanly made in general is – or can be – out in the open. It is even a "force and power." This comes out clearly in student notes that were attached to this paragraph of the preface.[4] Hegel is reported to have said:

> Laws are of two kinds – laws of nature and laws of right. The laws of nature simply are what they are and are valid as they are; they are not liable to wither away, though they can be infringed in individual cases. To know the law of nature, we must learn to know nature itself, since its laws are correct and it is only our ideas about them that can be false. The measure [*Maßstab*] of those laws is outside us; knowing them adds nothing to them and does not assist in their operation; our knowledge of them can expand, that is all. Knowledge of right is in one way similar, but in another way not. . . . The laws of right are something *posited*, something *originated* by human beings. Between what is so originated and the voice within us there may of necessity be a clash or agreement. The human being does not stop short at the existent, but claims to have in himself the measure [*Maßstab*] of what is right. (*GPR* 15–16/6–7)

Hegel here is describing the difference in our attitude to the laws of nature and laws of our societies. Even though both laws are in some way *given* (at some moment in time), so that we can have factual knowledge of both kinds of laws, Hegel claims that when we look at what is given in nature, we assume that the standard for its laws lies within nature itself, while the standard for the correctness of human laws lies within *reason* itself, and therefore within us. It is for this reason that Hegel, in the notes that follow, repudiates the idea that there should be a "theory" of the laws of the state, which would suggest that the laws are something "set over against" the thing they are a theory of. Instead, he writes, we must grasp the very "thought" of right itself, which is "not an opinion about the thing but the *concept of the thing itself*" (16/7). This means that Hegel rejects what he calls

[4] The editors of Hegel's works have identified this passage as Eduard Gans's notes from lectures on *Naturrecht und Staatswissenschaft* from the winter semester of 1822–3.

a "half-philosophy that locates knowledge in an *approximation* to truth" (27/16). Apparently, this is because we do not need merely to approximate the truth of something of which we are the measure. We need rather to realize that this measure is somehow already effective. Thus: "It is a warmer peace with the world which knowledge supplies" (27/16).

That Hegel accepts an inversion of the priority of spirit to nature is also one of the most distinctive claims of his *Aesthetics*. Hegel famously claims there that the beauty of nature is inferior to the beauty of art, so much so that the beauty of art (as a product of *Geist*) sets the standard for the beauty of nature. He writes: "On the contrary, spirit [or mind] is alone the *true* comprehending of everything in itself, so that everything beautiful is truly beautiful only as sharing in this higher sphere and generated by it. In this sense the beauty of nature appears only as a reflection of the beauty that belongs to spirit" (VÄ I 15/2). As in the case of the state, Hegel explains the existence of art in terms of its *conceptual* origin:

> In the products of art, the spirit has to do solely with its own. And even if works of art are not thought or the concept, but a development of the concept out of itself, a shift of the concept from its own ground to that of sense, still the power of the thinking spirit lies in being able not only to grasp itself in its proper form as thinking, but to know itself again just as much when it has surrendered its proper form to feeling and sense, to comprehend itself in its opposite, because it changes into thoughts what has been estranged and so reverts to itself. . . . Thus the work of art too, in which thought expresses itself, belongs to the sphere of conceptual thinking. (27–8/12–13)

Evidently, Hegel does not think that the mind-dependence of art makes it any less worthy of philosophical consideration than natural beauty. Quite to the contrary, for Hegel, this mind-dependence (specifically its "spirit"- and "concept"-dependence) makes art eminently worthy of philosophical reflection.

The contrast between Hegel's view on this point and the mainstream philosophical attitude today, which gravitates toward naturalisms of various stripes, is a striking one. Many contemporary philosophical naturalists quite clearly endorse the view that philosophy should produce *theories* about its objects, which do not differ essentially from scientific theories in their attitude of *deference* to objects of study (this motivates a secondary deference to the authoritative research of empirical scientists). That is, a philosophical naturalist takes the mind-independent object of philosophical study to set the standard for the philosophical account. In so doing, let us say that the philosophical naturalist accepts a *natural paradigm* for

philosophical knowledge.[5] To accept such a paradigm is not to reject the possibility of nonnatural or humanistic knowledge, but it is to see this as derivative and thus non-exemplary. For example, knowledge in the practical domain will either need to pose as a kind of theory about entities (i.e., "moral realism") or admit defeat (i.e., a form of noncognitivism). Philosophical thinking will, in any case, have to *answer* to its relation to scientific, theoretical knowledge about the mind-independent and natural. By contrast, I will argue that Hegel endorses an *artifactual paradigm* of philosophical knowledge.[6] An artifactual paradigm implies that the best case of objective philosophical knowledge is closer to the knowledge we have of a mind-dependent artifact than to the knowledge we have of a mind-independent thing of nature. An artifactual paradigm thus allows philosophical knowledge to be unlike a "theory" in which we grasp an object that is independent from our participation in its existence. Consider, for example, the cases of *the state* or *works of art*. What states or works of art *are* is not a mind-independent matter, even if it is independent of any particular mind. To treat *these* kinds of objects as paradigmatic is clearly not to endorse a generally constructivist or fictionalist view of the world – especially not the natural world. On the contrary, to accept the artifactual paradigm is to freely concede an important *independence* of nature from thought and the products of thought, for a paradigm sets a standard but does not define every case. Nor does this inversion *exclude* a mind-independent nature as an instance of philosophical knowledge. But it suggests that we see our knowledge of nature as a deviation from an ideal that is fully instantiated in other cases.

I think of Hegel's commitment to an artifactual paradigm in philosophy as a form of philosophical humanism, for *we* are the relevant artificers. An artifactual paradigm is also present in theologically influenced authors, where creation is the production of God's artifact.[7] Precisely for this

[5] I emphasize that I am using "paradigm" in its original sense (found in Plato) as a kind of *standard-setting instance* or *exemplar*. See, e.g., Patterson 1985: 15. This is also how Thomas Kuhn used the term, I believe, but it seems that in the popular reception of his notion of a "paradigm shift," a "paradigm" has been taken to mean something like a theoretical framework or even a kind of intellectual epoch. I do not intend the term "paradigm" in any such sense.

[6] In this work, I use "artifact" in the broad sense that is now current in contemporary philosophy (Preston 2020: section 1). An artifact is something that is the product of human making, in which the intention is typically thought to be essential in some way to what it is.

[7] See Thomas Aquinas: "*I answer that*, The knowledge of God is the cause of things. For the knowledge of God is to all creatures what the knowledge of the artificer is to things made by his art. Now the knowledge of the artificer is the cause of the things made by his art from the fact that the artificer works by his intellect. Hence the form of the intellect must be the principle of action; as heat is the principle of heating. . . . Now it is manifest that God causes things by His intellect, since His being is

reason, the theological use of an artifactual paradigm does not end up grounding any privilege to the humanly made. In that case, the objects of human craft are not themselves paradigmatic for knowledge; they only offer an appropriate class of examples or analogies. Perhaps the clearest precedent for a humanistic use of the artifactual paradigm in the history of philosophy is Giambattista Vico. It is Vico who most famously attempts to leverage the notion of "maker's knowledge" to alter the focus of science.[8] In short, if the maker's knowledge of his own artifact is the exemplary case of knowledge, then human knowledge of the humanly made should better exemplify knowledge than our knowledge of the unmade. Hence, Vico's "new science" is no longer the new science of seventeenth-century mechanism; he invites us instead to think of human culture and history as artifacts on a grand scale, and thus as more suitable objects of science than the natural world, which is only God's craftwork. Vico famously announces that "the criterion of the true should be to have made the thing itself" (Vico 1988: ch. 1, iv). This is his so-called verum-factum principle.[9] Vico accepts that the principle does apply abstractly to nature, since nature is God's "factum." But his use of the principle is primarily in service of the human sciences: the knowledge of the civil, cultural, and historical world. For Vico, we have the criterion for truth in these sciences as fellow makers of this world. This idea persuades Vico to make a number of bold, speculative historical claims about the origin, elements, and basic principles of past and present civilizations. He justifies this ambition in his *New Science* by appealing to an apparent variant of his verum-factum principle:

> It is a truth which cannot be doubted: *The civil world is certainly the creation of humankind*, And consequently, the principles of the civil world can and must be discovered *within the modifications of the human mind*. If we reflect on this, we can only wonder why all the philosophers have so earnestly pursued a knowledge of the world of nature, which only God can know as its creator, while they neglected the study of the world of nations, or the civil world, which people can in fact know because they created it. . . . Because it is buried deep within the body, the human mind tends to notice what is

His act of understanding; and hence His knowledge must be the cause of things, in so far as His will is joined to it" (*ST* I, q. 14, a. 8, reply).

[8] See Hintikka 1974, who is often credited with popularizing the term. As Hintikka already points out, the theme bears a close relation to what Anscombe 1963 calls (following Aquinas) "practical knowledge." See Chapter 2 for the difference. In the literature on Hegel, I have only been able to locate the use of "maker's knowledge" in Knowles 2003 and Yeomans 2012. For a critical account of Vico's concept of maker's knowledge, see Gaukroger 1986.

[9] This principle was influential among neo-Kantians, Ernst Cassirer (e.g., 2000: 9–10) in particular. For an account of the role of Vico in the Marburg neo-Kantian school, see Luft 2015.

> corporeal, and must make a great and laborious effort to understand itself, just as the eye sees all external objects, but needs a mirror to see itself. (Vico 1999: 119–20)[10]

Vico used the verum-factum principle to challenge the *paradigmatic* status of knowledge about nature, and instead to crown the cultural world, and our knowledge of it, as the standard against which knowledge is to be measured, as its best instance.[11] Vico gives us a clear example of adopting an artifactual paradigm for philosophical knowledge and thus a humanistic metaphysics.

Vico's precedent is especially important because it shows how the maker's knowledge principle might be taken not in a 'constructivist' kind of idealism, according to which the world as we represent it is a construction of our own minds (an interpretation to which Kant and the German Idealists have often been subjected, however unfortunately),[12] but in a quite realistic and almost literal sense. In Vico's view, the human world is constructed (perhaps not completely, and certainly unevenly) according to the concepts and designs of human minds, and so is in principle intelligible to us, especially as compared to nature. This 'construction' of the human world is not a merely cognitive one but a practical and historical achievement, which then has cognitive consequences. Nothing in this position need involve idealism in any subjectivistic sense, or in the sense of a speculative metaphysical theory.[13] If this is an idealism, it is close to an idealism of reflective common sense.[14]

1.2 The "Logical" Basis of Humanistic Metaphysics

Prime facie, it seems clear that Hegel is a humanist in some sense. Though his affinity with Vico has not received a great deal of

[10] Underlining throughout this book is my emphasis (in cases where it is necessary to differentiate my emphasis from italics in a quoted passage).

[11] On this point, see Hösle 2016: 46ff.

[12] See Rockmore 2016. Contrary to this whole tendency, see Beiser 2002.

[13] The specific case of Vico is somewhat controversial. Against a tradition of reading Vico in merely anthropological terms, it has been claimed by Hösle (2016: 50) that Vico's *New Science* "is ultimately grounded in the metaphysical world of the Spirit – to be reconstructed a priori – which exists in God, with whose image human spirit is stamped." While I cannot weigh in on this issue in Vico, my point is only that idealism about the human world is apparently intelligible without this metaphysical or theological foundation.

[14] Interestingly, in some contemporary discussions of artifacts, we find references to idealism in a local or partial sense similar to this suggestion. See Thompson (2008: 80) on "partial idealism" in the case of artifacts (following Anscombe [1981: 118]) and Evnine (2016: 21 n. 45), who writes, "My point is that the world of artifacts produces a kind of localized idealism regardless of one's more general philosophical views."

attention,[15] it is hard to deny. Moreover, it is simply a datum that Hegel gives a more prominent place to *Geist* than nature in his philosophy, and this position could be supported in a direct way by considering numerous remarks to this effect. My aim in this book is not to show *that* Hegel is a humanist in this way but to *explain* this humanism on its more general and substantial basis. However, while Vico's version of humanism arguably concerns the priority first-order historical knowledge about the civil world, Hegel's concerns the priority of humanistic *philosophical* knowledge. Here I aim to demonstrate the "logical" or metaphysical basis of Hegel's humanistic inversion of philosophy. Hegel's mature masterpiece, *The Science of Logic* (*WL*),[16] contains, in its third book, *The Doctrine of the Concept*, an account of concepts that, I believe, amounts to a criticism of the natural paradigm in philosophy. It aims to demonstrate the possibility of a special domain of knowledge and truth to which our conceptuality has special access, since our conceptuality is its source. In short, Hegel justifies the philosophical priority of *Geist* to nature on the basis of his account of concepts.

Before considering how Hegel's account of concepts could have this implication, I should outline the understanding of *The Science of Logic* that will guide this work. Hegel famously says of his *Logic* that it is a "replacement" of metaphysics (see Section 4.1). In my view, Hegel would not need to say that his *Logic* was a *replacement* of metaphysics if it simply offered a new metaphysical theory. It must be doing something else. This does not mean that Hegel's *Logic* bears no relation to metaphysics. Indeed, the Objective Logic, in particular, comprising the *Doctrine of Being* and the *Doctrine of Essence*, begins with a consideration of the concept of mere <being> and develops a series of concepts central to traditional ontology: <quality>, <quantity>, <essence>, <cause>, and so on.[17] There is clearly an overlap in topic between Hegel's *Logic* and texts such as Spinoza's *Ethics*, Leibniz's *Principles of Philosophy*, and Wolff's *Ontologia*. However, the resemblance is in some way superficial. Texts

[15] There are certainly notable exceptions. In addition to Cassirer and Hösle, see Flay 1985: 324 n. 21; Pompa 1990; Otto 2007; and Verene 2007, 2011. The connection was also explored by the Italian Hegelian Benedetto Croce; see especially Croce 2008 (1964).

[16] In this work, I will use "*Logic*" to refer indifferently to the relevant books, the *WL* and *EL*. I will occasionally use "Logic" to refer to the project carried out in that work: whatever it is that Hegel thinks replaces metaphysics. The various books (or *Doctrines*) of the *Logic* will sometimes be called *Being Logic*, etc. In addition, "Objective Logic" is a collective term for the *Being* and *Essence Logics*, while "Subjective Logic" is an alternate designation for the *Concept Logic*.

[17] I use angled brackets ('<. . .>') to refer to concepts, so that (e.g.) "<being>" could typically be read as "the concept of being."

like those just mentioned assert claims and defend principles about their subject matter, whether that has been picked out as *substance* or *beings in general*. These claims and principles (and the arguments for them) are what is of central interest. But it is a curious feature of Hegel's *Logic* that it is not at all straightforward to see when or even *if* he is making any claims in the main body of the text. This is not simply because Hegel is an unclear writer (though he often is). The feature of Hegel's *Logic* I am pointing to is, I think, intentional on his part and suggests a deeper separation between his approach and that of other authors of the metaphysical tradition. Hegel is approaching questions of metaphysics *not* by examining claims and making assertions of his own but simply by an immanent investigation ("dialectic") of the concepts necessary to make any such claims in the first place.[18] Hegel's *Logic* is thus in some way, like Kant's *Critique of Pure Reason*, an attempt to examine the possibility of metaphysics. However, unlike Kant, who thought that the critical project should be pursued by first investigating the cognitive capacities of the knowing subject, Hegel pursues this question in perhaps a still more radical way: by focusing on the very meaning of the concepts that are used to make metaphysical claims. From the beginning, Hegel shows that concepts that are the basis of some metaphysical theory or other, starting with <being>, in fact cannot play the central role they are assigned. They prove to be "untrue" on their own and so "pass over" into other concepts. In general, Hegel is "criticizing" concepts – though this means not rejecting these concepts altogether or putting them out of use but showing the *internal* boundaries and limits of each ontological concept.[19] In my view, the Objective Logic overlaps topically with ontology but is no ontology: for each concept that could form the basis of an ontological system proves unable to do so. To achieve this project, Hegel does not need to make positive claims about the world but only develop and investigate the concepts of any *would-be* ontology.

In my view, the primarily critical goal of the Objective Logic turns to a constructive task in the Subjective Logic, or the *Doctrine of the Concept*. As I will argue in Chapter 3, what Hegel calls "the Concept" (*der Begriff*) is something like the power of conceptuality in general. In particular, it is his thematization not of the kind of thought that characterizes empirical categorization and judgment but precisely the thinking involved in the development of philosophical concepts themselves. What Hegel calls the

[18] See Section 4.2 for a more detailed account of the claims in this paragraph.

[19] For a recent account of this dimension, see Alznauer 2023. My emphasis on the critical dimension of the Objective Logic also bears strong affinities to Theunissen's (1980) classic work.

Concept is thus the form of philosophical thinking in general.[20] As he writes in the *Encyclopedia*: "Philosophical thinking has its own *peculiar forms,* apart from the forms that they [sc. philosophy and the empirical sciences] have in common. The universal form of it is the *concept*" (*EL* § 9, 52/33). After showing that the ontological concepts of the Objective Logic are "untrue," Hegel sets himself the task in the *Concept Logic* of showing how the Concept – philosophical conceptuality – is "true." As he explains it, he aims to show what it means for Concept and object to agree; such agreement (which is for Hegel a matter of degree) he calls "the Idea." It is sometimes thought that Hegel's concept of the Concept signals the moment in the *Logic* where it becomes self-reflective about its own activity.[21] This would make the topic of the *Concept Logic* primarily retrospective in the context of the whole work. I will try to show that the goal is rather *prospective*: the account of the Concept is not primarily an explanation for the thinking within the *Logic* but a grounding of Hegel's "*Realphilosophie*" – his concrete accounts of the philosophical topics of nature and spirit. That is, Hegel is interested in a kind of conceptual truth, but not the conceptual truth of the very general determinations of thought found in traditional logic and metaphysics. Instead, he wants to explain the kind of concrete truth one seeks in philosophy as a whole.

Hence, what Hegel calls "the Concept" is deeply connected to philosophical thought, and what he calls "truth" is primarily philosophical truth. The positive aim of the *Concept Logic* is to explain what makes concrete philosophical truth possible in its best instance; though in doing so, it also deals with forms of thought that do not achieve this kind of truth. This does not mean that Hegel deals concretely with nature or *Geist* in the *Logic*. As I will often emphasize, the accounts of concepts in Hegel's *Logic* are all "topic-neutral."[22] The *Logic* is an account of certain thought-determinations "in and for themselves," *without* determining or delimiting any specific domain of application in advance. But I will argue that this does not prevent the *Logic* from developing concepts that are in fact exemplified to different degrees or in different domains. In particular,

[20] See, e.g., *EL* § 160Z, *EL* § 20R, *EL* § 88R, *GPR* § 1R.

[21] See, e.g., Pippin 1989: 235. Similarly, Kreis (2015: 21) articulates a common view according to which the Concept stands for something like the whole system of "categories."

[22] The term "topic-neutral" was coined by Ryle 1954. In broad strokes, to give a "topic-neutral" analysis of some concept is to describe it in such a way that it does not require entities of a certain class for its satisfaction. The notion has been used by identity-theorists in the philosophy of mind (e.g., J. C. C. Smart) who wish to accommodate phenomenal qualities without settling their referents in advance. For a discussion of the role of the "topic-neutrality" criterion in evaluating the formality of logic, see Dutilh Novaes 2011.

Hegel's explanation of the paradigm case of philosophical truth could not apply to everything equally, even if it is defended in a topic-neutral manner: it is compatible with Hegel's logical and topic-neutral approach that the concepts he deals with will be differently realized in the domains of *Geist* and nature. In effect, my claim is that, despite the topic-neutrality of the *Logic*, its solution to the problem of how concepts can be "true" always tends in the direction of *Geist*; and hence, certain instances from the artifactual domain provides the best – paradigmatic – exemplification of Hegel's account of philosophical truth.[23]

This prospective reading of Hegel's concept of the Concept is nicely illustrated by the use to which Hegel puts concept-talk in the introduction to his *Philosophy of Right*:

> Philosophy has to do with ideas, and therefore not with what are commonly dubbed 'mere concepts.' On the contrary, it exposes such concepts as one-sided and without truth, while showing at the same time that it is the *concept* alone (not the mere abstract category of the understanding which we often hear called by that name) which has actuality, and further that it gives itself actuality to itself. All else, apart from this actuality established through the working of the concept itself, is ephemeral existence, external contingency, opinion, unsubstantial appearance, untruth, illusion, and so forth. (*GPR* § 1 R, 29/17)

On my reading of this passage, Hegel here assumes that his theory of "the Concept" from the *Doctrine of the Concept* is decisive for his account of <right> in the *Philosophy of Right*. Why so? It is because the subject matter of right is a concept that has "truth" and "actuality" and indeed "gives itself actuality to itself." Not everything that occurs in the political realm – much of which is "ephemeral existence, external contingency, opinion, unsubstantial appearance, untruth, illusion, and so forth" – counts as the actualization of the Concept. Hegel suggests here that a faulty understanding of what a concept is stands in the way of distinguishing all this from the truth. Accordingly, some account of what it means for a concept to be "true" or indeed to give itself actuality is required to understand what Hegel could mean in this specific application. On my view, then, even if there is an initially topic-neutral discussion of the Concept giving itself actuality in the *Logic* itself, we should expect such an account to be exemplified to varying degrees in the various regions of philosophy.

[23] See, by contrast, Stern's claim: "It is arguable that it is in [the *Logic*], rather than the *Philosophy of Nature*, that the best evidence for Hegel's Aristotelian naturalism can be found" (2017: 99). Stern's case for this rests on his interpreting Hegelian "concepts" as natural kinds.

This passage implies that whatever Hegel's account of the Concept is, it is not such that it applies to everything equally. For surely "concepts" in a loose sense apply even to the "ephemeral existence" of the modern state: we have "concepts" of corruption, mismanagement, inequality, and more. Hegel must be supposing that a certain *kind* of concept is at issue here. Though in some sense the whole sphere of conceptuality is at issue in Hegel's account of the Concept, only a narrower kind of concept seems to fulfill Hegel's project of explaining what is true.

To see this, it should prove useful to consider it on a more intuitive philosophical basis. We can begin from a distinction between concepts – using that term in a non-technical sense for now[24] – that only *represent* their objects and concepts that in some way *constitute* their objects.[25] For a concept to merely represent its object is for the concept to be used as a device for reference, where the representing device is essentially different than the thing it represents. This sense of "representation" is akin to Hegel's own use of the term *Vorstellung*. Hegel says that "representing begins from intuition and the *ready-found* material [gefundenem *Stoffe*] of intuition" (*EPG* § 451). I take this to mean that representation is a relation of *deference* to the object as given (initially in intuition). This is true even if activity on the part of the subject is necessary to generate the representation: its function is still to bound to what has been given. Arguably a concept like <water> has the task only of representing its object in this sense: what water really is, as given. Accordingly, a given concept of water can fail in this task miserably. A user of the concept might be completely in the dark about what water really is. This possibility is central to recent arguments to the effect that terms like "water" are natural-kind terms, whose reference functions independently of their sense.[26]

We might say that the dominant conception of concepts treats representation or reference as their primary or even *only* function.[27] By contrast, for a concept to constitute its object requires that there is a relation of

[24] For contemporary readers, it is better to think of the difference between concepts in (Hegel's) proper sense and representations as a difference between kinds of concepts, rather than between concepts and something else. (I owe this suggestion to Mark Alznauer.) See Section 3.1 for more on the distinction between concepts (proper) and representations.

[25] This constitutive role of concepts (or sometimes intentions) is acknowledged, even if not always under that name, by contemporary philosophers of artifacts and social ontology, including Searle 1995, Thomasson 2003, and Evnine 2016. For an application of this kind of work to Hegel, where the notion of "constitution" also plays a significant role, see Ikäheimo 2011. See also Wolf 2020.

[26] See Kripke 1980 and Putnam 1975 for the *loci classici*.

[27] See especially Fodor and Pylyshyn 2014. A different challenge to the representational dimension of concepts comes from various forms of pragmatism, especially Brandom's (1994) inferentialism. It should be clear that the "constitutive" dimension is distinct from this inferentialist one.

dependence not simply of the concept on the object (as in the case of representation) but also of the object on the concept. The idea of a concept constituting its object can be nicely illustrated by a remark of Hegel's from an 1810 lecture. He uses "intention" (*Vorsatz*), rather than "concept" (*Begriff*), but that difference can be ignored for present purposes:

> The intention [*Vorsatz*] to build a house is an inner determination, the form of which consists in first being only an intention; the content comprehends the plan of the house. Now when this form is sublated, the content still remains. *The house which is supposed to be built according to the intention, and the [house] built according to the plan, are the same house*. (W 4: 217, my emphasis)

To build a house involves a conception of, or intention for, the house as built, so that the built house (the object) *is* the conception or intention that was to be realized. We cannot think of the intention or concept as merely representing a house that would exist apart from the concept. Rather, the object is a realization of the concept or intention. The notion of "constitution" suggests itself as an appropriate description of this relation. The example of a house shows that conceptual constitution can be understood on an artifactual model.

Even before a more detailed account is given of the notion of a concept constituting its object, we can notice several unique characteristics of this relation of concept and object. First, the priority of *singular* reality and *universal* concept is reversed in the case of conceptual constitution. That is, where a concept has the task of representing its object, we often begin with some singular reality, and our task is to consider *which* concept or determination should be applied to it. But in the case of conceptual constitution, we have the universal or concept 'first,' which determines how the singular reality should be shaped. Second, since the object's character is determined *by* the concept, the object has a feature we can label *conceptual transparency*.[28] That is, the nature of the object is given by its concept: there can be no final gap between the nature and the concept. In our simple example, this is because what a house is is sensitive to the concept <house> in a way that the nature of water is (presumably) *not* sensitive to the concept <water>. It is easy to understand a claim like, "This is what we think water is, but we may be completely wrong!" but hard, to my ears, to understand a claim like, "This is what we think a house is, but we may be completely wrong!"

[28] I discuss this notion with greater centrality than I do here in my 2019a dissertation.

I have started with the simple concept <house> to make the point of conceptual constitution relatively clear. I hasten to add that my final account will not credit <house> as a concept in the fully Hegelian sense; nor will I suggest that material artifacts like houses are bona fide instances of Hegelian conceptual constitution. My claim will be that artifacts like this provide a *model* of Hegel's theory of conceptual constitution. However, certain artifacts (especially social artifacts) are genuine *instances*. Accordingly, the notion of conceptual constitution should apply in a similar way in the case of concepts of traditional philosophical significance, like, for example, <law> (meaning the use of "law" in legal systems rather than "laws of nature"). I think we can we say something similar about law to what we can say about houses: that what law *is* is sensitive to the concept <law>, that law in some sense involves a universal preceding and determining its own singular reality (the case where a genuine law exists).[29] We cannot say these things if <law> simply has the aim of representing something, of deferring to an object already given, such as the natural kind, or at least empirical kind, *law*.[30] But we may be able to say these things if law depends on a different relation to its concept than mere representation. And so on, *mutatis mutandis*, for anything that exhibits the relation of conceptual constitution that we have sketched. Insofar as there are objects whose concepts are constitutive concepts, there are objects to which we, if we are thinkers of those concepts, have a special, transparent relation.

Now, this brief treatment may suggest that the notion of conceptual constitution is intelligible independently of any of Hegel's grand ambitions in the *Logic*, and this might be taken as a mark against it as an account of Hegel's position. However, my claim is not simply that Hegel recognizes the existence of conceptual constitution, which could be taken as obvious (though I would argue underappreciated). What is significant about conceptual constitution is precisely its systematic significance: it answers the question of the "true" relation of concept and object in a way that the representationalist approach of the natural paradigm does not. Only thus does it have the potential to "invert" a traditional understanding of philosophy. For Hegel's project to succeed, it is not enough that he shows that conceptual constitution is possible or even actual; he must

[29] It is not my aim to sketch out Hegel's view of law here, but see his claim that laws are "the general *work* [*allgemeine* Werk]" (*EPG* § 538). As I will argue in the next chapter (Section 2.4), "work" (*Werk*) is a term for the product of art or craft for Hegel.

[30] Treatments of philosophical concepts as natural kinds are increasingly common. See, e.g., Kornblith 2002 in the case of <knowledge>.

show that it stands at the center of philosophical interest, that it answers our philosophical needs.

This is not obvious. For example, Spinoza is convinced that artifactual concepts lead to a corruption of philosophy. Not only does Spinoza take the object of genuine knowledge (and, ultimately, the only thing that exists) to be "God, or nature," he diagnoses some of the central failures of other philosophers as owing to their implicit reliance on an artifactual model of nature and our knowledge of it. Spinoza's God is not a designer or artificer. Hence, according to Spinoza, our knowledge of nature should no longer bear the trace of illicit analogies to the artifactual realm. For Spinoza, our attachment to normative language in describing even nature relies on precisely this analogy. He writes:

> But after men began to form universal ideas, and devise models of houses, buildings, towers, and the like, and to prefer some models of things to others, it came about that each one called perfect what he saw agreed with the universal idea he had formed of this kind of thing, and imperfect, what he saw agreed less with the model he had conceived, even though its maker thought he had entirely finished it. (*Ethics* IV, Preface/1994: 198)

Here, Spinoza has an interesting explanation of our evaluation of artifacts – one with illuminating connections to what we find in Hegel. For Spinoza, we begin with "universal ideas" or "models" of artifacts, which become standards of evaluation of artifacts, against which we measure their goodness or perfection. This is the origin of our normative concepts, not only in their use for the evaluation of artifacts but also when they are extended to everything:

> Nor does there seem to be any other reason why men also commonly call perfect or imperfect natural things, which have not been made by human hand. For they are accustomed to form universal ideas of natural things as much as they do of artificial ones. They regard these universal ideas as models of things, and believe that Nature (which they think does nothing except for the sake of some end) looks to them, and sets them before itself as models. So when they see something happen in Nature which does not agree with the model they have conceived of this kind of thing, they believe that Nature itself has failed or sinned, and left the thing imperfect. (*Ethics* IV, Preface/1994: 198)[31]

[31] Compare Aquinas: "We need to keep in mind that the good of any thing with a standard and measure consists in its conforming to that standard or measure. That is why we say that a thing is well disposed when it has neither more nor less than it ought to. / Next, we must note that the moral virtues' matter is human actions and passions, just as craft's matter is producible items. Therefore, just as the good in the case of items that craft makes consists in their receiving the measure demanded

For Spinoza, the use of an artifactual model to understand nature is a sign of the misapplication of concepts in the natural realm. We think we can apply terms like "good" or "perfect" to the natural world, forgetting that the home use of these concepts comes from the evaluation of artifacts.[32] Spinoza's solution is not to accept a dualism of nature and artifact but to overturn this dualism in favor of monism of nature. Thus, Hegel's metaphysical humanism cannot just show that there is such a thing as conceptual constitution (though even this, I think, would be denied by Spinoza); he must also show that it is not reducible to some other form of naturalistic explanation. For this, an inversion of the natural paradigm in metaphysics is required.

1.3 Interpreting Hegel's Idealism and Metaphysics of the Concept

There has often been a prominent place in the study of Hegel for those who emphasize his significance for "humanistic" disciplines, especially in terms of his providing a precedent for hermeneutics.[33] This tradition is a significant inspiration for the present one. However, I do not know of a humanistic reading of Hegel that shows how his humanism is rooted in his theory of concepts. Some, like Taylor's (1975) influential work, treat Hegel's use of "the Concept" to mean something akin to God or a cosmic spirit.[34] Presumably such an entity will not well explain how *we* have special conceptual knowledge of the human world. (I sketch an argument for this claim later in this section.) In recent years, however, it has become more popular to explain even the humanistic or social side of Hegel's thought in terms of the natural or even (supposedly) naturalistic side of his thought, including his sizeable debt to Aristotle. Books by Pinkard (2012), Sell (2013), Kreines (2015), Khurana (2017), and Ng (2020) emphasize

by the craft, which is the standard for artifacts, so the good in the case of human actions and passions is that they attain the measure of reason, which is the standard and measure of human actions and passions" (2014: 574 [*Disputed Questions on Virtue*, A 13, Reply]).

[32] It would be more correct to say that Spinoza does not recognize any genuine artifactual context, for there is no sui generis characteristic of works of art; nor do we need to appeal to genuine intentional causation to explain their existence. On this, see Morrison 1989.

[33] See, e.g., Taylor 1975; Gadamer 1976: ch. 4; Redding 1996; Forster 2011. The humanistic side of Hegel's work is also emphasized in the French reception of Hegel, i.e., Kojeve 1969 and Hyppolite 1974, and in Marcuse 1987.

[34] While Ikäheimo (2011), for example, presents a view of Hegel's social ontology much in keeping with my own, he also subscribes to a general conceptual realist reading (see 201 n. 42).

Hegel as a thinker of nature and organic life.[35] Some have looked to Hegel (though even more to Schelling) as a source of inspiration for environmental thought.[36] And though the domain of *Geist* has by no means been ignored in this recent trend, Hegel's use of the Aristotelian metaphor of *Geist* as "second nature" has gained a special prominence. This gives the impression that nature is playing a key role even in the *concept* of *Geist*.

It is true that nature plays an important role in Hegel's thought and also that organic metaphors are almost ubiquitous in his work. It will be an important desideratum for my interpretation to show how placing the realm of spirit (read in artifactual terms) as a *paradigm* of philosophical knowledge does not exclude nature as a genuine *instance* of such knowledge, and not a mere anomaly (see Section 7.4.2). Even so, an implication of my interpretation will be that the emphasis on Hegel's naturalism should give way to a "humanist" or indeed "artifactualist" interpretation that I do not believe has received its full due.

What distinguishes my approach is its use of the artifactual paradigm as a new way to challenge traditional interpretations of Hegel's metaphysics. Despite a spate of deflationary or non-metaphysical readings of Hegel in the past few decades,[37] several dominant interpretations of Hegel continue to affirm that he offers a full-blooded theory about the nature of reality as such, a metaphysics in its most ambitious sense. On this kind of view, Hegel's metaphysics, especially as presented in his *Logic*, involves the claim that there is some important and *general* convergence or identity between "thought" and "being," or "subjectivity" and "substance." A common way to put the basic view is as a variation on Spinoza: Hegel offers an important modification of the Spinozist conception of substance by introducing an element of dynamic subjectivity into the picture.[38] In Hegel's famous words, "everything depends on conceiving and expressing the true not as *substance*, but just as much as *subject*" (*PhG* 22–3/¶ 17). Rather than substance being what it is eternally, substance proves to be a dynamic subject that makes itself what it is over time. Eventually, in the course of human history the substance realizes itself most completely in becoming

[35] See also the article by Stone 2013 for a good summary. Thompson 2008 has also been a source of inspiration. Although not a book about Hegel, Hegel's treatment of "life" as a logical concept plays an important role in it.

[36] See, e.g., Stone 2005.

[37] Although some might contest the deflationary label, I have in mind readings by (e.g.) Hartmann 1972, 1999; Pippin 1989; Stekeler-Weithofer 1992, 1996; Brinkmann 2011; and McCumber 2014.

[38] See Beiser (2005: 55–79) for a prominent recent exposition of Hegel's metaphysics along these lines. For example: "Yet, for Hegel, there was no choice but to transform Spinoza's substance into a living organism" (95).

aware of itself in human (Protestant Christian) thought, which indeed contributes to its full realization. On this metaphysical reading of Hegel, *Geist* is one designation for this dynamic substance-subject, while "the Concept" is a designation for its logical structure, becoming the "Idea" or "Absolute Idea" when it is fully developed. On such a view, Hegel's absolute idealism is the claim that thought and being, Concept and reality, are one and the same, though this merely implicit identity becomes increasingly explicit over the course of history. Importantly, since *all* of reality is the product of the Concept, on this monist view there would be no use looking for a fundamental logical distinction between nature and spirit.[39]

This reading of Hegel requires a very different understanding of Hegel's Concept than the one I have just sketched in the previous sections. While I have said that Hegel's use of the term "Concept" refers to some aspect of human thought, on the standard metaphysical readings it is something like a logical description of the subject-substance just described. Without doubt, there are passages in Hegel that suggest such an account. For example, consider a passage from the 1831 preface to the *Science of Logic*:

> This concept is not intuited by the senses, is not represented in imagination; it is only object, product and content of *thinking*, the issue [*Sache*] that is in and for itself, the logos, the reason of that which is, the truth of what we call things; it is least of all the logos that should be kept outside the science of logic. (*WL* I 30/19, modified)

Introducing the Concept in the *Encyclopedia Logic*, he writes, "As the *substantial might which is for itself* the concept is what is *free*, and since *each* of its moments is *the whole* that *it* is, and is posited as inseparable unity with it, the concept is *totality*" (EL § 160, 307/236). And in a *Zusatz*[40] a few paragraphs later, Hegel explains:

> Instead, the concept is what truly comes first, and things are what they are through the activity of the concept that dwells in them and reveals itself in them [*die Tätigkeit des ihnen innewohnenden und in ihnen sich offenbarenden Begriffs*] . . . Thought and, more precisely, the concept, is the infinite form or the free, creative activity that does not need a material at hand outside it in order to realize itself. (*EL* § 163 Z_2, 313/241)

[39] This point is nicely made by Padui (2013: 126–7). He points out that it is incumbent on monistic readers to deny any kind of fundamental nature/spirit distinction, since on this view nature itself must be a product of spirit.

[40] Since *Zusätze* or "additions" were added by editors to Hegel's works, often drawing from lecture notes, their specific wording cannot be taken for granted as accurate ways of expressing Hegel's thought. I will occasionally draw on them, but they should be used with some caution.

These passages, taken by themselves, are not clear in their details. But one can perhaps already see in them what a number of commentators have drawn from them. It is frequently claimed that the way to understand Hegel's metaphysical idealism is in terms of a *conceptual realism*.[41] On this view, "the Concept" does not refer (primarily) to human acts or contents or thought but to something present in the objective world, perhaps its most fundamental structure.

Broadly speaking, there are two main variations of this kind of view that have been presented in recent interpretations. On the one hand, monistic interpretations see Hegel as holding that the Concept is a single quasi-logical structure constituting reality as a whole. This view is classically articulated by Charles Taylor:

> Our basic ontological vision is that the Concept underlies everything as the inner necessity that deploys the world, and that our conceptual knowledge is derivative from this. We are the vehicles whereby this underlying necessity comes to its equally necessary self-consciousness. Hence the concept in our subjective awareness is the instrument of the self-awareness of the Concept as the source and basis of all, as cosmic necessity. But if this is so, then the concept in our minds must on closer examination turn out to function like the Concept at the root of reality. (1975: 300)

Brady Bowman's (2013) more recent, well-developed version of this view holds that Hegel's idea of the Concept is a competitor to Spinozian "substance"; in contrast to substance, the Concept is a purely and absolutely *negative* structure ("absolute negativity"). There is no positive substance but a dynamic structure of negative relations. The whole structure of mutual negative relations amounts to reality as a whole, including the finite minds (our own) that grasp this structure.[42]

Another strand of conceptual realism we may call the *essentialist* view. It holds that Hegelian "concepts" are akin to real essences or natural kinds, inhering in the world, perhaps especially the organic and animal world.[43] Everything, in some way, is what it is because of its inhering concept. Frequently cited in this regard is a different passage from the *Science of Logic*'s 1831 preface: "The nature, the specific essence, that which is truly

[41] I broach the issues discussed here in Wolf 2018. A notion of conceptual realism has continued to remain central to the scholarly discussion. A distinct variant of conceptual realism plays an important role in Brandom's 2019 reading of Hegel's *Phenomenology*.

[42] A similar substance-free monism is thoroughly defended by Lau 2004.

[43] Perhaps some essentialists would contest "especially" here. But many of them certainly think Hegel's view of the concept is committed to the claim that animals, for example, *must* come in determinate natural kinds.

permanent and *substantial* in the manifold and accidentality of appearance and fleeting externalization, is the *concept* of the thing [*Sache*], *that which is universal in it*" (*WL* I 26/16, modified). Essentialist readings differ on the status of "the Concept" when used in its conspicuous grammatically singular form.[44] But in general they emphasize the role of Hegelian "concepts" as the essences of existing individuals.[45] Hegel's idealism is an "objective" idealism, on this view, precisely because of his commitment to the existence of mind-independent "concepts."

One can see quite clearly that if we accept a conceptual realist reading of Hegel, he will be found not to support an artifactual paradigm in philosophy but rather a natural one. For if our goal in philosophy is to express the content of "concepts" that are (human-)mind-independently in the world (whether in the monist or essentialist manner), then philosophical inquiry will be wholly deferential to those "concepts." Indeed, it will even be "theoretical": philosophy will be an attempt to approximate in thought the true "concepts" that are the hidden essences or kinds of things.

There is no doubt that some of Hegel's texts can be read in support of conceptual realist readings. But I find that these accounts face a common difficulty, which I do not think can be met. To put it simply, these accounts do not explain how Hegelian metaphysics can amount to someone's *knowledge*, and especially in the strong (even "absolute") sense that Hegel wishes to credit this metaphysics as knowledge. As I will argue in the next chapter, Hegel's use of the term "Concept" is involved in crediting human beings, in some instances, with *absolute* knowledge. For this to work, I believe, concepts themselves must be what subjects *think*;[46] concepts themselves, whatever their content may be, must be directly present in thought. Call this the *immediacy-of-thought condition*.[47] By contrast, an

[44] For example, Knappik 2016 is an essentialist but also a monist, while at least in his 2015, Kreines endorses an essentialism without monism. Stern (2009: 57–66) argues that neither holism nor monism are essential to Hegel's idealism.

[45] For readings that fit this essentialist picture, see Stern 2009; Kreines 2015; and Knappik 2016. A response to recent criticisms of this view is Stern and Weiss 2024.

[46] Hegel likes to make the connection deeper – he even hesitates to say that we "have" concepts because they are so fundamental in making us up as who we are: "True, I *have* concepts, that is, determinate concepts; but the 'I' is the pure concept itself, the concept that has come into *determinate existence*" (*WL* II 253/514). See also the second preface to the *WL*, where Hegel, speaking specifically of the thought-determinations of the *Logic*, writes, "What is there of more in *us* as against them? How would *we*, how would *I*, set myself as the superior universal *over* them?" (*WL* I 25/15).

[47] In a passage that might be thought to support the conceptual realist position, we find a clear affirmation of the immediacy-of-thought condition. In the second preface to the *Logic*, Hegel writes, "Thus, inasmuch as subjective thought is our own most intimately inner doing, and the objective concept of things constitutes what is essential to them, we cannot step away from this doing, cannot stand above it, and even less can we step beyond the nature of things. We can,

account of Hegel's metaphysics that states that even *concepts* are on the 'other side' of thought – they are 'in' the object, they are present in things or as the structure of reality – must take away the directness of our access to the concepts themselves, since we are not ourselves *thinking* these concepts in their objective form, for example, as governing something about animal life. Suppose we then say that there is a relation between our human concepts and these concepts* (the objective things posited by conceptual realism), what will explain our knowledge of this relation? It cannot be concepts* themselves, if we concede that concepts* are mind-independent (at least for minds like ours). For those are now the objects we are trying to know, and not the concepts we know them with. We have a few options. We may, firstly, assert an identity or isomorphism between concepts and concepts*. But this assertion must be merely dogmatic, since we must rely on our concepts to gain knowledge of this isomorphism, which assumes the very same isomorphism.[48] For example, it would be dogmatic to assume that our concept <dog> is the same as, or identical to, what we posit as the objective concept* *dog*, since we need <dog> to think *dog*. Yet the same problem seems to hold no matter what objective concept is posited.

Or, secondly, we might deny that concepts are immediately thought at all and make our knowledge of real concepts an 'inference to the best explanation.'[49] That is, we might say that the world is better explained by assuming that there are real concepts* in things than not. Yet, even if true, that would not make it the case that *those* concepts* are immediate to thought. It will be hard to see how our knowledge *of* those concepts* will be our *knowledge* rather than, say, reasonable belief. Neither of these solutions will succeed in showing how metaphysical knowledge is possible in the "absolute" but non-dogmatic sense Hegel requires.

However, even if my criticism here is apt, one might think that it presents Hegel's view of concepts as a nonstarter in another way. For

however, dispense with this last claim; inasmuch as it is symmetrical with the one preceding it, it says that our thoughts have a reference to the essence of things; *but this is an empty claim, for the essence of things would then be set up as the rule for our concepts whereas, for us, that essence can only be the concepts that we have of the things*" (*WL* I 25/16, my emphasis). In my view, Hegel here affirms that a concept is always in thought, so that we do not need a theory that posits concepts in things. This view is defended further in Chapter 3.

[48] The alternative would be to, like Schelling, promote "intuition" as a reliable guide to metaphysics – a path that Hegel's appeal to the Concept is explicitly designed to repudiate. This difference from Schelling is eminently clear in the preface to the *PhG*, esp. ¶¶ 12–13, 16, 51, 67–70.

[49] This is one suggestion of Kreines (2015: 51), which draws on similar considerations for believing in natural kinds in general. It must be noted that this is not Kreines's main argument for accepting conceptual realism, but, as I read him, he remains skeptical of building any requirement for epistemological transparency into Hegel's *Logic*.

suppose we stipulate that when Hegel speaks of "the Concept," he is referring to some kind of activity that is possible for human thought, exemplified in *philosophical* thought. That certainly makes it clear how it could be known by us: simply by thinking. But it would then become questionable how Hegel could want to say what he says about the Concept in the passages that seem to neatly support the conceptual realist position. Evidently, or at least apparently, my own thought is *not* "the infinite form or the free, creative activity that does not need a material at hand outside it in order to realize itself." Nor does it seem that one's own thought could be confused for a quasi-Spinozian "substance." Satisfying the immediacy-of-thought condition seems to require that we radically deflate the content of Hegelian knowledge.

Existing accounts that attempt, as I do, to meet the immediacy-of-thought condition commonly address this problem by appealing to something like a universal conceptualism about knowledge and experience. This is especially characteristic of Robert Pippin's still-influential 1989 work, *Hegel's Idealism*.[50] He writes there, "For it is with a denial that a firm distinction can ever usefully be drawn between intuitional and conceptual elements in knowledge that distinctly Hegelian idealism begins" (9). Pippin understands the Concept to be Hegel's answer to the Kantian notion of the transcendental unity of apperception (6). The Concept is something like self-consciousness in its freedom from the givens of experience, which also has the power of unifying our experience. On this account, Hegel's neo-Platonic-sounding statements about the "concept giving itself its own reality" should be interpreted in terms of Hegel's challenge to Kant's distinction between concepts and intuitions.[51] To put it simply, the conceptual structure of experience is grounded in conceptual activity or spontaneity. There can be no final, nonconceptual 'check' from outside.

Pippin's comparison of Hegel's Concept or "Notion" (as it was formerly translated) with a Kantian notion of the unity of apperception thus makes

[50] Pippin's more recent work on Hegel (2015, 2017, 2019) endeavors to emphasize Hegel's continuity with Aristotle's conception of metaphysics. Despite this, Pippin's insistence on the centrality of conceptualism remains constant in the later work.

[51] From Pippin's recent book: "If we understand this properly, we understand apperceptive spontaneity 'in its actuality,' as having 'given itself' its own actuality, the actuality of the intelligibles, what there is. This is related to what Kant called establishing the objective validity of the categories, but Hegel insists that such an understanding of the relation between thought and being is established *within* the activity of pure thinking, not by appeal to anything extraconceptual, like the pure forms of intuition" (2019: 35). "So, contra Kant on what we might call thought's absolute discursivity, Hegel thinks that thought is always already giving itself its own content" (2019: 91).

the focus of Hegel's theory of conceptuality its relation to perceptual experience. In line with the idea that the Hegelian Concept is the unity of apperception, for Pippin, the specific concepts of the *Logic* are moments of this unity, and thus akin to Kantian categories, conditions for possible judgments and hence any empirical uptake. At least in his early work, Pippin reserves the name "Notion" for the specific concepts discussed in the *Logic* itself: concepts such as <becoming>, <essence>, and <life>.[52] Hegelian "Notions" differ from Kantian categories in that they are not static, they are defined mutually, and they do not depend on a nonconceptual given.[53]

We can see how closely Pippin conceives the Hegelian to the Kantian project in a passage such as the following: "And, as I have been stressing, Notions have this [sc. empirically unrevisable] status for basically Kantian reasons, because for Hegel, the issue of the 'determinations of any possible object' (the classical Aristotelian category issue) has been critically transformed into the issue of the 'determinations of any object of a possibly self-conscious judgment'" (Pippin 1989: 250). On this view, Hegel's apparent realism about conceptuality is an occasional misstep. Pippin writes, "On the face of it, there are several places where Hegel . . . slips frequently from a 'logical' to a material mode, going far beyond a claim about thought or thinkability, and making a *direct* claim about the necessary nature of things" (187). But he thinks this "slip" is not required by Hegel's considered view.

Though Pippin's work will receive further attention in what follows, I agree with critics who complain that his account does not satisfactorily explain the grander-sounding claims that Hegel makes about the Concept, those that lead others to accept the conceptual realist reading.[54] Rightly or wrongly, a view in which the Concept is akin to Kantian categories will have the ring of subjectivism (or in Pippin's terms, "impositionism"[55]): for

[52] McDowell (2009: 85) similarly criticizes Pippin for the close proximity between his view of Hegelian "Notions" and Kantian categories.

[53] "Being able to understand and being able to argue plausibly for the legitimacy of some putatively absolute, isolated 'Notional' candidate can be shown to fail unless that original Notion is supplemented and expanded in some way by the understanding of another such Notion" (Pippin 1989: 233).

[54] So-called non-metaphysical readings of Hegel in general have been accused of being inadequate on textual grounds. Pippin's in particular is criticized on this score by Pinkard 1990; Siep 1991; Ameriks 1992; and Stern 2009. Pippin's (2015, 2017, 2019) more recent attempt to deal with the apparently neo-Platonic "self-productive" connotations of the Hegelian *Begriff* merely in terms of his supposed denial of the concept–intuition dualism continues to be unsatisfying, in my view. See Houlgate (2021: 127–32) for a criticism of Pippin's more recent work.

[55] See Pippin 2019: 73 n. 80, 80. By "impositionism," Pippin appears to mean a view according to which the categories are imposed on reality in virtue of a requirement on the finite subject (I am indebted to a manuscript by Andrew Werner here). Though Pippin does not endorse an interpretation of either Kant or Hegel as impositionists, it is not fully clear how this charge can be escaped.

it looks like what *makes* the world show up with the determinations it has is the fact that these are the forms that judgment brings to it. When, more recently, Pippin's (2019) Hegel is more willing to make claims about "being qua being," this can even have the appearance of a yet more complete subjectivism: a subjectivism so thorough that even the thought of the Concept's non-objectivity is simply ruled out, as if by fiat. For it is unmistakable that the apparent symmetry between being and thought, for Pippin, stems entirely from the activity of *judging*. To claim that to be is to be intelligible, and to be intelligible is to be the object of judgment, seems to achieve absolute objectivity by a kind of willful blindness to the possibility of a non-judgmental object. That it does not make sense *to me* to think of a nonconceptual, non-judgmental object does not seem to rule it out *simpliciter*. True, I cannot draw the distinction between the thinkable and the unthinkable. But one might easily take that to be further evidence of my own limitation, not a reason to think that there is no such distinction.[56]

The systematic interpretive significance of the artifactual model I will propose is its ability to avoid both conceptual realism (as commonly understood) and the arguably subjective idealism of the Kantian accounts like Pippin's, with which I am otherwise more in sympathy (since these do not abandon the immediacy-of-thought condition). There are two key sources of this advantage. First, as I've suggested, Hegel's interest in concepts or the Concept is not an interest in the relation of the concepts employed in judgments of perception or experience, and thus not akin to Kantian categories. Hegel does not, on my view, envision concepts as something ubiquitous in everyday perception or experience. He even claims that "ordinary life has no concepts, only representations of the imagination [*Vorstellungen*]" (*WL* II 406/628). Instead, his interest is in philosophical concepts more generally: concepts as varied as <beauty>, <perception>, <knowledge>, <law>, and <civil society>. He wants to explain how *they* have a special reality or truth, in contrast both to empirical concepts and the more formal concepts he discusses in the *Logic* itself.

Second, and relatedly, this model no longer requires the Concept to have some completely *general* absolute or constitutive relation to the world. Pippin's earlier use of the Kantian "apperception" motif is precisely meant to attribute this kind of generality to Hegel's idealism. Categories bound to

[56] Without rejecting his 2019 reading of Hegel, in Pippin's 2024 book, he has recoiled, in a Heideggerian vein, from the seeming hubris of Hegel on his account.

apperception must apply to *all* objects of experience. By contrast, while it may be true that for Hegel the Concept is the form of our thought in general, on my reading thought has a constitutive relation to the world only in the special case of the domain of *Geist*. The artifactual *paradigm* shows what it means for an object to be completely conceptually transparent, namely when the Concept takes on a constitutive relation to an object through its practical dimension; but this does not hold of thought and its object in general. In no way is this practical-constitutive dimension of the Concept unfamiliar to Pippin (see his 2008a). But it seems to me that it has not been treated as a solution to understanding Hegel's objective and absolute idealism. Pippin certainly speaks of *Geist* as a "product of itself,"[57] and so gives a prominent place to an artifactual metaphor. But Pippin seems to use this notion for the special case of our production of ourselves as reason-responsive creatures of a certain sort. This may be a part of Hegel's view. But it is not the center of my own "Vichian" account. Whether *we* are products or not,[58] some of the objective, historical world, the domain of *Geist* in general, is (for Hegel) the product of rational thought, or, rather, it is always being reproduced. We must factor in our special access to those things when we consider the kind of idealism Hegel endorses. Given the existence of objects that are conceptually constituted, our conceptual knowledge of the world is sometimes knowledge of the nature or essence of "things" (*Sachen*, not *Dinge*: see Sections 2.4 and 5.1). This much idealism is sufficient to show us that human thought is not alien to the world, and that we should not think of thought as only subjective. These are desiderata of any reading of Hegel. It also explains Hegel's tendency to speak in seemingly neo-Platonic terms about the Concept realizing itself in the world, as if through a demiurge. For this *is* (or can be) something like the relation of human action and institutions to conceptual thought. Hegel is thus a conceptual "realist" in the full sense only in the case of the humanly constructed world.[59] And since it is (or can be) *our*

[57] This phrase is used frequently in Pippin 2008a. I have not been able to locate it in Hegel's work other than in the passage Pippin quotes from manuscripts collected by Petry (Hegel 1978: 6–7): "das ist er [= der *Geist*], nur als zu sich gekommen, als ein solches Produkt seiner selbst ist er; seine Wirklichkeit ist nur, daß er sich zu dem gemacht hat was er ist." (Petry's translation: "[Spirit] being itself only as it comes to itself as such a product of itself; its actuality being merely that it has made itself into what it is.") However, even if this phrasing is not typical for Hegel, the idea is genuinely his own. See the *GPR*: "The human being is rational *in himself*, but he must also become so *for* himself by working out the production of himself [*Produktion seiner selbst*], not only by going outside himself [*Hinausgehen*] but also by developing himself internally [*Hineinbilden*]" (*GPR* § 10Z, 62/34, modified).

[58] See Schuringa 2022 for a recent challenge to Pippin's claims in this domain.

[59] I have previously argued for this claim in Wolf 2018.

concepts that can be recognized as objective in the artifactual domain, we satisfy the demand for realism and the immediacy-of-thought condition at the same time. I contend that without understanding the special metaphysical significance of the humanly made world in Hegel's thought, it will be difficult to understand how he holds both of these sides together.

1.4 Plan of the Work

Though the focus of this book's argument is on the *Science of Logic*, in Chapter 2, I first motivate my reading of the *Logic* by exhibiting the connection between his theory of concepts and his social ontology within Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit*. Though Kant and Fichte recognized that practical knowledge is driven by concepts, they did not recognize practical knowledge as issuing in sui generis conceptually constituted reality. Hegel's move beyond his predecessors rests on this point. He shows in the *Phenomenology* that practical knowledge issues in "works" (*Werke*), which are grounded in the concepts necessary for their constitution. Knowledge of such works, which often stem from institutional histories, is what Hegel calls *absolute knowledge*. I argue that Hegel's idea of absolute knowledge is qualitative rather than quantitative: it concerns a specially transparent form of knowing rather than a certain massive extent or even finality of knowing. The constellation between the topics of concepts, artifacts, and social-historical realities present in the *Phenomenology* becomes a precedent for the more abstract argument for concrete conceptual truth in the *Logic*.

In Chapter 3, I turn to the *Doctrine of the Concept*. It is crucial for my whole account that Hegel's use of the term "Concept" (*der Begriff*) is closer to its ordinary philosophical meaning than is often claimed. In this chapter, I argue that the singular use of "the Concept" is a synecdoche for the structure of conceptual thought as exemplified in philosophy in general, and that this structure is distinct from (though related to) what Hegel sometimes disparages as "representation" (*Vorstellung*). Hegel argues that conceptual thought has a formal structure of universality, particularity, and singularity. However, unlike many accounts, I do not see these as properties that all concepts must have to be concepts. Rather, these formal features are exhibited variously in different concepts, judgments, and syllogisms. Hegel's discussion of the formal dimension of thought sets up his attempt to show that some structures of thought more perfectly exemplify the form of the Concept than others.

Why does a discussion of the formal structure of conceptuality occupy a text that is supposed to be a "replacement" of metaphysics? In Chapter 4, I attempt to answer this question. I first argue that the Objective Logic, the part of the *Logic* that most overlaps with the concepts of traditional metaphysics, is an examination and development of metaphysical concepts without leading to any metaphysical theory. The reason for this, I argue, lies in Hegel's use of a device I call *suspended reference*, which is not unique to Hegel but rather common in philosophy. Suspended reference is a way of using a concept (not only mentioning it), but without being committed to the reality of its referent. Hence, the Objective Logic is not a metaphysical theory, and the transition to the *Concept Logic* is not a progressive development within a metaphysical theory. Instead, it is Hegel's attempt to provide a grounding for the metaphysical concepts of the Objective Logic. Hegel's bold claim, which is enacted in his transition from <substance> to <the Concept>, is that the metaphysical concepts have their grounds within the *logical forms* he discusses in the Subjective Logic. In effect, metaphysics is a self-exposition of the form of thinking. This transition motivates a turn away from metaphysics as a theoretical discipline, which attempts to grasp the structure of a reality that may be unlike it; in my view, the transition opens the door to a view of philosophy in which the mind-dependent is privileged *because* it is more transparently dependent on concepts.

The remaining project of the *Concept Logic* is to articulate on explicitly logical grounds a new standard for the kind of "truth" – agreement of Concept and object – that most characterizes the object of philosophical inquiry. In Chapter 5, I argue that Hegel develops an account both of the least adequate logical relation of Concept to object, which he calls *judgment*, and the most adequate such form, which is the syllogistic form of *teleology*. For Hegel, what best corresponds to its concept is what is conceptually constituted. And Hegel's model for conceptual constitution is a teleological process governed by some universal. I argue that the Teleology chapter of the *Logic* does not reject the artifactual model for teleology but in fact embraces it, for the teleology of artifacts requires its intention to come "first" in the construction of its object. Hegel's aim is thus not to defend a claim about natural purposes but to show what it means for an object to become adequate to the Concept. A teleological process solves Hegel's attempt to find a "true" relation of Concept to object because teleology involves a universal being realized through particular means as a singular object – this is its "syllogism." Teleology shows in a concrete way how the moments of conceptual form can be unified in the objective domain.

Chapter 6 concerns the contentious issue of the role of the concept of life in the *Logic* and its consistency with the artifact-centered conception of teleology I defend. Here I oppose a common tendency to think that the Life chapter implicitly imports abstract references to the biological domain in the *Logic* itself. I argue instead that Hegel's Life chapter must be read in "topic-neutral" terms: in a way that requires application neither to the natural or "spiritual" domains. Once it is read in this neutral way, we can see that the notion of "logical life" is simply the notion of a self-determining purpose. This concept can apply equally (and, I argue, even more appropriately) in the domain of culture and human institutions as in that of living organisms. Only a "living" purpose could be conceptually constituted because only thus could a universal play a determining role in the purposive object, rather than as a mere plan or design. Yet I argue that the concept of life as developed by Hegel is not at all contrary to the artifactual domain; this is especially because the social and cultural domain give us prime examples of "living artifacts," which are precisely the kind of artifacts that *can* be based in a self-referential form of thought. I argue that Hegel provides a logical foundation for the living artifacts of the domain of *Geist* precisely because these are purposive processes that must also be guided by the universal, or the domain of cognition. Some contemporary work in social ontology provides a useful reference point for understanding the way that (objective) *Geist* involves both life and cognition. For social ontology is precisely that which exists because of the way it is known.

In the final chapter, I consider how my explanation of the artifactual paradigm at work in Hegel's thinking affects his overall philosophical position. Speaking loosely, Hegel sometimes suggests that 'everything' is conceptual. However, I argue that essential to Hegel's idealism is an asymmetry in the domains of *Geist* and nature that is rooted in Hegel's theory of concepts. *Geist* is that which is conceptually constituted; nature is that which is not conceptually constituted. This asymmetry between the two domains is the "inversion" of philosophy that Hegel's concept-centric metaphysics inspires. In this chapter, I assemble evidence from Hegel's so-called *Realphilosophie* – specifically his works on political philosophy, natural philosophy, and aesthetics – to show that Hegel's treatment of these topics indeed demonstrates an inverted conception of philosophy, one that is rightly considered a humanism.

CHAPTER 2

From Practical to Absolute Knowledge
The Artifactual Model in Hegel's Phenomenology

A common reference point for recent discussions of Hegel's epistemology and action theory is Elizabeth Anscombe's revival of the notion of *practical knowledge* in her *Intention* (1963).[1] Anscombe argues that our knowledge of what we are doing when we act is different from any form of theoretical or purely observational knowledge. Practical knowledge, for Anscombe, is that by which what is done is *settled*. Anscombe describes practical knowledge as follows:

> § 45. We can now consider "practical knowledge." Imagine someone directing a project, like the erection of a building which he cannot see and does not get reports on, purely by giving orders. His imagination (evidently a superhuman one) takes the place of the perception that would ordinarily be employed by the director of such a project. He is not like a man merely considering speculatively how a thing might be done; such a man can leave many points unsettled, but this man must settle everything in a right order. *His* knowledge of what is done is practical knowledge.
>
> But what is this "knowledge of what is done"? First and foremost, he can say what the house is like. (Anscombe 1963: 82)

Following Anscombe's lead, it has become common to say that, whereas theoretical or speculative knowledge (taken in a broad sense, to include empirical knowledge) has a "mind-to-world direction of fit" – that is, the mind ought to fit the world – practical knowledge has a "world-to-mind direction of fit" – the world ought to fit the mind.

It may be thought that my use of a similar example in Chapter 1 – that of building a house – would suggest that my account of Hegel's view of conceptual knowledge is the same as (or quite similar to) Anscombe's view of practical knowledge. If this were true, it would be difficult to distinguish Hegel's view of conceptual knowledge, or *absolute knowledge* as he calls it in

[1] See, e.g., Quante 2004; Moyar 2008; Pippin 2008a; Yeomans 2012; Brandom 2019.

the *Phenomenology*, from the kind of practical knowledge already considered by Kant and Fichte. For Kant and Fichte endorsed a substantially similar account of practical knowledge as Anscombe,[2] and, moreover, they sometimes described their views in terms of the practical realization of *concepts*. To be sure, Hegel would acknowledge and accommodate these insights. However, Hegel's advance to "absolute knowledge" depends on recognizing a second, quasi-theoretical stage of conceptual knowledge, though it is one that relies on a prior practical stage. That is, absolute knowledge is not akin to the practical *settling* of reality but our conceptual and rational recognition of what has been practically and rationally *settled*. It is thus akin to what some have called *maker's knowledge*. Anscombe's own account seems to make room for this, since she suggests that the practical knowledge of the house builder will lead to some knowledge of the house's properties: he will know "what the house is like." It is this second, theoretical or "speculative" stage in our knowledge of practically determined reality that I believe is analogous to what Hegel calls absolute knowledge in the *Phenomenology*. Though absolute knowledge may involve knowledge of what we are *doing*, it is also knowledge of what has thereby been *done* or *made*. It can also extend to my knowledge of what has been done (or is being done) by "fellow minds" equipped with concepts like my own.

My aim in this chapter is to work out the epistemological foundations of Hegelian humanism in his *Phenomenology*. The position framed here in epistemological terms significantly prefigures the one worked out "logically" in the *Science of Logic*; I hope to help motivate my reading of the *Logic* by showing how it builds on his earlier position. To do so, I begin by sketching the similar views of Kant and Fichte on practical knowledge (Section 2.1). I hope to show that Kant and Fichte leave theoretical space for the position Hegel later occupies. I then turn (Section 2.2) to the epistemological project of Hegel's *Phenomenology* (which, to be sure, is only one of its several concurrent projects). Hegel argues that an adequate conception of knowledge will show concept and object are coherently united; "absolute knowledge" is simply a designation for a concept of knowledge that has achieved this goal. In Section 2.3, I show that Hegel's Absolute Knowing chapter defends a specific conception of what absolute knowing is: the conceptually explicit self-knowledge of "*Geist*." In Section 2.4, I argue that Hegel's explanation for the domain of which we

[2] See especially Engstrom 2009 for an account that draws substantial connections between Kant and Anscombe.

have absolute knowledge depends on his view that *Geist* is a "work" (*Werk*) or artifact. The contemporary thinker gains absolute knowledge when she thinks the conceptual basis of the human world, knowing that this is the same conceptual basis that gives this human world its existence. Hence, she gains a kind of 'fellow-minded maker's knowledge' of her world. This knowledge depends on the fact that "the Concept" has been practically realized in a social-historical context. All this implies a humanistic restriction on absolute knowledge (Section 2.5).[3]

2.1 Practical Knowledge in Kant and Fichte

Kant famously claims in the preface to the B-edition of his *Critique of Pure Reason* that "reason has insight only into what it itself produces according to its own design" (B xiii). This claim, though made with reference to the production of principles in the natural sciences, seems to align Kant with a maker's knowledge principle, and perhaps to the artifactual paradigm.[4] However, whatever Kant means by this programmatic statement, I would suggest that it does not lead to the kind of philosophical program that moved Hegel.

Some understand Kant's transcendental idealism to be a constructivist kind of idealism, according to which all the objects of our knowledge would be 'made' by us.[5] If this were true, Kant would hold to more than an artifactual *paradigm*, since artifactual knowledge would not simply be exemplary but characteristic of *every* case of knowledge. But in my view, Kant's attempt to demonstrate a priori principles for the objects of experience is not a claim that we construct the things that figure in our experience. For that to be the case, Kant would have to hold that we construct the *matter* of our intuition and experience. Rather, it is a crucial claim of Kant's theoretical philosophy that we depend on the matter or objects of our intuition being *given* to us, for which we rely on a faculty of our *receptivity*, namely sensibility.[6] Kant is not a constructivist about the things

[3] For accounts of absolute knowledge that emphasize its *practical* presuppositions, I am especially indebted to Pinkard 1994 and Moyar 2017b.

[4] In his *Von den göttlichen Dingen* (1811), F. H. Jacobi explicitly connects Kant's view to Vico on this point. See JW 3: 79. This is one of the few references to Vico among Hegel's contemporaries I have been able to locate. See Bergel 1968 for discussion of Vico's influence among German intellectuals.

[5] See Rockmore 2016.

[6] For example: "If cognition is to have objective reality, i.e., to be related to an object, and is to have significance and sense in that object, the object must be able to be given in some way" (A 155/B 194). "Thus all concepts and with them all principles, however *a priori* they may be, are nevertheless related to empirical intuitions, i.e., to *data* for possible experience" (A 239/B 298).

of nature,[7] even if he accepts that our a priori knowledge of nature is built up from principles that depend only on our own rational faculties and are not constitutive of things per se.[8] Indeed, when Kant considers theoretical cognition, it is clear that it is empirical cognition (or otherwise a priori principles that depend on empirical application) that is the paradigm case. And empirical cognition is the exemplary case of knowledge within a natural paradigm, a knowledge that depends on deference to the objects of representation.

Instead, Kant accepts a dualism of theoretical and practical knowledge, and the use of concepts in each case differs accordingly.[9] In theoretical cognition, we use concepts in the context of judgments, which relate to an object in some way (A 68/B 93; Ak. 9: 86; 110). Usually, this object is given to us through the faculty of sensibility. Only in the special case of the pure concepts of the understanding is the "matter" for concepts drawn from ourselves, namely from the pure forms of a priori intuition. But in every case, a theoretical concept must have some intuition that provides its matter.

The case is different with practical cognition. Whereas concepts represent the world through judgments in theoretical cognition, concepts (or, more generally, representations) are the *cause* of actions in the case of practical cognition. Kant calls "desire" (*Begierde*) the general faculty to be the cause of the object of a representation, by means of a representation (Ak. 5: 9/8). Because of the faculty of desire, human action can be governed by imperatives, which express not how the world is already but how it "ought" to be. Of the practical "ought," Kant writes, "Now this 'ought' expresses *a possible action, the ground of which is nothing other than a mere concept*, whereas the ground of a merely natural action must always be an appearance" (A 547–8/B 575–6, my emphasis). For Kant, concepts have a fundamentally distinct relation to the world in the domain of practical cognition.

One might think that practical cognition, given its causal force, results necessarily in a world that has been altered according to the "ought" represented in the imperative. This may be true in the ordinary case in which we desire to eat a slice of cake and thus change the world's quantity

[7] He writes, "Yet there are in the study of nature an infinity of suppositions in regard to which certainty can never be expected, because the appearances of nature [*Naturerscheinungen*] are objects which are given to us independently of our concepts, to which therefore the key lies not in us and our pure thinking, but rather outside us" (A 480/B 508).

[8] See Wolf 2023a and Wolf 2026 for my own (non-standard) account of Kant's use of this expression.

[9] To be sure, Kant also wanted to find a common source of unity between these two stems of knowledge. I am here, admittedly, simplifying Kant's position. Since I am mainly interested in drawing out where Hegel's difference from Kant and Fichte is most overt, I hope this can be forgiven.

of this good. However, what primarily interests Kant in his moral philosophy is not the practical desire that realizes its object due to some sensory representation (such as an inclination) but because of a *pure* and thus non-sensuous one. For Kant, *pure* representations can be the cause of objects only if they do so in the form of purely practical laws (Ak. 5: 44). Only if a will is determined through pure reason alone is a non-empirical causality possible that is necessary for the existence of morality.[10] Once such a causality is granted, however, it becomes possible to suggest that in the practical causality of pure reason (namely, through moral action), an "intelligible world" is revealed, the world as determined by pure practical reason:

> On the other hand, the moral law, even though it gives no such *prospect*, nevertheless provides a fact absolutely inexplicable from any data from the sensible world and from the whole compass of our theoretical use of reason, a fact that points to a pure world of the understanding and, indeed, even *determines* it *positively* and lets us cognize something of it, namely a law. (Ak. 5: 43)

It is important to distinguish the "intelligible world" that is revealed to us by the practical use of reason from any alteration in the sensible world. Clearly, such an intelligible world is not something that enters our *intuition*, which Kant maintains is impossible (cf. Ak. 5: 45). Nor does Kant think the intelligible world is accessible to theoretical cognition of a different kind. Instead, what we discover about the pure world of understanding is only the structure of the laws that direct moral action. The reality of this world is nothing outside our action (cf. Ak. 5: 70). For this reason, we do not bring about the intelligible world as a kind of result within the familiar, sensible world.

It is thus important to see that Kant's notion of practical knowledge is different from a maker's knowledge principle, which would emphasize the significance not only of the *doing* of action but also what is thereby *done*. Pure practical cognition moves us to act; it does not mainly make a new thing.[11] Yet this does not mean that Kant's work is devoid of interest in artifacts. At points, he alludes to a kind of humanistic maker's knowledge almost in passing. In the first *Critique*, he makes a relevant allusion in an otherwise unrelated context:

> It is an ancient wish . . . that in place of the endless manifold of civil laws, their principles may be sought out; for in this alone can consist the secret, as

[10] See Wolf 2023b. [11] For Hegel's complaint on this point, see *VÄ* I 84/56–7.

> one says, of simplifying legislation. But here the laws are only limitations of our freedom to conditions under which it agrees thoroughly with itself; *hence they apply to something that is wholly our work, and of which we can be the cause through that concept*. But that objects in themselves, as well as the nature of things, should stand under principles and be determined according to mere concepts is something that, if not impossible, is at least very paradoxical in what it demands. (A 301–2/B 358, my emphasis)

This passage connects Kant with Vico in the latter's conception of the civil world. We can understand transparently the laws governing the civil world, despite the fact that they involve limitations of our freedom, because they apply to something that is our "work" and which our own concepts are involved in causing. Kant contrasts this kind of case to the concepts of theoretical cognition, which at least cannot stand in the same maker's relation to their objects.

Kant also uses a kind of maker's knowledge conception of artifacts to pose one of the central problems of the third *Critique*. Namely, Kant wants to explain how we might be justified in employing teleological judgments – judgments about the purposiveness of a thing – about what is living in nature.[12] This presents a problem precisely because natural things are *not* artifacts, yet our model of teleological judgments is built on an artifactual analogy. He writes,

> For we adduce a teleological ground when we ascribe causality in regard to an object to a concept of the object as if it were to be found in nature (not in us), or rather *we represent the possibility of the object in accordance with the analogy of such a causality (like the kind we encounter in ourselves)*, and hence we conceive of nature as **technical** through its own capacity; whereas if we did not ascribe such an agency to it, we would have to represent its causality as a blind mechanism. (Ak. 5: 360, my emphasis; bold type in the original)[13]

For Kant, our conception of nature as purposive gains its intelligibility (if not its objectivity) by an analogy to our own "technical" capacity to be the cause of objects through our concepts. Indeed, when we attribute purposes to nature, we "merely borrow [this kind of causality] from ourselves" (Ak. 5: 361).[14] The products of art, in contrast to nature, have "a cause whose productive capacity is determined by concepts" (Ak. 5: 370). While these passages indicate that Kant sees artifactual causality as one that is

[12] For further discussion, see Section 5.4. [13] See also B 61; Ak. 5: 367–8, 370–2.

[14] As Kant further develops the notion of internal purposiveness, he qualifies this claim: "Strictly speaking, the organization of nature is therefore not analogous with any causality we know" (Ak. 5: 375). This is because the organization of nature cannot rely on the will of a being outside the object (cf. Ak. 5: 374).

determined by a concept of an end that is carried out in the product (and so one that would seem to underwrite a privileged maker's knowledge), his use of this model in the third *Critique* is mainly illustrative of the problem of ascribing purpose in nature, where we cannot assume such a technical capacity is at work.

Thus, for Kant, though there is a clear distinction between practical and theoretical cognition, and thus a distinction between practical and theoretical concepts, he does not greatly emphasize the role of practical concepts in bringing about objects in the world as matter for a new kind of theoretical cognition. We see a similar trend in Fichte, with some important developments. Much like Kant, Fichte distinguishes between the practical and theoretical use of a concept by the respective priority the concept has vis-à-vis the object. Unwittingly echoing Kant's famous letter to Hertz,[15] Fichte opens his *Das System der Sittenlehre* (*The System of Ethics*) of 1798 with the question: "How can something objective ever become something subjective; how can a being for itself ever become something represented [*vorgestellten*]?" (FW IV: 1/2005: 7). He notes that modern philosophical attention has focused on the case of theoretical cognition, where "what is subjective follows from what is objective" (2/7). He claims that the alternate case of a practical agreement of subject and object has been almost completely taken for granted (2/8). Yet, interestingly, in this case when "I act" (*ich wirke*), the opposite order of agreement is brought about. Here, "What is objective is supposed to follow from what is subjective; *a being is supposed to result from my concept* (the concept of an end [*Zweckbegriff*])" (2/8, my emphasis).[16]

Fichte sees a kind of perfect mirroring between theoretical and practical cognition, and thus he wants to show how practical reason leads to the same result as theoretical reason from a different side: namely, the agreement of subject (here as concept) and object. More so than Kant, however, Fichte emphasizes that the nature of the agreement between concept and object is generically symmetrical in both the theoretical and practical uses of concepts. Building on ideas of Salomon Maimon,[17] he claims that it is the mere *determinateness* (*Bestimmtheit*) of a concept that is necessary to its

[15] "I asked myself this question: What is the ground of the relation of that in us which we call 'representation' to the object?" (Ak. 10: 130/Letter to Herz, February 22, 1772).

[16] Not *all* acting should be classified as involving the causality of a concept for Fichte. In the case of acting for the sake of enjoyment (a species of what Kant calls inclination), Fichte writes: "To the extent that a human being aims at mere enjoyment, he is dependent on something *given*: namely, the presence of the objects of his drive" (FW IV: 130/2005: 124).

[17] Maimon resurrected a form of Leibnizian rationalism by claiming against Kant that objects can be individuated conceptually, through an infinite determination rather than through sensible intuition

application to objects. Since this implies that specially *sensible* modes of determination are incidental to the content and application of a concept, there is no need for special pleading to explain the practical agreement of concepts and objects. Fichte writes:

> To say that a concept possesses reality and applicability means that our world . . . *is in some respect determined by this concept*. The concept in question [sc. morality] is one of those concepts through which we think objects; and, because we think objects by means of this concept or in this manner, the object possesses certain distinctive features for us. To seek the reality of the concept thus means to investigate how and in what way it determines an object. (FW IV: 63/65, my emphasis)

Concepts of morality "determine" actions by *specifying* them out of indeterminate possibilities (cf. 137–8/131). They do not have content because there is a sensible intuition that can be correlated with the action, but because an object can be determined by an end. Though he does not go into detail here, the same is true for theoretical concepts. They have content because they "determine" objects, without any necessary requirement that they do so through sensible intuition.

This leads to a purer kind of symmetry than Kant admitted between the relation of concepts and objects in the theoretical and practical cases, respectively. The distinction can be made simply (though perhaps rather crudely) with reference to relations of priority ("*vor*-") and posteriority ("*nach*-"):

> How might we ever come to assume such a remarkable harmony between a concept of an end and an actual object outside us, the ground of which is supposed to lie not in the object itself but in the concept? – Let me make this question clearer by contrasting it with another one. A cognitive concept is supposed to be a *copy* [*Nachbild*] of something outside us; a *concept of an end* is supposed to be a *model* or *pre-figuration* [*Vorbild*] for something outside us. . . . So . . . in our present case we are asking about the ground for assuming a harmony *of the thing, as what comes second, with the concept, as what comes first*. (FW IV: 70–1/2005: 72–3)

A practical concept corresponds to its object because it "prefigures" the object in advance. Fichte accordingly sees a teleological concept as a "design" (*Entwurf*) for an object.[18] Just as the design comes before an

alone. Cf. Maimon 2010: 103–4. See Beiser (1987: ch. 10) for an account of Maimon's influence on German Idealism, much of it mediated by Fichte.

[18] "A free being acts as an intellect, which is to say that it acts in accordance with a concept of an effect, a concept *designed prior to the effect in question* [*voher . . . entworfenen Begriffe*]. What is to be brought about must therefore be so constituted that it can at least be thought of by an intellect" (FW IV: 66/2005: 68).

object and determines it accordingly, so the concept of an end determines the object of action.

This does not mean that a practical concept *qua* design cancels the general difference between concepts and objects in the domain of action, for many practical concepts do not become (or determine) objects. Fichte follows Kant in calling practical concepts that do not require a corresponding existence "ideas" (*Ideen*):

> When one speaks of the reality of the concept of morality, then this cannot – at least not *to begin with* – mean that something is immediately realized in the world of appearances simply by thinking this concept. The object of this concept, i.e., what arises in us when we think in accordance with the concept of morality . . . can only be an *idea* [*Idee*], a mere thought *within us*, with no claim that anything in the actual world *outside us* corresponds to this concept. (FW IV: 65/2005: 67)

This allowance of a reality for morality that is *only* a "thought *within us*" is where Fichte stands in harmony with Kant. Hegel will later deride this dimension of morality as the mere "ought" (*Sollen*) that is without actuality. But unlike Kant, and in anticipation of Hegel, Fichte recognizes that if practical ends (concepts) *are* carried out, then to that extent "reality" is determined by concepts. Accordingly, practically determined reality can *in principle* also be cognized theoretically.

Unfortunately, at least from Hegel's perspective, Fichte typically treats the purely practical determination of reality as a *conditional* or *hypothetical* possibility, even a "conjecture":

> Were this conjecture – that is, *the conjecture that a part of the world we find is determined through freedom*, as a theoretical principle – to be confirmed, and were it to turn out that it is precisely this part of the world that constitutes the sphere of objects of our duties, then it would follow that the law of freedom . . . would only be a continuation of what that same law of freedom, as a theoretical principle, had already initiated. (FW IV: 68–9/70, my emphasis)

Fichte is clear that knowledge of the world as determined through practical reason would be a kind of theoretical knowledge. If the world is so determined, then there is a different kind of reality to be cognized, what he calls "products of freedom": "A reality that has its ground in a concept is called a product of freedom" (134/128).

But *are there* such products? If Fichte affirms this conditionally, this is at least because whether there are such products depends in the first instance not on what exists *anyways*, but on the actual acting of beings self-

determined by free purposes. Yet if we assume the reality of such actors and their actions, it seems clear that Fichte can affirm the existence of products of freedom:

> The concept (of an end) immediately becomes a deed [*wird . . . zur That*], and the deed immediately becomes a (cognitive) concept (of my freedom). . . . It would have been quite correct to deny that freedom can be an *object* of consciousness; freedom is indeed not something that develops by itself, without any assistance from a conscious being, in which case the latter would only have to be an observer. Freedom is not the object but the subject-object of a conscious being. (FW IV: 137/130–1)

Fichte both agrees and disagrees with Kant here. He agrees that freedom is not an object of consciousness *simpliciter*. We cannot merely observe freedom in the external world. However, he disagrees that freedom cannot *become* an object of cognition. It becomes an object of cognition as the subject-object, which we might gloss as the subject's concept of her deed in the realization of the end or aim of her deed. This subject-object is given within the very action itself rather than from the point of view of its result.

Fichte's view is recognizably similar to Anscombe's (1963) notion of practical knowledge, in which a subject knows what she does in that she *settles* the matter. Subjects can know *that* an end has been carried out by performing an intentional action. Though Kant and especially Fichte each recognize this, neither emphasize that this conception of practical knowledge carries in tow a second kind of theoretical knowledge, which can be directed toward the results of practical achievement.[19] It is this second kind of theoretical knowledge that Hegel will introduce under the name *absolute* knowledge. My aim thus far has been to show that there is room for philosophical innovation on Hegel's part here, one distinctive of his contribution to the conversation with Kant and Fichte.

2.2 The Goal of Knowledge in the *Phenomenology*

Hegel's 1807 *Phenomenology* is centrally concerned with knowledge or "science" (*Wissenschaft*). The work was conceived (and titled) originally as an introduction to the "system of science," and if we are led by the plan of the work suggested in its introduction, we will see the aim of the work as

[19] A complete account of the precedents of these ideas would of course have to include Schelling. I think Hegel's position by the time of the *Phenomenology* is best explained by a turn away from Schelling and closer to Fichte (see Hyppolite 1974; Bristow 2007), but in any case, a detailed treatment of Schelling would be distracting for my purposes.

providing us with a solution to a problem about knowledge.[20] If we leap over the work to its end, the final chapter, Absolute Knowing, we are apparently supposed to see that some such problem has been solved, and that absolute knowing can or does exist. How does Hegel expect to convince his readers of this? In the remainder of this chapter, I aim to show that Hegel's eventual defense of absolute knowing combines elements of practical and theoretical knowledge in a way that depends on an artifactual model. The artifactual model of absolute knowledge in the *Phenomenology* forms an important piece of background for the model of conceptual constitution I discuss in the rest of the work.

In my view, common interpretations of absolute knowing make it difficult indeed, prima facie, to see how Hegel could provide any argument showing that we could possess it. For example, Clinton Tolley (2018) has recently argued that "the *Phenomenology*'s conception of absolute knowing bears much closer affinities with the idea, not of any sort of human knowing, but of the knowing by the divine infinite intellect that Hegel thinks Kant himself had already hit upon" (145). On this view, it would not be reasonable to ascribe absolute knowing to ourselves unless we could consider ourselves to have precisely such a divine intellect. Other scholars see absolute knowledge as a kind of comprehensive, universal knowledge of reality, or at least of its basic structure. On such a view, "absolute knowing" is knowledge *of* an entity we could call "the Absolute," namely "a single spiritual actuality" that comprehends the oppositions such as nature and spirit, thought and matter.[21] Though there certainly are passages in Hegel that can suggest such a reading of absolute knowing, it is difficult to see how any argument could convince us that such knowledge is possible.

A first encounter with the phrase "absolute knowing" no doubt conjures up images of a form of knowing that no sane human could hope to obtain. Along with other easily misunderstood features of his ideas, this one contributes to the image (encouraged, for example, by Kierkegaard) of Hegel as a hubristic but also buffoonish thinker, who wished to congratulate himself as being the culmination of philosophy and history in general. This impression is, perhaps, an unfortunate consequence of Hegel's vocabulary. But Hegel himself makes sincere efforts to avoid this kind of misunderstanding. In the Introduction to the *Phenomenology*, he notes the

[20] For the story of Hegel's early plans for the *Phenomenology*, see especially Förster (2012: ch. 13).

[21] Siep 2014: 239. "Yet it is the goal of the *Phenomenology* as a whole to show that the actual nature of reality is a network of these concepts" (Siep 2014: 80). Siep glosses "the absolute" as "reality proper" (2014: 57). See also Houlgate (2009: 20): "Absolute knowing, as I understand it, is the recognition that the structure of a priori thought and the structure of being are identical."

tendency to treat words like "the absolute," "cognition," "objective," and "subjective" as if their meaning could be "presupposed as universally familiar" (*PhG* 70–1/¶¶ 75–6). Instead, he contends, it is a part of the philosophical task to *give* this meaning and to make it comprehensible. I believe this advice is especially crucial with reference to "absolute." With an abstract and unfamiliar term like "absolute," it is difficult to avoid substituting some paraphrase conjured by the expression (perhaps such as "reality" or the "structure of reality"), especially as Hegel's own meaning is largely implicit. However, if we attend carefully to Hegel's own elucidations of absolute knowing, rather than to any preconception that might be suggested, a possessable form of absolute knowing can turn out to be plausible.

Hegel's understanding of absolute knowing can be approached by considering a central argument of the *Phenomenology*'s Introduction. The Introduction offers a stunning piece of *meta*-epistemology.[22] It is not concerned to defend a conception of knowledge, but to outline what *any* conception of knowledge must do. How would we show not just how we know some *object* but what concept of knowledge is the right one? What is the right *standard* for what should count as knowledge? Hegel first motivates this problem by describing some guiding metaphors of various opposing conceptions of knowledge. Some of them implicitly employ the metaphor of knowledge as an "instrument," by means of which something (the object of knowledge) is altered; others work with the image of knowledge as a "passive medium," through which the object of knowledge must be filtered (*PhG* 68/¶ 73). Each such conception (and they could be multiplied) carries with it some presupposition about what knowing is, and about what is supposed to be known. Conceptions of knowledge, Hegel thinks, rarely consider whether these second-order presuppositions are well founded. This question about knowledge, Hegel insists, ought not only to be a "*presupposition*" of the investigation but also a target of the investigation itself (70/¶ 75).

Hegel approaches a solution by offering a condition of adequacy on any conception of knowledge, a "goal" that something must aim at if it is meant to be knowledge.[23] He writes: "But the *goal* is fixed for knowledge just as necessarily as the sequence of the advance; it is situated where

[22] Prominent readings that emphasize this dimension of the introduction include Westphal 2003: chs. 5 and 6; Bristow 2007: ch. 5; and Brandom 2019: chs. 1 and 2.

[23] This is closely related to what Brandom (2019: 44–50) calls the "Genuine Knowledge Condition" (GKC).

knowledge no longer needs to go beyond itself, where knowledge finds itself, and the concept corresponds to the object and the object to the concept" (PhG 74/¶80). There will be various conceptions of knowledge, Hegel admits. But each of them, he claims, must have a single goal: expressing knowledge as the agreement of concept with object, namely as knowing, conceptually, something *as it is*. For Hegel, this goal for knowledge is not the goal of any given, parochial theory of knowledge but a constraint on any such conception. Notably, this conception of the goal of knowledge was explicitly shared by Fichte, who, as we saw, treated the aim of both theoretical and practical cognition as the agreement of concept and object.

If Hegel is correct about the goal, each conception of knowledge will implicitly posit some various notion of a *concept* and some notion of an *object*. If there is any adequate conception of knowledge, it will be able to make intelligible how the object and the concept correspond. As Hegel puts it, "But the essential point to bear in mind throughout the whole investigation is that both these moments, *concept* and *object*, *for-another-ness* and *in-itself-ness*, themselves fall within the knowledge we are investigating, and consequently we do not need to import standards, to apply *our* notions and thoughts in the investigation" (PhG 77/¶ 84, modified). In order to understand the passage, it is crucial to bear in mind that Hegel is using "object" in a relative sense, as something like the *target* of a given form of cognition.[24] "Object," as is often pointed out, is not a genuine-kind term or even a sortal noun.[25] Objects are not a class of "things." Instead, something is an object in the relevant sense when it is the target of some state or activity; in particular, it is what someone desires or expects to know.[26] Hegel also calls this element, variously, the "essence," "in itself," or "truth." Notice in the following passage that "object" becomes elucidated by the phrase "standard of assessment":

> Since consciousness thus finds in its object that its knowledge is at odds with the object, the object itself does not hold out either; or the *standard of assessment* [*Maßstab der Prüfung*] alters when that of which it was supposed

[24] See Stang 2021 and Wolf 2023a.

[25] See, e.g., Lowe 2009. In this way, "object" differs from the philosophical German use of "thing" (*Ding*).

[26] Compare the usage of Hegel's contemporary F. H. Jacobi in his famous letter to Fichte: "Where this direction towards the true is lacking, there is no reason. This direction; this compulsion to consider as its object [*Gegenstand*] the true that hovers before it only in intimation, to consider it as the final aim [*Absicht*] of every desire for cognition – this constitutes the essence of reason" (1994 [1799]: 513–14). Though Hegel would disagree with the substance of this remark, it illustrates the close association between "object" and "aim."

> be the standard fails the test; and the assessment is not only an assessment of the knowledge, but also of the standard of the assessment. (*PhG* 78/¶ 85, my emphasis)

The passage would be paradoxical if we treated "object" as meaning something like a concrete material thing.[27] It is not that *those* things must change as we come to know them. This would also inappropriately assume that knowledge necessarily concerns such things. Instead, if it means throughout something like the "target" or "standard of assessment" of a given form of knowledge, it is not so difficult. Whenever a claim to knowledge is at issue, there are two ways it can fail. First, it can fail to meet the standard that is taken to be given. For example, if knowledge is justified true belief (JTB), then a true belief without justification is not knowledge. However, it can also be the case that a given claim of knowledge fails not because it does not meet the given standard but because the standard of assessment is itself taken to be inadequate,[28] for example in light of Gettier's (1963) criticism of the "JTB" analysis of knowledge. What counted as knowledge according to the first standard, without ceasing to meet that standard, no longer count as knowledge because "consciousness" no longer accepts the old standard.[29]

This kind of standard-adjustment is what Hegel means when he speaks of the object changing:

> But as we have shown above, consciousness thereby has its first object altered; the object ceases to be the in-itself, and becomes to consciousness an object that is the *in-itself* only *for consciousness*; and so this, the *being-for-consciousness of this in-itself*, is then the true, which means, however, that this is the *essence* or the *object* of consciousness. This new object contains the nullity of the first, it is what experience has made of it. (*PhG* 79/¶ 86)

[27] Brandom (2019: ch. 3) gives an extensive reading of this and related passages. He would agree that the "object" in question is not a concrete material thing. For Brandom, the "object" is something like the *status* something represented has for consciousness (2019: 92). This is not far from my use of the notion of "object" as "standard of assessment," or what knowledge is measured *against*. However, Brandom's use of perceptual examples – the bent-stick illusion – is not, in my view, well suited to illustrate the meta-epistemological point that Hegel is making. After all, later in the *Phenomenology* (ch. II, "Perception, or the Thing and Illusion"), Hegel is interested in whether perception *itself* should function as a standard of assessment for knowledge; treating examples *within* the domain of perception as altering the status of perceptual representations must take for granted that perception provides an adequate paradigm of knowledge in the first place. That seems to beg important questions in advance of Hegel's account.

[28] For a helpful discussion of this point on Hegel's own case of "perception," see Bristow 2007: 225–47.

[29] The problem of assessing the standard of justification in particular is often called "the Problem of the Criterion," which can be traced to Sextus Empiricus. See Westphal 1989, 2003: ch. 5, and Bristow 2007: 5.2, for discussion.

In other words, when a consciousness gains a new concept of the object of knowledge, it looks askance at the old conception of the object of knowledge – its old standard of assessment – as merely "for" some consciousness, as relative to a previous, inadequate conception. But a consciousness cannot have a conception of the inadequacy of some conception except in light of a new standard, which is most likely only implicit in the new position.

When does the process end? Only when there can be a conception of knowledge that meets the fixed goal of knowledge, to explain the agreement of concept and object. It is meeting this goal that Hegel anticipates as "absolute knowing" as the Introduction to the *Phenomenology* comes to its end:

> In pressing on to its true existence, consciousness will reach a point at which it sheds its semblance of being burdened with alien material that is only for it and as an other, *a point where the appearance becomes equal to the essence*, where consequently its presentation coincides with just this point in the authentic science of spirit; and finally, *when consciousness itself grasps this its essence, it will signify the nature of absolute knowledge itself*. (*PhG* 80–1/¶ 89, my emphasis)

Consciousness comes to describe "absolute knowing" when, first, the object of its knowledge (the "essence") is in fact matched by the concept or consciousness of it ("the appearance") *and* when this consciousness *grasps* that this is the case in its consciousness. As Hegel understands it, "absolute knowledge" is simply knowledge that meets the goal of knowledge without qualification.[30] Since many possible conceptions of knowledge leave open the possibility, and even likelihood, that their implicit standard will not be met, not just *any* conception of knowledge allows for absolute knowledge in this sense. Thus, it is the meta-epistemological project of Hegel's *Phenomenology* to show that there is a conception of knowledge whose implicit standards can be met.

2.3 Absolute Knowing

I now wish to show that there is a relatively straightforward way to understand the *Phenomenology*'s ultimate account of this conception of

[30] Here I follow Emundts (2012: 108): "I do not read the relevant passages [sc. concerning the 'absolute'] as if Hegel were from the beginning concerned with the cognition of a certain object [sc. the Absolute, or God]; rather I read them as suited to the project of providing general conditions for cognition that can hold for anyone. To say, 'We know the absolute,' accordingly means as much as 'We know something as it is.' That is, it is concerned with cognition that we can know about something that is such as we claim, independently of or 'detached' [*abgelöst*] from the fact that we claim it."

knowledge. In leaping from the beginning to the end of the book, I am of course violating Hegel's own demands that we arrive at a conclusion only through the process itself (*PhG* 11–13/¶¶ 1–3). However, for most readers of Hegel, some sense of where he is leading us is crucial for understanding the process as well. Since my aim here is only to show that there is a precedent for an "artifactual model" in Hegel's epistemology and metaphysics, this approach seems justified for our present purposes.

Hegel's chapter Absolute Knowing follows his Spirit and Religion chapters, and this is significant for my account. The earlier Spirit chapter describes a series of forms of historical, social life. We begin with a description of pure "ethical life" (*Sittlichkeit*) corresponding to the Athenian polis; we move through a description corresponding to the modern Enlightenment, and on to an account of spirit that succeeds a Kantian conception of individual morality. These forms of life are each in some way a manifestation of "spirit" or *Geist*. Whatever else *Geist* might be, in the Spirit chapter it is *at least* a form of "collective mindedness,"[31] or, as Hegel says, "the I that is the we; the we that is the I" (*PhG* 145/¶ 177). The Spirit chapter gives us an account of the transformation of each such collective form into another.

The Religion chapter describes a parallel movement as the Spirit chapter, though it no longer considers forms of life themselves but the styles of the *self-representation* of these forms of life. In short, religion is something like the self-understanding of a given community's form of life.[32] The aim of the chapter, according to Hegel, is to show the unity of *Geist*'s form of life with its form of self-representation. As he writes at the beginning of Religion,

> As we now know that spirit in its world and spirit conscious of itself as spirit, or spirit in religion, are the same, the completion of religion consists in the two becoming equal to each other: it requires not only that spirit's actuality be embraced by religion, but, conversely, that spirit, as spirit conscious of itself, become actual to itself and *object of its own consciousness*. (*PhG* 497/¶ 678)

This passage makes it quite clear that religion is completing a task in terms of spirit's consciousness of itself *as* itself. However, the tendency of religion, for Hegel, is to treat this self-understanding as the representation of an "other," namely as a god or gods. As he writes near the end of the

[31] Cf. Pippin 2008a.

[32] As Hegel writes earlier in the *Phenomenology*, in terms of its knowledge, religion "is the speech of the community about its own spirit" (¶ 656). On this theme, see especially Hyppolite 1974: part IV, ch. 3 and, more recently, Gante 2025: section II.

Religion chapter, "[Religious consciousness] grasps this aspect, in which the pure internalization of knowledge is *in itself* absolute simplicity or the substance, as the representation [*Vorstellung*] of something which is so, not in virtue of the *concept*, but as the action of an *alien* satisfaction [sc. God]" (573/¶ 787). The chapter ends with Hegel's description of what he takes to be unique to the modern Christian form of self-consciousness. The key element of this form of consciousness is its *identification* of the essence of the community with *itself*. The "Holy Spirit" is not a spirit other than the spirit of the community of believers; thus, what the spirit of a community *is* is not represented as something outside the community, but as itself.

This background is important to understanding the arrival of absolute knowing, since absolute knowing will, like religion, involve some form of life or "spirit," as well as some form of self-understanding – now replacing the religious form. Hegel thus speaks of absolute knowing as reconciling "consciousness with self-consciousness" (*PhG* 579/¶ 794); that is, a reconciliation of what we are aware *of* with our awareness of ourselves. He then writes:

> The unification of the two sides has not yet been exhibited; it is this that closes the series of configurations of spirit, for in it spirit reaches the point of knowing itself, not only as it is *in itself* or according to its absolute *content*, nor only as it is *for itself* in its form devoid of content or on the side of self-consciousness, but as it is *in and for itself*. (579/¶ 794)

This passage indicates what the *object* of absolute knowing – what is supposed to be known – will be. It will namely be "spirit" as itself. If we take the discussion in the Spirit chapter to be a clue to this – and more discussion on this point will be given below – the *content* of absolute knowing is something like a form of historical, cultural life itself. In particular, Hegel claims that absolute knowing will represent crucial features of historical and cultural life as products of *action* rather than, for example, an alien being like a transcendent god. For this reason, in Absolute Knowing, Hegel treats not only the side of cognition or self-consciousness as essential to absolute knowing but also a *practical* dimension. He writes,

> This concept gained its fulfillment on the one hand in the *action* of spirit certain of itself, and on the other, in *religion*: in religion the concept acquired the absolute *content as content* or content in the form of *representation*, in the form of otherness for consciousness; in the shape of acting spirit, by contrast, the form is the self itself, for it contains the self-certain spirit in *action*; the self accomplishes the life of absolute spirit. (580–1/¶ 796)

The movement from religion to absolute knowing, Hegel here suggests, does not only occur within a purely cognitive domain. Instead, the

movement presupposes the "actions" of *Geist*; and what is new in absolute knowing is the way these actions are treated not as belonging to an "other" but to itself. Hegel again emphasizes the role of action in the paragraph's close: "Through this movement of action, the spirit – which is only spirit in *being there*, in elevating its thereness into *thought* and thereby into absolute *opposition*, and in returning from this opposition through and in this opposition itself, – spirit has emerged as pure universality of knowing, which is self-consciousness, – as self-consciousness that is the simple unity of knowing" (582/¶ 796). Thus, the kind of knowing that is absolute knowing involves a recognition of something that is, in some way, already given, namely "spirit"; and this is something that is both a matter of *action* and *thought*, in a way that involves the reconciliation of thought and action.

It is at this stage that we get Hegel's explicit explanation of absolute knowing:

> This last shape of spirit – the spirit which at the same time gives its complete and true content the form of the Self and thereby realizes its concept while remaining in its concept in its realization – is absolute knowing; it is spirit knowing itself in the shape of spirit, or *conceptual knowing*. . . . As a result, that which is the very essence, viz. the *concept*, has become the element of being-there, or has become the *form of objectivity* for consciousness. Spirit, *appearing* to consciousness in this element, or what is here the same thing, produced in it by consciousness, *is science*. (*PhG* 582–3/¶ 798, modified)

Absolute knowing has here a twofold structure. First, it involves some form of "realized" conceptuality or selfhood. The realization of such a concept is required for this form of spirit to have the form of "objectivity" that can "appear" to consciousness. In short, absolute knowing involves the realization of something in the world that expresses spirit, conceptuality, or the self. Second, since that element of the world is itself the expression of conceptuality, it can be grasped conceptually; absolute knowing, strictly speaking, is the conceptual grasp of that element of the world that is the product of conceptuality. The "spiritual" world must be taken, at least possibly, as this kind of expression. Whatever this spiritual world is must be the product of the actions of spirit.

To be sure, the "spiritual" side of the world is not first realized *as* self-consciously conceptual. That is, the form of cultural life is not an explicitly designed or engineered process guided by conceptual knowledge. Hegel says clearly that the "knowing substance is there earlier than its form or its conceptual shape" (*PhG* 584/¶ 801). He says that the religious community

is "at first the substance of absolute spirit" but that it is an "uncultivated consciousness" (586/¶ 803), perhaps unaware of what it is doing. Evidently, the historical process that brings "spiritual" reality into existence is not itself a conceptually explicit one; but it must develop in such a way that its products are especially compatible with conceptual knowing. As Hegel says in the preface to the *PhG*, reason is "purposive activity" (26/¶ 22). Conceptual reason can self-consciously recognize itself in the results of an implicit, purposively rational activity, even if that activity does not involve the explicit deployment of concepts.[33]

As the chapter continues, I think it becomes clear that the content of absolute or conceptual knowing is not the world as a whole but just that portion of the world that can be seen as the realization of self or conceptuality.[34] In a broad sense, of course, one might think that *any* conceptual thought can recognize itself in the world. In observing natural things, for example, I am indeed observing them with the aid of my conceptual capacities. But Hegel has a stronger relation between concepts and the world in mind, and this relation does not seem to be so ubiquitous. As we have just seen, the "substance" that Hegel names in the context, which transforms into a self-knowing subject, is initially quite specific: it is the religious community.[35] That must involve a somewhat narrow scope for this "substance." It is only after rejecting the "alienness" (*Fremdsein*) of this supposed substance that the self can attain the relation to the world implied in absolute knowledge:

> [O]nly then does it turn to its own world and present, discover it as its property, and has thereby taken the first step toward coming down out of the *intellectual world*, or rather towards inspiriting the abstract element of

[33] In Chapter 6, I will argue that "life" is Hegel's general term for a purposive process that is not explicitly guided by the universal (or thought), and that history in general is an example of life in this sense.

[34] There is a passage that suggests otherwise. After explaining the transition between the concept of religion to the form of the concept, Hegel writes, "For this concept is, as we see, the knowledge of the doing of the self within itself as all essentiality and all existence, the knowledge of *this subject* as the *substance* and of the substance as this knowledge of its doing" (*PhG* 582/¶ 797, modified). Unfortunately, the context does not help much in understanding Hegel's reference to "all essentiality and all existence [*aller Wesenheit und alles Dasein*]." This remark may be reconciled with the considerations I offer later in this book about the sense in which the Concept has a universal domain (see Chapter 3) and its place in nature (Section 7.4.2).

[35] This is also confirmed by the close relationship, in the Religion chapter, between the "substance" and the "community" (cf. *PhG* 573–4/¶¶ 786–7). Hegel even writes in a note that "Absolute knowing makes its first appearance in the guise of reason as law-giver; in the concept of ethical substance there is not a distinction between consciousness and being-in-itself; for the pure thinking of pure thought is both in itself, i.e. self-identical substance, and consciousness at the same time" (as quoted and translated in Förster 2012: 364 n. 24, from GW 9: 437).

> that world with the actual Self. Through observation it finds, on the one hand, being-there as thought and comprehends it, and, conversely, it finds being-there in its thinking. (*PhG* 586/¶ 803)

This reference to the world here apparently cannot mean the world as a whole, since Hegel writes just above that the "movement of bringing forth the form of self-knowledge is the labor which spirit accomplishes as *actual history*" (586/¶ 803). What precisely history is for Hegel is a complex question. But one thing that is clear in this context is history's distinction from *nature* in particular. Hegel treats nature as the "negative" or other of self-knowledge. Nature is the "limit" of knowledge (cf. 590/¶ 807). This implies at least that nature cannot be identified with that which is the product of the self in actual history.

We will have an opportunity to return to the topic of nature later in this book. It will certainly be important not to deny, as Hegel says, that nature is one side of spirit's "becoming" (*PhG* 590/¶ 807). That is, there can be no spiritual, cultural, or social realization without there first being bodies, organic processes, and natural desires. In this sense, nature "becomes" spirit in the human being when the human community comes to use its natural abilities to express itself in the world. Nature comes first in time, and, even after spirit's arrival, there is no ontological dualism between nature and spirit.[36]

But what is important here is that this natural genealogy of human culture and spirit is for Hegel not the same as history, which Hegel calls, explicitly in contrast with nature, "the other side of spirit's becoming," which is a "self-*mediating* becoming" (*PhG* 590/¶ 808). It follows that history, not nature, is the mode of becoming of spirit that permits the arrival of absolute knowing, and thus that absolute knowing has a restricted domain for its object. Nature will be the object of absolute knowing only in an incidental sense, insofar as nature is in some way taken up in history. But just as history, along with the "ethical substance" that is its product, is distinguished from nature, so absolute knowing is distinguished from a knowledge of everything. Absolute knowing must be restricted to that objective knowing of the world that can be plausibly construed as *self*-knowing. I believe we can see the domain of spirit as one of objective self-knowing precisely by adopting an artifactual model of that domain.

[36] Despite some disagreements in points of emphasis, the best account I know of the compatibility of nature and spirit from this perspective is Khurana 2017.

2.4 Hegelian "Work" and Artifacts

We have already seen that, in the Absolute Knowing chapter itself, Hegel uses a variety of practical and 'technical' notions to explain the possibility of absolute knowing. He speaks of spirit's "actions," he refers to the "products" of such action, and the term "realization" is ever-present. These terms hint at the "artifactual model" of absolute knowing that I will defend, though perhaps not as explicitly as one may wish.

However, earlier in the text, there is strong evidence that what makes absolute knowing possible is that the world of spirit *is* the product of human making. This point comes through at an important place in the *Phenomenology*. When Hegel first comes to say explicitly what "spirit" is, at the outset of its eponymous chapter, he writes,

> Spirit is the *Self* of the actual consciousness which it confronts, or rather which confronts itself as an objective actual *world*, but a world that has, for the Self, entirely lost the significance of something alien . . . Spirit is the *substance* and the universal, permanent essence equal-to-itself, – it is the unshakeable and indissoluble *ground* and *starting-point* for the doing of everyone, – and it is their *purpose* and *goal*, as the *in-itself*, in thought, of all self-consciousness. This substance is equally the universal *work* [*Werk*] that generates itself through the *doing* of all and everyone as their unity and equality, for it is the *being-for-itself*, the self, the doing. (*PhG* 324/¶ 438)

Hegel describes "spirit" as a kind of world in which the self confronts itself, but also as a "work" (*Werk*). It is easy to ignore Hegel's reference to "work," here and elsewhere, or to conflate these references with his discussion of "labor" (*Arbeit*). But the notions are importantly distinct.[37] I believe it is crucial to notice not only the distinction between labor and work in Hegel's thought but also that the notion of "work" in particular is central to the argument of the *Phenomenology*.

In my view, Hegel consistently maintains a conceptual distinction between work and labor not unlike the linguistic one that Hannah Arendt (1958) would later point out. Arendt observes that in a number of European languages, the words for "work" can refer to both an activity and the product of the activity (*Werk*/*wirken*, *œuvre*/*œuvrer*, etc.), while the words for "labor" (*arbeiten*, *travailler*, etc.) refer exclusively to an activity, typically the toilsome activities tied to our biological survival.[38] By contrast, "works" can be associated with a number of products that exceed the

[37] See Verene (2011: ch. 4) for a similar conception of *Werk* in Ernst Cassirer.

[38] Arendt 1958: 80 n. 3. For an alternate view on the relation of Hegel to Arendt's conception, see Matějčková 2017. As far as I know, *no* translation of Hegel (of the *Phenomenology* or other works

cyclical meeting of needs and maintain permanence beyond these cycles. This usage is preserved in expressions like "works of art," "public works," and "good works."[39] For Arendt, "work" is responsible for producing the relative stability of the "human artifice."

Since Arendt's starting observation is primarily linguistic, it is not surprising to find that Hegel's usage roughly matches the distinction she outlines (though Arendt herself argues that this distinction becomes blurred a generation after Hegel, especially in Marx). Hegel treats labor primarily in connection with the satisfaction of needs or desires.[40] The original purpose of labor is to meet a strictly individual need and so is tied to the individual's body; only later does labor become "universal," so that the labor of one can help meet the needs of another through a process of exchange. In this view of labor, Hegel is openly influenced by Adam Smith.[41] However, at least beginning in his Jena period, Hegel does not use "*Werk*" for the same or similar purpose. Instead, Hegel uses "work" to describe the products of human doing and making, in particular those products that are not produced merely for the meeting of basic material needs. Accordingly, "*Werk*" can at least occasionally be translated "artifact."[42] Yet the kind of "works" that ultimately interest Hegel are not those that simply exist in their material substrate, artifacts like tables and chairs. Rather, he is interested in the kind of works that are what they are partly due to the human and social response to them. Examples of work for Hegel include books and works of art (*Kunstwerke*) but even language and, importantly, the social world itself, what Hegel calls "ethical substance" and later "objective spirit."[43] Indeed, the artifacts that most concern Hegel are those that are objects of "social ontology" in the contemporary sense.

The most important discussion of "work" in this sense from the Jena period is in the Reason chapter of the *Phenomenology*, in the oddly titled section "The Spiritual Animal Kingdom and Deceit, or the Thing Itself."

where the terms are used) in English consistently preserves a linguistic distinction between "*Arbeit*" and "*Werk*."

[39] Luther's translation of the Pauline concept of "good works" thus uses "*Werk*." Cf., e.g., Luther's 1520 work, *Von dem guten Werken*. To this one must contrast Luther's attitude to labor, as noted by Arendt (1958: 139 n. 3). Hegel seems to use the term *Werk* in this Pauline-Lutheran sense at *PhG* 315/ ¶ 425.

[40] See especially the available fragments from Hegel's Jena lectures; e.g., "Fragment 22," *JS I* 227 ff. and in his *System of Ethical Life*, GW 5: 284 ff. This usage is maintained through the *Philosophy of Right*; e.g., *GPR* § 192, § 196, § 209.

[41] See Lukács 1975: ch. 5. [42] Inwood does this occasionally in his 2018 translation.

[43] See Alznauer 2016 on the genesis of this concept in Hegel's thought.

This section of the book is a crucial background to the reference to "work" we have already seen at the outset of the Spirit chapter.[44] In The Spiritual Animal Kingdom, Hegel sets out to explain how an individuality that is "real in itself" comes to *take herself* to be real, to gain a *concept* of her own reality (*PhG* 294/¶ 397). The answer to this question is, in brief, the individuality's "doing" (*Tun*) or "action" (*Handlung*). At the beginning of the discussion, Hegel sets out the structure of doing in its three essential parts. First, there is the "object" or "purpose" of the deed, as it is present to consciousness. Second is the "actualization" of the purpose in the "means" selected for the achievement of it. Third is the result of this actualization, where it appears in public: "The *third* moment is, finally, the object, no longer as purpose, of which the doer is immediately conscious as *its own*, but as it is out in the open [*aus ihm heraus . . . ist*] and an *other* for the doer" (*PhG* 295/¶ 400). The third element, where the action is completed *as* the actor intended, but now as its result, is what is necessary to explain why action shows the agent her own reality, for in the completed action she sees her own self expressed.

It is this third element of action or doing that Hegel eventually calls the "work," and it is this element that is mainly neglected in Kant and Fichte's conception of practical knowledge, as well as in the common reception of Anscombe's version.[45] The work is not simply the action as it was intended by the actor, but the action as it has resulted, sometimes as a produced item, as it is available to the inspection of others. As Hegel expresses the point:

> The work is the reality which consciousness gives itself; it is that in which the individual is for consciousness what he is *in himself*, and in such a manner that the consciousness *for which* the individual becomes in the work, is not particular consciousness, but *universal* consciousness; in the work in general, consciousness has ventured forth into the element of universality, into the space of Being, devoid of determinacy. (*PhG* 300/¶ 405)

The work is the point at which the individuality and subjectivity of consciousness becomes "universal" (in the sense of being open to all) and objective, existing outside of the actor. One senses in Hegel's discussion of work his own experience of being an author. An author expresses himself in

[44] Though I do not wish to rest too much on considerations of textual history, Hegel's original plan for the *Phenomenology* involved moving directly from the Reason chapter to Absolute Knowing. This suggests that the discussion of "work" is at a more decisive moment, at least in the *epistemological* story that Hegel planned to tell. (See on this Forster 1998: ch. 13 and Förster 2012: ch. 14.) The addition of the Spirit and Religion chapters do not negate but corroborate this significance.

[45] For an exception, see Haase 2013, 2018.

his work, in his writing; but the worth and value of the book lie not solely in what the author intended but how the work exists in its reception. This part of the work is, notoriously, out of one's hands.

Importantly, then, Hegel's does *not* believe that the maker, or author for that matter, has perfect knowledge of the "work" she has made. In many places, Hegel emphasizes that intentions do not preexist the action or production but can only be known, even by the actor, from the deed itself (cf. *PhG* 296–7/¶ 401).[46] Moreover, since the actor typically compares the initial, universal purpose with the singular and determinate "work," she is left unsatisfied by it (301/¶ 405). The work is marred by details and contingencies not present in the intention alone: the work as intended is "vanishing" (303/¶ 408). Finally, the work stands before "other individualities" (300–1/¶ 405). Their own interests and purposes obscure the intended purpose of the original maker. In short, in the work, or at least in some works, "concept and reality again separate from each other" (302/¶ 407). This way of putting the point is suggestive indeed.

But this is not the end of the story for Hegel, for it is not necessary that a work's purpose goes unfulfilled and unrecognized. He also describes what he calls the "true work," or the "very thing at issue" (*die Sache selbst*).[47] He writes:

> Truth consists solely in the unity of consciousness with the doing, and the *true work* is only that unity of *doing and Being*, of *willing* and *achieving* . . .. In this way, then, consciousness affirms its concept and certainty as what *is* and *endures* in the face of experience of the contingency of doing; it experiences in fact its concept, in which actuality is only a moment . . .. This unity is the true work; the work is the *very thing at issue* [*die* Sache selbst], which affirms itself completely and is experienced as that which endures, independently of the issue that is the *contingency* of the individual doing as such, the contingency of the circumstances, means, and actuality. (*PhG* 303–4/¶ 409, slightly modified)

[46] This "retrospective" (and even retroactive) dimension of intention is emphasized by Pippin 2008a: ch. 6, 2008b, and Brandom 2019: ch. 11. See Alznauer (2015: 115–16, 152) for an account that tempers this dimension.

[47] There is no fully satisfying translation of "*Sache*" or "*Sache selbst*" that I am aware of. Inwood translates "*Sache*" with "Thing," and it has also been translated as "the matter at hand" (Miller) and "the crux of the matter" (Pinkard). Though "issue" (or "thing at issue") is imperfect, I prefer it for a few reasons. First, "*Sache*" is frequently involved in genitive constructions that suggest that a "*Sache*" must belong to someone or other, or a collective. An "issue" is something that is for or of someone in this sense as well. Second, "issue" has the sense of something that is brought forth or produced: *x* issues from *y*. Since "*Sache*" is associated with something produced (i.e., the true work), this is a nice connection. Finally, since "*Sache*" and "*Ding*" could sometimes be exchanged in ordinary German usage (see *PhG* 304/¶ 410), I typically use "*thing* at issue" to account for the similarity between the terms. Cf. Hegel's remark on the term at *GPR* § 42R.

The "very thing at issue" is the work that achieves what it does, freed of arbitrary contingencies. This "thing at issue" is what it is as something intended and conceptualized; Hegel thus calls it a "spiritual" (*geistige*) essentiality rather than a mere "thing" (*Ding*) (304/¶ 410). In the thing at issue, "self-consciousness has come into a possession of its true concept of itself, or has attained to consciousness of its substance" (304/¶ 410). To see this work is to see one's own concept as realized, even in the face of contingency. Hegel freely draws on the language about concepts being realized when discussing the "thing at issue."

Hegel is not very explicit in the context of just what sort of work a "thing at issue" is, and the passage is lacking in examples. But I do think the passage suggests that appropriate examples are objects of *social ontology* – those 'things' that exist partially due to the achievements of a community.[48] Hegel himself says that the thing at issue is "an essence whose *Being* is the *doing* of the *single* individual and of all individuals, and whose doing is immediately *for others*, or is a *thing at issue* and is only a thing at issue as the *doing of each* and *everyone*; the essence which is the essence of all essences, the *spiritual essence*" (PhG 310/¶ 418). This kind of "work," here thematized as a "thing at issue," occupied Hegel in fragments a few years prior to the *Phenomenology*. In a difficult passage from those fragments, he writes:

> The spirit of the people must eternally become the WORK [*zum WERKE*], or it *is* only as an eternally becoming of the spirit. It has become the work when activity is posited within which is hereby against it; and this activity against it is immediately the sublating of itself . . .. [A]nd since this common work of all is their work as being-conscious as such [*Bewußtseiender überhaupt*], they become therein something external; but this external [something] is their deed, <u>it is only what they have made it, it is they themselves as active</u>, sublated; and in this externality of their self, in their being as sublated, as means [*Mitte*] they intuit themselves as one people [*Ein Volk*], and this their work is *thereby* their own spirit itself. (*JS* I 224)

It looks like Hegel is describing a people's conscious activity resulting in something external and objective that somehow allows them to recognize themselves in it. In the same context, Hegel uses the term "ethical work" (*sittliche Werk*) to describe his subject matter (*JS* I 225). Surprisingly, the main example of a "work" he discusses in the context is *language*.[49] A language is a work or "thing at issue" that is what it is as both subjective

[48] See Section 6.4 for more discussion of this theme.
[49] Hegel uses language, or at least speech, as an instance of work in the *PhG* at 240/¶ 319.

and objective expression. Roughly speaking, it "is only what [a people] have made it." It is, we may say, a social artifact.[50]

Language is not the only relevant example of a "true work" we can find in Hegel's Jena period. In discussing the failures of the "absolute freedom" of the French Revolution, Hegel says that this movement "cannot arrive at any positive work, neither universal works of language nor of actuality, neither at laws and universal arrangements of *conscious* freedom, nor at deeds and works of *willing* freedom" (*PhG* 434/¶ 588). Here we get the impression that laws and institutions of freedom are relevant examples of "works." Later in the *PhG*, especially in the Religion chapter, Hegel also discusses the work of art in similar terms, emphasizing the connection of a work of art to its concept. The true or "absolute" work of art "give[s] birth to itself from its concept . . . [has] its very concept for its shape, so that the concept and the work of art [*Kunstwerk*] produced know each other mutually as one and the same" (514/¶ 702). Such activity "has made the pathos into its own material and given itself its content, and this unity emerges as a work, as universal spirit individualized and represented" (515/¶ 704). Like a language, a work of art is more than a bare material artifact; it is infused with a meaning or concept. It is a social artifact, but also a concept-dependent object.

And we have already seen, most generally of all, that shortly after introducing the main discussion of "work" we have just witnessed, Hegel says:

> Spirit is the *substance* and the universal, permanent essence equal-to-itself, – it is the unshakeable and indissoluble *ground* and *starting-point* for the doing of everyone, – and it is their *purpose* and *goal*, as the *in-itself*, in thought, of all self-consciousness. This substance is equally the universal *work* [*Werk*] that generates itself through the *doing* of all and everyone as their unity and equality, for it is the *being-for-itself*, the self, the doing. (*PhG* 324/¶ 438)

There is thus a clear line from Hegel's model of "work," at first with all the contingencies of its production, to the notion of a true work or "thing at issue."[51] In this model the true work is the realization of a concept in and as

[50] For a contemporary view of language as an artifact, see Evnine 2016: 4.4.3.

[51] Some have expressed skepticism here about the central role I give to the "work" and the "thing at issue," given the fact that they are intermediate stages in Hegel's *Phenomenology*, both of which seem to reveal some inadequacy. I answer, first, that Hegel himself refers to spirit as a work without hesitation or qualification. Second, it is not obvious to me that Hegel sees an essential defect in the "thing at issue" in its role of presenting the unity of concept and object, even if the Spirit chapter is needed to fill in the details in terms of historical shapes. Finally, if one considers the common text-developmental hypothesis discussed above (note 44, this chapter), the "thing at issue" is closer to a culminating concept than it might otherwise appear.

an object in which the concept can be recognized. In particular, the object can be recognized by many or "all" who participate in its creation: its *fellow-minded makers*.

2.5 The Artifactual Basis of Absolute Knowing

The Absolute Knowing chapter can be seen as tying two strands of the *Phenomenology* together. First, we have the model of the goal of knowing: a state in which concept and object are perfectly suited, when a concept is recognized in an object. This strand is outlined in the *Phenomenology*'s Introduction. Second, we have the model of at least *some* artifacts or works as the realization of concepts, often through a social collective that can recognize itself in the products of its activity. The Absolute Knowing chapter shows us that the first strand can be completed only if we understand the second strand. In other words, there is such a thing as absolute knowing because certain objects in our world can be plausibly understood as being of "our" making. These are the social artifacts of spirit or *Geist*, which make up the recognizably human world, insofar as it is conceptually constituted.

Let us lay out the basic line of thought leading from Hegel's model of spirit as artifact to the realization of absolute knowing at the end of his work:

(a) Human action and production is (or can be) implicitly guided by the attempt to realize certain conceptually articulable ends or goals. (This point is shared between Hegel, Kant, and Fichte.)
(b) Thus, some of what humans "make" involves the implicit realization of concepts. In this sense, their production involves some kind of practical knowledge or cognition.
(c) We can think of the structures and institutions of a given social world of artifacts in this sense. No individual makes them according to their own representations, but individuals can recognize their being made as realizations of ends or concepts.
(d) However, this realization of concepts is typically implicit and not recognized *as* the realization of the human mind. Religious consciousness is a consciousness of the humanly made world, but not *as* made.
(e) It is possible, however, to have explicit conceptual knowledge of implicitly conceptual productions, including the basic structure of the "spiritual" or cultural world itself. This knowledge is "absolute" because it is a knowledge in which concept and object are fully transparent: what is known and what *is* are one and the same.

(f) Absolute knowledge is not, then, a knowledge of everything; for knowledge can only be absolute in the domain that is itself an implicit realization of conceptuality.

This amounts to an artifactual model of absolute knowing. Like the humanism of Vico, it extends the ordinary idea that makers have a special knowledge of what they make to the novel application of the social, historical world. Though no one of us individually is responsible for the social world, nor even are we collectively responsible as contemporaries (since the world we know has also preexisted us), we can regard certain worldly achievements as constituted by the very concepts we employ when we later come to represent the world. We must realize that these concepts are not *mere* representations. They are something like the constitutive ground of the human world.

It is important to emphasize, however, that not every historical and social artifact will, for Hegel, be considered the realization of a (or "the") concept. For example, in Hegel's discussion of the tension between "wealth" and "state-power," he writes of the consciousness for which wealth is the dominant consideration: "Therefore, although this consciousness gets back from wealth the objectivity of being-for-itself and sublates it, it is not only . . . *not completed in accordance with its concept, but is unsatisfied for consciousness itself*" (*PhG* 382/¶ 517, my emphasis). It seems that the inadequacy of some institutions in spiritual or cultural worlds (such as those involving a dominance of wealth) can be diagnosed partly by their *not* being conceptually adequate. A similar point is made later in Hegel's *Philosophy of Right*, when he writes that in Roman law "there could be no definition of 'human being,' since 'slave' could not be brought under it – the very status of slave indeed violates the concept of the human being; it would appear just as hazardous to attempt a definition of 'property' and 'proprietor' in many cases" (*GPR* § 2, 31/18). Here again, we cannot assume simply because the institution of slavery is in some sense an artifact that it is the realization of a concept. Rather, the contrary can be true: the institution of slavery could make it impossible to *have* an adequate concept of human beings. Such examples make it clear that, while we can assume that Hegel allows that our social world is, or can be, the realization of conceptuality, we should not assume that the mere representation of a given social phenomena secures its status as the rational realization of a concept.[52] Even so, we cannot have absolute knowledge, on my reading of Hegel, unless

[52] In this chapter, I will not be able to demarcate the way to distinguish genuinely conceptual realizations from those that are not. It is simply important to bear in mind that some such distinction must be made, on Hegel's view.

certain practices have been historically effected. Actual history is not incidental to Hegel's view of even philosophical knowledge.

Accordingly, the idea of absolute knowledge is not a generic truth about the relation of "subject" and "object" or "thought" and "being." Absolute knowledge is made possible through a historical process that can be seen as actually realizing conceptually articulate ends, ends that contemporaries can recognize as their own. Crucially, this depends on the possibility that contemporaries can have the very concepts that express what these historical realities are, so that they can *share* conceptual knowledge over time.[53] It depends on us being 'fellow-minded' makers of our worlds (something that cannot be taken for granted). It is when a contemporary subject has *this* kind of relation to *that* kind of social and historical process that absolute knowing can be available to that subject. Only then can concepts and objects be completely adequate to one another. The pedagogical aim of Hegel's *Phenomenology* is to enable his contemporaries to have such a cognitive relation to the existing historical world.[54]

Importantly, since the subject's knowledge is a kind of shared maker's knowledge, there is a sense in which the subject's knowledge of the conceptually articulate social and cultural artifactual world *is* akin to the kind of divine knowledge that is frequently *opposed* to humanly available knowledge (recall Tolley 2018). For if God's knowledge of nature is simply the maker's knowledge of an artifact, then the case in which we have maker's knowledge of the artifactual world of human culture will be similar in kind to the divine sort.

We are, no doubt, left with questions here, and especially regarding the guiding element of this reconstruction of absolute knowing: namely, the Concept. For it is only when the Concept is realized in the world that we can be said to have a relation of absolute knowledge to it. Though the

[53] For an account illuminating what happens when this presupposition fails, see Lear 2017.

[54] My emphasis on the artifactual basis of absolute knowing separates me from other "deflationary" readings of absolute knowledge, which take it to be a more generally available characteristic of knowing. Though not intending an exegesis of Hegel per se, Rödl 2018, for example, sees absolute idealism as consisting in the identity of absolute and *empirical* knowledge: "Yet absolute knowledge is nothing at all unless it is knowledge of that which is known empirically and by means of the senses. Indeed, absolute knowledge must itself provide for its comprehension as knowledge of what is known empirically: in knowing what we know originally, or absolutely, we must comprehend ourselves to know the very reality that is the object of empirical knowledge" (2018: 17–18). Similarly, Pippin (1989: 168) writes that absolute knowing is "the conditions of human knowing 'absolutized,' no longer threatened by Kant's thing-in-itself skepticism." I cannot see how history would be required for either of these accounts of absolute knowing.

Phenomenology itself has a number of important things to say about this topic, to see Hegel's full and mature view of the matter we must turn to the *Science of Logic*. What the material from the *Phenomenology* has given us, I hope, is a firmer sense of at least one interpretive area where a theory of concepts has a role to play, namely in explaining our relation to the human world. It is this dimension that I aim to show *remains in play* when we turn to the more abstract characterization of the *Logic*.

CHAPTER 3

The Concept as Form of Thought

Hegel's *Phenomenology* is not only filled with references to conceptuality, but concepts can even seem to be one of the central topics of that book.[1] We have seen that an understanding of concepts is essential to an understanding of absolute knowing. For absolute knowing is in some way a *conceptual* knowing of the world that is also the realization of concepts. Hegel frequently expresses this kind of point with a singular reference to "the Concept" (*der Begriff*). It must be admitted that this usage can often sound strange. On the one hand, Hegel uses this term to refer to something that seems quite close at hand to the knowing subject, even as a reference to something that simply *is* a subject's knowledge, as Hegel seems to say in Absolute Knowing:

> for this concept is, as we see, the knowledge of the self's own doing within itself as knowledge of all essentiality and all being-there, the knowledge of *this subject* as *the substance* and of the substance as this knowledge of its doing. (*PhG* 582/¶ 797)

> In knowledge, then, spirit has concluded the movement of giving shape to itself. . . . Spirit has won the pure element of its being-there, the concept. (*PhG* 588/¶ 805)

Though these passages refer to the Concept as if it were something already known to his readers, he also elucidates the notion with obscure phrases that make it sound completely foreign. For example, he writes that the nature of the Concept "is the undifferentiated which absolutely sunders itself" (419/¶ 565). Even more bewilderingly, he writes, "This simple infinity, or the absolute concept, is to be called the simple essence of life, the soul of the world, the universal bloodstream, which is omnipresent,

[1] This is the basic interpretive thesis of Brandom 2019. I disagree with him that Hegel's project in the *Phenomenology* has something to do with providing a general explanation of conceptual content. As I will argue, Hegel's main interest in the Concept concerns philosophical conceptuality in particular, not semantic content in general.

neither dulled nor interrupted by any difference, which is instead itself both every difference as well as their sublatedness" (132/¶ 162). What could Hegel be referring to in a passage such as this? And how could this "absolute concept" maintain its connection to thought and knowledge that seems to be so important to its other occurrences?

Almost a decade after *Phenomenology* was completed, in 1816, Hegel published the third book of his *Science of Logic*: *The Doctrine of the Concept* (*Die Lehre vom Begriff*), also called the "Subjective Logic." It is here (and in its *Encyclopedia* counterpart, first published in 1817), or so one might think, that we receive a complete treatment of the elusive "concept of the Concept." However, perhaps no question is more controversial in the recent attempts to interpret the *Doctrine of the Concept* as that of what its subject matter even is.[2] Hegel's understanding of the basic sense of "the Concept" remains much in dispute. As I mentioned in Chapter 1, commentators are divided in a few central ways. In contrast to the view I will present, some scholars treat "the Concept" as a term of art for a monistic metaphysical entity that is realizing itself in or as the world as a whole, as part of a "post-Kantian Spinozism."[3]

But is Hegel's *Doctrine of the Concept* about such an entity? And if so, what would that say about the possibility of absolute or even "conceptual" knowledge for *us*? Recall that knowing in general, and absolute knowing in particular, depends for Hegel on there being a kind of coincidence of *concept* and the *object* – so that what is known and the knowing of it meet in one. We said earlier that this required satisfying the *immediacy-of-thought* condition. Yet if what Hegel calls the Concept is *itself* a metaphysical entity, which we may or may not know, it is hard to see how the activity of that entity could redound to *us* as knowing at all, much less "absolute" knowing. The monistic reading of the Concept threatens to destroy the rich epistemic confidence we have gathered from Hegel in the last chapter.[4]

But there are numerous positive textual reasons to associate the Concept with a power of thinking that we can actually exercise. Hegel writes, "This concept is not intuited by the senses, is not represented in the imagination; it is only subject matter, the product and content of *thought*" (*WL* I 30/19). Perhaps the most relevant systematically are the numerous places where Hegel stresses the relation of what he calls "representations" (*Vorstellungen*) to genuine concepts, especially in the introduction the *EL*. He writes that

[2] Pippin 2019: 18. [3] See Houlgate 2021: 132.

[4] Reading the Concept in a more metaphysical way can be motivated by its systematic place in the *Logic*. I will consider this issue in the next chapter. Until then, I will put forth my positive view without trying to explain how it fits in the *Logic* as a whole.

"in the order of time consciousness produces *representations* of objects before it produces *concepts* of them; and that *thinking* spirit only advances to thinking cognition and comprehension [*Begreifen*] by going *through* representation and by converting itself to it" (EL § 1, 41/24). In the same text, Hegel says that concepts "transform" representations (§ 20 R) or "take the place" of them (§ 3 R). The content of a representation is thus altered in conceptual thinking (§ 22) but is clearly related to it. Hegel strongly emphasis that "this thinking is *my* activity, this true nature [of the object] is also the *product of my spirit*, [of me] as thinking subject" (§ 23). It is hard to see how concepts and conceptual thinking, so considered, could be severed from the thinking capacities of human minds.

The central task of this chapter is to defend a reading of Hegel's "Concept" that shows it to be a reference to the activity of recognizably human, philosophical thought. In this sense, Hegel's "Concept" is not simply a technical term or term of art, and, despite some passages that appear to suggest the opposite, it maintains strong connections to its ordinary philosophical meaning. By saying that Hegel's "Concept" has a connection to human thought, I do not mean to imply that we should think of Hegel's *Doctrine of the Concept* in psychological terms, as if it were an attempt to portray states or acts of human thought as such. Better to say that Hegel attempts to give an account of thought that is *neutral* on the question of who its thinker is, since it considers only the *form* of such thought.[5] Even so, I think it is valuable to show that, despite this neutrality, this kind of thought is not alien to human beings. Neutrality is not negation: the fact that the *Doctrine of the Concept* is not *about* human psychological processes (since it does not include additional anthropological detail that is appropriate for the Philosophy of Subjective Spirit) does not mean it cannot be *recognizable* in certain human psychological processes.

As far as the present chapter is concerned, then, Hegel's account of the Concept need not weigh in on metaphysical issues as such. What I say should thus be compatible with a more Kantian reading of the Concept, which takes it as *ultimately* grounded in human subjectivity. However, in my view, the important questions about the objectivity and truth of the Concept are not yet answered by this part of the account alone.

I will begin the chapter (Section 3.1) by responding to passages that appear to suggest otherwise. Hegel clearly distinguishes his understanding

[5] Cf. Nuzzo 2016 and Pippin 2019: 17 n. 28. By contrast, McNulty 2023 advocates a view in which the activity of thinking subjects is *subtracted* from the account until such activity is deduced as a form of being.

of the "Concept" from some common assumptions about concepts, or what he calls "representations" (*Vorstellungen*). I first argue that none of Hegel's criticisms of the standard conception of concepts imply that his account of the Concept does not apply to recognizably human (philosophical) thought. I then (Section 3.2) attempt to explain his singular use of "the Concept." I defend the view that this usage is *synechdochal* for the active power of thought that is employed not primarily in ordinary experience but in the kind of philosophical thought that produces *distinctions*. It is the comprehensiveness of this power that enables it in some way to be about 'everything.' Finally, in Section 3.3 and its subsections, I go into some detail about the formal structure of the Concept: what Hegel calls the "moments" of universality, particularity, and singularity. Hegel's treatment of these moments, I believe, is central to everything he says in the *Doctrine of the Concept*.

3.1 Hegel's Critique of the Standard Conception of Concepts

There are strong prima facie reasons to expect that Hegel's use of "Concept" is compatible with a more ordinary one. Hegel's *Doctrine of the Concept* begins with a treatment of "concept," "judgment," and "syllogism," and this corresponds, at least superficially, to the organization of logics from Christian Wolff through Kant and to Hegel's contemporaries like J. F. Fries. Accordingly, in the introduction to the *Doctrine of the Concept*, he writes, "there already exists for the logic of the *concept* a fully ready and well-entrenched, one may even say ossified, material." This would seem to suggest that Hegel shares a subject matter with these previous logics. Rather than the innovative work undertaken in the so-called Objective Logic, he says that here "the task is to make [sc. this old material] fluid again, to revive the concept in such a dead matter" (*WL* II 243/507). It would be a curious way to modify and "make fluid" an existing tradition of logic to alter its subject matter entirely. And, indeed, Hegel makes his intention to refer to "concepts" in a recognizable sense even more explicit, stating: "The concept as deduced here should in principle be recognized in whatever else is adduced as such a concept" (*WL* II 252/514). And: "However great the distance between the concept of formal logic and the speculative concept may be, a more careful consideration will still show *that the deeper significance of the concept is in no way so alien to general linguistic usage as it might seem to be at first sight*" (*EL* § 160Z, 308/237, my emphasis). He even commonly speaks of concepts as the *products* of thought (see *WL* I 30/19).

Despite this, not only some of the curious remarks we have already encountered but also some of Hegel's further disparaging statements about the common understanding of concepts have led readers to suggest that the connection between Hegel's *Concept Logic* and the traditional meaning of concepts is mainly superficial. Clearly, if Hegel's "Concept" is implicitly a reference to God,[6] or to natural kinds,[7] or to a Spinozian substance-subject,[8] Hegel's *Doctrine of the Concept* would share little in common with other works dealing with "concepts." But that impression is bolstered by remarks such as the following:

> What is usually understood by "concepts" are *determinations* of the *understanding*, or even just general *notions* [*Vorstellungen*]; hence such "concepts" are always *finite* determinations (cf. § 62). (*EL* § 162 R, 310/239)

> What are also called concepts, and, to be sure, determinate concepts, e.g. human being, house, animal, and so forth, are simple determinations and abstract representations [*Vorstellungen*], – abstractions that, taking only the moment of universality from the concept . . . are thus not developed in themselves and accordingly abstract precisely from the concept. (*EL* § 164 R, 314–15/242)

> The *distinct* concept is supposed to be one whose *mark* [sic. *Merkmale*] can be given. But then it is, strictly speaking, the *determinate concept*. The mark, when taken in its strict signification, is nothing else than the *determinateness* or the simple *content* of the concept in so far as the latter is distinguished from the form of universality. But the *mark* does not quite have at first this more precise meaning; it is generally taken as only a determination by which a *third party* takes note [*merkt*] of a subject matter or of the concept. (*WL* II 290/541–2)

> If we stop at white, red, as representations *of the senses*, then we call concept what is only a determination of representation [*Vorstellungsbestimmung*]. This is common practice. (*WL* II 321–2/564, modified)

Some scholars have concluded from such passages that Hegel has little interest in concepts in any ordinary sense.[9] Instead, Hegel must be using "Concept" to refer to one of the objectively existing entities mentioned above.

[6] Thus could Düsing's (1976: 232) position be taken: "The Concept is namely for him the one substance in the manner of self-thinking and freedom. . . . [T]he Concept or Subjectivity *has for him the significance of the highest being* and all being" (my emphasis). See also Moss 2020: 336.

[7] See Stern 2009; Kreines 2015; Knappik 2016.

[8] Cf. Düsing (1986: 279): "The Concept is thus not to be considered as a traditional *conceptus communis*, not as a discursive concept and analytical idea of manifold differences, but as the spontaneous, self-referential subjectivity which has emerged from the (spinozistically considered) One Substance and its actuosity." I owe this reference to Sell 2013: 206.

[9] See Bowman 2013: 32; Horstmann 2017: 133–4.

I think this conclusion is too quick. I contend that Hegel's criticism of traditional views of concepts is restricted in its scope. Put simply, his criticism is that the traditional view conflates concepts with "representations" (*Vorstellungen*), and in so doing misses the distinctive nature of philosophical thought, which deals with concepts and conceptual thought in a special way. As I mentioned in Chapter 1, Hegel uses "representation" to refer to psychological states the content of which is typically generalized from the matter of sensible intuition. To have a "representation" of a house, say, means to be able to recognize a sensible mark common to houses. Both in Hegel's day and in our own, the word "concept" is used to refer to such representations. As a matter of usage, there can be nothing wrong with this. We can use words how we like, so long as we can make distinctions clear. It may have been better if Hegel had conceded the use of "concept" to what he calls representations, while determining the kind of concepts that interest him in a different way, perhaps 'philosophical concepts.'[10] But the substance of Hegel's complaint is that in using the word "concept" *both* for representations and for philosophical concepts, one is likely to ignore relevant distinctions. One is likely to think that concepts *as such* are not philosophically crucial, just because this may be true of (what Hegel calls) representations.

The conflation of concepts and representations leads to three ancillary assumptions being made about concepts; call them "standard assumptions" (SAs). These assumptions may be true about representations as such, but they are problematic when applied to concepts of philosophical interest. Hegel's predecessors and contemporaries commonly relied on just such assumptions in their discussion of concepts. (See footnotes corresponding to each SA for a sample of relevant citations.) The SAs are as follows:

> (SA 1): *Any general representation is a concept*.[11] Even if a singular concept is considered possible, a general mental representation is necessarily a concept. If a representation is sufficient to reidentify something, or identify several things of a type, it is a concept.
>
> (SA 2): *The content of concepts is a sensible mark or characteristic of several individuals*.[12] Concepts are classifications that unify sensible material. They

[10] Thanks to Mark Alznauer for this suggestion and for helpful conversation on these topics.

[11] See Kant, Ak. 9: 91; Wolff 1713: §§ 28–9; Fries 1811: § 19. In the Leibnizian tradition, of course, all general representations are concepts a fortiori, since all singular representations are concepts as well.

[12] See Kant Ak. 9: 92/1992, 590; A 68/B 93; B 33. See Wolff's (1713: § 4) characterization: "I have a concept of the sun, e.g., when I can represent it in my thought, *either through an image* . . . or through mere words by which I can understand *what I perceive of the sun*" (1713: 123, my emphasis). Wolff gives a basic account of abstraction in terms of commonality and distinction in his 1751: § 286.

are essentially *abstract* in that they *omit* a number of secondary characteristics of the individuals they classify.

(SA 3): *Conceptual content is atomistic*.[13] Since concepts derive their content from the individual marks of the objects they classify, their content is determined only by the properties of the objects in their extension. Therefore, the contents of concepts are not dependent on the contents of others.

Suppose Hegel rejects SA 1–3, as seems clear from the quotations above. Does this suggest that he cannot maintain a view of concepts that is in some way consistent with a traditional philosophical account? Not at all. The standard assumptions can be safely rejected without abandoning a recognizable philosophical account of concepts. Let us consider Hegel's response to each point in some detail.

Hegel's rejection of SA 1, that a concept is *any* general representation, requires the most care. The common interpretation of Hegel's "conceptualism" in light of the influential challenge to "Sense Certainty" in the *Phenomenology* seems to entail that the generality of a meaning or representation is *eo ipso* conceptual. That is, interpreters often gloss Hegel's suggestion that we cannot receive material purely from the senses without the mediating role of general terms like "here," "now," "this," and so on as a claim that sense experience is thoroughly conceptual.[14] This view implies that a general representation in thought is alone sufficient to be a concept. Yet as the quotations above indicate, Hegel frequently refuses to consider mere universals as concepts. He disputes the common practice of designating as concepts any representation that is common to several things: "What are also called concepts, and indeed determinate concepts, for instance, man, house, animal, etc., are simple determinations and abstract representations" (*EL* § 164 R, 324–15/242). By "abstract" here, Hegel refers to the fact that the general representation is acquired by *omitting* features found in singular cases of a term (*WL* II 258/518). A concept is available, on this view, in any case such a selective omission can be performed with at least

[13] This view is explicit in Leibniz, though it is arguably implicit in Kant's abstraction theory of concept formation. It also seems implicit in Kant's argument for a special class of "relational" concepts ("concepts of reflection") in the "Amphiboly" chapter of the first *Critique*. Fries largely adopts Kant's understanding of the dependence of concepts on intuitions, though intuitions arguably play an even clearer foundational role for Fries, as "immediate representation[s] that are clear on [their] own" (1811: § 5). Clear intuitions could play the role of atomistic primitives for Fries.

[14] DeVries (2008: 68) claims, "In the 'Sense-Certainty' chapter of the *Phenomenology*, Hegel gives us an argument to show that we cannot avoid the *this-such*. Every *this* is, in fact, already (if only implicitly) a *this-such*. And thus every *this* is conceptual in a fairly straightforward way." I argue this view should be rejected in Wolf 2019b.

two objects. In that case, concepts are both plentiful (since they depend only on perceptible similarities between things) and, in terms of content, superfluous, however useful they may be for keeping track of things. For the content of abstract general representations is reducible to the content of singular representations: nothing more could be "in common" to many than could be present in one. By contrast, Hegel thinks the notion of a concept should be reserved for something that differs in content from what is available in singular intuition. To have a concept of something in addition to a mere representation of something is an achievement of understanding or *comprehending* (*Begreifen*).[15] To have a concept, for Hegel, is to *know* something, not just to possess a reliable ability to classify objects of a certain kind. If so, then our use of concepts is not as common as our thoughts containing general representations, or our use of words.[16] For this reason, though it is a necessary condition that concepts are universal representations, it is in no way sufficient. Concepts, as achievements of understanding, are rarer in our thought than the standard model permits. Hegel even says that "ordinary life has no concepts, only representations of the imagination [*Vorstellungen*]" (*WL* II 406/628).[17] Thus, it is significant to note that Hegel is not attempting to use his concept theory to provide, say, a theory of linguistic meaning or even the involvement of linguistic or representational capacities in ordinary perception.[18]

Assuming SA 1, SA 2, which credits sensible marks as the basic source of conceptual content, is the most common explanation for what a general representation is. Once Hegel gives up SA 1 from the standard conception, it is clear he does not need SA 2 for its explanation. But Hegel's rejection of the second assumption goes further than this: Hegel tries to sever the

[15] "But the objects of consciousness ought not to remain so simple, ought not to remain representations or abstract thought determinations, but should rather become *conceptualized* [*begriffen*], that is, their simplicity should be determined together with their inner difference" (*WL* II 291/542). Interestingly, Kant credits only a certain class of concepts, "concepts of reason," with comprehension (*Begreifen*) in contrast to the concepts of understanding (*Verstehen*) involved in mere perception (see A 311/B 367).

[16] The converse relation holds, however: "It is the privilege of philosophy to choose such expressions from the language of ordinary life, which is made for the world of imaginary representations, as *seem to approximate* the determinations of the concept" (*WL* II 406/628).

[17] See *WL* II 282–3/536 for an explicit statement of the greater diversity of natural species than the diversity of concepts.

[18] This, of course, points to a problem with readings of Hegel as a "conceptualist" in the philosophy of perception, à la John McDowell (1994), who maintains that color terms, for example, correspond to concepts (Hegel rejects this explicitly at *WL* II 320–1/564). From a different angle, Robert Brandom's (1994, 2002, 2019) inferentialism proliferates concepts beyond Hegel's allowance by attempting to derive a general theory of linguistic meaning from Hegel. See Hösle 2010 for a similar criticism.

connection between sensibility and conceptual content at its roots. This is a significant departure from the standard conception of concepts, which, even in its non-empiricist versions, tends to assume that the senses are the starting point for conceptuality. It is, for example, precisely because of the *anomaly* of their non-sensuous content that Kant has to provide a special "deduction" for the pure categories of the understanding (even despite their sensuous application conditions). One of the most unique features of Hegel's theory of conceptuality, by contrast, is his denial that sensibility has *any direct relation* to conceptual content (see Section 3.3.3).[19] Given that he seems to think generic (nonconceptual) mental representations are sufficient to represent abstract contents of sense, concepts proper must, in every case, have something further to them than such sense contents.[20]

Connected to his rejection of the notion that concepts represent abstract sense contents is his rejection of concepts as nominal definitions.[21] Since Locke, nominal definitions are regarded as classificatory principles that are sufficient to pick out objects designated by a given name. Nominal definitions are what must be attached to mere words so they can qualify as concepts at all. Nevertheless, since nominal definitions only provide criteria to pick out objects that fall under a name, they retain the abstractness criticized above. Hegel points out that the "marks" (*Merkmale*) given in a nominal definition are at best only *subjectively sufficient* characteristics for an individual to recognize an object;[22] they say nothing about that object's nature or essence.[23] Moreover, nominal definitions taken thus subjectively should consistently differ on the basis of the psychological constitution required for the object's recognition; with a nominal definition "it is a mere accident, a historical fact, what is understood by a name" (*WL* II 303/551). A blind person's "concept" of a cactus will deal primarily with its prickly and hazardous texture, while a seeing person's may also include its typically

[19] A key word being "direct" because of the circuitous connection between *Vorstellungen* (representations tied to sensibility) and *Begriffe* (cf. *EL* § 1), which allows Hegel to endorse the doctrine that nothing is in the intellect that is not first in the senses (*EL* § 8R). He (characteristically) reverses the dictum in the same context, however, emphasizing just as well the priority of the intellect over the sensible.

[20] In his logic lectures of 1810/11, Hegel refuses to call apprehension by means of sensation "thinking" (for him a still weaker act than comprehending): "To the extent that we apprehend the sensory manifold, we do not yet think, but rather only the relating of that manifold is thinking. We call the immediate apprehending of the manifold feeling or sensing" (W 4: 163).

[21] See *WL* II 511–19/706–13 for the systematic context.

[22] "In this view, to abstract means to select from a concrete material *this or that mark, but only for our subjective purposes*" (*WL* II 258/518).

[23] This is why Kant can admit that we have nominal definitions yet no "real definitions" (at least of empirical objects), which would represent the nature or essence of something. See Kant, Ak. 9: 143–4/1992: 634.

green color. Hegel likes to joke that the "concept" of a human could, *qua* nominal definition, contain the condition of having earlobes (*WL* II 516/711), since that is sufficient for us to subjectively distinguish humans from other animals. Such conditions tell us more about our epistemic needs than they do about the objects falling under the concept.

Hegel would not, of course, deny that humans possess mental representations serving just such subjective functions,[24] nor does he deny that sensations are genetically prior to concepts per se. In fact, he admits this specifically:

> Intuition or being are no doubt first in the order of nature, or are the condition for the concept, but they are not for all that the unconditioned in and for itself . . .. If it is not the *truth* which is at issue but only *narration*, as it is the case in pictorial and phenomenal thinking, then we might as well stay with the story that we begin with feelings and intuitions, and that the understanding then extracts a universal or an abstraction from their manifold. (*WL* II 260/519)

While Hegel does not deny the value of developing a "narration" of the genetic origin of concepts, he claims that it does little to address an additional purpose a theory of concepts may serve, namely an explanation of the *truth* of cognition. For this purpose, Hegel suggests, the involvement of sensory content in concepts has little to add.

The final standard assumption (SA 3) claims that conceptual content is built up of primitives that do not involve further conceptual relations. This view is again implicit in the idea that concepts are formed by a process of abstraction from singular, nonconceptual individuals. Instead, it is widely agreed that Hegel accepts a *holistic* view of conceptual content. Upon rejecting the "extensional" foundation of concepts in mere abstraction, so that all differences in concepts could be reduced to differences in marks of objects, Hegel is barred from an atomistic view of conceptual content. What remains, then, is a form of conceptual holism – a view according to which the content of a concept is at least partly determined by its relation to other concepts. Though it is not easy to define the precise nature of Hegel's holism, it is hard to deny its presence in his thought: "To be sure, any determinate concept is *empty* in so far as it does not contain the totality, but only a one-sided determinateness" (*WL* II 285/538). Indeed, Hegel suggests that part of what it means to see something *as* conceptual is to be able to connect its abstract form to a more universal unity: "the

[24] Indeed, he devotes *EPG* §§ 387–482 ("Subjective Mind") to just such issues.

abstract determinate is posited as one with universality and, for this reason, *not for itself* (for it would then be only a determinate), but, on the contrary, only as the unity of itself and the universal, that is, as concept" (287/540, my emphasis). Thus, it is clear that Hegel's position on conceptuality demands at the very least that concepts stand in relations to each other, and that these relations are significant for conceptual content itself – not merely for our ability, say, to *discriminate* conceptual contents. By contrast, though the standard assumptions can allow conceptual relations, the content that originally constitutes these concepts must be found in *simple* object-based qualities, not in relations between concepts. At best, a proponent of the standard conception could admit that concepts have subjective 'contrastive' relations to each other: by this, one might maintain that someone is subjectively unable to have a concept <white> (an example Hegel, for one, would not recognize as conceptual) unless one has another term or terms, say <black> or <orange>, which can be contrasted with it. But this does not mean that the latter terms are involved in the *content* of <white>, since that content remains an abstraction of just those individual simples it classifies. On this view, relations would be contingent and subjectively useful features of concepts that play no positive role in giving them content. Instead, Hegel will claim that part of what makes some term a concept is the way that it is related to other concepts. This claim is involved in the central Hegelian notion of "negativity," as we will see later.

Notice, however, that while Hegel's rejection of an atomistic conception of concepts does entail rejecting a standard assumption about concepts, it in no way entails that his treatment of concepts is totally different in subject matter. If it did, there would be no danger of conflating the two, and, furthermore, it would be hard to explain why Hegel would be *criticizing* a standard assumption in the name of his own rival conception.

To sum up: none of the central complaints Hegel makes against standard assumptions about concepts entail that his discussion of the Concept is about something other than a power of human thought, or that there is little overlap between his treatment of the Concept and concepts in a more typical sense. Rather, his criticisms are directed against the assimilation of concepts and mental representations that are primarily meant to track the similarities between sensible objects. If that is our view of concepts as such, then of course nothing Hegel says about the impressive power of the Concept will make sense. Even so, it would be hard to see why Hegel would dispute the power of the Concept with Kant and other figures in the tradition unless there was something in common between concepts proper

and representations.[25] Hegel's critique of representations amounts to a refusal to reduce concepts to them, but not to deny any relation between them.

3.2 The Concept of the Concept

Even if Hegel's criticisms of the standard assumptions do not stand in the way of our treating his *Begriffslehre* as a theory of concepts in some recognizable sense, it must be admitted that his curious reference to "the Concept" (sometimes emphatically in the singular) can seem to speak in favor of a metaphysically monist reading. It should first be pointed out that Hegel's usage is not always grammatically perspicuous. In Hegel's German, expressions of the form "the *F*" could either be instances of singular reference – "the one and only *F*," for example "the US president is waning in popularity" – or *generic* reference – "things of the kind *F*," for example "the US president is the commander in chief." It is possible that in many cases in which Hegel seems to be referring to one 'thing' called "the Concept," he is using the term as a generic, in which case it could be rephrased "concepts" just as the previous example could be rephrased "US presidents are commanders in chief."[26] However, there are indeed a few clear references that indicate that Hegel treats "*der Begriff*" as uniquely singular rather than only a generic. For example, in the preface to the second edition of the *Logic*, he writes, "But *a* concept is also, first of all, *the* concept, and this concept is only one concept, the substantial foundation" (*WL* I 29–30/19).[27] This passage confirms the relevance of the singular use of "the" Concept in as strong terms as could be hoped. This usage leads Bowman (2013: 32) to claim, "'Concept' denotes a *singulare tantum*, the unique 'entity' whose various modifications and degrees of manifestation constitute the whole of reality. Thus, Hegel is clearly not using the term 'Concept' to mean what we ordinarily mean by it." Indeed, if Hegel's use of

[25] That is, Hegel sees in Kant's view of conceptual knowledge a failure to recognize precisely the kind of conceptual thinking we are capable of. Hegel poses similar challenges to others in the history of philosophy, for example Francis Bacon, who challenged the power of conceptual thought. Cf. *VGP* III 78–83. Again, these criticisms would be odd if Hegel could make the verbal point that "the Concept" does not overlap in meaning with "representation" at all.

[26] As in the following passage, where Kant is discussed: "One should that expect in reason, which is the highest stage of thought, the concept would lose the conditionality with which it still appears at the stage of the understanding" (*WL* II 261/520). Since Hegel is discussing Kant's view of concepts, it is plausible to assume that he takes himself to be referring to what Kant called "concepts" with his use of "the Concept."

[27] Cf. also, "On the contrary, it is false to speak of concepts of diverse sorts, for the concept as such, although concrete, is still essentially one" (*EL* § 166Z, 317/245).

"the Concept" were a "*singulare tantum*," that would *exclude* its connection to "concepts" taken plurally.[28]

While I want to account for Hegel's use of "the Concept" as singular, I do not follow Bowman in the conclusion that this implies a strong departure from a more recognizable philosophical understanding of concepts, which allows for a plurality of concepts. Hegel's use of "the Concept" in the singular involves a deep and somewhat revisionary understanding of philosophical concepts, not a change in subject matter.

We can begin with a hypothesis about Hegel's usage of "the Concept": it is a case of synecdoche, where a term that refers to a partial aspect of some whole is used for the whole itself. In this case, we name some whole "the Concept" after its *products*,[29] which are specific philosophical concepts. If this is right, then we would have a neat explanation for the relationship between Hegel's use of "the Concept" and an ordinary one. Hegel's usage would differ from a common one in that he is referring to some whole; but since it is the whole of which individual concepts are a part or product, there remains a firm and important connection between the two.

Unlike other thinkers in the tradition, Hegel thematizes the "whole" that has individual concepts as its products rather than those products simply on their own terms. Given his suspicion of any conceptual atomism, Hegel does not treat (philosophical) conceptual change or development as an accidental feature of concepts, but as a requirement of conceptuality from the outset. Quite famously, Hegel sees thought as a dynamic process that moves between the *fixing* of various concepts and their distinctions to one another and the *breaking up* and *fluidifying* of these fixed concepts and distinctions. Roughly speaking, the moments of fixation and fluidification correspond, respectively, to what Hegel distinguishes as "understanding" (*Verstand*) and "reason" (*Vernunft*) (see *WL* II 287/539–40). As he writes, "The understanding is taken to be the faculty of the *determinate* concept which is held fixed *for itself* by virtue of abstraction and the form of universality. But in reason the *determinate* concepts are posited in their *totality* and *unity*" (351–2/588). The understanding by itself

[28] A *singulare tantum* is a noun without a plural form, à la "the air" or "*das Kapital*." Cf. Fulda (1978: 132): "at the end of the entire investigation of basic metaphysical concepts, the ontological claim makes reference only to one singular object [*einzigen Gegenstand*]."

[29] To ward off a possible misunderstanding: though I am using the word "product" here, this book is not focused on the claim that *concepts* are something 'produced' or 'made.' Whether that is true or not, my eventual interest is in the more particular sense in which concepts can produce something outside themselves. If we said that all objects or all concepts are made, and that Hegel's philosophy was about the made in *that* sense, the account would not be able to make sense of the *distinction* between the domains of spirit and nature as I understand them.

(to consider it abstractly) thinks of concepts as if they were a fixed number, provided with clear definitions. If this faculty could exist by itself and without interruption, we could speak simply of a theory of concepts and ask what makes each concept the one concept that it is. However, if Hegel sees "reason" as, from the outset, involved in bringing these apparently fixed concepts into a *whole* – in which the once fixed concepts may be fluidified – then it would be fruitless to consider the nature of concepts in isolation from this whole. Being a fixed concept in the first place would depend on the creative activity of reason. Accordingly, no one who has the ability to fix the content of determinate concepts lacks the power to dissolve them. Since Hegel thinks that even relatively and momentarily fixed concepts can exist only because of the active power of reason, he has reason to single out this power and name it after its products.[30]

I am thus sympathetic with other scholars who think of Hegel's "Concept" as something like the whole "space" of conceptuality rather than any specific concept or indeed object.[31] A few qualifications are in order, however. First, one must keep in mind that the "whole" of the Concept is not the whole of *representation*. That is, in my view, nothing in Hegel requires sympathy with a holism about the content of empirical representations (what would be called "concepts" today).[32] Hegel is marking out a rational power that may not be exercised in every psychological state. Second, the spatial metaphor can be misleading, since the connection between individual concepts and the Concept is more immediate than the relation of part to whole. Instead, for Hegel, the *same* "Concept" is exercised in the determination of any philosophical concept. This means that an individual concept is, or can be, a full expression of this power. To conceptualize, say, <the state> is just as much a use of "the Concept" as conceptualizing <essence>, or one of the other concepts of the *Logic*. Still, an individual determinate concept is an isolated and momentary exercise of this power, which always has implications for the generation and modification of the whole system of concepts. Hegel alludes to the merely relatively "firmness" of concepts in a passage, which recalls Quine (1951) uncannily: "Here and there on this web [of the categories of spirit] there are

[30] Hegel himself speaks of the Concept as a power. "The universal," which is a key moment of the Concept, "is therefore *free* power [*Macht*]" (*WL* II 277/532).

[31] Cf., e.g., Pinkard 2012; Koch 2014.

[32] I worry that this is an implication of Brandom's 2019 view. Brandom's broader theory (1994) also treats proper names as conceptual, which (whatever its merits as a philosophical view) I regard as antithetical to Hegel's view. Hegel commonly treats proper names in contrast to concepts. See Wolf 2019b.

knots, more firmly tied than others, which give stability and direction to the life and consciousness of spirit; they owe their firmness and power simply to the fact that, having been brought before consciousness, they stand as independent concepts of its essential nature" (WL I 27/28). Hence, any given concept might turn out to be only a temporary determination, suitably transformed and fluidified. Others might remain as relatively stable constants of conceptual thought.

What needs to be theorized, for Hegel, and what deserves to be the special subject of one book of his *Logic*, is not what makes a given concept what it is but what makes it possible for there to be philosophical concepts at all, and in particular what gives "freedom" and "fluidity" to the whole process of conceptual development. This is what Hegel calls "the Concept." It is called "concept" not by a loose analogy but because the Concept is responsible for the "determinate concepts," which are (or can be) its products.

We might cautiously specify this power of thinking called "the Concept" by speaking of the form of thought, *whatever it may be*, that stands behind the movement and determination of concepts. Hegel, however, tends to identify it quite specifically as the *self* of "I." Already in the *Phenomenology*, he writes,

> [The pure concept] is absolute, too, not only for us, but for the concepts themselves which stand in this opposition. For these concepts are certainly *determinate* with regard to one another, but are at the same time in themselves universal, so that they fill out the whole range of the Self, and this Self has no other content than this its determinacy, which neither goes beyond it nor is more restricted than it; because one of them, the absolute universal, is just as much the pure knowing-of-itself as the other, the absolute discretion of singularity, and both are only this pure self-knowing. (*PhG* 493/¶ 671)

This passage gives us a picture of conceptual content as both constituting the self and being constituted by the self, such that the determinacy that gives concepts content is provided by the self. This picture is spelled out further in the introduction to the *Doctrine of the Concept*, "True, I *have* concepts, that is, determinate concepts; but the 'I' is the pure concept itself, the concept that has come into *determinate existence*" (*WL* II 253/514). Hegel then famously connects his view of the Kantian unity of apperception: "It is one of the profoundest and truest insights to be found in the Critique of Reason that the *unity* which constitutes the *essence of the concept* is recognized as the *original synthetic* unity *of apperception*, the unity of the '*I think*' or of self-consciousness" (254/515). This seeming identification of the Hegelian "Concept" with Kant's unity of apperception or

self-consciousness has had a profound influence on the understanding of Hegel in recent decades, especially through the work of Pippin (1989). As stated in Chapter 1, in my view, the early Pippin's treatment of this passage makes the connection between Hegelian Concepts and Kantian categories too close, and thus somewhat muddles Hegel's specific interest in philosophical concepts, which may or may not have the role of unifying our cognition of objects of experience. For my purposes, what is important about this seeming identification of the Concept and the I is that this power of thinking that Hegel develops is a power that is inseparable from us, something that we do not need a 'theory' of, as if from outside it. The question is, if we do not take Pippin's lead in thinking of the Concept in terms of apperception, what power of thinking that we actually exercise is a clue to the Hegelian account of conceptuality? An answer to this question should also explain the way in which the power of the Concept is a *free* one.

As suggested, we need to get our bearings from the unique character of philosophical thinking. Philosophical thought, I take it, does not have its primary aim to represent the given world of the surrounding environment. While to say what the aim of philosophical thought positively *is* would be a herculean feat (and beyond my current ambition), I think one way of showing the unique freedom of philosophical thought is to emphasize the significance of *distinctions* in philosophy. Hegel himself speaks of the "absolute determinateness which is conceptual distinction [*Begriffsunterschied*] and [which is] *the only true content in the element of the concept*" (*WL* II 285/538). He seems to be convinced that distinction can amount to the sole source of the content of concepts. And, indeed, philosophers are sometimes historically significant not simply for the arguments they make but because of the distinctions they draw. Consider the insight required to draw basic distinctions such as Leibniz's "truths of reason" and "truths or fact," or Kant's "analytic" and "synthetic" judgments, Frege's "sense" and "reference," or the significant moral distinction between "doing" and "allowing," to take just a few examples. Distinctions do not simply sort objects into two classes.[33] Yet distinctions cannot be arbitrarily constructed because they tend to disrupt or alter a

[33] R. G. Collingwood (1933: ch. 2), possibly inspired by Hegel, claims that it is characteristic of philosophical distinctions that they involve the "overlap of classes"; that is, non-exclusive distinctions (Collingwood [1933: 41] gives the example of the concept of the good being divided non-exclusively into the pleasant, expedient, and the right). If this is true, distinctions cannot really be compared to acts of thought that divide up the world into different kinds of objects or things, since there would be, in principle, no way of *first* having the sets of things and then finding their respective concepts.

whole system of thought. Recognizing one distinction may require rejecting another. Distinctions earn their keep by showing a new way to rationally organize the whole. Though distinctions are constrained by the whole, they are *free* because there are no fixed classes of objects to which philosophical distinctions could be beholden to.

Though it is true that Hegel is not thematizing the act of making distinctions in the *Logic* (at least not *qua* activity), the role of distinctions in philosophy helps to draw attention to the nature of conceptual content in its purest form: prior to representation of given objects, thought has the form of distinction within its own nature. We witness concepts playing this role in philosophy, not in the organization of experience. Hegel makes a similar point when he comments on the way that the fixed concepts of the understanding can always be made fluid. He writes that "the understanding exhibits the infinite force that determines the universal," so that "it is the understanding that through the form of universality imparts stable subsistence to the otherwise inherent instability of determinateness" (*WL* II 287/539). Here, he seems to be referring to the way the understanding can use the form of universality to conceptualize *anything*, by fixing some determinacy. There is no "inherent stability" in this determinacy; some power is needed to settle it. But Hegel continues, adding that "the understanding at the same time *quickens* them *with spirit*, and it so sharpens them that only at that point, only there, do they also obtain the capacity to dissolve themselves and pass over into their opposite" (287/539). Hence the power of forming fixed concepts is initially unconstrained and creates its own determinacy, but that fixity can soon be dissolved.

The power of the Concept to draw distinctions helps explain Hegel's conviction that nothing can stand totally outside the form of conceptual thought. One of the key arguments of Hegel, as well as Fichte before him, is that even the attempt to draw a distinction between what is within thought and what is outside it implicitly relies on the power of thought itself, the Concept, to draw it.[34] This makes the power of conceptuality fully *comprehensive*. There is no content that can be thought that does not at least implicitly draw on our power to make distinctions in some way. Hence, the Concept is not only "free" but also in some sense "total" or universal. The Concept has the power to include everything within it, since the very thing that is supposed to be outside it is included by the very act of

[34] For example, "Hence the sum of that which is unconditioned and is purely and simply certain has now been exhausted, and I would like to express it in the following formula: *the I posits in the I a divisible Not-I in opposition to the divisible I*" (FW I: 100/2021: 214).

distinguishing it from what is inside; it draws on the same free power of conceptuality. This power to comprehend everything, to draw it into a context of understanding, is what is exercised in any philosophy. For Hegel, it is this power that must be placed at the center of our understanding of thought itself. It is this power that he is even willing to equate with the self or I, the subject of all rational thought.

3.3 The Formal Structure of the Concept

The best way to confirm the view of the Concept we have just sketched is by beginning from Hegel's own account of the formal structure of the Concept, which involves what he calls the three "moments" of the concept: universality (*Allgemeinheit*), particularity (*Besonderheit*), and singularity (*Einzelheit*). There is a common trend in more metaphysically loaded readings of the Concept to ignore this section and thus to read Hegel's more effluvious remarks about the Concept without its guidance.[35] Though this material is quite abstract and difficult, understanding Hegel's account of the "formal Concept" is central to understanding any use to which he puts the Concept. For, though Hegel will attempt to show that the Concept is "realized" in the world, the earlier "formal" stage of Hegel's account does not assume that the Concept has any special connection to reality, or in Hegel's terms, that it has "truth." As he puts it, "*At first*, the concept is only *implicitly* the truth; because it is only something *inner*, it is equally *only something outer* . . . The shape of the *immediate* concept constitutes the standpoint that makes the concept a subjective thinking, a reflection external to the *thing at issue*" (WL II 270/526–7). That is, what Hegel describes as the stage of the formal Concept is acknowledged to be the stage of subjective thought. This does not mean thought will be considered in terms of psychological acts or states, but it does imply that thought will be considered in terms of its basic formal structure, without assuming its objectivity.[36] If the Concept is more than subjective thought, it will have to be explained how it can be objective, starting from its

[35] Thus in readings such as Bowman 2013 and Kreines 2015, almost no attention is given to the passages I am commenting on. Even non-traditional readings (like Pippin 2019) do not pay much attention to the specific treatment of conceptual form. Important exceptions to this neglect include Stekeler-Weithofer 1992; Schick 1994, 2018; Sans 2004; Martin 2012; Redding 2012, 2017; Koch 2014; Gerhard 2015; Ficara 2021. However, even work that treats the formal side of the Concept in more detail tends not to emphasize its central connection to Hegel's challenge to traditional metaphysics.

[36] Here I at least apparently part ways with Martin (2012: 217–18). Though I agree with him that Concept, judgment, and syllogism are not treated as "shapes of subjective performances" (217), he

subjectivity: "The *formal* concept makes itself into the thing at issue [*Sache*] by virtue of the necessary determination of its form, and it thereby sheds the relation of subjectivity and externality that it had to that matter" (271/527, modified). Hegel's account of the Concept is meant to *show* how it is possible to begin with a formal account of the Concept and end up with an account of something "substantive" or indeed a "thing at issue" (*Sache*).[37] This is a task Hegel will take on and one that will receive attention below.

But before Hegel can claim that the Concept is the "truth," so that it becomes what he calls "the Idea," he must show that the form of the Concept is capable of the truth. Hegel's discussion of the "moments" of the Concept is meant to help in this aim. The discussion is meant to show, in outline, something like this: the power of thought called the Concept requires three dimensions, working in unity, if it is capable of being more than subjective. The Concept has a dimension of *universality*, which is something like the ability of thought to be about anything. By itself this power is vacuous, since to be about anything is to be about nothing. The Concept thus has a second dimension, which is that of *particularity*. This is the power to make *distinctions* within the space of universality, so that lower, more specific concepts and determinations of concepts can be formed. Particular concepts, and the distinctions involved in their determination, can be such that they can represent an individual example. This occurs when the particular concepts are sufficiently determinate. This final dimension – the "reference" of the Concept to individuals – is what Hegel calls *singularity*.

Why are these three dimensions important to Hegel's account? I think Hegel's view is that though conceptual form "implicitly" contains each of these three dimensions, it is quite possible for them to be separated. Consider, for example, a case where one has a generic thought, say of the universal <virtue>, but has no means of identifying genuine virtue in practice nor any way to distinguish conceptually between <virtue> and <vice>. Or consider a case where one can identify an individual thing as *some individual* but without any conception of what it *really* is: as might

further argues that Hegel's turn to objectivity is possible only because the so-called subjective Concept already expresses the ontological form of "pure self-determining."

[37] This approach to the "subjective Concept" differs from the one recently offered by Ng (2020). For Ng, Hegel's discussion of the subjective and objective concept at the beginning of the *Doctrine of the Concept* is meant to be *regressive*, in that these accounts find their unity in the concept of "life," as the original unity of subjectivity and objectivity, inspired by Hölderlin (Ng 2020: 172–3). Such an account does not let Hegel *demonstrate* that an originally subjective Concept can become objective; it requires us to presuppose this unity.

happen in discovering what seems to be a dinosaur fossil to one with no training to identify it as <fossil>.[38] These are cases in which the "moments" of conceptuality are separated in thought. Thus, while Hegel wants to affirm the in-principle unity of the moments of conceptuality, he thinks that the mere form of conceptuality makes it possible and likely that they are not united in any given case. Indeed, Hegel's interestingly treats *judgment* as the paradigmatic expression of this disunity. Hegel would say that the judgment can exhibit a "contradiction" between subject and predicate, singular and universal (cf. 310/556).[39] Hence, Hegel assumes that the various moments of conceptual form make it possible for the subjective Concept *both* to remain subjective, even in a kind of state of internal contradiction, *and* to pass over into objectivity. The latter would be the case if, somehow, the universal, particular, and singular were united in the right way.[40] In what follows, I give an account of each of these moments separately.

3.3.1 Universality

The very fact that Hegel sees the forms of conceptuality as properly identical and interrelated makes a linear account of them difficult. Though some circularity is unavoidable, we will begin where Hegel does, with the form of *universality* (*Allgemeinheit*) or "the universal concept" (*WL* II 274 ff./530 ff.). Hegel often speaks of the form of universality interchangeably with the singular use of "the Concept," which we have already discussed: "The universal is thus the totality of the concept" (277/532).[41] This suggests that Hegel sees the universal as central to the power we have identified as the Concept, the ability of thought to be free and independent of the given. Such universality has no "features" or "characteristics," since to ascribe any such characteristics would be to make it a *particular* concept (275/530).[42] The content of universality, by itself, is bare "self-identity" (275/530).

[38] This case would fall under the Kantian concept of "reflective judgment": "If, however, the particular is given, for which the universal is to be found, then the power of judgment is merely **reflecting**" (Ak. 5: 179) (bold type in the original).

[39] See Section 5.1 for a more detailed treatment of Hegel's account of judgment.

[40] In Section 5.3, I argue that the unity of these forms is best exhibited in teleology.

[41] For example, "the concept, the universal which is thought itself" (*WL* I 26/17). In lectures from 1808/9, Hegel writes, "The concept is the universal that is at the same time determined, but which remains the whole universal in its determination" (W 4: 104). See also W 13: 148 for a lucid statement of the Concept as universal.

[42] This is why Hegel says that "one cannot speak of the universal apart from determinateness which, to be more precise, is particularity and singularity" (*WL* II 277/532).

It is because universality is so empty of specific content that it is open to any content: it is *unbounded* or *free*. Given the emptiness of universality, it imposes nothing on objects external to it; thus does Hegel address the popular notion that conceptualizing something "does violence" to it: "The universal is therefore *free* power; it is itself while over-reaching [*greift . . . über*] its other and embracing it, but without *doing violence* to it; on the contrary, it is at rest in its other as *in its own*" (*WL* II 277/532, modified). A possible content would be violated by conceptual universality only if it contained something alien to vacuous self-identity.

This does not mean that universality is always vacuous, but that, to be contentful, the universal requires the introduction of particularity. Distinctions, in some sense, create more universals. Hegel writes that when a concept is posited with less than the total scope of pure universality, that Concept "does not lose its character of universality" but is simply a "relative universal" (*WL* II 278/533). Although all conceptual difference will depend on the subsequent form of particularity, every lower "determinate concept" can be treated as a *genus* (*Gattung*) and thus as relatively universal vis-à-vis some other possible concept. Hegel thus insists that "even the determinate concept remains in itself infinitely free concept" (278/533). Universal conceptual form is preserved without loss in every concept:[43] "The universal . . . even when it posits itself in a determination, *remains* in it what it is" (276/531). Thus, on the one hand, there remains an abiding conceptual form, "the universal," that is merely shared by any additional concept that may occur; on the other hand, each determinate concept fully possesses the necessary form of the Concept as such.

3.3.2 Particularity

Hegel's discussion of particularity (*Besonderheit*) or "the particular concept" (*WL* II 280 ff./534 ff.) is his explanation of how determinate conceptual content is formally possible, given that all concepts share universal form in common.[44] Granted that α and β are logical terms, the question

[43] As is further clarified in the subsequent section: "The particular has one and the same universality as the *other* particulars to which it is related" (*WL* II 280/534).

[44] It should be borne in mind that *logical* or *conceptual* particularity is something quite different than "particularity" as used in English to mean something like the individual details of something (or using "particular" to refer to an individual object, i.e., "bare particular"). Such a mistake vitiates Winfield's (2006: 76–84) remarks on this passage. He does not conflate particularity and individuality, but he treats a particular, quite anomalously, as an "undifferentiated instance" (77). For a related corrective, see Rand 2015. Standardly, logical particularity corresponds to the use of "some" in categorical judgments, in contrast to "all" (cf. Arnauld and Nicole 1996 [1683]: part II, ch. 3). Kant

here is why we should expect that they express *different* concepts (which a difference in symbols, of course, does not guarantee). Hegel's answer turns on the notion of *distinction* (*Unterschied*). All determinate concepts are particular,[45] in Hegel's sense, because in order for a concept to have content, it must contain distinction, and all distinction implies a limitation on (intensional) content.[46] If α is distinct from β, then neither has a total intension; neither 'means everything' (which, as we saw, might be said of the universal form as such). Every distinction implies particularity of content, but the totality of distinctions is equivalent in content to the universal: "The particular, therefore, does not only *contain* the universal but exhibits it also *through its determinateness*; accordingly the universal constitutes a *sphere* that the particular must exhaust" (280/534).

However, the notion of "distinction" that Hegel uses to explain particularity does not only provide a necessary condition for conceptual content. The key and perhaps most difficult thesis of Hegel's theory of conceptual form is that distinction is even *sufficient* for conceptual content (at least logically considered).[47] This comes out in Hegel's dispute with Kant in the introduction to the *Doctrine of the Concept*. There he reproached Kant for apparently failing to recognize that even concepts without supporting intuitions cannot be (intensionally) empty, since the concept "surely contains determinateness and distinction [*Unterschied*] within itself" (*WL* II 261/520, modified). Though he is arguably being unfair to Kant, Hegel's point is that a distinction between concepts is already sufficient for conceptual content of some kind, and such distinction is itself not something sensory or 'intuitive' in Kant's sense.

However, this tells us that distinction is sufficient for some content (the mere content that α ≠ β, perhaps), but not that distinction is solely

distinguishes between the general and particular *use* of concepts in their relative abstractness from individuals. Cf. his *Jäsche Logic*, § 16/Ak. 9: 99–101.

[45] Hegel explains that, ironically, even <universal> is a species (a particular) of itself. Cf. *WL* II 281/535.

[46] Cf. Schick 1994: 201. Hegel's context had a clear place for the distinction between extension and intension. Kant himself made a correlative distinction well enough: "The content [*Gehalt*] and extension [*Umfang*] of a concept have an inverse relation to one other. The more a concept contains *under* itself [*unter sich*], the less it contains *in* itself [*in sich*], and conversely" (*Jäsche Logic*, § 7/Ak. 9: 96). For example, <being> has a massive scope, but little or no content or distinguishing conditions, while (were we to follow Leibniz's acceptance of individual concepts) the concept <Julius Caesar> has tremendous content but a scope or extension of one. Hegel discusses and dismisses a purely extensional interpretation of logical quantities at *WL* II 295/545.

[47] By this qualification of "logically considered," I mean that it may well be the case that there are historical, social, or psychological conditions on conceptual content coming to be. For Hegel, this is clearly the case, given his belief that concepts are always transformations of preexisting "representations" (*Vorstellungen*). See *EL* §§ 1–6.

sufficient for any conceptual content at all.[48] For example, if I introduce the concept <schleep> with the qualification that <schleep> is not (is distinct from) <sleep> (or even <schleep> is <not-schleep>), this is enough to give *some* conceptual content to the term. This content obviously relies on the preexisting content of <sleep>, but even setting that issue aside, we can hardly get off the ground. For as far as we know, there is not necessarily even an interesting contrastive relationship between <sleep> and <schleep>. The latter could turn out to be equivalent to <blue>; the content of the distinction would amount to <blue> is not <sleep>.[49] The mere distinction, understood in this way, tells us next to nothing.

Even so, Hegel insists on the point, in a passage we have quoted above: "To reproach the concept as such for being empty is to ignore its absolute determinateness which is conceptual distinction [*Begriffsunterschied*] and *the only true content in the element of the concept*" (*WL* II 285/538, slightly modified, my emphasis). It is one thing to admit that conceptual distinction is necessary for conceptual content; it is another thing to imply that it is solely sufficient.[50] Even though Hegel will not need to explain the content of *representations* (like "blue" or "sleep") in this way, I believe he is committed to thinking that the content even of very concrete concepts of his *Realphilosophie*, like <right>, <state>, and <art> have their content solely in their distinctions or negative relations. These concepts might receive psychological content from experience, but their purely conceptual content is supposed to be something like the negative relations between them.[51]

Though I do not know of a model that nicely explains how this could work, an important clue to Hegel's thought is that negative relations between concepts, and thus conceptual particularity, can provide a suitable

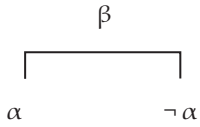
[48] See Inwood 2013: 222.

[49] Hegel is clearly aware of this interpretation of the negative as "other" rather than opposite. See *WL* II 320/564. He must not understand negativity in its logically significant sense as equivalent to the mere "not" of distinction or otherness. This issue is also discussed by both Kant and Hegel under the heading of an "infinite" (i.e., indefinite) judgment. Cf. Kant, A 71–2/B 97.

[50] Many attempts have been made to make sense, but despite promising efforts, in my view, interpretations never prove to fully illuminate Hegel's position; it continues to seem elusive. The problem is to show how mere negative relations can constitute something positive. Sophisticated proposals generally suggest that some kind of recursive algorithm ("*Grundoperation*") could be entrusted to aggregate new content. Cf. Henrich 1976 and the attempt to carry this program on the scale of a commentary in Martin 2012. Such proposals can often make good sense of initial moves in Hegel's *Logic*, but I am unconvinced that they can be extended to make sense of the whole range of concepts in the *Logic*.

[51] Elsewhere, he writes, "A thing, a subject, a concept [*Das Ding, das Subjekt, der Begriff*], is then precisely this negative unity; it is something inherently self-contradictory, but it is no less the *resolved contradiction*" (*WL* II 79/384).

basis for non-arbitrary *division* (*Einteilung*) of concepts.[52] The main upshot of Hegel's view is that such divisions should be restricted to oppositional or *contrary* predicates. In this kind of opposition, lower determinations that divide a higher concept become *mutually determining*: "When we speak of *two opposing sides*, we must repeat that the two constitute the particular, not just *together*, as if they were *alike* in being particular only for external reflection, but because their determinateness *over against each other* is at the same time essentially only one determinateness; it is the negativity which in the universal is *simple*" (WL II 281/535). A higher concept is adequately analyzed, Hegel says, only when its lower concepts or determinations are found to be mutually exclusive. Thus, a branch on a conceptual "tree" will look something like this:[53]



This oppositional relation amounts to a concept's particularity: what restricts its scope vis-à-vis other concepts. For Hegel, genuine oppositions ensure that a distinction is not an arbitrary one, so that concepts so divided will be genuine *centers of thought*. The system of concepts as a whole will then be structured by "joints" of such oppositions – what he would call "contradictions."[54] The whole structure can be called "*absolute* negativity" insofar as all *positive* content is reduced to these negative relations.[55]

[52] The notion of conceptual "division" goes back to Plato's use of *diaeresis*, especially in the *Sophist* and *Statesman*. See Koch 2014 for more on this connection.

[53] See M. Wolff 2023 for more on conceptual trees of this form. Kreis (2015: 256–60) has a good discussion of how this structure works in the case of <attraction> and <repulsion>. See also Kreis 2015: 265–72.

[54] It is still controversial whether Hegel accepts the principle of non-contradiction (PNC) or not, and so whether the contradictions he attributes to concepts (or indeed things) are genuine logical contradictions. Brandom (2002, 2019), e.g., argues Hegel is among the firmest supporters of the PNC, while M. Wolff (2017) argues that Hegel countenances "*de re*" contradiction (interpreted, however, as "real oppositions"). De Boer (2010b: 362, 366–7) argues that Hegel refers only to intra-conceptual contradiction rather than contradiction in things, though this is hard to square with evidence where Hegel speaks of both (cf. *WL* II 79/384, where Hegel says that "a thing, a subject, a concept" can be "resolved contradictions"). Redding (2007: ch. 7) adopts a kind of social-perspectival reading of Hegel on contradiction. Others (see, e.g., Priest 2002; Moss 2020: ch. 8; Ficara 2021: chs. 15–16; McNulty 2023) have read Hegel as an early proponent of dialethism. Even if Hegel can be given a sensible reading on contradiction, however, this does not amount to showing how the contradiction constitutes conceptual content.

[55] "For in its absolute negativity the universal contains determinateness in and for itself, so that, when speaking of determinateness in connection with the universal, the determinateness is not being imported into the latter from outside" (*WL* II 277/532).

Clearly, this remains a holistic picture, since we cannot explain the content of one concept except by giving it in terms of others.

This account of the "negativity" of concepts helps explain the shape of Hegelian dialectic. Hegel's philosophical procedure does not involve producing a top-down analysis of a concept, for example β, by pointing out that it can be analyzed into its contraries, α and ¬ α. Rather, one can think of dialectic as a procedure for generating conceptual trees *from below*. If we begin with a concept α, and we find that it "passes over" into its opposite, ¬ α, we then have in this opposition the content of a higher concept β, in which both α and ¬ α are "sublated" (*aufgehoben*).[56] Subsequently, β can be divided into α and ¬ α. In this process, the content of concepts is constructed solely on the basis of "negativity."[57] What is, from one point of view, the movement of dialectic also outlines the nature of conceptual content.

What a concept authentically contains thus cannot be a purely material or empirical determination, which would lack such pure "negativity." Hegel points to this deficiency in the division of natural-descriptive (so-called) concepts: "The manifold genera and species of nature must not be esteemed to be anything more than arbitrary notions of spirit . . . [T]hey do not exhibit [the concept] in a trustworthy copy, for they are the sides of its free self-externality" (*WL* II 282/536). Instead, conceptual division must be guided by a non-arbitrary formal feature of conceptuality. In a concept, after all, "the subject matter is reduced to its non-contingent essentiality" (263/521). If one finds the structure of contrary determinations in a concept, this reduction is complete. In "negativity," then, Hegel finds a resource from within purely "logical" features of conceptuality for expressing content "outside" of the purely formal.

It is important to note, then, that despite Hegel's attempt to reduce conceptual content to something minimal and apparently formal ("negativity"), this does not imply that only purely "logical" or categorical concepts are genuine concepts. As I stated in Chapter 1, in my reading,

[56] "The *dialectical* moment is the self-sublation of these finite determinations on their own part, and their passing into their opposites" (*EL* § 81, 172/128). But then: "The dialectic has a *positive* result, because it has a *determinate content*, or because its result is truly not *empty, abstract nothing*, but the negation of *certain determinations*, which are contained in the result." The result, Hegel then says, is a "*unity of distinct determinations*" (*EL* § 82R, 177/131). The stages in this description fit very well, I believe, with the notion that dialectic is the 'bottom-up' development of conceptual trees.

[57] Interesting confirmation of this view is that Hegel is reported to have said that <becoming/*Werden*> is in fact the first *concept* of the *Logic* (see *EL* § 88Z). Yet <*Werden*> is the unity of the contrary determinations, <being/*Sein*> and <nothing/*Nichts*>. Being and nothing would not yet be concepts, strictly speaking, because they do not contain contrary relations.

Hegel's *explanandum* in the *Doctrine of the Concept* is *not* the conceptual content of the categories of the *Logic* itself. (Indeed, I do not think it is coherent to ask for an explanation of the content of pure thought, as if it consisted in a relation to something else.[58]) Instead, Hegel thinks this his account of minimal conceptual form permits us to affirm how *any* concrete subject matter can be conceptual – so long as it could be reduced to its contrary determinations. After polemicizing against the standard view of determinate concepts as mere abstract universals (= SA 2 above), he adds: "To be sure, any determinate concept is *empty* in so far as it does not contain the totality, but only a one-sided determinateness. Even when it has otherwise concrete content such as, for instance, humankind, the state, animal, etc., it remains an empty concept inasmuch as its determinateness is not the *principle* of its distinction" (WL II 285/538, slightly modified). This passage does not say, as a first glance may suggest, that concrete contents such as "humankind, the state, animal, etc." are *not* conceptual. It suggests instead that such content *is* conceptual, so long as the content of such concepts is understood as a principle of distinction or opposition. The content of a term like <humankind>, *qua* conceptual, is not merely the mental summary or common denominator of known human beings (that would be its *Vorstellung*); it is the negative principle that sets that term apart from – *against* – all others.[59] When a concept contains such a principle, Hegel suggests that it "contain[s] the totality."

3.3.3 Singularity

The particularity of conceptual form leads to the possibility of particular concepts: "particular universals."[60] But *singularity* (*Einzelheit*) never qualifies a different type of concept;[61] in Hegel there are no "singular concepts"

[58] Cf. Werner 2020: section 4.

[59] An interesting passage in this regard comes in Hegel's explanation of the Concept in the *Lectures on Aesthetics*. He writes, "Thus are the representations *human being*, *blue*, etc., at first not to be called concepts, but rather abstractly-universal representations, which only become a concept if it is presented in them that they contain distinct sides in a unity, since this determinate unity within itself makes up the concept; as, e.g., the representation 'blue' as color has the unity, and indeed the specific unity, of light and dark for its concept and the representation 'human being' encompasses the oppositions of sensibility and reason, body and spirit" (*VÄ* I 147/108). Here we see that almost any topic could be shown to be conceptual, even if it is at first merely representational (see above, pp. 60–61). In addition, this passage shows that some words can designate both a concept and a representation, as the references above also indicate. This helps to explain, psychologically, how the advance to conceptuality, even if it cannot be reduced to representation, can significantly rely on the scaffolding of representation when developing genuine concepts. For example, the concept <humankind> will not be unrelated to the representation "humankind," though also not reducible to it.

[60] Schick 1994: 197. [61] See McTaggart 1910: 198; Gerhard 2015: 33.

such as we find in Leibniz. Instead, Hegel suggests that what he means by singularity is something already implied in his discussion of particularity – "particularity [is] also *singularity* in and for itself" (*WL* II 288/540) – and thus no new conceptual type is needed. Singularity is merely "determinate determinateness or absolute negativity" (288/540), which is captured in the oppositional relations within determinate concepts. Preliminarily, we can already conclude that the formal features needed to explain conceptual content are exhausted by the negativity displayed in the structure of particular concepts.

The form of singularity, then, contains nothing other than particularity: negative determinacy or distinction. Instead, singularity differs from particularity only because of its intended *use* or *role* in thought.[62] This role does not leave a mark on conceptual form itself: a concept used in two ways, say, as subject and predicate of different propositions, does not change its content.[63] This is also the case with Hegel's notion of singularity: singularity may defined as the *object-level positing* (*Setzung*) of conceptual determinacy. Before returning to Hegel's text to show this, I will attempt to illustrate my understanding of Hegel's meaning. Consider the difference in the role of the term "rooster" in the following sentences:

(a) "The rooster is a male chicken."
(b) "The rooster is bound to wake you in the morning."

Though (a) can be taken ambiguously, the most plausible reading is that it defines or determines the concept <rooster>, rather than providing information about a particular rooster (even "That rooster is a male chicken" would be an odd thing to say). On the other hand, though "rooster" also stands as the grammatical subject of (b), its intended target has clearly shifted. Though the conceptual content of the subject of (b) is the same as of (a), (b) employs the term in an object-level position, to *refer* to some rooster. Moreover, each use results in different inferential possibilities. Because the predicate (a) functions as an identity, we can use substitution to conclude from (a) and (b) that

(c) "The male chicken is bound to wake you in the morning,"

[62] The emphasis on the singular as use is especially to be found in the work of Stekeler-Weithofer (e.g., 1992: 39, 356–9).

[63] Compare a remark from the *Doctrine of Being*, referencing deictic expressions that Hegel associates with the form of singularity: "By 'this' we *mean* to express something completely determinate, overlooking the fact that language, as a work of the understanding, only expresses the universal, albeit *naming* it as a single object" (*WL* I 126/91).

but we cannot use the predicate "bound to wake you in the morning" in (b) as a substitute for "the rooster" in (a), since (b) is not an identity statement.

Now Hegel would not end up accepting <rooster> as a concept per se,[64] but the example illustrates the formal issue all the same. What Hegel attempts to account for with <singularity> is the fact that in using self-same conceptual content, an object rather than a concept can be under consideration.[65] If a concept can be used both generically, as the subject of a definition, and as a predicate of a certain singular object, the same content must be suitable for both uses. This does not mean that Hegel's discussion of the form of singularity already imports any object-level content, only that Hegel is making a formal provision for this kind of content.

Hegel explains this metaphorically by saying that singularity is a "*doubly reflective shine*," namely a reflection *inwards* (*nach innen*) and *outwards* (*nach außen*): "Insofar as the reflective shine is *inward*, the particular remains a universal; through the outward shining, it is *something determinate*" (*WL* II 296/546, modified). The inward "shining" of singularity is its relation to existing conceptuality or particularity; the outward shining is its relation to the world outside of pure thought. In particular, the inward relation of singularity involves the *fixing* of a conceptual distinction that otherwise has the form of particularity. Hegel says this more directly later: "But, as this negativity, singularity is the determinate determinateness, *distinguishing* as such, and through this reflection of the distinction into itself, the distinction becomes fixed; the determining of the particular occurs only by virtue of singularity, for *singularity* is that abstraction which, precisely as singularity, is now *posited abstraction*" (*WL* II 296/546, slightly modified). Hegel thus credits singular reference as helping to create conceptual distinctions that otherwise have the merely negative form of particularity. This happens through what he calls the outward shine. Clarifying this aspect, Hegel says, "Singularity is not, however, only the turning back of the concept into itself, but the immediate loss of it. Through singularity, where it is *internal to itself*, the concept becomes

[64] "There is only one animal type and all the varieties are merely modifications of it . . .. One must not therefore seek conceptual determinations everywhere, although traces of them are everywhere present" (*EPN* § 368Z, 503–4/418, modified).

[65] Hegel's thought on this point seems in harmony with much that Frege would later say. For example, Frege (1980: § 47) writes that (in a case like mine about roosters) the statement 'whales are mammals' is not about whales, but the concept of a whale, while ordinary predicative statements of the form *F* (*a*) are about objects and not concepts. See "On Concept and Object" (1892) in Frege 1997.

external to itself and steps into actuality" (299/548).[66] Though singularity involves conceptual form, the singular "this"[67] belongs not only to conceptual form considered as internal to thought but to its outer boundary. In describing the form of such singular reference in terms of mere "negativity," however, Hegel has suggested that the singular is not formally different than the particularly qualified universal, which is itself nothing other than a distinction. What this means is that the logical form of the singular for Hegel is again mere distinction, or even contradiction, just in a different register than the particular. Thus, singular reference is "conformable" to (universal and particular) conceptual form.

Yet it is not only that the singular is formally compatible with pre-given particular concepts (whatever those turn out to be). The form of singularity is supposed to clarify something that is left a mystery in terms of particularity alone: how could concepts of differing content arise on the basis of merely negative form? Hegel thinks that the object-level positing of conceptuality is what determines or gives boundaries to conceptual content in the first place. Something singular puts pressure, as it were, on conceptual distinctions, so that definite conceptual content is a certain kind of "abstraction." But though Hegel uses the term "abstraction" to describe the determining of a concept by the singular, he means it quite differently than, say, a typical empiricist would. For while in the standard empiricist view of concepts, the universal content is only available as the common denominator to many cases, so that the universal "abstracts" from the differences in the many, Hegel envisions the one singular *itself* as the abstraction:[68] "This abstracting by the singular [*Abstrahieren des Einzelnen*] is, as the reflection of the distinction into itself, the first positing of the distinctions as *self-subsisting*, reflected into themselves" (*WL* II 300–1/549, modified). Abstraction is not performed on a number of similar cases; abstraction is something a singular case "by itself" can do. As far as I can tell, the best way to understand the role Hegel gives to the singular here is that of an *exemplar* or *paradeigma*. The exemplar of a new type, we can say, "abstracts" from an existing type; it thereby "posits a distinction." Moreover, in doing so, the exemplar can in principle act alone; there is no need for 'more of the same.' This point, which I take to be Hegel's, is

[66] See also: "The singular is the same as the actual, except that it has issued from the concept, and hence is *posited* as something-universal, or negative identity with itself" (*EL* § 163R, 311/240).

[67] See just below: "The singular, which in the reflective sphere of concrete existence is as a *this*" (*WL* II 300/549).

[68] I have (conservatively) downplayed the way this point comes across in the di Giovanni translation ("This *act of abstraction by the singular*"), but I think the point stands in the original.

familiar in ordinary thinking: a novel case can help define a new type (indeed, sometimes a "case makes law"[69]), and this is not only after it has been joined by enough followers to produce a new common element between them, but simply by expressing a difference to the types at hand.[70] That is, the singular can establish a negative relation to the concepts at hand on its own. In terms of conceptual content, it does not matter *how many* cases of a singular type there are, but there should be at least one case that "demonstrates" that difference in content.[71]

Hegel is claiming, then, that exemplary instances are *conceptually productive*. Exemplary singular instances that are incompatible with given concepts are productive of a new concept. This suggests that concepts do not first have fully determinate content prior to the existence of their instances; instead, the instance and the concept are potentially co-determining. This is unlike the inductive process of so-called concept formation in natural science, which depends on the similarity of multiple instances of a kind. For Hegel, the role of conceptual singularity is more on display in cases of *historical* development. For example, a recurring figure in Hegel's historical and political writings is the "hero," who is responsible in the formation of a state (*GPR* §§ 93, 350). The hero embodies the principles of law or justice that will later be in force in the state. As such, the individual hero, we might say, bears the new universal. However, a key moment in such a process is the hero's *transition* from a previous regime: the hero will be a *criminal* in terms of the former regime (cf. § 93Z). The new universal that the hero represents is in conflict with the old one. This is the hero's "negative determinacy" vis-à-vis the then available determinations. Yet, through a negation of the negation (here, perhaps, a negation of the status of criminality through novel founding acts), the hero can represent a new, positive term. It is thus *through* the negative activity of the singular that a new "universal" (the justice of the new state) is "abstracted" from what is given. The hero's actions "make a difference," or rather a *distinction*.

[69] The common law analogy is used heavily in Brandom 2019.

[70] Given a type, say "jazz," it is reasonable to think that a sufficiently different jazz performance could at first merit the description "not jazz." Consider, for example, the so-called free jazz of Ornette Coleman and followers. However, this "not jazz" – a contradiction with existing jazz – can just as well establish a new species of jazz. It does not take a whole wave of new performances to create the new concept, only the allowance that the new performance *distinguishes* itself from "bad jazz" of the old type, and is rather "good jazz" – but only of a new type.

[71] Kant similarly implies that only one intuition is necessary to prove the potential reality of a cognition (B xxiii–xxxiv). The theme of comprehending via a single intuition becomes prominent in his *Critique of Judgment* (see Ak. 5: 259).

However, even apart from Hegel's history-based examples, I believe his view of the role of the singular in the formal Concept is otherwise familiar in philosophical thinking. Consider the way a compatibilist notion of free will might be explained by appealing (as in Frankfurt 1978: 160) to the difference between the attitude of two addicts to their respective drug addictions. One might argue that an addict who identifies with his addiction counts as free, while a second addict who repudiates his addiction does not, regardless of the deterministic processes potentially at play in both cases. While, for a researcher of addiction, it would be extremely important to keep track of slight observational differences between addicts of these two kinds, the use of a pair of examples in *philosophy* is meant precisely to illustrate a non-observational distinction between the two cases: one is responsible and free, the other is not. We find the *difference* between the two cases only by first stipulating a large amount of continuity between them. So, for example, the compatibilist will take natural causation for granted and provide two cases of people who are naturally determined (addicted). The effectiveness of the example of the compatibilist freedom depends on its showing how the "free" case can be *opposed* to the one it is otherwise continuous with. This "negative" component seems important in the case I just mentioned, for example, since a philosophical novice may not initially identify the self-endorsing addict as free. Instead, the effective example will encourage her to make a new distinction where she precisely did not before, which enables her to "see" a difference between two cases, and only on that basis (if the compatibilist is persuasive) provisionally hang the new title "free" (in the compatibilist sense) on the seeming exception to normal determinism.

I take this example to illustrate the kind of role that Hegel expects singularity to play in the philosophical determination of a concept. First, it seems clear to me that a conception of <compatibilist freedom> that cannot point out how it would distinguish logically between singular cases is simply not yet rich enough as a concept. The concept must be capable of discrimination, and this requires potentially singular application. Second, examples like Frankfurt's often play an *essential* role in the determination of conceptual content: without some singular case, we have no reason to introduce (e.g.) a new distinction between different kinds of freedom or responsibility. Yet we are not simply grouping a class of similar single cases together and looking for what they have in common (à la Hegel's "*Vorstellung*"). One singular case is enough to demonstrate the relevant distinction. Third, the *philosophical* content of the singular example is not the sensuous, imaginary detail of the two cases of addiction; it is in some

sense reducible to the *conceptual difference* that is illustrated between the two cases. As Hegel emphasizes, the content of singularity is in a way reducible to the content of particularity, which is itself only difference or negativity.

Thus, taken abstractly, Hegel's account of the moment of singularity articulates the formal moment of conceptuality that corresponds roughly to the notion of singular reference. However, my illustration indicates how singularity functions in philosophical thought, where it is intimately connected to the universal and the particular. In philosophy, singular thought is co-constitutive of conceptual content. For Hegel, this singular use of conceptuality, even though it points "outside" thought to the world, is still at the same time a moment "within" conceptual thought. It depends solely on the structure provided by the formal or subjective Concept. This is because its content does not come from mere sensuous intuition but rather from the role of distinction in the singular case itself.

3.4 Conclusion

Let us recall our starting problem: Hegel's use of "the Concept" seems to bring to mind a quasi-theological entity, which is realizing itself in the world, like an active Spinozian substance or a neo-Platonic "One." If so, then the Concept cannot simply be something *we* can think; it can at best be "deploying" itself in human thought. On this view, Hegel's *Doctrine of the Concept* would be teaching us about the nature of that entity rather than about the powers of human (if not *qua* human) philosophical thought.

I have tried to show how we can think of the basic moments of the Concept as moments in conceptual or philosophical thinking. Universality, particularity, and singularity are forms present in different dimensions of such thought, but I have suggested that these forms are best exemplified in the act of making distinctions. Though this might seem like a meager thing, thought's ability to produce ever new distinctions is, for Hegel, what makes thought *comprehensive*: it is such that everything that one might want to separate from thought is at the same time within it. Here, again, we find Hegel relying on an insight of Fichte's. Let an objector propose something that is supposed to be outside the grasp of the Concept (or in Fichte's case, the "I"). Modifying Fichte's "not-I," we can call it "non-Concept." The Fichte–Hegel move – and the hence Fichtean moment in Hegel's theory – is to point out that non-Concept (or "non-I" in the case of Fichte) can only be "posited" by *distinguishing* it from the Concept (or "I").[72] But the act of

[72] On this move in Fichte, see especially Pippin 2000: 157, 165–6.

distinguishing is precisely the expression, for Hegel, of *particularity*: we have just found the "non-Concept" to be a more particular concept or universal. Similarly, if we say of some supposed object that "it" is outside the Concept, we are simply relying on the logical form of *singularity* in making the point. By similar procedures, we can show that the effort to distinguish what lies outside the Concept from what lies within it comes to naught. The Concept comprehends all: it is "unbounded," to use McDowell's (1994) famous phrase.

I must hasten to qualify this picture, since I believe it can be taken too far. I have previously argued (Wolf 2019b) that the fact that conceptual moments (like universality or singularity) are involved in, say, perception should not by itself lead us to conclude that perception is necessarily conceptual. For it does not follow that the use conceptual form is in some way involved in perception that determinate concepts in a Hegelian (or even Kantian) sense are involved. Though I am thus not persuaded that Hegel is a conceptualist about perceptual experience, I do think Hegel's view implies that nothing can be thought that does not in some way exemplify the moments of universality, particularity, and singularity. And this "in some way" must be enough to ensure that there is no use in trying to distinguish whether a part of reality lies outside the bounds of thought or conceptuality. The significance of this lies more in our view of philosophy in general than simply our view of perception. It may *not* be the case that my perception is structured so that I must employ certain concepts in the perception of something. Even so, when I try to think about *what it was* that I perceived, it is only a question of *which* universal I might use to think it, not *whether* I might use some universal.[73] The same is true in metaphysics, where some may be tempted to allow (e.g.) for a God that is posited without being able to be thought or comprehended. Yet there is no question, for Hegel at least, of leaving room for a non-conceptualizable reality within philosophy in this way. Any reference to a non-conceptualizable reality must be standing on the ladder it wants to kick away.

So far, and as I mentioned at the outset, the view of the Concept I have presented is *compatible* with a "Kantian" subjective-idealist reading of Hegel, according to which we can only claim that *we* must use concepts (or simply universals) in thinking about the world, from which (a critic could complain) the only ground we have for speaking of the "truth" or

[73] This requires that there is room on Hegel's view for perception without thought. I think there is such room in Hegel: see note 20, this chapter. Obviously, we cannot think what we perceive without thinking (and thus relying on the form of universality), but we can perceive (it seems to me, at least for Hegel) without thinking.

objectivity of the Concept is our own imposition of it. For the view I have developed to be recognizably Hegelian, it must also be the case that concepts can be the "nature or essence" of things – or at least of some things. We must not find ourselves with a yawning gap between thought and the world, where skepticism always threatens. There must be some account of how thought has *some* constitutive relation to the world. This issue has not yet been resolved. But I will argue that Hegel does not address it by presenting a theory of some reality called "the Concept" that exists behind or outside of our own (human, but not *too* human) thought. Instead, he addresses it by drawing on the formal resources of the Concept that have been sketched in this chapter.

CHAPTER 4

The Concept's Comprehension of the Metaphysics of Substance

4.1 Introduction

In the previous chapter, I gave an account of the Concept on its own terms but without considering the place of that account in the *Logic* as a whole. Yet in order to understand the relevance of Hegel's conception of the Concept to his critique and inversion of metaphysics, the latter task is also essential. The mere fact that the Concept is the form of thought may not itself seem to have metaphysical consequences. However, once we are in a position to see the systematic place of Hegel's *Concept Logic* within the *Logic* as a whole, the reading of the Concept I have offered in the previous chapter will prove to be significant for understanding Hegel's conception of metaphysics (his "metametaphysics"). In this chapter I will argue that the transition to the *Concept Logic* implies a deflationary (by contemporary lights) conception of metaphysics.[1] This deflationary conception is first prefigured by the Objective Logic's resolute abstention from metaphysical claims in favor of the determination of concepts in their own right; it is then fulfilled by the Subjective Logic's argument that these concepts are grounded in the form of thought. In my view, the grounding of metaphysics in the form of thought opens the door to Hegel's inversion of philosophy more generally.

Over the past several decades, debate has raged in Hegel scholarship about *whether* he is a metaphysician.[2] This debate has apparently resolved – or fizzled out – in favor of the consensus that Hegel is a metaphysician after all, with "non-metaphysical" readings falling out of prominence. However, this supposed resolution can easily paper over tacit assumptions about what

[1] Wolf 2024 contains some overlapping material with this chapter.
[2] See Kreines 2006 for a summary, and the essays collected in de Laurentiis 2016 for a sample. The debate owes its origin to the provocative Hartmann 1972.

metaphysics *is*, assumptions that Hegel himself seems determined to unsettle. In particular, it is common to take metaphysics to be a theoretical enterprise whose aim is to determine the basic structure of reality. Something like this may be the majority view, at least in contemporary metaphysics. Thus, to affirm that Hegel is a "metaphysician" can often seem to mean that he shares precisely this project of metaphysics. I believe that the debate about Hegel and metaphysics has been misplaced precisely because Hegel's own aim was to transform metaphysics. In various ways he claims not merely to be offering his own metaphysics but to "replace" metaphysics.[3] Prima facie, it would be odd of Hegel to say that he is replacing metaphysics if he only planned to offer his own metaphysical theory in the same vein as his predecessors. Charles Darwin effected a revolution in biology, but we do not speak of even him as "replacing" biology but rather as improving or maturing or even revolutionizing it. Presumably, one replaces something only if one puts something new in its place. We would, for example, rightly speak of chemistry as *replacing* alchemy, since chemistry is different in kind than alchemy, while making it obsolete in principle. It would be strange indeed to say that chemistry *is* alchemy, for this seems to require that alchemy remains as the stable element. It is equally strange, from my point of view, to say that Logic *is* a metaphysics, for this implies that "metaphysics" is the stable element with which Logic can be identified. Rather, Hegel's claim that Logic *replaces* metaphysics implies that Logic is a new thing that makes metaphysics, according to its previously given identity, obsolete.

To be sure, we should not make any argument depend on a reading of the ambiguous term "replacement." My case does not depend substantially on that. Instead, what I hope to show in this chapter is that the structure of the *Logic* itself is intended to deflate metaphysics as traditionally conceived. In this project, the account of the Concept in the last chapter will play a central role. For what I believe the *Logic* attempts to show is that the concepts that have been used in order to present the objects of metaphysical inquiry – concepts like <substance>, <cause>, and <essence> – are grounded in the logical forms of thought or the Concept. This logical grounding of the concepts of metaphysics prevents metaphysical inquiry from being theoretical in a broad sense. That is, it prevents metaphysics from being a science that aims to present the nature of an independently given subject matter.[4]

[3] See, e.g., *WL* I 61/42; *EL* § 24.
[4] On this conception of "theoretical" (and Hegel's view of its limitations), see especially Werner 2020.

Rather, metaphysics (or what replaces it) is essentially the self-articulation of the structure of thought, or Logic.

The conception of metaphysics that Hegel aims to overcome has a focal concept: <substance>. Hegel himself does not avoid appropriating this concept in his own work; his use of it is complex and varied. But a certain role for the concept of substance, evident most clearly in Spinoza, makes that concept stand for the theory-independent object of metaphysics as such. It is the definitive concept for what there is "anyway." In my view, Hegel denies *any* concept this significance. The drama at the center of the *Logic* is Hegel's attempt to show that the "truth" of the concept of substance is in fact the Concept itself. As he writes, "the relation of substantiality, considered simply *on its own* [an und für such *betrachtet*], leads to its opposite: it passes over into the *concept*" (*WL* II 250/512). What does this mean? In my view, to be spelled out as we proceed, it means that metaphysics as it was supposed to be – an inquiry into the nature of the theory-independent object – turns out to be grounded in thought's own self-investigation of its own form. Metaphysics presents thought's thinking of itself: our metaphysical knowledge takes the shape of logical knowledge.

That this is a view Hegel defends *within* the heart of the *Logic* itself may not be obvious. But I believe this is the key to remarks that Hegel often makes concerning the foundational status of the *Concept Logic* with respect to *Being* and *Essence*, or the Objective Logic. Here are a few important, though elusive, passages:

> It is precisely the Concept that *contains* [*enthält in sich*] all *the earlier determinations of thinking sublated within itself*. . . . [T]he Concept is what is utterly concrete, precisely because *it contains Being and Essence, and hence all the riches of both these spheres*, within itself in ideal unity. (*EL* § 160Z, 307–8/236, my emphasis)

> Being and essence are therefore moments of [the concept's] becoming; but the concept is their *foundation* and *truth* as the identity into which they have sunk and in which they are contained. (*WL* II 245/508)

> The concept is the truth of the substantial relation in which being and essence attain their perfect self-subsistence and determination each through the other. (*WL* II 269/526)

Hegel sees the *Concept Logic* as "containing" in some way the content of the Objective Logic and as being its foundation. This claim has not been a major focus of Hegel scholarship. In this chapter, I hope to make this key element of the *Logic* comprehensible and suggest its fundamental significance for the self-understanding of metaphysics. I believe that the claim

that the *Concept Logic* contains or grounds the Objective Logic is equivalent to the claim that metaphysical concepts have their grounds in the forms of thought, including judgments and syllogisms. This implies that metaphysics (as Logic) is not a theoretical science, in the sense of having a theory-independent object for its investigation. In short, Logic replaces metaphysics.

The chapter that follows cannot pretend to put forth a convincing systematic account of the structure of the *Logic* as a whole. My aim is first (in Section 4.2) to present an outline of what the Objective Logic attempts to achieve on its own terms. In my view, the determinations of the Objective Logic are used without consideration of their place in the world: their reference is "suspended." This means, for example, that when Hegel uses a term like "being," we cannot assume that he is using it to pick something out and describe its nature. The same holds for the final major concept, <substance> or <substantiality> (Section 4.3), which I argue does not form the basis of Hegel's "theory" of substance or substantiality. Using this case as an example (Section 4.4), I argue that Hegel's aim in the transition to the *Concept Logic* – followed through in the course of the book – is to show that the metaphysical concept <substantiality> is nothing other than the concept of the form of thought in general, namely <universality>. This claim then generalizes. In Section 4.5, I try to show that Hegel's elusive claims about the *Concept* being the foundation of *Being* and *Essence* amount to a sustained program within the *Concept Logic*, namely of showing how various forms of thought are grounds of the concepts previously investigated (then in *suspense*) in the earlier Objective Logic. The consequence is that all metaphysical concepts are, at least ideally and potentially, clear to view. They are of what is essentially close to hand for the thinking subject, and thus not akin to the objects of a theory.

4.2 The Status of the Objective Logic

I said in Chapter 1 that Hegel's *Science of Logic* differs from typical metaphysical texts because it is not easily interpreted as making *claims* or assertions. I now wish to clarify this statement with respect to the Objective Logic in particular. Hegel says specifically in the introduction to the Objective Logic that this book "takes the place rather of the former *metaphysics* which was supposed to be the scientific edifice of the world as constructed by *thoughts* alone." He then says that "it is *ontology* which objective logic most directly replaces in the first instance, that is, that part of metaphysics intended to investigate the nature of *ens* in general"

(*WL* I 61/42). It is common to take passages like this as evidence that the Objective Logic *is* an ontology, Hegel's own theory of the nature of "being," rather than his replacement for such a theory. However, just below this remark, Hegel clarifies how his approach will differ from previous metaphysics. He says this kind of metaphysics produces theories about "substrata" – like God, the soul, and the world – that *use* fundamental determinations of thought without first investigating these determinations in themselves. Specifically comparing his own approach to Kant's, he writes, "That metaphysics neglected to do this, and it therefore incurred the just reproach that it employed the pure forms of thought *uncritically* [ohne Kritik], without previously investigating whether and how they could be the determinations of the thing-in-itself, to use Kant's expression – or more precisely, of the rational" (61–2/42). The solution to this problem, which he thinks even Kant neglected to do, is to investigate the basic determinations of thought *prior* to the making of assertions about their supposed objects. Hence, he writes, "The objective logic is therefore the true critique of such determinations – a critique that considers them, not according to the abstract form of the *a priori* as contrasted with the *a posteriori*, but in themselves according to their particular content" (62/42). To consider thought determinations "in themselves" is simply to consider them in abstraction from their association with certain objects or contexts. It is something like a pure conceptual analysis. Hegel even writes to his friend Niethammer in 1812, the year the first book of the *Logic* was published, that the concepts of the *Logic* "are independent of metaphysical system; they occur in transcendental idealism as well as in dogmatism; the former calls them determinations of *entium*, the latter [determinations] of the understanding" (W 4: 407). This could only be possible if Hegel's treatment of concepts does not amount to a metaphysical system.

Hegel is clear on several occasions that the need simply to consider the concepts in and for themselves is both important in itself and not adequately satisfied by previous metaphysics. This kind of systematic investigation of concepts, absent first-order theorizing, is a new project relative to its predecessors. Thus, the Objective Logic is a replacement of ontology because it substitutes a new discipline for ontology. Whereas ontology would be taken already as a first-order theory of the nature of "being" – setting aside complications about what that term means[5] – Hegel

[5] It is worth noting that a common tendency in the literature involves assuming that a term like "being" naturally carries with it a reference to the world as a whole, or reality. This assumption is of course even questionable on grammatical grounds, as the term "*sein*" is first an infinitive, and more directly carries with it the verbal sense of "to be." See note 13 in this chapter.

substitutes a treatment of the concepts or thought determinations of ontology. This discipline no longer makes straightforward assertions about the objects of metaphysics, but merely clarifies the content of certain concepts, with a view toward challenging their first-order theoretical significance.

Hegel's Objective Logic is thus a critical project, first in a Kantian sense, in that it is an attempt to investigate the concepts prior to their theoretical use, akin to Kant's attempt to investigate the faculties of cognition prior to their use in metaphysics. But it is a critical project in a second, more familiar sense as well. That is, Hegel expects to determine the contents of metaphysical contents, but also to show their limitations. Hegel alludes to the potentially destructive results of such a project at the outset of the *Logic*: "When the thought determinations which are only external forms are seriously considered in themselves, the result can only be the demonstration of their finitude and of the untruth of their supposed being-for-itself, and that the concept is their truth" (W I 30/19). Referring elsewhere to the thought determinations of rationalist metaphysics, Hegel writes,

> First, these determinations, in their abstraction, were taken to be valid on their own account, and capable of being *predicates of what is true*. In any case, this metaphysics presupposed that cognition of the Absolute could come about through the *attaching of predicates to it*; and it investigated neither the peculiar content and validity of the determinations of the understanding, nor yet this form of determining the Absolute by attaching predicates to it. (*EL* § 28, 94/66)

He continues in the corresponding Remark:

> *Being there*, for instance, is a predicate of this kind like in the proposition, "God is there"; or *finitude* and *infinity*, in the question whether the world is finite or infinite; or *simple* and *composite*, in the proposition, "The soul is *simple*"; or, again, "The thing is *one*, a *whole*," etc. – There was no investigation of whether predicates of this kind are something true in and for themselves, nor of whether the form of the judgment could be the form of truth. (§ 28 R, 94/66)

Hegel suggests that it may not be a safe assumption that the concepts of metaphysics are appropriate "predicates of what is true." For example, concepts or predicates like <simple>, <composite>, <cause>, or <thing> might be taken to be completely general and unproblematic in their application. Such an assumption was indeed made in the rationalist tradition of metaphysics. So, for example, that God is the "cause" of the world might be thought of in the same breath as that smoking is the "cause" of cancer: both use a broad and general-purpose concept of <cause>.

A thinker like Kant would challenge the applicability of the concept <cause> in the theological case not because of the limitations of the pure concept <cause> itself but because of the sensible conditions attaching to our use of this and any other theoretical concepts. Hegel thinks even this may be assuming too much. It might be that there are rather intrinsic limitations in the content of (or "finitude" to) the concept of a cause, such that even to ask whether God is the cause of the world would be something like a category mistake. Likewise, asking whether the soul is simple or composite might already be to treat the soul as if it were a mere thing, comparable in kind to a physical object, thus using a concept in an infelicitous application. In other words, certain misleading metaphysical questions may arise from hidden assumptions built into the concepts involved in our theorizing. The solution for Hegel is not a critique of cognition, along the lines of Kant, but a critique of thought determinations themselves, prior to theory.

Thus, the Objective Logic is a critical examination of the thought determinations of metaphysics. Of course, it is not a haphazard and piecemeal conceptual analysis but an attempt to generate the thought determinations through a rational dialectical sequence. Each concept earns its place in the sequence only by being a necessary consequence of its predecessors, and any limitations would not be exposed by an external form of criticism, but within their own development.[6]

If we appreciate this critical aim of the Objective Logic, we are closer to understanding why this part of the *Logic* cannot be making *assertions* or proposing *theories* about its supposed objects. For example, if the project is critical in the sense outlined above, it cannot be that each concept Hegel treats is some kind of basic ingredient in the complete picture of the world. Instead, it is likely that Hegel makes statements using the concepts of metaphysics *without* making claims about the world. This may sound strange. What is the alternative to making claims?[7]

To make this intelligible, I want to argue that Hegel's statements in the Objective Logic employ what I will call *suspended reference*.[8] A term is used under suspended reference if it is used in a sentence without the speaker

[6] As Rosen (2014: 213) puts it, "The objective logic . . . is a presentation of the incoherent conceptual structure of classical and modern (i.e., pre-Hegelian) ontology. But one can present this conceptual incoherence only *conceptually*."

[7] Though they do not use the precise notion of suspended reference as I develop it in what follows, I take the account of Hegel's project in the Logic to be in broad sympathy with those such as Hartmann 1972; Marconi 1980; Berto 2007; de Boer 2010a; Nuzzo 2010; McCumber 2014, among others.

[8] I do not mean every sentence in the *Science of Logic* employs suspended reference, of course, but only the statements that constitute the philosophical core of the work.

being committed existentially to its (apparent) object. It is now mainstream in the philosophy of language that much of our use of terms – especially names – is directly referential. Though there are different ways to cash this out, a simple way of doing so is to say that a speaker intends to use a term directly referentially when the meaning of the term should be restricted to the object it is supposed to point out. That is, the word functions as a mere *name*. And for this reason, no special collateral knowledge *about* its object is needed for its proper use. To take a classic example, whether or not I know what disguises birch and beech trees, the term "birch" has a meaning that is fixed by a certain class of birch trees. When I use "birch," the meaning of the term *is* that class of trees, whether or not I know this.

Hence, when a term is used with direct reference, we are often helpless to specify its meaning except disquotationally. Thus, we might say:

"birches" refers to birches

or

"water" refers to H_2O,

for a less seemingly trivial case. These formulations may seem uninformative. But the point is that the mention of the expression on the left only has meaning by the implicitly referential use on the right. As far as I'm concerned here, it may be that the meanings of many terms can't be specified any more precisely than by saying what objects they refer to, in just this kind of way. We carry with us naïve and usually unproblematic commitment to the objects we are talking about.

The need for suspended reference arises when such commitment cannot be taken for granted. It seems to me that we encounter this need, especially if not exclusively, in philosophical thought. It may be useful to consider some examples outside of Hegel. Philosophers like Zeno and Hume wrote about motion and miracles, respectively; they even make statements that have "motion" or "miracles" as their grammatical subjects. But apparently they did not believe in these objects, respectively. Thus, when we interpret and report the words of these philosophers, we cannot rightly say, in Zeno,

"motion" refers to motion.

Or, in Hume,

"miracles" refers to miracles.[9]

[9] That is, we cannot rightly say these supposing that the "refers to . . ." component is specifying the source of the meaning of the words in quotations. Likewise, we cannot explain the meaning of "phlogiston" by saying "'phlogiston' refers to phlogiston."

Zeno and Hume can speak about these topics because they have some notion of what it *would* take to be motion or a miracle, without assuming that their use of terms commit them to thinking either "thing" exists. Hence, they use these terms under suspended reference. Accordingly, there is a sense in which they can make statements "about" motion and miracles, but we cannot say that they make *claims* about miracles and motions, since this would seem to imply that their statements were beholden to certain objects, about which their statements could be right or wrong.

In the context of this chapter, we can use slanted brackets ('/ . . . /') to designate a term under suspended reference. Thus, when Hume (2007: 83) says of miracles, for example, that they are violations of the laws of nature, we can represent this as:

a /miracle/ is a /violation of the laws of nature/

since one can affirm this statement without thinking *either* the subject or the predicate is instantiated.

It is important to recognize that suspended reference stands *in contrast* to second-order reference to a concept, which I mark in this book with angled brackets ('< . . . >'). The use of suspended reference allows Hume to say that "miracles are violations of the laws of nature" without being committed to miracles. But the same statement cannot be paraphrased "the concept of a miracle is a violation of the laws of nature," which is obviously false. (We do not violate laws of nature in thinking a concept.) Suspended reference is a genuine way to *use* a concept, and not only mention it, while avoiding commitment to its object.[10]

I should clarify that suspended reference is *indifference* to reference, not *antipathy* to it. I have already admitted that direct reference may well be the most basic form of meaning, so that the appeal to suspended reference does not embody any skepticism about reference in general. But it is also not incompatible for a term that is once used under suspended reference that it come to be used to refer. Suppose Hume determines miracles to be thus and so, unsure whether there is any such thing. Still, the concept thus considered might well find instances, which would be determined by the content given under suspended reference. What matters is simply that the sense of a term like "miracle," if given under suspended reference, must not

[10] Robert Brandom draws attention to a related phenomenon (which is theoretically significant for him) in ordinary speech and writing, which is the use of terms within "scare quotes." See Brandom 1994: 545–7, 589.

be determined *by* its reference, but must itself act as a criterion for any supposed referent.

How does this relate to Hegel's *Logic*? While the explicit question of the reference of the *Logic* is not often raised in the scholarship on Hegel, one way of understanding the readings that call themselves "metaphysical" is precisely as *referential* readings of the *Logic*. That is, what marks these readings out as metaphysical is that they take some central term or concept of the *Logic* to stand for its central object of reference. A clear and prominent instance of this, I believe, is Stephen Houlgate's understanding of Hegel's talk of "being" (*Sein*). For Houlgate, what it means for Hegel to overcome the Kantian critique of metaphysics is his willingness to disclose the nature of "being" and to undermine the apparent opposition between thought and being. Though he doesn't put it this way, I think it is clear from Houlgate's work that "being" is understood as a kind of master referent of the *Logic*, as standing in for "reality" or the "world." He writes, for example: "the indeterminate being with which we begin [in the *Logic*] *itself* mutates, logically, into the realm of finite things and objects, and eventually nature, that surrounds us. Logic thus does, indeed, disclose the true character of what is 'out there'" (2021: 109).[11] While Houlgate doesn't think Hegel's *Logic presupposes* the determinate character of the world, the progressive determination of its content is a progressive determination of *that*.

For Houlgate, Hegel's *Logic* concerns "being" in some emphatic sense: a sense opposed to mere thinking, for example.[12] And Houlgate's use of "being" is not idiosyncratic. Perhaps many philosophers use the term to mean something like all of what there is. But is this what *Hegel* means when he begins the *Logic* with <being>?[13] For my part, it is hard to see how this conception of <being> is compatible with Hegel's critical aims in the Objective Logic. Hegel wants to examine *all* the concepts used in metaphysics prior to their role in assertions about their supposed objects. And

[11] Houlgate (2005: 44) glosses "being as such" as "that which we otherwise call 'existence' or 'actuality.'"

[12] Houlgate (2021: 110–11) writes: "The impression created by such passages [sc. in which Hegel seems to say the *Logic* is just about thinking] is, however, contradicted by others in which Hegel makes it clear that logic is, indeed, concerned with unambiguous *being*." See also Dunphy 2023: 5; McNulty 2023: 92–5.

[13] There are historical reasons not to accept Houlgate's reading of "being" as a mandatory one. The important work of Charles Kahn (2009) argues that being became a topic of philosophy precisely in its "veritative" meaning – i.e., being is *truth*. Hegel at least sometimes uses "being" in this sense. (Among Hegelians, Theunissen [1980] is one of the few to take Kahn's work as a reference point.) A further option is treating Hegel discussion as focusing on being in the infinitive, i.e., "to be," which no longer looks like an object of reference.

this must include <being/*Sein*>. If we accept a key concept like <being> as referential, Hegel will be read as progressively committed to more and more in his account of the nature of being. There is little space, if any, for Hegel's critical aims to be carried through. Followed through to the end of the Objective Logic, Hegel will be committed to the nature of being as *substance*, and thus be a kind of Spinozist. Indeed, Houlgate – along with many others – claims just this.[14] Though such interpreters acknowledge a critical dimension to Hegel's treatment of concepts in the Objective Logic, they also take on a significant set of positive theoretical commitments.

The alternative is to think of Hegel's *Logic* as employing suspended reference in a more complete and systematic way than thinkers like Hume and Zeno. This implies that a proposition of the form:

> Being is in fact nothing[15]

may not be a statement about the identity of being or a predication of being, understood as an object. It may be represented rather as

> /being/ is /nothing/

where the angled brackets signify terms whose reference is suspended, so that the meaning of /being/ is the mere *sense* of the concept <being> (i.e., "to be"), without any supposition of what its referent is, or even that it has one. This treatment of /being/ under suspended reference permits us to further determine the concept <being> by using it, and not just mentioning it.

The need for suspended reference arises from two features of Hegel's project that we have already observed: first, Hegel's claim that the concepts of metaphysics need to be investigated before they are assigned to certain "substrata" in the world. Hegel seems to make a distinguishing factor of his approach his refusal to decide how the relevant concepts attach to the objects of traditional metaphysical investigation. This seems to motivate the turn to suspended reference. Second, there is Hegel's suggestion that the results of his investigation will often show the scope and limitations of metaphysical concepts, thus not resulting in a positive theory but a mere critique. Simply put, it is hard to envision what it would be like to critique the referent of a term when understood as the object of naïve reference. We can understand, for example, a critique of the *concept* of identity; it is hard to understand a critique of identity 'itself.' For presumably the real identity relation (whatever it is) is in good order. Hence, if Hegel is going to *use* and

[14] See, e.g., Houlgate 2021: 132. [15] See *WL* I 82/59.

not just mention concepts like <identity> in his critical investigation, it seems that something like suspended reference is required.

In my view, Hegel's project of determining concepts without assigning them a referent (or assuming otherwise that they have one) is truly unique in the history of philosophy. It enables him to criticize metaphysics without incurring theoretical metaphysical commitments himself, while also eschewing a complex account of our epistemic capacities.[16] In the next section, I will spell out the consequences of this reading further with respect to the notion of substance, with which the Objective Logic concludes.

4.3 Substance and the End of the Objective Logic

The above account of concepts in the Objective Logic is important to bear in mind when considering the status of Hegel's statements about <substance> (and related concepts) at the end of the Objective Logic. If Hegel's treatment of concepts in the *Logic* amounts to his own progressive metaphysical theory, then Hegel's claims about <substance> will amount to his own theory of substance (outside of any brackets). Though the move to the later stages of the *Logic* may *modify* this theory, they will not make it obsolete. However, if Hegel's treatment of /substance/ is carried out under suspended reference, prior to the concept's use in a theory, then there is no need to assume that his treatment of the concept is also his own theory. This latter option is essential to my own reading of the transition from the Objective to the Subjective Logic. Hegel's transition to the *Concept Logic* is

[16] This account of the *Logic* may seem vulnerable to an objection James Kreines (2015: 13–15, 140–4) has developed against readings of Hegel like this one. What he calls the "swimming argument" is Hegel's repeated challenge (see, e.g., *EL* § 10R) to a procedure that would begin to approach problems of metaphysics by first considering the possibility of attaining such metaphysical knowledge (i.e., learning to swim before swimming). Accordingly, Kreines says that accounts of the Logic that begin with "semantics" (or epistemology) are guilty of precisely the error that Hegel warns against. In my view, Hegel's argument has a narrower target: it is a challenge to the examination of cognitive faculties before doing metaphysics. And the reason for that is a specific one. To examine one cognitive faculty, we must rely on *some* other cognitive faculty that is not being examined at the time. Accordingly, the critical project, construed as an examination of faculties, can never be complete, unless it rests dogmatically on some unexamined faculty. My account would be vulnerable to an analogous critique only if I tried to give a *theory* of the meaning of concepts independently of concepts themselves. But my account does not depend on such a theory. Cf. Lau 2016: 33. Moreover, Hegel specifically complains that Kant failed to perform the task of examining concepts prior to his critique. He objects that Kant did not consider concepts "in and for themselves." He writes: "the material of the senses, the manifoldness of intuition, was too strong for [Kant] to be able to wrest himself away from it and turn to a consideration of the concept and the categories *in and for themselves*, and to a speculative form of philosophizing" (*WL* II 267/524). For a fuller discussion of the swimming argument, with which I am sympathetic, see Hettig-Rolfe 2024.

his attempt to show that the concepts of "former metaphysics" are grounded in the logical forms of the Concept. But this is only possible if Hegel is not already committed to a metaphysical theory in the Objective Logic.

To see how this works, let us first consider the basic setup of the end of the Objective Logic. At the end of the *Doctrine of Essence*, Hegel presents an account of what he calls "The Absolute Relation" in a chapter of the same name. The Absolute Relation chapter is the final larger development within the "Actuality" (*Die Wirklichkeit*) section of *Essence*, which is preceded by two previous chapters, first "The Absolute" (*Das Absolute*) and second (also titled) "Actuality." These chapters develop a metaphysical picture that is recognizably Spinozist, if not Spinoza's own. In a remark, Hegel says explicitly that "to the concept of the Absolute and the relations of reflection to it, as presented here, corresponds *the concept of Spinozian substance*" (*WL* II 195/472). Indeed, though the term "substance" is not one of the section or chapter titles in Actuality, Hegel often uses it to summarize the culmination of the whole movement;[17] I will follow suit. Accordingly, I will describe the transition between *Essence* and *Concept* as the comprehension of *substance* by the Concept. Though I will not give a full account of this stage of the *Logic*, at least some background is needed to explain my understanding of the transition between *Essence* and *Concept*.

The *Doctrine of Essence* as a whole arises as a result of the *Doctrine of Being*.[18] *Being* is perhaps the most straightforward section of the *Logic*. Beginning from the trio of determinations <being>, <nothing>, <becoming>, it develops increasingly determinate concepts for the characterization of what "immediately" is.[19] These include concepts like <quality>, <quantity>, <limit>, <infinity>, and <measure>. Once this movement is completed, Hegel says that *Essence* arises as a "negation" of the whole preceding series.[20] In my view, the concepts of *Essence* are not "further determinations" of <being>.[21] Instead, the concepts of *Essence* result from a kind of

[17] See, e.g., the account of the "genesis of the Concept" in *Concept* (*WL* II 245 ff./508 ff.) where "substance" is almost always the name of the antecedent.

[18] To simplify, I will sometimes abbreviate *The Doctrine of Being* as *Being*, the same *mutatis mutandis* for *Essence* and *Concept*.

[19] Though the *Logic* as a whole is often described as beginning with the indeterminate and developing more determinate concepts, in my view this mode of progression is *only* apt within *Being*. The two remaining books of the *Logic* have different tasks. Though defending this claim is not the main goal of this chapter, some evidence for it will appear in what follows.

[20] See *WL* II 13/337; 16/339; 18–19/341–2.

[21] "This determining [in *Essence*] is thus of a different nature than the determining in the sphere of *Being*, and the determinations of *Essence* have a different character than the determinations of *Being*" (*WL* II 15/338).

dualism that opens up between <being> and *reflection*. To simplify, <essence> seems to arise because, considering all that develops in the "immediacy" of what *is*, one can still ask: but what *else* is there? What is still *hidden* or *behind* or *beyond* mere being (see *WL* II 13/337)? This attempt to transcend <being> does not eliminate the latter, but rather alters its status. At least in the larger *Logic*, the status of <being> is found to be <semblance>. The status change is more suggestive in German: *Sein* becomes *Schein* (19/341). Being is now mere seeming.[22] In contrast, in *Essence* the "true" is what is higher than what immediately is, and thus the negation of <being>. The altering of the status of being Hegel relates to the move of a skeptical philosopher, who in some sense retains the content of "the whole manifold domain of the world" (20/342–3) but claims that this world is mere appearance. This is a transposition (Hegel calls it a "translation": 20/342) by which being becomes "reflection" (*Reflexion*). Reflection thus opens up a sphere of thought that is not tied to what is supposed to be immediately. Accordingly, *Essence* includes a discussion of the "laws of thought" that require thinking of the contents of thought as having self-relations ("Identity") and relations to other thoughts (i.e., "Distinction" and "Contradiction"). It should be observed that these are the *kind* of determinations that could apply to thoughts *even if* they were not of any existing object.

Essence thus originates from a standpoint in which pure thought (reflection) and "being" stand in opposition, since the former arises as a negation from the latter. As Hegel writes in the *EL*,

> This part of the Logic . . . contains most notably the categories of metaphysics and of the sciences generally; – it contains them as products of the reflecting understanding, which both assumes the distinctions as *independent* and at the same time posits their relationality *as well*. But it only ties the two assumptions together . . . it does not bring these thoughts together it does not unity them into the Concept. (*EL* § 114 R, 236/179)

Hence, the early stages of *Essence* develop several more specific oppositions, including that between form and content, ex-istence[23] and appearance,

[22] "The same determinations occur in the development of Essence as in the developing of being – but they occur in *reflected* form" (*EL* § 114R, 235/179). "Being has not vanished [in Essence]; but, in the first place, essence as simple relation to itself is being; while on the other hand, being, according to its one-sided determination of being *something-immediate*, is *degraded* to something merely negative, to a *shine* [or *semblance*]" (*EL* § 112, 231/175).

[23] I use "ex-istence" for Hegel's "*Existenz*" (translated "concrete existence" by di Giovanni) to mark a distinction from "*Dasein*." Hegel emphasizes that what ex-ists (*existiert*) comes out of or "emerges" from its ground (see *EL* § 123Z); hence it seems fitting to single out the "ex."

thing and property, and so on. All the oppositions in some way incorporate the earlier sphere of *Being* in juxtaposition with the sphere of reflection proper to *Essence*.[24] However, none of these dichotomies are permanent. At each stage, Hegel shows how the members of the oppositions depend on each other and resolve into one another. In the final main movement, the Actuality section is meant to show how the dualisms of *Essence* can be unified: "Actuality is the *unity of essence and ex-istence*; in it, *shapeless* essence and *unstable* appearance – or subsistence without determination and manifoldness without permanence – have their truth" (*WL* II 186/465). This means, in particular, that the supposedly *negated* categories of *Being* are fully reincorporated into <actuality>, whose first stage is titled "the Absolute." All throughout the Actuality chapter, Hegel alludes to this incorporation.[25] Actuality seems to bring into a single picture the concepts sundered by the dualism wrought by *Essence*.

To put this in other terms, the final concepts of the *Essence Logic* are important because they in some way contain all the previous concepts of *Being* within them. It is as if the determinations of the Objective Logic are all attributes of actuality or substance. It is in this way that one can understand Hegel's attitude that Spinozism in general (taken more as an orientation than as a depiction of Spinoza's own views) represents a kind of summing-up of the whole tradition of metaphysics. Hegel even says: "Spinoza is the high-point of modern philosophy. Either Spinozism or no philosophy" (W 20: 163–4, quoted from Franks 2005: 84). A system like Spinozism shows that all basic concepts of metaphysics can be placed within a single whole.[26]

Many readers of Hegel have believed he is some sort of Spinozist, and from the preceding account, it is not hard to see how one could gain this impression. Of course, everything hangs on what Hegel is *endorsing* in the picture of substance he presents. Further still, is Hegel endorsing it as suitable to *refer* to something that is assumed (or perhaps shown) to exist?

4.4 The Transition from Substance to the Concept

I believe that there is a clear alternative to reading Hegel as endorsing the apparent Spinozism at the end of *Essence*. Namely, Hegel presents this

[24] See on this point Theunissen 1980: 35–7.

[25] For example, the "movement of accidentality" – which signifies the mere formal identity of what Hegel calls "substantiality" – "exhibits in each of its moments the mutual reflective shine of the *categories* of being and of the *reflective determinations* of essence" (*WL* II 219/490).

[26] On the unsurpassed influence of Spinozism on the generation prior to Hegel, see Beiser 1987: ch. 2.

Spinozist picture of substance only to undermine it by explaining its true basis. The theory of substance takes itself to be a complete and universal picture of the world, which even includes thought and mind within itself. What Hegel aims to show is that the 'entity' that the theory of substance is actually tracking is nothing other than the mere *form* of thought, or the Concept. Hence, it does not present a general picture of the world as a whole. It presents thought's own thinking of itself – which only needs to be recognized as such to be undermined *as* a theory of something else.

The key basis for this interpretation is the important and difficult passage at the transition between *Essence* and *Concept*. The passage expresses what the "absolute substance" becomes on the cusp of the Subjective Logic. Though it is extremely dense, it is worth quoting at length to see the important pattern contained in it:

> No longer, therefore, does absolute substance as self-differentiating absolute form repel itself as necessary from itself, nor does it fall apart as *contingency* into indifferent, external substances, but, on the contrary, it *differentiates* itself: *on the one hand*, into the totality (the heretofore passive substance) which is at the origin, as the reflection from internal determinateness, as simple whole that contains its *positedness* within itself and *in this positedness is posited as self-identical* – this is *the universal* –; *on the other hand* into the totality (the hitherto causal substance) which is the reflection, equally from internal determinateness, into the negative determinateness which . . . equally is the whole, but posited as the *self-identical negativity* – the singular. But, because the *universal* is self-identical only in that the *determinateness* that it holds within is *sublated* . . . it immediately is *the same negativity* that *singularity* is. And the singularity, because it equally is the determinedly determined, the negative as negative, immediately is *the same identity* that *universality* is. This, their *simple* identity, is the *particularity* that, from the singular, holds the moment of *determinateness*; from the universal, that of immanent *reflection* – the two in immediate unity. (*WL* II 240/505)

To recall, a referential reading of the Objective Logic will treat Hegel's remarks about "absolute substance" as committing him to a theory about the absolute substance as an actual entity. On the reading I am proposing, a given remark about /absolute substance/ is potentially only elucidating the concept <absolute substance>. But, in this passage, Hegel is doing something else as well. He is suggesting that features that belong to the conceptual determination of <absolute substance> are in fact logical moments of the Concept: universality, particularity, and singularity. The relation or movement described is something like this:

Passive substance → Self-differentiating positedness → Universality

Causal substance → Self-identical negativity → Singularity
Identity of the two sides → Immanent reflection → Particularity

The left-most side are elements of Hegel's final development of <actuality> or <absolute substance>. Actuality has divided itself into a passive and active substance, which are bound together in interaction (*Wechselwirkung*). These two "sides" to actuality are meant to resemble the two attributes of the Spinozian substance. Hegel suggests that a distinction between two attributes develops into a new "interactive" (*wechselwirkend*) substance, in which the distinction between the sides is somewhat blurred.

The key question here concerns the relation of the left-most side to the right-most side in this picture. Is, for example, the "heretofore passive substance" *also* the universality of the Concept, or is it *nothing but* the universality of the concept?[27] The difference is important. If the "also" holds sway, Hegel's moment of universality in the Concept is something added to the account of substance (i.e., it is the logical structure of substance itself); the commitment to substance remains but undergoes further development as a specifically logical structure. Universality would be something like a further attribute of the one substance. But if passive substance is *nothing* but universality, the latter is shown to be the basis of substance, but also to take its place: what we thought was substance was really logical universality – and nothing else. So no commitment to substance remains, for substance is replaced by something else.[28]

In my view, the latter "replacement" interpretation is the correct one. Hegel is not committed to the "absolute substance" he describes. He tries to show that the thought of absolute substance is nothing other than the (unwitting) thought of the Concept; each moment of the absolute substance is unmasked as a moment of the Concept. Recall from the last chapter that the power of thought that Hegel calls the Concept is a fully

[27] For complementary readings of the issue, see, e.g., Iber 2003; Sandkaulen 2023: ch. 15.

[28] Di Giovanni has recently argued that the famous passage in Hegel's *Phenomenology* in which Hegel is often read as saying "the True" should be grasped *not only* as substance but *also* as subject can be understood along similar lines as my reading of the transition in the *Logic*. He points out that the passage has been widely misunderstood and even mistranslated. The passage says "not as *substance*" ("nicht als *Substanz*") rather than "not only" or "not just." Di Giovanni (2021: 199) writes, "One needs to expand Hegel's otherwise elliptic statement to bring out its meaning clearly: 'In my view . . . all depends on grasping and expressing the True, not as *substance*, but [on grasping and expressing it] rather as *subject just* as much [as not as *substance*].' The 'so sehr' has the meaning of 'as strongly,' as when one says, 'es regnet sehr,' 'it rains hard.' The point is that one must grasp and express the True as subject exactly as much as one must grasp and express it as *not* substance. The rest of the paragraph confirms this reading."

comprehensive power: thought does not acknowledge anything that stands outside of its grasp, if for no other reason than that the emptiness of bare universality allows it to do no violence to what it comprehends. Logical universality presents the thinker with a kind of totality without outer bounds. Now, relying on this kind of insight, Hegel is suggesting something like the following: the supposed grasp of a universal "thing" one wants to call substance is nothing but the implicit grasp of the universal, if empty, form of mere thought. It is as if a thinker like Spinoza, in the grip of the power of his own thinking, failed to grasp the true source of his theory's insight, which is nothing but that power of thinking itself. The metaphysician's description of substance holds of *something*, but not of what the metaphysician supposes: for it only describes the empty form of thought. Hence, far from endorsing a metaphysics like Spinoza, Hegel's transition to the Concept deflates all such metaphysics.

The transition is more thoroughly explained at the beginning of the *Concept Logic*. Specifically, Hegel is there clearer on why his account of substance should amount to a *refutation* of Spinozism. He writes:

> This [concept], the totality resulting from the relation of interaction, is the unity of the *two substances* that stand in that relation, but in such a way now that the two belong to freedom, since they no longer had their identity as blind, i.e., as something *intrinsic*, but have the determination that they are essentially *semblance* or moments of reflection, and for that reason each has immediately rejoined its other or its positedness. (*WL* II 251/513)

Hegel's claim here seems to be that the two "substances" at the end of *Essence* are reduced again to moments of mere *reflection* or *semblance*. That is, though one side of <actuality> or <substantiality>, the "causal" substance, is meant to refer to something real and independent of thought, it too is found to be a moment of pure thought or reflection. Both "sides" of substance turn out to be two moments within reflection itself, and thus moments of logical form. Substance turns out to be mere "positedness" and an empty self-referential identity (251/513).

Part of Hegel's argument depends on an appeal to the thinking that is active in philosophy itself. The Spinozian system places thought within itself as one of its attributes (cf. *WL* II 250/512). But this subordination of thought to substance is only possible by the very use of that power. It seems incoherent, at least methodologically, to place the thinking that makes concepts like <substance> possible under the supervision of any such concept. For even if one were committed to the existence of substance, the power to think will always refuse to be contained within it, will always

be more free that that to which it is supposed to be subordinate, if for no other reason than the power to think is also the power to *distinguish* oneself from substance (or whatever is taken to represent what really is), to think both the true and the false.[29] Thought's power to posit itself, even to incorporate itself into a subordinate position in a metaphysical system, thus depends on what Hegel calls the Concept. The very ability of thought to posit itself as a moment of substance demonstrates the power that thought has to free itself from such a substance. Hence, it cannot be that <thought> is a moment within <substance>; at best, <substance> must be a moment within <thought>.

It may be helpful to point out that the very same kind of deflationary move toward Spinozian "substance" was widely attributed to Fichte, whose system was early recognized as an "inverted Spinozism."[30] Akin to Hegel (in my reading), Fichte clearly thinks that his notion of the "I" *replaces* features of the Spinozian substance. He writes:

> Dogmatism's supreme unity is *in fact nothing other than the unity of consciousness*, and it cannot be anything else; and its thing in itself is the substrate of divisibility as such, or the supreme substance, within which are posited both I and Not-I (Spinoza's 'intellect' and 'extension'). But by no means does dogmatism elevate itself to the pure absolute I, let alone go beyond this I. (FW I: 122/223, my emphasis)

Fichte is clearly suggesting here that a system like Spinoza's *misidentifies* the true subject that lies behind its description of substance as the unity of thought and extension. This apparent unity is a misinterpretation of a different one, the one that Fichte articulates as the unity of I and Not-I, which is a division within the I. Fichte goes on to say that the theoretical part of the *Wissenschaftslehre* is "a systematic Spinozism, with the proviso that every I is itself the sole supreme substance [*nur dass eines Jeden Ich selbst die einzige höchste Substanz ist*]" (FW I: 122/223). Accordingly, Fichte

[29] Hegel alludes to this limitation on Spinoza's appeal to thought earlier in *Essence*: "Of course, substance [for Spinoza] is the absolute unity of thinking and being or extension; it therefore contains thinking itself, but only in its unity with extension, that is to say, not as separating itself from extension and hence, in general, not as determining and informing, nor as a movement of return that begins from itself. For this reason in part substance lacks the principle *of personality*" (*WL* II 195/472).

[30] This is how F. H. Jacobi (1994: 502) framed it, considering that what "had hitherto been 'substance' for [Spinoza] . . . would have disappeared before his eyes, and in exchange a pure flame would have flared up, burning all by itself, with no need of *place* or *material to nourish it: Transcendental Idealism!*" See recently the pertinent remark by Haag (2019: 145): "the pivot to the subject [sc. in Fichte] may not be interpreted as a turning to simply another substance that now fulfills the function of an absolute *ens* . . .. The concept of (divisible) substance is here subordinated to the concept of an absolute subject."

repeatedly treats his own concepts as replacements for Spinoza's. For example, we can compare Spinoza's account of a *causa sui* as "that whose essence involves existence; or that whose nature can be conceived only as existing" (Spinoza, E I, Def. 1/2006, 3) with Fichte's statement that, "*The being (essence)* [*Seyn (Wesen)*] of the I qua absolute subject *consists simply in positing itself as existing [als seyend].* It is as it *posits* itself to be, and it *posits* itself as it *is*" (FW I: 97/204). Here, Fichte's language clearly *parrots* Spinoza's, but the reasons for this imitation are deep rather than merely rhetorical. The attempt to take over Spinoza's concepts amounts to a diagnosis of the dogmatic error. The idea seems to be that we can account for what seems right about Spinoza's views by showing that he provided something like a coherent set of characteristics for the wrong 'object.' Spinoza could achieve the characterization of substance as the unity of thought and extension, and as a cause of itself, only because he implicitly grasped the nature of the I – but failed to identify the I as the source of his insight.

Hegel is making a move of the same kind, applied to the Concept rather than the I,[31] and perhaps more systematically. He completes the *Doctrine of Essence* at the point where Spinoza might seem to be vindicated: <actuality> comprises the whole content of <substance>. But just here, Hegel shows that this "dogmatic" unity can be reduced to nothing other than the relation of thought to itself. This is what makes the move to *Concept* an attempted refutation of Spinozism rather than its further development.

4.5 The Subjective Logic as Foundation

Clearly, on the reading offered so far, the Objective Logic ends on an almost entirely destructive note. Metaphysics evaporates into the mist of pure thought, and even the mere form of pure thought. However, as I have

[31] However, the proximity of Hegel to Fichte on this point should not be missed either. Though Hegel famously relates his Concept to the Kantian "I think" and therewith the unity of apperception, a number of his references to the Concept as "I" at the beginning of the *Begriffslogik* seem even more Fichtean than Kantian. This comes through especially in his use of the language of "positedness" to describe the Concept or I: "In point of fact, *comprehending* [*Begreifen*] of an object consists in nothing else than in the 'I' making it *its own*, in pervading it and bringing it into *its own* form, that is, into a *universality* which is immediately *determinateness*, or into a determinateness which is immediately universality . . .. When it comprehended, the *in-and-for-itself-ness* that it has in intuition and representation is transformed into a *positedness*; *in thinking* it, the 'I' pervades it" (WL II 255/516). In his discussion of Fichte in his *Lectures on the History of Philosophy*, Hegel even seems to credit Fichte with the fullest discovery of the "absolute concept," though not with its scientific development: "Now, Fichte has only established this concept; only, he has not brought it yet to science, to the realization [of the concept] out of itself" (*VGP* III 390).

also suggested, Hegel's ultimate aim in the *Logic* is to offer a replacement for metaphysics, not its pure destruction. This means that Hegel will ultimately find a use even for the concepts that suffer this initial loss. In this section, I will outline the way in which Hegel's Subjective Logic has a positive, reconstructive task when it comes to the metaphysical concepts of the Objective Logic. Destruction must come first, but it is not Hegel's final word.

Recall one of the passages I shared at the beginning of this chapter, which suggests that the *Concept Logic* plays a foundational role with respect to the Objective Logic: "Being and essence are therefore moments of [the concept's] becoming; but the concept is their *foundation* and *truth* as the identity into which they have sunk and in which they are contained" (WL II 245/508). Hegel acknowledges a two-fold way of understanding the progress of the *Logic* here. On the one hand, and quite obviously, Hegel says that the Concept is a development out of the *Essence Logic*. By the end of that book, we see that that substance transitions to the Concept, moments of the absolute substance turn out to be moments of logical form. But, on the other hand, the passage suggests that the linear progress of the book is something like the regression to the *ground* of the previous books. In reaching *Concept*, we find the basis of *Being* and *Essence* as well.

In my view, explaining how the *Concept Logic* could be the basis of *Being* and *Essence* is a majorly neglected task in Hegel scholarship.[32] Especially within the popular view that Hegel's *Logic is* an ontology, a theory of the nature of being, it is hard to see how it should not be the *Being Logic* that provides the foundation of the rest of the work. Many readings tend to see the *Logic* as a progressive project, and thus one whose third part builds on the foundation of the first and second. Yet Hegel seems to suggest quite the opposite.

An important clue to understanding how Hegel sees the relation of the Objective Logic to the Subjective comes from a report (*Privatgutachten*) to his friend Immanuel Niethammer in 1812, the year the first volume of the *Logic* was published. He writes there:

> According to my view, metaphysics in any case falls entirely within logic. Here I can cite Kant as my precedent and authority. His critique reduces metaphysics as it has existed until now to a consideration of the understanding and reason. *Logic can thus in the Kantian sense be understood so that, beyond the usual content of so-called general logic, what he calls transcendental*

[32] I have attempted my own attempt at this explanation in Wolf 2021. What follows reworks portions of that essay.

> *logic is bound up with it and set out prior to it* [*vorausgeschickt*] . . . . [T]hose Kantian distinctions already contain a makeshift or rough version of [my logic]. (Report to Niethammer, October 23, 1812, W 4: 406–7/Hegel 1984: 277, my emphasis)

It is first striking to note here that Hegel openly endorses Kant's plan to "reduce" metaphysics to Logic, or to "a consideration of the understanding and reason." As he explains, his claim is not that metaphysics can be reduced to general logic – roughly equivalent to formal logic – but to what Kant called "transcendental logic" as well. In short, Hegel suggests that Logic in some broad sense is "prior" to metaphysics.

If we compare this passage to those we noticed at the end of Section 4.1, the parallel is striking. In the report to Niethammer, Hegel says that "transcendental logic" is prior to metaphysics and contains it; in the elusive passages from Section 4.1, Hegel says that the *Concept Logic* is prior to *Being* and *Essence* and contains them. This parallel leads to the suggestion that the *Concept Logic* outlines a kind of transcendental logic, one so powerful that metaphysics could be reduced to it.

As Kant used the term, a transcendental logic was one that could itself be used for contentful cognition and so could contain a certain kind of principle. General logic concerns the mere form of thought. A logical form such as the *Barabara* syllogism (i.e., all A are B, and all B are C, so all A are C), at least according to Kant, does not say anything true about anything, for the variable terms are not short for "thing" or "object"; they are placeholders for concepts. A law of general logic merely specifies a rule that holds, whatever content is added to it.[33] A transcendental logic, by contrast, contains contentful rules for thought in general. When in his Transcendental Analytic, Kant aims to justify principles such as the rule that every event has a cause, or that accidents must inhere in substances, these qualify as rules of transcendental logic because they are concrete rules for thinking of any object of cognition. Incidentally, these are principles that were formerly counted as metaphysical or ontological principles. But Kant considers them to fall under a special branch of logic (i.e., transcendental) because their justification derives from being rules for thought-cum-cognition, not because they are truths about a class of things. Kant's key innovation in "transcendental logic" involved showing that certain general concepts could not be put to use without an implicit reliance on the forms of *sensory intuition*, space and time. Hence, the principle that substance remains while accident changes required, for Kant,

[33] I am especially indebted to the work of Michael Wolff (1995 and 2023) for his account of general logic in Kant and the broader tradition.

the supposition that substance *outlasts* the accident, and thus exemplified a temporal distinction from accidents (A 182/B 224; A 144/B 183).

The connection Hegel himself emphasizes to Kant leaves us wondering how Hegel's *Concept Logic* could be something like a transcendental logic. To be sure, it does not contain principles like the ones found in Kant's Transcendental Analytic. There is no question of repeating Kant's own transcendental logic. On the face of it, Hegel's *Concept Logic* looks more like a discussion of general or formal logic, since it includes a kind of derivation of a large variety of forms of judgment and syllogism. However, this appearance is somewhat misleading. Hegel's *Concept Logic* does indeed contain a sequential derivation of logical forms, but Hegel thinks these forms are more contentful than Kant supposes. Hence, Hegel says of logic as he understands it, "This formal discipline must therefore be thought of as inherently much richer in determinations and content, and also of infinitely greater efficacy over the concrete, than it is normally taken to be" (*WL* II 267–8/524–5).

But what, specifically, does Hegel's *Concept Logic* contain that is so much "richer" than logic is usually thought to be? We saw in the previous chapter that the basic form of the Concept is the unity of universality, particularity, and singularity. These are the central "moments" of logical form, indeed *all* logical form. The first part of the *Concept Logic*, the "Subjective Concept," is devoted to a derivation of further logical forms – of judgments and syllogisms – on the basis of the basic formal moments. For example, Hegel will discuss judgments that attribute a "quality" to a vanishing singular thing ("this rose is red") and distinguish them from judgments in which their basic kind is articulated ("this rose is a flower"), and still further from judgments in which a general kind is determined ("a rose is a flower"). The difference between these judgments can be understood as differences in the various roles that singularity, particularity, and universality play. These differences can be masked in traditional formal or general logic. For if we were merely offered one variable type for subject and predicate concepts, we could render each basic judgment: X is Y.[34] But this uniform variable type would cover up important differences in the form of these judgments, which has nothing to do with the specific "material" being described (roses, color, etc.). Hence, behind the various forms of judgment (and syllogism) we use,

[34] See: "This expression [sc. *the singular is universal*] must not be put in the form of 'A is B,' for A and B are totally formless and hence meaningless names, whereas judgment in general . . . has determinations of the concept for its extremes" (*WL* II 312/558).

there is a specific "logical content," which is a designation Hegel uses throughout the Subjective Concept section.[35] What Hegel calls logical content would today be treated perhaps in semantics. So, for example, the fact that a term is being used to refer to a singular thing, or that it has generic reference, or is involved in a modal claim, are all features of logical content. The logical content is not an empty form, but neither does it contain a specific reference to anything sensory. The first part of the *Concept Logic* concerns itself precisely with this logical content. I would contend that what is analogous to Kant's "transcendental logic" in Hegel's *Doctrine of the Concept* is precisely this treatment of logical content, rooted in the various semantic possibilities of the moments of the Concept.

This is the first step, then: specific logical contents (akin to types of semantic content) can be developed out of the basic moments of universality, particularity, and singularity, and these forms have content, but not a sensory content, that distinguishes them from each other. But this first step does not yet show why the *Concept* is the foundation for *Being* and *Essence*. How does that work?

This second part of the picture plays out largely on the margins of the Subjective Concept, enough so that what Hegel is doing there vis-à-vis metaphysics is often ignored.[36] I believe the key to noticing how Hegel expects the *Concept Logic* to be the foundation of the Objective Logic is his attempt to show that the metaphysical concepts of the Objective Logic are grounded on the various logical contents developed in the Subjective Logic. That is, though Hegel develops the sense or content of metaphysical concepts in the Objective Logic, he explains their *basis* in the Subjective Logic by showing how they are rooted in the logical forms.

As anticipated, this is not altogether unlike Kant's strategy of replacing traditional metaphysics. Kant shows how a concept like <substance> is rooted in a logical form, namely the subject concept of a categorical judgment, with the addition of a sensory schema. Hence, our insight into the "nature" of substance is really an insight into a capacity of our own thought. This is why he writes, "there arise exactly as many pure concepts of the understanding, which apply to objects of intuition in general *a priori*, as there were logical functions of all possible judgments in the previous table" (A 79/B 105).

[35] See Harrelson 2015 for an illuminating treatment of the importance of the diversity of logical contents in Hegel's theory of judgment.

[36] For some exceptions, see note 35 in Chapter 3.

Hegel's version of transcendental logic is an account of the various forms of semantic content in judgments and syllogisms. But, analogously to Kant, Hegel thinks that each of these forms of semantic content are the basis for metaphysical concepts. Hegel calls this the "objective meaning" (*objective Bedeutung*) of logical content. A systematic treatment of the "objective meaning" of the logical contents is beyond my purpose here, but I will offer a few examples. One of the more detailed discussions Hegel gives is of one of the basic forms of a judgment, the positive judgment. Hegel writes,

> The objective meaning of the proposition stating that *the singular is universal* conveys . . . both the perishability of singular things and their positive subsistence in the concept in general. The concept is imperishable, but that which emerges from it in its division is subjected to alteration and to falling back into its *universal* nature. But the universal, conversely, gives itself a *determinate existence*. (*WL* II 313/559, modified)

This passage claims that a singular judgment in its most basic form, the positive judgment, expresses an objective meaning, and that this objective meaning pertains to both terms involved in the judgment. The objective meaning of the positive judgment pertains, moreover, to the logical content specific to it. In this case, the subject term is a singular, and this use of a singular term implies "perishability" (*Vergänglichkeit*). The predicate is a universal term, and this term subsists outside of the singular while also attaining determinate existence (*Dasein*) in the singular.

In both elements of the logical content, some "objective" feature is attached: <perishability> and <existence>. Though Hegel's use of "perishability" may suggest a kind of natural process, it is, for Hegel, first and foremost a defining feature of what is immediately finite or has "existence" (*Dasein*) from *Being*; it stems from the disunity in these things between object and concept.[37] Yet here, Hegel sees perishability expressed in the asymmetry between subject and predicate in positive judgments. I think we can make sense of this. The singular term has, in these judgments, a potentially momentary usage. Most clearly, the referent of the "this," as Hegel demonstrates in the *Phenomenology*, changes as the sentence is repeated. Hegel's example in the context, "The rose is red," is evidently meant to be taken demonstratively, as referring to a given, singular rose.

[37] As discussed in *Being*: "It is the *definition of finite things* that in them concept and being are different; that the concept and reality, soul and body, are separable; that they are therefore perishable [*vergänglich*] and mortal" (*WL* I 92/66). Cf. also *WL* I 142/103. The root concept <*Vergehen*> is a feature of <becoming> as such. Cf. *WL* I 111–12/80.

Here, too, the referent of "the rose" can change with the context, and the predicates ascribed to it at one time may not apply at another. In this way, it "perishes." The predicate, meanwhile, can be used to characterize a number of such singular items. It thus has "positive subsistence" (*ihr positives Bestehen*) even if it depends on the singulars to achieve "concrete existence." Simply put, it lasts outside the context and applies to new objects even when the first disappears. Taken together, this logical content expresses a relation between two kinds of objective "being": a momentary singular existence (expressed by the singular term) and an abiding universal subsistence (expressed by the predicate). These objective categories stem not from additional theories attached to the use of terms in judgment but from the logical content of the judgment itself.

Though Hegel gives his most extensive discussion of the objective meaning of the positive judgment, his treatment of the relation of logical forms to concepts of the Objective Logic is sometimes more direct in other places in the Subjective Concept. Hegel constantly alludes to categories of the Objective Logic in these discussions. In one place, he gives another important example while also generalizing on it:

> The hypothetical judgment can be more precisely determined in terms of the relationships of reflection as a relation of *ground* and *consequence*, *condition* and *conditioned*, causality etc. Just as substantiality is in the categorical judgment in the form of the concept, so is the connection of causality in the hypothetical judgment. This and the other relations all [*sämtlich*] stand under it [sc. the form of the concept], but they are here no longer as *independent sides*, but rather in this relation essentially only as moments of one and the same identity. (*WL* II 338/577, modified)

The relations of <ground> and <consequence> and <condition> and <conditioned> are all explicit matters of the *Essence Logic*, as is <substantiality>. But here Hegel says that "all" such relations stand under the form of the Concept. I take it that (again, along the lines of Kant) Hegel is giving the ultimate *ground* or *explanation* of these concepts within the logical forms made possible by the Concept itself. Specifically, all such concepts have their ground in a certain form of relational judgment.

The reference to <substantiality> in this passage is particularly important, since, as we have seen, this concept is a part of the discussion that closes the *Doctrine of Essence*. That concept is discussed again in "The Judgment of Necessity," in the context of the categorical judgment. A categorical judgment, for Hegel, comes to expression when the subject term of a judgment is not a singular entity ("Socrates" or "this human") or even

a collection of singular entities ("all humans"), but when a universal term stands for the whole kind, namely in statements like "the human being is rational," where it is presumed that "the human being" refers to the kind (*Gattung*). Such a judgment says that "what belongs to all the singulars of a genus belong to the genus by nature" (*WL* II 334/575). Hegel thus sees the categorical judgment as involving a different *form* of universality from that of mere sets or classes. He writes,

> The determination to which universality has advanced is, as we have seen, the *universality that is in and for itself* or *the objective universality* that in the sphere of essence corresponds to substantiality. It is distinguished from the latter because it belongs to [the sphere of] the *Concept* and for this reason is not only the *inner* but also the *posited* necessity of its determinations. (335/575, slightly modified)

On my reading, what Hegel describes here is not a *mere* correspondence between stages of the Objective Logic and the Subjective Logic, but a relation of *dependence*. Hegel is giving the grounds or explanation of the concept of <substantiality> as coming from *within* a certain form of judgment.[38] That is, to speak of <substantiality>, metaphysically, is nothing but a shorthand way of describing the relation of the concept <the human being> to <rational> in the judgment "the human being is rational." We can say that the "substance" or "substantiality" of the human being is rationality; but this is only to make explicit the conceptual relation that is found already in the logical content of categorical judgment. This means that something like a referential use of a metaphysical concept can be grounded after all, but here on the basis of the form of thought.

Thus, although the naïve presentation of the contents of metaphysical concepts in the Objective Logic leads to a kind of loss of reality, an evaporation of substance into the mere form of thought, Hegel's Subjective Logic continues by giving a foundation to those very metaphysical concepts. But this is not a return to the same. For these metaphysical concepts only return on a condition: that these concepts should not be thought of as designating theoretical objects that might stand beyond the ken of human insight, but rather should be thought as adhering to the logical or semantic content that is bound to the mere form of thought. This amounts – as promised – to a *replacement* of metaphysics by Logic, not merely a new metaphysical theory. For Logic determines when and how

[38] Substance and substantiality return also in the syllogism of necessity; see *WL* II 392/618.

a metaphysical concept applies. It does not determine the nature of objects as given independently of Logic.

What does this imply for the first-order *use* of concepts like <substance> or <substantiality>? As I understand it, it allows that these concepts can well be used in philosophy, but that they have acquired a new, more transparent basis. That is, we can, as Hegel does, describe something, even like *the state*, as "substance" or "essence."[39] But the use of this concept no longer serves to designate something whose nature may well be outside our ken. The same cannot be said of a common conception of <essence>. It may well be that someone "believes" that there are essences without a clear conception of what exactly it *is* to have an essence. (Is it something hidden that could be discovered? Does it have its own causal effects above and beyond the material of the thing? Is it a "thing" at all?) But if what it means to be an essence or substance is given by some form of thought, it would then be a confusion to think that an essence is something hidden in things. For the use of the concept is now supervised by the form of thought itself and essentially laid out in the open. If Logic is the basis of metaphysics, then metaphysical concepts should be more mysterious than logical or semantic ones.[40]

4.6 Conclusion

In closing this chapter, I want to briefly describe how the preceding amounts to a view that is unique in the pride of place it gives to concepts in metaphysics and philosophy more generally. There is a basic sense in which concepts are central to every philosophical inquiry. The example that Socrates set for philosophy, especially as represented in Plato's early dialogues, suggests that no progress on questions *about* some topic, say whether virtue can be taught, can be adequately pursued until we first

[39] See, e.g., *GPR* Preface; § 144; § 144A; § 146A.

[40] Here, one could make the interesting objection that logical and semantic concepts are themselves the subject of inquiry (perhaps even theoretical inquiry) and controversy. Though I cannot hope to convince a skeptic here, I would make an initial suggestion. Whether some consequence relation (in logic) holds, or whether a certain term has a certain sort of meaning, it seems to me, is *finally* settled by actual thinkers making clear to themselves what they are doing when they think. There may sometimes be room for misalignment in the way we clarify ourselves in words to others: whether I "refer" to phlogiston when I say "phlogiston does not exist" is partly a question about how to use the word "refer" with others. But there is, it seems to me, no higher court of appeal than the thought of actual thinkers here. There may be room for uncertainty and controversy, but in matters theoretical such uncertainty and controversy can signal a fundamental lack of acquaintance with the thing at issue. In matters of thought – thus logic and meaning – there is no similarly fundamental lack of acquaintance.

inquire into the nature of the topic (or concept) itself (i.e., <virtue>). Similarly, one of the insights of Hegel's Objective Logic is that we cannot answer questions about being or substance or essence until we perform a systematic and rational derivation of these concepts in their own right. A metaphysics that did not pay attention to the concepts that it uses would be likely to make serious errors. Hegel's Logic is *at least* "concept-centric" in the sense that it determines the content of concepts before it produces theories that use them.

But I have argued that Logic – and thus Hegel's replacement for metaphysics – is concept-centric in a stronger sense as well. The foundation of the Objective Logic is the Subjective Logic; that means that the foundation of the traditional metaphysical concepts is their connection to the logical forms of the Concept, as they appear in judgment and syllogism. In providing a rational deduction of these logical forms, Hegel is also discovering the grounds for the concepts he treats in the Objective Logic. In finding these grounds in the form of thought, the status of metaphysical concepts cannot remain unchanged. In my preferred terms, this discovery amounts to a realization that metaphysical concepts do not have a primarily *theoretical* function; they should not be thought as pieces of a theory about how the world really is. Considering the concepts in this latter way, we might wonder – as Kant did – what gives us the right to suppose that finite minds like our own could limn the true nature of the world just by thinking about it. But if these concepts do nothing other than explicate our own form of thought, whether in a theoretical use or not, then there is no *essential* mystery in our coming to possess and understand these concepts. This, I believe, is what Hegel means when he says that Logic comes to be *transparent*. He writes, "The idea" – which here is meant, I believe, as the "logical Idea" or Idea of Logic – "is, therefore, only in this self-determination of *examining itself* [sich zu vernehmen]; it is in *pure thought*, where difference is not yet *otherness*, but is and remains perfectly transparent [*vollkommen durchsichtig*]" (*WL* II 550/736, modified). There is simply no room to wonder whether the concepts it discusses are matching up to their 'objects,' for there is no space for such a gap when the object is thought itself.

This view of what metaphysics should do (or what the replacement for metaphysics that Hegel calls "Logic" should do) cannot help but signal a sea-change for philosophy in general. Contemporary metaphysics, which understands itself well within the theoretical conception of the subject matter, often looks with contempt, or resignation, on the need to use "our concepts" to understand the structure of the world (or whatever it takes to

be the object of metaphysics). With this dismissive attitude toward our own thought, it can hardly be an accident that the topics that theoretical metaphysics takes most seriously are in the domain of mind-independent nature. But if one supposed that the logical form of thought – the Concept – was the ground of all the concepts we use in metaphysical theorizing, one could hardly take the same attitude toward the mind-dependent domain of human creation. For it then could emerge that the products of the human mind are more closely related to the logical form of thought than the natural objects that are what they are anyway.

A concept-centric metaphysics implies that *all* the concepts of metaphysics are determined by their place within the structure and form of thought. This does not make all things – or whatever is 'out there' – mind- or concept-dependent. But it does mean the key determination of anything, whether mind-independent or not, must find its place within the structure of the Concept, and thus the self-transparent form of thought. As we will see, this requirement seems to be the starting point for an approach to philosophy (namely, Hegel's) that privileges that which is *more* dependent on its concept over that which is less so, or not at all.

CHAPTER 5

The Constitutive Concept
The Logical Significance of Teleology

The previous chapter outlined a crucial movement in Hegel's challenge to traditional metaphysics, though its significance for the remainder of this work is mainly negative. The "inversion of philosophy" that Hegel envisions is only possible once a certain picture of metaphysics is no longer in view. But, as I have used this expression, Hegel's inversion of philosophy is his determination that the paradigmatic objects of philosophical knowledge are objects of *Geist*, which are, as I will argue, artifactual in their structure. In other words, Hegel's inversion of philosophy is something carried out within the *Logic* itself, but its significance is forward looking with respect to Hegel's system.

Thus, while the Objective Logic is, on my reading, largely destructive in nature, the Subjective Logic, or *Concept Logic*, is constructive. It quite specifically sets itself a positive task, which Hegel describes as the explanation of "truth," even as a response to Pontius Pilate's exasperated question: "what is truth?" (*WL* II 244/507–8). As becomes clear as the work progresses, Hegel uses the word "truth" not to describe the truth of a proposition (which Hegel would call its "correctness") but rather to describe something's being adequate to its own concept (*WL* II 462/670; 268/525).[1] Hegel uses his own term "the Idea" (*die* Idee) for truth in this sense (see *WL* II 271/527), which he says is the "*absolute unity of concept and objectivity*" (*EL* § 213, 367/286). It is important to see that Hegel does not think this unity is explained by the end of the Objective Logic. Nor is it explained by the mere appearance of the Concept, which emerges as the empty form of thought. Hence, the new, constructive task of the *Concept Logic* is to explain the relation of concepts to something Hegel wants to call their "object" or "objectivity," and in particular the possibility of concrete

[1] "It is in this deeper sense of truth which is at issue, e.g., when one speaks of a *true* state or a *true* work of art. These objects are *true* when they are what they are *supposed to be* [*sollen*], i.e., when their reality corresponds to their concept" (*EL* § 213Z, 369/287). On the difference between truth and "correctness" in Hegel, see Ficara 2021: 93–6.

philosophical truth. To explain truth in this sense would be to show what it means to give an adequate philosophical account of topics like art, the state, the mind, history, and nature. This is not merely a circular interest in the truths of concepts in Logic; it is an interest in philosophical thought's relation to the world.

Although I believe the Subjective Logic offers the foundation for the concrete philosophical sciences, Hegel's argument does not rest on a prior account of the contents of the world. Instead, his procedure involves something like a construction from certain given logical materials, namely the mere logical forms of universality, particularity, and singularity. What Hegel shows in the first part of the Subjective Logic is that there are many possible relations of these forms to one another, and these various forms exhibit to different degrees the kind of truth that Hegel is looking for. These relations are described as forms of *judgment* and *syllogism*. These relations differ in their inherent capacity to exhibit the unity of universality and singularity, Concept and objectivity. Though Hegel makes no attempt to draw on concrete knowledge of the real world in this account, the various logical relations he considers map on to relations that we would ordinarily think of as relations of thought to the world. In particular, if *singularity* is the logical form of the contents of the objective world, and *universality* is the logical form of thought itself, then Hegel can reconstrue problems about the relation of thought to the world as a problem about the relation of thought in one of its forms to another.

Accordingly, the logical forms Hegel discusses range from expressing a maximally *inadequate* to a maximally adequate form of the relation of universality to singularity. The "finite," inadequate forms will be those that "have the Concept as an external determination" (*WL* II 465/672). This inadequate or untrue relation is where we begin in the *Concept Logic*. As Hegel says, "The said pure concept passes through the finite forms of the judgment and the syllogism precisely because it is not yet posited in and for itself as one with objectivity, but is conceived only in the process of becoming that objectivity" (*WL* II 405/627). The Concept thus begins at a distance from its object. From here, it is Hegel's task to show how and to what extent the Concept can find the "adequacy" or "identity" with its object that he calls the Idea. What is the logical form that is best capable of expressing "truth" or "the Idea" for Hegel? I will argue that the *Concept Logic* offers an account of what I'll call a *constitutive concept*. From what has emerged above, to speak of *a* concept, in Hegel's picture, is to speak of a universal, which has content in its distinction (particularity), in such a way that it can be instantiated by a singular item; we individuate concepts

when they are rooted in different universals. A constitutive concept would thus be a universal whose relation to reality is such that what the universal is determines some reality to be what it is. If something were the object of a constitutive concept, it would thus be an adequate expression of the Idea or truth. I will argue that the role of the Teleology chapter in Hegel's *Concept Logic* is to describe the nature of conceptual constitution and thus provide the foundation for the Hegelian Idea.[2]

The most basic relation of the moments of the Concept to themselves lies in what Hegel calls *judgment*, which is also the logical form that Hegel associates with untruth: judgments are not capable of expressing the Idea. Hence, the chapter begins (Section 5.1) by considering the form of judgment (and its associated concept of a *thing*) to see what Hegel could mean in saying that some logical forms do not express the truth. From here, I briefly consider the path from judgment, through syllogism, to the first stage of "objectivity," namely mechanism (Section 5.2). The central claim of the chapter is that the paradigmatic form of the relation of Concept to object is already given in the form of teleology or purpose. For teleology exhibits how a concept can – more than *represent* – also *constitute* its object. In Section 5.3, I describe why Hegel thinks of teleology as a logical form, comparable in that way to the more typical logical forms of judgment and syllogism. In Section 5.4, I argue that the logical form of teleology is, broadly speaking, an artifactual one, contrary to a tendency to read Hegel's Teleology chapter primarily in terms of its implications for the existence of natural purposes. Even if Hegel's account of teleology does not imply that all artifacts exhibit the kind of truth he is interested in, it does entail that the paradigmatic objects of philosophical knowledge will be those that are the products of constitutive concepts.

5.1 Judgment and Untrue "Things"

To understand Hegel's appreciation of the logical form of teleology, it will be helpful to see an example of a logical form that Hegel finds deficient. For we cannot understand the special case in which the Concept *constitutes* a reality except by comparison to a case in which it does not. A remarkable feature of Hegel's view is that though he is on the one hand committed to

[2] It should go without saying that teleology is not the end of the story here. While I believe that the key logical form of a constitutive concept is given as <teleology>, its full realization requires especially <life> and <cognition>, subjects of the following chapter. There I will argue that it is especially *living artifacts*, artifacts that are rooted in processes directly determined by cognition, that satisfy Hegel's standard for truth.

the comprehensive power of the Concept, this does not entail that everything is captured perfectly in its net, that everything is to the same degree intelligible. The comprehensive power of the Concept enables conceptual form to articulate *both* thought's reconciliation with reality and its potential disunity.

Hegel uses the term "judgment" (*das Urteil*) to describe a form of thought that he thinks does *not* exhibit the unity of the Concept with its object.[3] This sounds noteworthy, especially when we compare his views to someone like Kant. But Hegel has an unusual conception of judgment, and an unusually high standard for what it would mean for the Concept to be unified with its object. Hegel's account of what a judgment is *supposed* to be is something like the analysis of a concept, or indeed a kind of definition. He writes that judgment "requires that the predicate behave with respect to the subject in a relation of conceptual determination" (306/553), and says, "the judgment is the concept as determinate" (*WL* II 302/550), suggesting perhaps that a judgment makes the content of a concept explicit. Hence, Hegel treats the goal of judgment in his sense as expressing an identity. He writes: "To restore again this identity of the concept, or rather to *posit* it – this is the goal of the *movement* of the judgment" (*WL* II 309/556).[4]

When Hegel describes the "goal" of a judgment, he seems to have in mind something that might be pursued in philosophy itself. It is not uncommon to think of philosophical propositions as akin to definitions, like "A human being is a rational animal" or "knowledge is justified true belief." These statements aim to express the content of a concept in judgment, and they stand in contrast to what Hegel calls propositions or sentences (*Sätze*). Roughly, a "sentence" is a catch-all term for the linguistic expression of something that is not in itself a judgment.[5] Hegel offers as an example of a *Satz*: "Aristotle died at the age of 73 in the fourth year of the 115th Olympiad." This sentence is not (as such) an example of a judgment because it is not an attempt to articulate the content of a concept. "Aristotle" is not a concept, and, even if it were (i.e., a "singular concept"), most uses of a predicate articulating the date of his death are not attempts

[3] Given Hegel's critique of the form of judgment, it is puzzling that recent accounts like Pippin 2019 and Ng 2020 make judgment central to the *Logic*'s explanation of Hegel's idealism.

[4] Hegel is often accused of *confusing* predication and identity. This can hardly be the case, as he recognizes numerous forms of the relation between subject and predicate in propositions and judgments. Yet, it may be true that in his conception of the *goal* of judgment, predication is seen as a kind of failed attempt at identity. On this topic, see, e.g., Stern (2009: ch. 2) and Rosen (2014: 250).

[5] See Martin 2016 for a good treatment of the issue. Martin does not think that a "*Satz*" is limited to linguistic expressions and so uses the term "posit" to translate it.

to define or determine <Aristotle> (the predicate "the founder of formal logic" would be a harder and more contentious case). Accordingly, judgments proper are a restricted class of thoughts (which may be expressed as sentences) that have the distinct goal of expressing the content of concepts.

It is important to see that Hegel is imposing this specific goal on judgments to understand his dissatisfaction with judgment in general. We know that the Concept as such is supposed to be a form of thought in which the forms of universality, particularity, and singularity are unified. If the judgment is going to make explicit the unity of the Concept, then it must posit these forms in their unity. As he says, "The judgment is the *determinateness* of the concept *posited* in the *concept* itself. . . . The *judgment* is this positing of the determinate concepts [sc., universality, particularity, and singularity] through the concept itself" (301/550). Even superficially, though, judgment is a form in which only *two* of these forms are supposed to be identified, while at the same time the two forms are opposed as subject and predicate. This is why Hegel also says, "The judgment is the diremption of the concept through itself . . .. It is in that way the *original division* of the originally one" (*WL* II 304/552).[6] Thus, judgment aims at a goal whose completion seems to be precluded by its very form.

Hegel's description of the restoration of the Concept's identity as a "goal" implies that this identity cannot be taken for granted. That is, not every judgment really *does* express the content of a concept or the unity of a concept and an object. Indeed, the form of judgment that Hegel begins with, and which he often seems to treat as symptomatic of judgment in general, is one in which the identity of the Concept is not properly expressed. Understanding this inadequate form of judgment is essential for understanding why Hegel does not take what I call "conceptual constitution" for granted.

Hegel begins his account of the initial form of judgment in the section "Judgment of Existence," by saying,

> In the subjective judgment we expect to see *one and the same* object *double*, once in its singular actuality, and again in its essential identity or in its concept: the singular raised into its universality or, what is the same thing, the universal made singular into its actuality. The judgment is thus *truth*, for it is the agreement of the concept and reality. (*WL* II 311/557)

[6] Here, Hegel goes on to tie the idea of "original division" (*ursprüngliche Teilung*) to the etymology of "judgment" (*Urteil*), due to his friend Hölderlin.

This is a striking account of the goal of judgment. To express "truth," for Hegel, the judgment must express the agreement of Concept and reality. It is supposed to do so, Hegel here suggests, by uniting a *singular* actuality with its *universal* concept. The wider context suggests that Hegel is alluding to a judgment of the form:

A [singular] is B [universal],

where the subject term represents an "object" that is characterized by its general predicate. Hegel suggests that what is wanted from such a judgment is not *mere* characterization but *identity* – the predicate is, as it were, meant to "double" the identity of its object.

But, as Hegel continues the paragraph we have just cited, he says that the judgment "is not *at first* constituted in this way" (*WL* II 311/557). That is, even if the judgment is meant to express a "doubling" of its content, such that it would be a kind of identity not only of subject and predicate but also object and concept, the most basic form of a judgment does not achieve this. Hegel specifies this first form as the "positive judgment," which he characterizes more specifically as a judgment that attempts to unite "abstract singularity" and "abstract universality" (311/558). Abstract universality, represented by the predicate of the positive judgment, is something like the form of universality that we met in Chapter 3 with general "representations" (*Vorstellugen*), a universality that merely *omits* the unique features of things, as Hegel says, "by the sublation of singularity and particularity" (312/558). By contrast, abstract singularity, represented as the subject of the judgment, is "the *immediate* which is supposed *to be such* and therefore the singular as a *something* in general. The subject constitutes, therefore, the abstract side of the judgment, the side in it according to which the concept has passed over into *externality*" (312/558). Hegel is drawing here on his earlier account of <singularity>. Recall that singularity is something like the moment of conceptual form in which the Concept has an "outward" direction; in which it seems tied to "actuality" and is thus expressed with a "this" (cf. 300/548). A positive judgment contains a subject that is singular in this way, but abstractly so. I take this abstractness to involve something like a singularity that is supposed to be divorced from universality and particularity, so that its "this" is a *mere* singular reference, as if a mere pointing, devoid of specific conceptual content.

Hegel places special emphasis on the way that the subject of this kind of basic judgment, in its abstract singularity, depends for its meaning on its connection to the predicate, since it has no general content of its own. He writes,

> It is essential to be reminded of the remark made above that the subject obtains determinateness and content only in its predicate; that prior to the predicate, whatever that content might otherwise be for feeling, intuition, and representation, so far as conceptual cognition is concerned it is only a *name*; but in the predicate, with determinateness, there begins at the same time the process of *realization* in general. (*WL* II 403/626)

He similarly writes in the *Encyclopedia*: "The subject [of a judgment] only has its explicit determinacy and content in the predicate; and hence, taken on its own, it is a mere representation or an empty name" (*EL* § 169 R, 320/247). Predicates in general are not mere names; subjects of judgments *can* be names, or also demonstratives like "this." If we consider a name or demonstrative abstractly – that is, separately from our collateral knowledge of what it names or of associated characteristics – we can see that the mere singular, by itself, does not express much of anything. Hence, the "it" of "It's a bird!" requires supplementation – perhaps a genuine pointing – to mean something. Though this is a point associated with recent analytic philosophers like Keith Donnellan and David Kaplan, it was familiar to Hegel as well. Earlier in the *WL*, he writes,

> Language, as a work of the understanding, only expresses the universal, except in the *naming* of a singular object. But the individual name [*individuelle Name*] is something meaningless [*Sinnloses*] in the sense that it does not express a universal. It appears as something merely posited and arbitrary for the same reason that proper names [*Einzelnamen*] can also be arbitrarily picked, arbitrarily given as well as arbitrarily altered. (*WL* I 125–6/91, translation modified)

He goes on to say that the "meaning" of an indexical or name is established by demonstration or pointing: "The whole determinateness falls on the side of this external pointing [*Monstrienen*]." Hegel elsewhere associates the meaning of names with external pointing, when he writes, "By the subject of the singular judgment one could mean, 'this human,' a singularity [*Singularität*] that properly pertains to external pointing [*Monstrieren*]; it would best be expressed, therefore, by something like 'Caius'" (*WL* II 329/571).

Why is this significant? Hegel's insistence that an *abstract singular* subject has its meaning only through the supplementation of something like pointing helps to make clear that the judgment expressed by "this is hot" or "it's a fossil" certainly does not express a "doubling" of the object. For the subject term points to something that the judgment itself is not expressing. The very point of using a demonstrative is to point *outside* the judgment, something *not* contained in its terms. Far from expressing the

identity of subject and predicate, or object and concept, the merely positive judgment expresses a kind of gulf between subject and predicate.[7] For Hegel, this gulf is evident in the very *form* of the positive judgment, without considering problems about, say, our acquaintance with the subject matter at hand. Thus, even though Hegel's understanding of this gulf occurs *within* the forms of thought, and even though Hegel already acknowledges the way that singular thought contains a reference to the world, he nevertheless thinks that the early stages of judgment express a kind of untruth. We do not have an expression of the agreement of Concept and its object, even though both Concept and object are (in Hegel's exposition) treated as exemplifying forms of thought. The problem Hegel is pointing to thus does not amount to a kind of skepticism about reference or intentionality. It instead concerns something like the intelligibility of thought on its own terms.

Now, though I have been treating the Hegelian judgment in terms of its linguistic (and sentential) expression, it is important to note that Hegel considers the form of judgment to be more than propositional. At a first pass, there is nothing strange here. Though the form of a positive judgment can be put propositionally, the same logical forms are exhibited in a complex like the following:

> A [singular] that is B [universal].

For example, instead of judging that "a dog is shaggy," we could speak of a complex like "a dog that is shaggy." Here, the logical form is more like a complex concept than a proposition.[8] One might say it expresses a kind of thing or object rather than a state of affairs. But this involves nothing other than the recognition that the very same forms of thought involved in a proposition can be recognized in a non-propositional form. There should be nothing problematic in this for someone who thinks, like Hegel, that the logical forms are potentially exhaustive.

But a famous passage in the *Encyclopedia Logic* seems to make an even stronger claim. Though this version of the *Logic* evidently *also* treats judgment at the level of thought and language, Hegel writes,

[7] Doesn't this make the positive judgment more like a "proposition" (*Satz*)? This is perhaps true, but also unproblematic. Hegel himself sometimes describes the positive judgment as a proposition (cf. *WL* II 312–14/558–9). Judgments and propositions are distinguished by their respective functions or goals. Thus, the same sentence can be taken as an example of a genuine proposition but a failed judgment. If we take an empirical claim (like the examples I have given) as *if* it were determining the content of a concept, then we see it as inadequate to the task of judgment.

[8] Cf. Sellars's (1968: ch. 1) idea of the logical form of a Kantian intuition.

> The judgment is usually taken in a *subjective* sense, as an *operation* and a form, which occurs only in thinking that is *self-conscious*. But this distinction is not yet present in the logical [realm]; [here] the judgment is to be taken quite generally: *every thing is a judgment*. – That is, every thing is a *singular* which is inwardly a *universality* or inner nature, in other words a *universal* that is made singular; universality and singularity distinguish themselves [from each other] within it, but at the same time they are identical. (*EL* § 167, 318–19/245–6, slightly modified)

A first point to make here is that Hegel is not denying that he treats judgments as forms of self-conscious thought. Rather, he says that the "distinction" between judgments in that self-conscious form and some other form is not available in the logical domain. Indeed, the distinction does not arise when we consider the logical forms all by themselves. Instead, Hegel observes, the same logical forms that are exhibited in the form of thought are exhibited objectively.[9]

Though this passage is clear evidence that Hegel takes "judgment" to have a wider meaning than is typical, I think it is often overinterpreted.[10] The overinterpretation arises perhaps from thinking that Hegel's reference to "all things" (*alle Dinge*) is somehow a reference to reality as a whole. However, in my view, Hegel does not use the term "*Ding*" for this general ontological purpose, and he rather treats it as a kind of deficient ontological category.[11] In this passage, he is using the term in the specific sense in which it appears earlier in the *Logic*, as a category of *Essence*, which is always paired with "properties" (*Eigenschaften*).[12] In particular, "things" are a category for what is finite, and even indeterminate. In just the next paragraph, Hegel writes, "The standpoint of the judgment is *finitude*, and the *finitude* of things consists in their being a judgment, in that their existence and their general nature (their body and their soul), though they are united, otherwise the things would be nothing, yet these their moments are both already

[9] This transfer of logical concepts to the objective domain is common. For example, Hegel says that an "*evil* action" or a "crime" is an "*infinite judgment* that negates, not only the *particular* right, but the universal sphere, the *right as right*" (*WL* II 325/567).

[10] See recently Ficara (2021: 98), who takes the passage to mean "there is a correspondence between the structure of sentences and the structure of reality." See also Taylor (1975: 309): "But for Hegel, judgement is first and foremost an ontological reality."

[11] Ficara (2021: 86) takes Hegel here to be saying otherwise: "As it emerges from the quote, according to Hegel reality is structured in terms of what he calls 'things,' and Aristotle calls 'substances' (*ousiai*)." Yet Hegel (critically) describes "vormalige Metaphysik" as the science that considers "determinations of thought as the *basic determinations* [*Grundbestimmungen*] *of things*" (*EL* § 28). See also his remarks at *GPR* § 44R.

[12] Here, see Wolff (2017: ch. 9) on Hegel's challenge to the notion of *Dinge* as general-purpose bearers of determinations and properties.

different as well as separable in general" (*EL* § 168, 319/246). Importantly, what is "finite" in Hegel's special sense is precisely the kind of object that is *not* appropriate to its "concept": "the finite is such an objectivity to which its purpose, its essence, and concept at the same time is not appropriate, is different from it" (*EL* § 193, 349/270, modified). From this passage, we can already safely conclude that Hegel does not think *everything* is a thing, for then *nothing* would be appropriate to its concept! Hence, he must not think *everything* is a judgment – it must be restricted to what satisfies his special category <thing>.[13]

Hegel's idea here seems to be one he shares with Plato. Plato noticed that terms for individual things differ from terms that stand for general concepts (i.e., "forms") by the former's being able to receive contrary predicates. Even though tallness can only be tall and not short, Simmias can be tall *and* short.[14] So, which of these predicates is appropriate to Simmias? For Plato, the problem is that concrete individuals ("things") lack "being" in the sense of any permanent logical identity or essence: they *are* neither tall nor short. There is no determinate right answer to questions about what pertains to them, in contrast to the definable and abiding characteristics of general concepts. Similarly, what Hegel calls "things" are *nothing other* than this meeting-point of contrary predicates. More provocatively, things *are* a contradiction: after all, Simmias *is* tall and short.[15] This is why Hegel can say that "the truth of the thing is that it is only an unessential compass which is indeed a negative unity" (*WL* II 138/430). And he writes that things are such that their properties are indifferent to them: "The thing consists of self-subsistent matters indifferent to the connection they

[13] This must be a "special" class, since Hegel repeatedly warns that the domain of application of <thing> is limited, in particular that it should not be applied to what is properly *Geist*. See this statement from the 1817 version of the *Encyclopedia*: "*Geist* is likewise something living, but it is considered as something dead when acting *faculties* and *powers* are assumed, which it is supposed to *have*; it is then the *thing of many properties* [Ding von vielen Eigenschaften]" (GW 13: 101–2 [*Enc.* 1817, § 166]).

[14] See *Phaedo* 102e. Cf. *Republic* 479a–b; *Parmenides* 129b. Aristotle also writes in the *Categories*: "It seems most distinctive of substance that what is numerically one and the same is able to receive contraries. . . . For example, a color which is numerically one and the same will not be black and white, nor will numerically one and the same action be good and bad . . . [Yet] an individual man – one and the same – becomes pale at one time and dark at another, and hot and cold, and bad and good" (*Cat.* 5 4a10–21). See especially Mann 2000 on this theme in ancient philosophy.

[15] Hegel says that the statement "All things are in themselves contradictory" should be taken "in the sense that, as against the others, expresses rather the truth and the essence of things" (*WL* II 74/381). Though this is controversial, in my view, this statement should be taken in light of Hegel's use of "thing" in a specific way, and so not as a general ontological claim, and in light of the peculiar feature of the concept <thing> that it permits the ascription of contrary predicates to it. Incidentally, the ascription of contrary predicates to a thing does not imply a strict propositional contradiction, for these contrary predicates are not indexed temporally.

have in the thing" (141/432). Notice that we say that things "have" their properties, not that they "are" their properties. This suggests that the relation of properties to things is not conceived as a relation that is essential.[16]

If we keep this Platonic connection in mind, the claim that "all things are a judgment" is perfectly legible. For the special concept <thing> is defined, by Hegel, in such a way that a thing is a concrete singular that exemplifies a series of abstract universals, yet without any of those universals being the essence of the singular, not one of them stating what it means to *be* that thing. This is the same logical form that can be exhibited propositionally by predicating a series of universals of a concrete singular. This all falls out of Hegel's expansive notion of logical form, so it is *not* meant as a bold claim about the structure of reality. Because Hegel's idea of logical form is simply *neutral* between its propositional or objectual exemplification, it applies equally well in both cases.

Nevertheless, the passage in question (in which "things" are identified as judgments) is important in giving us a handle on what could be at issue, for Hegel, in raising a problem of the relation between the Concept and the world. For in saying that "*Dinge*" are finite, and that they exhibit a deviation between their objectivity and their concept, Hegel is not suggesting that things cannot be thought conceptually. He is not, for example, posing a skeptical problem for our knowledge of things. However, it does seem that he is suggesting that *Dinge*, as such, are lacking in their intelligibility. Something that was fully intelligible – or "true" – would be just what its concept says it is. But a *Ding* is a collocation of its mere singularity and a variety of universals, none of which gives us the essence or being of the *Ding*. This is the same structure as mere judgment. The singular here is "subsumed" by universals – that is the form the universal takes when we judge it. These universals, taken in a series, do not typically tell us what the thing *is* – its nature or essence. And, even if one of the properties that subsumes the thing could be a candidate for its essence, if the predication of properties shares the same judgmental form "the thing is . . .," there is no reason to single one of them out. We would

[16] Here, Hegel's argument in the Perception chapter in the *Phenomenology* is useful (relevantly subtitled, "Or, the Thing and Illusion [*das Ding und die Täuschung*]"). Hegel there tries to show that the concept <thing> is the concept of an "also." That is, if we examine a sugar cube, we find that it has a number of properties. What is the "thing itself" here? It is, Hegel says there, the 'also' that we express in saying the sugar is sweet *and also* white, etc. (*PhG* 94–6, 100/¶¶ 113, 115, 120). Hegel makes problematic the notion of what is "essential" to the thing in this context, but this problem pertains specially to the thing *as* mere thing.

find no privileged property, only a series of them, all on a par. On the level of subsumption, no way of distinguishing essential from inessential is available.

In summary, Hegel thinks that judgment is a deficient logical form because it does not express the identity of object and its concept, even though judgment has the expression of the identity as its goal. The judgment is a logical form that can be exhibited both linguistically and objectively. However, the claim that "every thing is a judgment" is not a theory about the indwelling rationality of things, but a statement that the logical form of mere "*Dinge*" is such that it expresses finitude, the distance between Concept and object. This is not because things are not "represented" or subsumed by concepts (since they certainly can be), but because concepts do not make them intelligible. Far from answering our question about the "true" relation of Concept to object, the judgment (and hence the "thing") shows the potential gap between them.

5.2 From Syllogism to Objectivity

The failure of judgment as a logical form, whether it is used to represent propositions or the form of "things," is that it does not exhibit the unity between the singularity, particularity, and universality of something. Because of this, it does not exhibit what it would mean for something to *be* what its concept or universal is. Positive judgments, Hegel would grant, can certainly be "correct" (which, for Hegel, is what we normally think of as *truth*).[17] But Hegel's point is that the *form* of the positive judgment both connects and at the same time separates the object that is supposed to be its subject from the concept or universal that is its predicate. Hence, this problem with the form of the positive judgment must thus be overcome on similarly "formal" terms: we must arrive at a point where we can see how the form of thought on its own account does not express a disagreement of Concept and reality.

It is in this light that I believe we should view the remainder of Hegel's discussion of the forms of judgment and syllogism in the *Concept Logic*. To be sure, this material also has a purely logical interest: Hegel aims to show that each form can be *derived* in a rational sequence, so that the forms of thought need not be simply gathered "historically" (or empirically) from

[17] "The positive judgment has in fact no truth through its form as positive judgment; whoever calls *truth* the *correctness* of an *intuition* or a *perception*, the agreement of *representation* with the subject matter, has for a minimum no expression left for that which is the subject matter and the aim of philosophy" (*WL* II 318/562).

what ordinary people think and say (see *WL* II 267–9/524–5). But this task of deriving the forms of thought subserves the more overriding aim of finding expression for the form of a concept that is the "truth" of its object or an object that corresponds to its concept. It is not until this task is achieved in formal terms, in the account of the syllogism, that Hegel can claim that the "subjective" or "formal" Concept has passed into "objectivity." Though I am bypassing Hegel's derivation of the different forms of judgment and syllogism, it is worth examining this final stage of the syllogism, since it offers the basis for Hegel's account of <objectivity>.

The final formal syllogism Hegel examines is the *disjunctive syllogism*, which falls within the section called "The Syllogism of Necessity." Hegel's interest is not to give an account of the formal validity of disjunctive syllogisms. He instead considers the relation of terms in a disjunctive syllogism as representing a certain connection between the conceptual forms of universality, particularity, and singularity. Whereas the positive judgment does not exhibit the "truth" or unity of the forms of universality and singularity, the disjunctive judgment apparently does so. Hegel expresses this by saying that in syllogisms of necessity a subject is combined with a predicate *through* its "substance," which is the universality of the predicate itself. In this way, a syllogism of necessity unites the "extremes of the syllogism, specifically universality and singularity" (*WL* II 392/618).

But how can a form of thought like a disjunctive syllogism express this kind of connection?[18] Expressed formally, a disjunctive syllogism says only, in Hegel's words:

> A is either B or C or D,
> But A is neither C nor D,
> Therefore, A is B. (*WL* II 399/623)

However, Hegel repudiates the practice of describing forms of thought with bare symbols (cf. 312/558) without expressing specific logical content. When he further explicates this form of syllogism, he writes,

> A is subject not only in the two premises but also in the conclusion. It is a universal in the first premise and in its predicate the *universal* sphere particularized in the totality of its species; in the second premise, it is as *a determinate*, or as a species; in the conclusion it is posited as the excluding *singular* determinateness. . . . Consequently, what appears to be mediated is the *universality* of A with the *singularity*. (399/623)

[18] See Schick (1994: 254–5) for a helpful brief account of the disjunctive syllogism.

Hegel here suggests that the form of a disjunctive syllogism should not be represented merely as undifferentiated variables. Rather, each symbol should be qualified by one of the basic moments of conceptual form. If we follow Hegel's remarks in the context, the disjunctive syllogism says something like this:

> A [*qua* universal] is either B or C or D [particularity *qua* totality of A]
> But A [*qua* determinate, particular species] is neither C nor D
> Therefore A [*qua* singular] is B. (399/623)

In this "syllogism" an A that begins as a purely universal genus is particularized into its species or specific determinations, and then 'singularized' into an instance of one of its species; the universal A becomes the singular A, a determinate A that is B.

What Hegel sees in this movement is a logical form that shows A being B not because it is *subsumed* under B, as if from outside. Rather, since it is B by excluding all other relevant possibilities within its *own* content, this is a case of A determining itself as B. Therefore, the disjunctive syllogism represents the fact that A is B not as an accidental feature of A but what A essentially *is*. Hegel says that this kind of syllogistic relation represents the "simple identity" of the Concept along with its "determinate difference" in its distinct moments (*WL* II 399/623). That is, the disjunctive syllogism exhibits both the distinctness of the moments of universality, particularity, and singularity as well as their meeting in one. Hence, here the "form of the syllogism, which consisted in the difference of the middle term over against its extremes, has sublated itself" (400–1/624). This result allows Hegel to meet a substantial aim of the *Concept Logic*, to show what it means, in formal terms, for a universal and a singular to be unified; that is, for a singular to be essentially what its universal says it is. The mere form of a disjunctive syllogism doesn't tell us *what* exhibits such unity. It only shows us what to look for. (As we will see in the next section, it prepares us for what to find in the form of teleology.)

Having laid out the form in which the universal and the singular are united, via the universal's own particularity, Hegel takes himself to arrive at the stage of the Concept's *objectivity*. Recall that Hegel associates the form of singularity with "actuality" and "externality" (see Section 3.3.3). It is the form of thought which thought posits outside of itself. Since the disjunctive syllogism ends with a conclusion about something *as a singular*, it expresses, in Hegel's terms, a form of *being* or *immediacy*, which is itself the result of the realization of thought. On the cusp of the Objectivity section, Hegel writes, "The result is therefore an *immediacy* that has emerged

through the *sublation of the mediation*, a *being* which is equally identical with mediation and is the concept that has restored itself out of, and in, its otherness. This *being* is therefore a *thing at issue* [*Sache*] which is *in and for itself – objectivity*" (*WL* II 401/624, slightly modified). I take Hegel's account of the disjunctive syllogism to achieve this turn to objectivity not by proving that any given concept or even the Concept as such is objective, but rather by expressing the specific form of thought in which we should expect thought to be fully objective, to arrive again at a form of immediacy. The disjunctive syllogism arrives at this stage by concluding with a singular, while starting from the universal as its premise. In contrast to the external connection between subject and predicate in an abstract positive judgment, when some predicate belongs to a subject through the particularization of a universal, through its incompatibility with neighboring species, the connection between that singular and the universal is then one of perfect unity. The Objectivity chapter is then an account of the various kind of such logical unity, once the syllogistic form has made itself redundant.

From this it should be clear that "objectivity" is not a generic term for reality or the world, or something along those lines. The Objectivity chapter opens by emphasizing the distinctness of its subject matter from reality in a more general sense, by comparing objectivity with other terms for "immediacy" (*Unmittelbarkeit*) that might seem synonymous:

> *Being* is as such the *first* immediacy, and *existence* is the same immediacy with a first determinateness. *Ex-istence*, along with the *thing*, is the immediacy that proceeds from *ground*, from the self-sublating mediation of the simple reflection of essence. But *actuality* and *substantiality* are the immediacy that proceeds from the sublated difference of the still unessential concrete existence as appearance and its essentiality. Finally, *objectivity* is the immediacy which the concept has determined itself by the sublation of its abstraction and mediation. (*WL* II 403/626)

Objectivity is that *form* of reality or the world that can be expressed as the unity or identity of the different moments of conceptual form.[19] That is, thought itself has a kind of *outward* direction; it thus arrives at a conception of an object that matches its form. In that way, objectivity is something like the world *insofar* as it can be expressed in a purely conceptual form, insofar as purely logical resources are sufficient to

[19] See here Schick 1994: 255.

articulate it.[20] Suggestively, while introducing his concept of objectivity, Hegel notes that "Rational laws, complete works of art, etc., are called *objective* insofar as they are free of and beyond any accidentality" (408/629). These examples are important because they are the kind of thing that we would normally say "exist," though their existence is, in certain ways, dependent on a concept, and distinct from their purely "sensible" form.[21] Hence, we should not expect the treatment of objectivity to be an account of all reality, but an account of the specific dimensions of reality that have a special relation to conceptuality.

Still, what Hegel is doing in the Objectivity chapter is not immediately obvious. The titles he gives to its three stages are "Mechanism," "Chemism," and "Teleology," and these have always generated controversy.[22] The apparent problem is that Hegel has leapt from the consideration of logical content in the forms of judgment and syllogism to categories that seem to stem from the natural sciences. This, of course, will not do. My reading thus far (and indeed most accounts of the *Logic*) would make this leap to the natural sciences completely unintelligible. Even with its turn to <objectivity>, the *Logic* is a movement of pure thought, constitutively independent of empirical matters. Unless and until it could be shown that pure thought leads to natural categories by itself, we should not suppose that Hegel intends any such leap.

In order to remain faithful to Hegel's project, the stages of Objectivity should be interpreted in "topic-neutral" terms. That is, while it may be true that Hegel selected the names for these stages because of their appropriate fit with certain modes of consideration in natural science, the genuine concepts Hegel derives under these names are, in themselves, not determined by such domains of application. Hegel himself illustrates the "mechanical object" using examples from the physical sciences, though he also insists that the same concept of an object can be in play in the

[20] This is comparable to Yeomans's formulation. He writes: "forms of objectivity are forms of conceptualized existence. . . . [O]bjectivity is realized conceptual form" (2012: 190).

[21] Hegel writes, "Now if external intuition as determined in time and space is required for objectivity, and it is this objectivity that is missed, it is then clear that by objectivity is meant only sensuous reality. But to have risen above such a reality is precisely the condition of thinking and of truth" (*WL* II 491/692).

[22] It was common among Hegel's early critics to object that such categories do not belong in a logic at all. See Hösle (1987: 240) for historical references; and the same work (245–50) for Hösle's arguments to the same effect. Hösle does not look past Hegel's use of specific examples to illustrate these categories, so he accuses them of being inordinately *realphilosophisch*. See, relatedly, Westphal (2008: 297), who agrees that these categories are empirical. My account will try to show why this claim should not hold. Interestingly, Hösle (1987: 249–50) admits that teleology does have a place in the logic (though not the one Hegel gave it).

"spiritual" domain as well; that is, with "laws, morals, rational conceptions in general" (*WL* II 416/636). Though it is clear that there can be *examples* of logical or topic-neutral concepts from concrete domains, what should be insisted upon is that Hegel's account of mechanism is not *about* any topic in the physical or cultural sciences.[23] That is, we should not think that Hegel's discussion is tied conceptually to the topics of natural science. A criterion of adequacy on any interpretation of these sections is that it maintain topic-neutrality, precisely by showing how the given form of objectivity can be derived from the logical contents that Hegel has thus far justified.

I will not here provide this interpretation of Mechanism and Chemism.[24] I mention this criterion of adequacy, however, because it should also apply to my own account of Teleology. Hegel's project throughout the Objectivity chapter is, after all, not to account for any specific domain as if it were already given.[25] That would contradict his procedure in the *Logic*. Instead, as always, he is attempting to show how the resources of the Concept are sufficient to generate its own standard of "truth." It turns out that mechanical and chemical concepts of objects do not fully achieve this standard; that task is left rather to teleology.[26]

Incidentally, this implies a difference in approach here than in some other readings of the Objectivity chapter. An alternative approach considers the movement from mechanism to chemism and to teleology to imply a kind of progressive universality of application. That is, because mechanism is not the "truth" of the object, and because teleology turns out to be the "truth" of chemism and mechanism, we are led to suppose that teleology is the more universal category, even to say that "mechanism presupposes teleology."[27] This reading seems to rest on a deep methodological assumption about the *Logic* that I do not share, related (I believe) to

[23] Anton Friedrich Koch's (2014: 182) reading seems to violate the topic-neutrality of Hegel's account when he suggests we should associate "mechanism with macrophysics, chemism with microphysics and chemistry (which – perhaps – supervenes on microphysics), teleology with protobiology . . . and on the other hand a philosophy of artifacts." See also Rosen (2014: 454), who writes that "Hegel is concerned with the concepts of mechanics and chemistry, with a statement of the dialectical significance of the general results of modern science." This is strange given how well Rosen articulates the syllogistic basis of the concept of a mechanical object (cf. 455).

[24] I go into more detail on mechanism in Wolf 2019a.

[25] This point, used as a criticism of certain readings of Objectivity, is well made by Werner 2020.

[26] It is worth noting that in early lectures on logic and metaphysics (collected in W 4), Hegel only included the category of teleology between the syllogism and the idea. As I read him, this was possible because mechanism and chemism are not necessary for Hegel's *positive* explanation of the "truth" of the concept, while teleology is.

[27] See, variously, Yeomans 2012; Kreines 2015; Ng 2020. See the critical discussion in Koch 2023.

the developmental approach discussed in the previous chapter. On this assumption, Hegel is progressively determining something (be it "the Absolute" or "being," etc.). So, if teleology comes after mechanism in the sequence, it follows that teleology is a further and more fundamental determination of the "whole" Absolute (just so it will follow that the whole must be "living," since that is a later category still). This requires each further category in the *Logic* to be more general than its predecessors.

However, I have argued that Hegel's project in the *Concept Logic* is to show what it means for something to be "true," for concept and object to achieve a certain kind of unity. In particular, the positive aim is to explain the nature of philosophical truth. This task distinguishes the *Concept Logic* from the other parts of the work. To pursue it, Hegel need not be progressively determining the nature of *everything*. Instead, he must constructively develop a conception of objectivity that expresses the unity of Concept and object that is his aim. This is compatible with an early stage in this development, say mechanism, achieving this to a less adequate extent, while still, for all that, representing a possible form of objectivity.[28] It is also compatible with the end result having a restricted range of application. What matters is that there is *some* truth (concrete unity of Concept and object) to be found, not that *all* objects or all concepts achieve this truth.[29]

5.3 The Logical Form of Teleology

For Hegel, it is *teleology* that represents the form of objectivity in which Concept and object achieve their unity, and thus prefigure the Concept's *truth*. That is, it is in teleology that *the content of a concept* and the *nature or essence of an object* can coincide. Hegel's account of teleology is not meant to entail a general claim about the world, or about nature in particular: it does not imply, for example, that everything has some purpose, or even that there are so-called internal purposes in nature. The account is not

[28] Indeed, Hegel certainly leaves space for processes in nature that are mechanical but not teleological. For example, "In nature, only the wholly abstract relationships of a matter which is still not opened up within itself are subject to mechanism; in contrast, not even the phenomena and processes of the physical domain in the narrower sense of the word . . . can be explained in a mechanical way" (*EL* § 195Z, 353/274). The statement leaves room for the minimal relevance of mechanism to nature. Just later he writes, "We must also vindicate for mechanism the right and significance of a universal logical category" (*EL* § 195Z, 354/275).

[29] Hegel writes, introducing teleology, that when the concepts of mechanical causes and final purposes are "laid down for themselves, then the objective world may present mechanical and final causes; its existence is not the standard of the *true*, but rather the true is the criterion of what is true among these existences" (*WL* II 437/651). In other words, logical accounts are given without deciding the extent of their applicability to various "existences."

obliged to account for everything that might be said to have a purpose or even to show that purposes are objectively possible. Rather, it is an account that explains how something, *if* it has a purpose in the sense Hegel describes, is the realization of the Concept and thus an expression of truth or the Idea.[30] However, in what follows, I will emphasize that, though Hegel's account of teleology is topic-neutral and is not precluded from applying to objective purposiveness in the realms of nature or spirit, its *artifactual* resonances are in fact prominent and have been much too neglected in other accounts. Teleology is thus a crucial linchpin in my reading of Hegel's *Logic* as having a kind of humanistic, artifactual trajectory.

Our question now is how teleology can come to represent something like a logical form, for we have seen that Hegel's procedure in the *Concept Logic* is carried out solely on the level of logical forms. Intuitively, if we were to take the point of view of an *observer* of a (putatively) teleological process, it is easy to see how the ascription of a purpose would seem to involve nothing other than a particular application of a judgment. Namely, in an observational context, for example in the perceptual encounter with a watch lying in a forest or a tube stemming from the heart, the question of purpose is a question about whether, or how, we can judge something to be purposive, or to satisfy a specific purpose. Here, the question is how a "presupposed other" can be *subsumed* under the concept of purposiveness. Hence, from an observational point of view, the form of teleology is nothing other than a form of judgment.[31]

However, Hegel recognizes that teleology proper represents a non-judgmental logical form because he instead considers teleology from the point of view of a purpose being carried out. From this perspective, the question is not whether or how purposiveness can subsume something outside itself; rather, the purpose is going to *make* something what it is. Hence, Hegel explicitly says that the "*Zweckbegriff*" (purposive concept) does not merely "subsume" its object (*EL* § 204 R, 360/280; cf. *WL* II 443/656). Teleology is thus not just a judgment *about* the purpose of a presupposed object; it determines an object to have a certain purpose.

Considered from this point of view, the logical form that represents a teleological process must be syllogistic, and it is through its syllogistic form that teleology exhibits the unity between the universal, particular,

[30] One should bear in mind, of course, that this is still an incomplete expression of truth, which requires the further development of the Idea chapter.

[31] This is the main point of view from which Kant considers the problem of teleology. See the next section.

and singular that is supposed to comprise the Concept in its concrete expression.[32] In Hegel's terms, a purpose is "the *syllogism* of the self-subsistent free concept that through objectivity unites itself with itself in conclusion" (*WL* II 444/656). Here is one of Hegel's most condensed formulations of this idea:

> Purpose [*Er* = *Der Zweck*] is to be taken as the *rational in its ex-istence*.[33] It manifests *rationality* [*Vernünftigkeit*] by being the concrete concept that holds the *objective distinction in its absolute unity*. It is thus in itself essentially *syllogism*. It is the self-equal *universal* and indeed as an at first universal (and to that extent still *indeterminate*) *activity* containing self-repelling negativity; but since this activity is negative self-reference, it *determines* itself immediately and gives itself the moment of *particularity*, and this particularity, as likewise *the totality of the form reflected into itself*, is *content* as against the *posited* distinctions of the form. The same negativity, through its self-reference, is just as immediately the reflection of the form into itself and *singularity*. (445–6/657–8, modified)

This passage (as difficult as it is) makes it quite clear that teleology is of logical interest for Hegel because it represents a unique logical structure. Whereas the basic positive judgment merely classified individuals by some (potentially arbitrary) universal, the teleological process is represented here as a process that *makes* a singular what it is precisely as a universal that becomes particular. Indeed, the purpose seems to present a concrete version of what we saw as the form of the disjunctive syllogism in the last section. Recall:

> A [*qua* universal] is either B or C or D [particularity *qua* totality of species]
> But A [*qua* determinate, particular species] is neither C nor D
> Therefore A [*qua* singular] is B. (*WL* II 399/623)

Teleological constitution fits into the disjunctive form roughly in this way: a purpose (the universal A) is something that *could* be carried out using several means (B or C or D), but in excluding rival means, A comes to be something particular (B). A is B because it is *made* to be B. But now B, since it is a determination of A, becomes A. This process moves by a kind of self-reference: the "A" that is the universal purpose at the beginning is what the singular "A" that results is made to be.

The logical form of teleology thus instantiates the logical form of a disjunctive syllogism, and the "premises" of this syllogism correlate in

[32] Here I much concur with Ng 2020: 234–5.
[33] Recall the statement from *the Phenomenology*: "What has been said can also be expressed by saying that reason is *purposive activity*" (*PhG* 26/¶ 22).

turn with certain elements of a teleological process.[34] The three formal moments of the Concept, each present in the disjunctive syllogism, correlate with the three subsections of Teleology: <universality> with "A. The Subjective Purpose," <particularity> with "B. The Means," and <singularity> with "C. The Realized Purpose." This is quite important. The disjunctive syllogism shows in a formal way what it would mean for a universal to be united with its resulting singular. Teleology shows this in a more concrete way, while still relying on the same logical form. Let us examine the stages in more detail to see this.

First, the "subjective purpose" shares the logical form of <universality>. The purpose "is the self-equal *universal* and indeed an at first universal (and to that extent still *indeterminate*) *activity* containing self-repelling negativity" (*WL* II 445/657, modified). I take the subjective purpose to be akin to purely logical universality because the purpose, prior to its realization, can be anything and everything. It is "indeterminate." As purely universal, one purpose is the same as any other. Only with particularization does the universal gain determinacy. Hegel emphasizes this purpose as *subjective*, not in the sense that he treats it explicitly as mental or psychological, but in the sense that the universal purpose is unrealized, and thus separated from its object. Hence, the universal shows up as a "striving": "Purpose, therefore, is the subjective concept as an essential striving and impulse to posit itself externally" (445/657).

Secondly, the "means" (*das Mittel*) plays the role of the formal Concept's *particularity*; it mediates universality and singularity. The purposive "means" becomes the middle term of the syllogism: "Through a means the purpose unites with objectivity and in objectivity unities with itself. This means is the middle term of the syllogism [*Das Mittel ist die Mitte des Schlusses*]" (*WL* II 448/659).[35] Given an abstract, still subjective purpose, it is the means – the way the purpose is carried out – that demarcates the purpose as *something* and gives it specific content. For Hegel, the means is the shape that "externality" takes on its way to being conformed to a subjective purpose (448–9/660). Hegel thus emphasizes that the object that would be purposively shaped must at first be seen as "mechanical" or "chemical": as relatively *indifferent* to the purpose or concept at hand (449–50/660–1). This suggests that the object that is to be shaped according to the concept or purpose is not *already* in conformity with the concept. In

[34] Cf. Ng 2020: 238.

[35] Hegel says explicitly that the means "is, like particularity in the formal syllogism, an indifferent *medius terminus*" (*WL* II 449/660).

the means, there is something "presupposed" as only "in itself" conforming to the concept (450/661). This implies that there is a distinction within the realm of objectivity between those objects that do, and those that do not, carry out means such as to realize a purpose.

Thirdly, it is largely implicit in Hegel's discussion (though also clear upon reflection) that "the realized purpose" (*der ausgeführte Zweck*), the final stage of teleology, corresponds to the logical category of <singularity>. He does not frequently use this term in Teleology, apart from the important reference quoted above: "The same negativity [sc. of particularity], through its self-reference, is just as immediately the reflection of the form into itself and *singularity*" (*WL* II 446/658).[36] But singularity is conceptually correlated with terms like "existence" (*Dasein*) and "externality,"[37] which are frequently used in the context; not to mention that the "objectivity" in which a purpose is realized is itself the product of the formal syllogism, including singularity. Since singularity is entailed in these connections, it is not especially noteworthy that Hegel does not frequently use the term.

What is important is that the singular is precisely the embodiment of the purpose; the purpose, though general in character, was to be singularly realized. Hegel is willing to speak of the product as "identical" to the concept or universal purpose:

> The product is an objectivity which is identical with the concept, is the realized purpose in which the side of being a means is the reality itself of the purpose. In the completed purpose the means disappears because it would be simply and solely the objectivity immediately subsumed under that purpose, an objectivity which in the realized purpose is the turning back of the purpose into itself; further, there also disappears with it mediation itself, as the relating of an external; it disappears into both the concrete identity of objective purpose, and into the same identity as abstract identity and immediacy of existence. (*WL* II 459/667)

Here we find the identity between concept and object that is lacking in the relation between subject and predicate in the judgment. In the realized purpose, the formal elements distinguishing the subjective purpose from the object in which it is realized begin to "disappear." It is when a purpose is realized that the object "merge[s] with it in the unity of the concept

[36] There is also an apparently derogatory reference to the "external singularity" of artifacts like houses and clocks (*WL* II 457/666). Presumably, not all singularity falls under that estimation.

[37] Recall: "Through singularity, where it is *internal to itself*, the concept becomes *external to itself*, and steps into actuality" (*WL* II 299/458).

through itself" (451/662). In other words, the realization or achievement of a purpose blurs the distinction between what was intended (the subjective purpose) and what was accomplished (the "object" of the purpose). It is just this kind of relation that was sketched in a passage I shared in Chapter 1 from Hegel's earlier lectures:

> The intention [*Vorsatz*] to build a house is an inner determination, the form of which consists in first being only an intention; the content comprehends the plan of the house. Now when this form is sublated, the content still remains. *The house which is supposed to be built according to the intention, and the [house] built according to the plan, are the same house*. (W 4: 217, my emphasis)

As Hegel says in later lectures, "The purpose produces something, but the product is what the purpose is" [*Der Zwek bringt etwas hervor, aber das product ist was der Zwek selbst*] (GW 23,1: 135). In Hegel's view, something singular can *be* the very thing that the universal was supposed to be.

Now, how something can be the product of a concept can be easily misunderstood, and here the example of the house can also mislead. It can be easy to suppose that a subjective purpose is something like a mental picture (a Hegelian *Vorstellung*), and the completed purpose is an object that somehow 'looks like' what was imagined.[38] But recall that for Hegel the only purely logical content of a concept is something like the totality of its distinctions. We may in philosophical thinking produce such distinctions dialectically and express them linguistically. But we need not limit the domain of such distinctions to the linguistic. We can think of the object of the realized purpose as *being* precisely the kind of distinction that would be *thought* in its concept. That is, the product is what results when the purpose "makes a difference." This does not require the conformity of a mental picture to an object. It requires something like the "negativity" of purposive activity expressing a logical distinction. Indeed, Hegel writes: "The *content* of the purpose is its negativity as *simple particularity reflected into itself*" (454/664, modified). Since this negativity is the sole content of the

[38] Sometimes it seems that Marx has this idea of what "labor" is: "We presuppose labour in a form in which it is an exclusively human characteristic. A spider conducts operations which resemble those of the weaver, and a bee would put many a human architect to shame by the construction of her honeycomb cells. *But what distinguishes the worst architect from the best of bees is that the architect builds the cell in his mind* [in seinem Kopf: lit. 'in his head'] *before he constructs it in wax*. At the end of every labour process, a result emerges which had already been conceived by the worker [*schon in der Vorstellung des Arbeiters*] at the beginning, hence already existed ideally" (Marx 1976: 284, my emphasis/1962: 193).

singular existence of conceptual form, it exhibits the "doubling" of the concept in the object that Hegel is looking for.[39]

Let us use the term I previously introduced, *conceptual constitution*, to describe the teleological process that Hegel describes. For it is specifically the most characteristically conceptual moment, namely universality, that comes to be the source of the process that Hegel describes as teleology. Conceptual constitution is the realization of a universal that becomes specific in its realization. We can then call a universal that comes to be the subject of such a teleological process a *constitutive concept* (for we often label specific universals "concepts"). In one of his most suggestive metaphors to explain the purposive process, Hegel writes: "The teleological process is the *translation* of the concept that ex-ists distinctly as concept into objectivity; as we see, this translation into a presupposed other is the rejoining of the concept *through itself with itself*" (*WL* II 454/664). A constitutive concept is the kind of concept that can be translated into its objectivity. For this reason, the resulting objectivity is non-accidentally related to its conceptual basis.

Thus, from the point of view of Hegel's logical problem about truth, teleology shows, as judgment did not, how there can be an identity between universal and singular. From the point of view of judgment, the universal predicate is *not* identical to the singular subject, though it is supposed to be. But in the teleological process, the purpose set out in the universal *is to be* the singular. There is thus a genuine conceptual identity between the subjective purpose and the realized purpose. For this reason, "purpose concepts," *Zweckbegriffe*, are essentially different than concepts that have as their aim to subsume or represent something. The teleological process *uniquely* demonstrates the solution to Hegel's starting problem about truth as the unity of concept with its object.

As something like the culmination of his progressive explanation of truth, teleology also represents for Hegel the stumbling block of previous metaphysical theories. In particular, Hegel emphasizes that teleology cannot be adequately placed within the metaphysics criticized in the Objective Logic. Hegel writes:

> Of the teleological activity one can say, therefore, that in it the end is the beginning, the consequence the ground, the effect the cause; that it is a becoming of what has become; that in it only that which already concretely exists comes into existence, and so on; that is to say, that quite in general all the relation determinations that belong to the sphere of reflection [sc. the

[39] Hegel revisits this language of doubling at *WL* II 460/668.

> *Doctrine of Essence*] or of immediate being [sc. the *Doctrine of Being*] have lost their distinction, and what, like end, consequence, effect, and so on, is spoken of as an *other*, no longer has in purpose this determination of other, but is rather posited as identical with the simple concept. (*WL* II 454–5/664)

In my view, teleology cannot be adequately represented in the framework of the Objective Logic precisely because objects that can be understood teleologically require explicit reference to conceptuality. Once we move (in the Subjective Logic) to a Logic that takes the form of thought *explicitly* into account, objects that depend on their concepts gain a new prominence.

5.4 Teleology and the Artifactual Paradigm

From the rarified perspective of the *Logic* itself, which deals with its concepts "in and for themselves" without considering problems of their application or reference, we perhaps need not say any more on the central point at issue: that there is a logical form that demonstrates the unity of Concept and object, and that teleology is the logical and even syllogistic expression of this unity. This claim can be made independently of the applicability of <teleology> to the real world. Indeed, I have insisted that one of the defining features of a Hegelian logical concept is its topic-neutrality. That is, a logical account in a broad Hegelian sense cannot implicitly be an account of the domains of nature or spirit. However, even if it is not essential for the argument of Teleology itself, I believe it is worth asking what Hegel thinks is supposed to be an instance of teleology or conceptual constitution so understood and, further, what Hegel's account of teleology is supposed to do for the remainder of his philosophical itinerary. The reader will rightly suspect that my interest here concerns the central thesis of this book. In my view, the account of teleology in the *Logic* provides a basis for an artifactual paradigm in philosophy. Hence, it is important to consider the artifactual resonances in the Teleology chapter.

To begin, we should note that Hegel's account of teleology as outlined above mirrors quite precisely his account of the "work" (*Werk*) from the *Phenomenology* (see Section 2.4). While in that earlier book, Hegel describes the production of an artifact in terms of its role for self-consciousness and its relation to the world, in Teleology he describes the same kind of structure in terms of its merely logical significance. It *seems* that Hegel is showing here in effect that the logical structure of teleology is parallel to the practical structure that made absolute knowing possible; and

that, we saw, had an essentially artifactual form. Indeed, against a broad tendency in the literature on the chapter, I think this artifactual structure is prominent in Teleology.[40] This does not imply that the aim of Teleology is to present a theory of artifacts. But it does seem to me that Hegel's account of teleology in the *Logic* uses an *artifactual model* to explain "truth" or the Idea; teleology is thus paradigmatically exemplified by certain kinds of artifacts. If so, artifacts are of a central interest in philosophy, for they help explain one of its core puzzles. Artifacts show, in a way that perhaps nothing else does, what it means for thought and its object, concept and reality, to be unified.

A positive reason for thinking that Teleology exemplifies an artifactual model of conceptual constitution is the role of the *universal* or the subjective concept in the account. Hegel treats the particularity of the means and the singularity of the realized purpose as further determinations of the universal, conceptual form of the purpose. This is the "top-down" kind of structure we expect to see when a thought is being put into action. He also says that purpose is "the subjective concept as an essential striving and impulse to posit itself externally" (*WL* II 444/657).[41] While Hegel's use of "subjective" does not always connote *thought*, his reference to the *subjective concept* seems to link his account to the formal Concept and thus the explicit form of thought. The same is true of Hegel's reference to the purpose as *universal*. On my reading, universality is always and only a property of thought for Hegel.[42] Accordingly, universality as such does not exist in unthinking nature (or does so, in a slippery turn of phrase, only "*an sich*").[43] Hence, though Hegel's reference to universality does not specifically connote acts of human thinking, it is a form that can only be instantiated by acts of thinking. Insofar as universality is the first stage of the purpose as described in Teleology, this suggests that the teleology thus

[40] A recent exception to this tendency is Koch 2023, though we differ on the implications of this.

[41] It is true that Hegel defines "subjectivity" in a broad way to include basically anything that can act with a kind of unity, and especially a kind of negative self-relation. My point of emphasis here is not on "subjective" but "subjective *Concept*."

[42] On universality as a specific power of the thinking subject, see *WL* II 253/514–15. Cf. Hegel's treatment as Platonic universals as concepts: *WL* II 44/30. See also the following note.

[43] "In thinking things, we transform them into something universal; but things are singular and the Lion as Such does not exist. We give them the form of something subjective, of something produced by us and belonging to us, and belonging to us in our specifically human character: *for natural objects do not think, and are not presentations or thoughts*" (*EPN* § 246Z, 16/7). "What exists naturally is simply a singular and is indeed individualized [*vereinzelt*] on all points and sides. Yet representation [*Vorstellung*] has the determination of the *universal* within it, and what emerges out of it already preserves therefore the character of universality, unlike what is naturally individualized" (*VÄ* I 216/164).

described is akin to the realization of a purpose that begins with thoughtful intention. Finally, Hegel treats the purpose "as the concept that exists freely over against the object and its process" (453/663), which seems to suggest that the purpose, as conceptual, is separable from the object, in a way that is hard to understand if a natural purpose were meant: if a "concept" were something immanent to a natural organism, it would not be separable from the thing or "over against" it.

To be sure, Hegel does not ultimately want to see the purpose as external to its object. For to realize a purpose is precisely to close the distance between the subjective purpose and its objectivity. Hence the metaphor of *translation* from the previous section. But the initial distance seems to be possible only in purposive activity that is governed by thought that is not attached to its object. This does not mean we should think of teleology as requiring a carefully planned design that exists fully formed before it is implemented. We have seen that the content of a universal might become determinate in its very realization, so that the thought or intention need not be a fully formed concept. But that does not preclude the role of abstract thought in guiding or directing, however indeterminately, the purpose of some activity.[44] This seems to be the only place for universality proper in the process. In short, the logical structure of teleology seems to demand for its exemplification a moment that corresponds to thinking intention on the part of an acting subject. This ties the structure closely to the kind of mind-to-world constitution we see in the case of artifacts.

Now, it may be objected that Hegel does not, given what is derived in the *Logic* thus far, have the resources to speak of "intention" or "human action" or "consciousness."[45] With this I quite agree. Hegel is discussing the *logical content* of teleology. Here, what matters centrally is the role of universality, particularity, and singularity. Nothing in this account *requires* referring to anything so complex as human consciousness, or indeed artifacts.[46] Still, it is a false austerity to *avoid* mentioning thought and

[44] This is why Hegel can say that the practical Idea, later in the *Logic*, uses the same syllogism as that of external purposiveness: "The syllogism of immediate *realization* does not itself require a further exposition here; it is none other than the previously considered syllogism of *external purposiveness*; only the content constitutes the difference" (*WL* II 543/730).

[45] I here give expression to a criticism developed at length by Maraguat 2023: ch. 6.

[46] In this way, I quite agree with Maraguat (2023: 117), who writes that subjective purposes are "purposes whose realisation is still *pending* and nothing else. For the sake of argument, the *Logic* assumes that there is room for a process of realisation that takes purposes from not being accomplished to being accomplished." Maraguat stresses that this characterization avoids mentioning the presence of purpose in consciousness. Thus far we agree. However, where we seem to differ is that, in my view, this avoidance does not preclude the paradigmatic instantiation of Hegel's account in the sphere of human purposes. Maraguat he later writes, "I think that all this indicates that

intention here. Since human thought and intention non-accidentally exemplify the specific logical contents of the teleological process, it would be mistaken to *deny* their relevance in the context. It would be a comparable error to say that one should not use the sentence, "If it rains, the streets will be wet" in formal logic because it concerns a *causal*, not a *logical*, connection. The error here is treating the neutrality of logic with respect to causality as involving an exclusion of causal connections from logical relevance. But it is no offense to the formality of logic to say that causal judgments especially well exemplify the logical form of hypothetical propositions.[47] Similarly, the logical form of universality is the characteristic form of thought and *not* the form of other existents in any usual sense. It is thus not inappropriate to think that Hegel's account of teleology is well (and even paradigmatically) exemplified in the domain of human action, though in such a way to leave room for a more determinate and explicit treatment of this topic later on (see "The Idea of the Good"). Once we are willing to see the logical form of something like intention in Teleology, it is much more plausible that it suggests an artifactual model.

However, among scholars who consider what kind of application Hegel's treatment of teleology in the *Logic* is supposed to have, the great majority consider his account to be designed to make a point about *nature*. There are understandable reasons for this. First, the labels Hegel gives to the prior subsections of Objectivity ("Mechanism" and "Chemism") are often taken to be primarily relevant to the natural sciences, even if Hegel insists that there are *geistige* applications of mechanism and chemism as well (and indeed even though the account should not depend on any such application). And, as we shall see, the first chapter of "The Idea," the successor to Teleology, is "Life" (*Das Leben*), which is also very often read as a quasi-natural category. It seems reasonable to think that, if Teleology is sandwiched between two chapters that are apparently focused on nature,

'Teleology' does not discuss the specific teleology of intentions, neither Anscombe's immediate intentions, nor Kant's moral intentions, nor any other kind of intentions" (2023: 132). Maraguat's reasons for this do not persuade me. It's easy to agree with him that teleology does not discuss actions "*qua* actions" (2023: 132). It also doesn't discuss natural purposes *qua* natural purposes. (Or anything else, other than purposes *qua* purposes.) From this it does not follow that the logical form of teleology is not precisely what gets instantiated in (some) human action.

[47] Similarly, suppose one was considering the general engineering principles for flight. These principles would not require a reference to feathers. But, of course, the absence of feathers in the engineering principles of flight does not entitle us to state that flight does not involve feathers! Indeed, even a general ("multiply realizable") account of flight engineering might be able to explain why a certain kind of material (like feathers) is especially well suited to perform that feat.

the intervening section should be interpreted in line with this trajectory.[48] Thus, even if Teleology includes artifactual examples, it is often thought that this is systematically out of place.

A second, more substantive, piece of evidence for reading Hegel's account in terms of nature, however, seems to come from Hegel's important references to Kant's problem about natural teleology in the introduction to Teleology. Hegel writes,

> One of Kant's greatest services to philosophy was in drawing the distinction between relative or *external* purposiveness and *internal* purposiveness; in the latter he opened up the concept of *life*, the *idea*, and with that he *positively* raised philosophy above the determinations of reflections and the relative world of metaphysics, something that the *Critique of Reason* does only imperfectly, ambiguously, and only *negatively*. (*WL* II 440–1/654)

For Kant, traditional creationist accounts of teleology, which were built on the model of artifacts, only attempted to explain how things could be purposive to something outside themselves – to God, for example, or perhaps to human beings. In other words, they attempted to explain how things could be *means* or indeed "useful" (cf. Ak. 5: 367). This is what Kant calls *external* purposiveness. But what puzzled Kant about organisms is that their members were purposive *for the sake of the organism itself*. This is to say, the organisms are not just *means* but *ends* or "natural ends" (*Naturzwecke*). Their purposiveness is thus "internal." For Kant, the conceptual problem of teleology is not about external but internal purposiveness. The problem is how natural things, which are precisely not artifacts of ours and whose members cannot guide themselves conceptually, can nevertheless be purposive in the internal sense. Connected along with this, of course, is the problem of how we can be justified in judging the purposes of organisms. That is, the question is: given a subject that cannot be *assumed* to be purposive, how can a purposive predicate be properly ascribed nonetheless? Ultimately, though Kant thinks we must consider organisms as sui generis natural purposes (cf. Ak. 5: 376), we are not permitted to ascribe a *constitutive* function to the purposes in nature.

Kant's problem about teleology and internal purposiveness is obviously a problem about nature. He is well aware that there is an alternative use of

[48] Christian Martin (2012: 406) is aware that logical categories cannot be specifically natural. But he treats the category of teleology as the category of "*mere* or un-ensouled life." Robert Pippin (2019: 281), who agrees that artifactual examples are at the core of Teleology, writes, "But it (artifactual making and so subjective end setting) seems oddly illustrative, used to make a point in preparation for the account of living beings." See also Maraguat 2023: 131.

teleological concepts in the domain of human action, but he takes this use of teleology to be unproblematic. Indeed, he thinks the teleology of action is the source (by analogy) of our search for it in nature. He writes:

> For we adduce a teleological ground when we ascribe causality in regard to an object to a concept of the object as if it were to be found in nature (not in us), or rather *we represent the possibility of the object in accordance with the analogy of such a causality (like the kind we encounter in ourselves),* and hence we conceive of nature as **technical** through its own capacity; whereas if we did not ascribe such an agency to it, we would have to represent its causality as a blind mechanism. (Ak. 5: 360, my emphasis; bold type in the original)[49]

For Kant, our conception of nature as purposiveness gains its intelligibility (if not its objectivity) by an analogy to our own "technical" capacity to be the cause of objects through our concepts. Indeed, when we attribute purposes to nature, we "merely borrow [this kind of causality] from ourselves" (Ak. 5: 361).[50]

Since only the use of purposive concepts in *nature* is problematic for Kant, it stands to reason that if Hegel's aim in the Teleology chapter is to criticize Kant, his solution should also concern the natural domain, where (and only where) Kant's problem emerges. And Hegel does evince some dissatisfaction with Kant's solution to the problem, according to which our purposive judgments "must be regarded not as *objective propositions* but as *subjective maxims*" (*WL* II 442/655). It is thus common to read the Teleology chapter as Hegel's attempt to solve Kant's problem about natural purposiveness, or at least to provide the logical resources that could be used to solve it.[51] Importantly, this way of reading Hegel clearly *precludes* artifacts from being at issue in Teleology. For it is clear that the seeming paradox of internal purposiveness in nature derives from the fact that natural purpose is supposed *not* to be conceptually represented by the organism. If Hegel is going to solve Kant's problem on Kant's terms, he must also suppose that internal purposiveness is not guided by a conceptually represented purpose.[52] Accordingly, many interpreters

[49] Cf. also Ak. 5: 367–8, 370–2.

[50] As Kant further develops the notion of internal purposiveness, he qualifies this claim: "Strictly speaking, the organization of nature is therefore not analogous with any causality we know" (Ak. 5: 375). This is because the organization of nature cannot rely on the will of a being outside the object (cf. Ak. 5: 374).

[51] See, e.g., deVries 1991; Kreines 2015; Khurana 2017: 279; Lindquist 2018; Pippin 2019: ch. 8.

[52] James Kreines (2015: 95), for example, sees affinity between Hegel and Aristotle on this point: "Hegel sees in Aristotle the denial that teleology requires intelligent representation of an end." And he claims that his response to Kant will work within this constraint (2015: 98). Hence, the role of

take artifacts, including anything governed by explicitly intentional causation, as excluded from Hegel's idea of internal purposiveness.[53]

However, it should first be pointed out that Hegel's *explicit* complaint about Kant's account of teleology does not concern Kant's timid failure simply to claim that internal purposiveness is objective in nature,[54] but rather the fact that he does not first consider "the *truth* of these determinations themselves, whether they both are determinations or the object or of cognitions" (*WL* II 444/655). In other words, according to Hegel, Kant does not adequately consider the notion of purposiveness *on its own terms*, prior to asking after its possible application to objects of nature. This complaint is frankly a rather mild one with respect to Kant's own concerns. It does not seem to imply that Hegel will solve the problem that Kant himself set out to solve. Indeed, it seems to suggest that Hegel wants to achieve a more basic conceptual grasp of purposiveness *without* attempting to solve Kant's problem about natural causality, or at least not per se.

In addition, though Hegel clearly has a special interest in internal purposiveness, it does not follow that the treatment of this topic is in Teleology. To be sure, Hegel's praise of Kant's rediscovery of internal purposiveness comes in the introduction to Teleology. But Hegel's outline of the Objectivity sections suggests that he sees internal purposiveness coming with the Life chapter. He writes, speaking specifically of Teleology,

> *Third*, this essential unity of the object is precisely thus posited as distinguished form its independence, it is the subjective concept, but posited as in and for itself related to objectivity, as *purpose* [Zweck] – *Teleology*. Since the purpose is the concept, which is posited as related in itself to objectivity, and its defect of being subjective sublated through itself, the at first *external* purposiveness becomes *internal* [purposiveness] through the realization of the purpose and *Idea*. (*WL* II 409/630, modified)

This passage seems to suggest that at least the bulk of Teleology considers "external" purposiveness, and only when it culminates in the Idea

concepts or universals as explicitly *guiding* the realization of purpose is not a part of Hegel's account, for Kreines. Accordingly, Kreines associates "internal purposiveness" – the kind that Hegel praises Kant for discovering – with natural Aristotelian-style purposiveness and "external purposiveness" with artifacts (cf. Kreines 2015: 77, 85). See Gentry (2019: 158) for a challenge to the natural/artificial dichotomy here.

[53] See deVries 1991, who reads Hegel as promoting a shift from an "intentional" to a "functional" model of teleology. Maraguat (2023: 131) even argues that the *will* is not an example of internal teleology.

[54] Here I again agree with Gentry 2019: 168.

(beginning with Life) does it reach "internal" purposiveness.[55] Indeed, we should recall Hegel's opening comment: "One of Kant's greatest services to philosophy was in drawing the distinction between relative or *external* purposiveness and *internal* purposiveness; in the latter he opened up the concept of *life*" (440–1/654). Hegel is not suggesting here that "external" purposiveness will not be important. He is praising Kant for noticing that there is also another form, which is associated not with teleology in general, but with "life" (a topic to be considered in the next chapter).

If Hegel's account in Teleology proper does not exclude artifacts from consideration, it is clear that his aim cannot be to solve the same problem as Kant. However, regardless of which chapter in the *Logic* is devoted to internal purposiveness, it seems to me that commentators dismiss the role of the intentional and artifactual in Teleology because they too quickly line up the notion of "external purposiveness" with artifacts and "internal purposiveness" with natural life. Hegel does give examples of the use of tools, and hence artifacts, to illustrate external or (in his more proprietary terms) "finite" teleology. These are examples where the means is separable from the end, so that there is nothing essential in the means for the end of a given kind.[56] As an example of external purposiveness, Hegel mentions the relation between the use of a plough and "the enjoyments which it procures and which are the purposes" (*WL* II 453/663). Hegel's main point here is that ploughs are in fact more valuable than their direct purposes, but the implication is that there is a kind of *separability* between the plough and the "enjoyments which it procures." The plough is only a means to enjoyment and not enjoyment itself. In this sense, there can be purposes that represent incomplete "syllogisms," for the universal of enjoyment is not to be found within the singular product.

This kind of example shows – almost exactly like Hegel's original discussion of the "work" (*Werk*) from the *Phenomenology* – that in finite material artifacts "concept and reality again separate from each other" (*PhG* 302/¶ 407). The "identity" that is supposed to be invested in a material thing by crafting it according to a purpose is not, in fact, a stable conceptual identity. This is a crucial point to keep in mind, as it helps to explain why Hegel does not take basic material artifacts as such to be adequate realizations of a concept. However, it would be a mistaken inference to suppose that the separation between concept and object is

[55] To be sure, the move to internal purposiveness comes in the transition to Life also at the end of the Teleology chapter. This is quite explicit in "The Realized Purpose" section (see *WL* II 456–61/665–9) and helps to confirm that the bulk of Teleology is on the topic of external purposiveness.

[56] Cf. *WL* II 453/663.

somehow *due* to the role of thought in bringing about the purpose: as if thought was what *made* purpose external. On that way of thinking, internal purposiveness would *require* the absence of thought in bringing about the purpose, in which case *only* unthinking plants and animals could be offer adequate examples.

This cannot be right. As we shall see, the "spiritual" artifacts that concern Hegel are the kind of objects that do not exist without thinking and are rather precisely those that require continual and constitutive involvement with their thinking purposes. The role of thinking does not make them examples of external purposiveness. They are "living" artifacts, in which thinking, purposive activity does not cease when the thing is built. For this very reason, their creation is not finished once and for all. Such artifacts include fine art,[57] language, religion, and the state itself. An overgeneralization about Hegel's distinction between internal and external purposiveness could imply that these are second-class examples of internal purposiveness because they *are* guided by thought and intention. We will have to wait until the next chapter to see the justification for taking these to be cases of internal purpose. But my point is simply that it is not at all obvious that *all* artifactual examples should (for Hegel at least) be put in the box of "external purposiveness" while the rank of "internal purposiveness" is reserved for, say, natural organisms. Yet naturalistic readings of Teleology deny a place for explicit thought in the purposive process altogether. In being tied to Kant's problem about natural purpose specifically, these readings *require* purposive processes to be unthinking. As a result, they rule out the relevance of teleology to the artifactual domain.

Reading the Teleology chapter in terms of nature thus seems to require two assumptions, both of which have proven to be questionable. First is the assumption that Hegel is attempting to answer Kant's problem about natural purposiveness on Kant's own terms. But the text does not force this assumption. If he were trying to answer Kant, this would seem to *require* the discussion of teleology to be about purposes in nature. It would

[57] Hegel is quite clear that the end or purpose of the work of art is not in some external utility, but in the art itself: "If on this account we now continue to speak of a final end and aim, we must in the first place get rid of the perverse idea which, in the question about an end, clings to the accessory meaning of the question, namely that it is one about utility. The perversity here lies in this, that in that case the work of art is supposed to have a bearing on something else which is set before our minds as the essential thing or as what ought to be, so that then the work of art would have validity only as a useful tool for realizing this end which is independently valid on its own account outside the sphere of art" (*VÄ* I 82/55). For example, the problem with treating art as an instrument for moral improvement is that "its substantial purpose" is treated as "not within itself but rather in another" (*VÄ* I 82/55).

also require excluding artifactual or practical instances from its scope. Hegel is interested in examining the concept of purpose in its own right, determining its own relevant distinctions, and this is what he claims Kant failed to do.

The second questionable assumption is that because, for Kant, only the internal purposiveness of nature is philosophically puzzling, Hegel is assuming a context for teleology in which the form of thought can play no role. As I have argued, this seems to require the assumption that Hegel treats primarily internal purposiveness in Teleology. This seems not to be the case. It also assumes that, for Hegel, human action and production could not exemplify the form of internal purposiveness, leaving only natural organisms as adequate instances.[58] However, even if Hegel treats purposiveness at an abstract level in the *Logic*, he by no means excludes purposiveness that involves thought and intention. Instead, the very form of thought and intention (namely, universality) seem to be included in Hegel's notion of teleology proper.

5.5 Conclusion

In my view, Hegel maintains the rather commonsense view that teleology is best expressed in intentional action that results in the constitution of an object.[59] Hegel's concept of teleology in the *Logic* is that of a "top-down" universal that is further determined and thus makes some singular object what it is. Teleology thus makes *constitutive concepts* possible: concepts or universals that do not aim to represent or subsume a given object, but which make their own object. I believe the concept of teleology has a specific role in the *Logic*, for Hegel. It is meant to solve a logico-metaphysical problem about the relation of thought to reality. If that relation were everywhere and only one of a representation, as expressed paradigmatically in the positive judgment, reality would always be considered as fundamentally foreign to thought, so that thinking would at best involve a kind of *faith* or *inference* that reality is as it is thought to be. In

[58] Contrast deVries 1991: 62: "Organisms provide Hegel with the best examples of the fundamental structures of teleological process, though even organisms, because of their finitude are not perfect examples." This, of course, implies that there are no perfect examples of teleology. To my mind, this is an un-Hegelian result, especially given Hegel's notion of the Idea (the unity of Concept and reality), which depends on teleology being realized.

[59] To this extent, my kind of view is not the main target of Maraguat's criticism, considered in note 46 above. He considers a reading, which I find equally puzzling, according to which "there are purely subjective purposes whose realisation (or carrying out) is easy, immediate or undeniable, or that in practice we cannot but admit" (2023: 134).

contemporary philosophy, problems about the 'reference relation' and securing thought's contact with reality seem to be stuck precisely in this problematic. But in this representational, judgment-centric conception, we ignore a logical structure that is not at all obscure or unfamiliar: the realization of an articulate purpose, which is the universal become singular. It is precisely Hegel's complaint against Kant's use of "the Idea" (as a term for "concepts of reason") that he could *not* countenance such a constitutive relation. He writes,

> The concepts of reason [for Kant], in which we would have expected a higher power and a deeper content, no longer possess anything *constitutive* [*nichts Konstitutives*] as still do the categories; they are *mere* ideas which we are of course *quite at liberty* to use, provided that by these intelligible entities in which all *truth* was to be revealed we mean nothing more than *hypotheses* to which it would be the height of arbitrariness and recklessness to ascribe absolute truth, for they – *cannot be found in any experience*. (*WL* II 262/521).

If we take the lead from the Teleology chapter, Hegel's answer to Kant is that "intelligible entities" are closer to hand than the latter was willing to reckon. For genuine instances of the universal being made singular, and thus intelligible thought being reconciled with reality, seem to abound. Much of the human world would not exist were it not for its conceptual intelligibility. If our world – the human world – is structured (to whatever extent) by realized purposes (and those that are being realized), it is unclear why the representational relation should count as the paradigm instance of thought's relation to reality, and the paradigm object of thought's characteristic activity, philosophy itself. If we begin from Hegel's insight into teleology, this view of philosophy can begin to be upended.

CHAPTER 6

Living Artifacts
The Logical Basis of Geist

6.1 Hegelian Naturalism?

Teleology gives us the basis for Hegelian "truth": the agreement of Concept with object, which Hegel calls "the Idea." And the paradigm case of teleology is the artifactual constitution of an object according to a thinking purpose. Or so I have argued. It does not follow from this, however, that just any artifact exemplifies what Hegel calls "the Idea." Conceptual constitution via teleology gives us a rough outline of a certain logical form: the logical form in which a universal particularizes itself to become a singular. This is a "syllogistic" form that resembles the structure of an actor or maker producing an object; it thus gets instantiated in artifacts. However, if this was all there was to Hegel's "Idea," we should perhaps expect him to extoll the rationality of tables, chairs, and pinball machines. It would be rightly pointed out that these kinds of artifacts do not constitute a major focus of Hegel's philosophy. Hegel's search for "truth" (in his sense) is a search for that which is the suitable, paradigmatic object of concrete philosophical knowledge. Looking ahead in his system, we recognize as a distinctive mark of Hegel's approach to philosophy that a certain class of "objects" comes to take a perhaps unprecedented significance in his thought. These are the objects of the domain of "*Geist*"; they include art, religion, social institutions, the subjective mind, and philosophy itself. I have been trying to lay the basis for an *explanation* of the centrality of these topics in Hegel's thought, finding this basis in his theory of concepts. What needs to be shown, however, is how this theory of concepts explains why the artifacts of *Geist* differ from the basic material "things" that are constructed according to human designs.

Here, however, my interpretation may seem to encounter an obstacle. I have claimed that teleology, especially as interpreted artifactually, gives us the foundation for the Hegelian Idea and thus the proper object of concrete philosophical thought. But immediately after introducing the Idea, Hegel

describes its first or "immediate" stage as *life* (*das Leben*) and devotes a notorious chapter to discussing this "life" in the *Logic*. As I mentioned in the previous chapter, many readers, especially those who *already* read the Objectivity chapter as mainly dealing with the objects of nature or natural science (however abstractly considered), find that this sequence confirms their prior assumptions about Hegel's procedure. It may look as if Hegel begins by showing that purposes can exist in nature (in Teleology) and then shows that these can be something like self-determining purposes (in Life). The positioning of Life prior to the Cognition chapter could then be taken to imply that there is an organic or natural presupposition to rational cognition, or that *Geist* is akin to the natural kind of human beings.[1] A recent emphasis on the Life chapter has led some to endorse "naturalistic" (or Aristotelian-naturalistic) readings of Hegel, according to which kind-properties of organic life are more central to his idealism than might be thought.[2]

In this chapter, I aim to locate the role of life in my own account, showing not only that it is no threat to my artifactual reading of Hegelian truth but even that it in fact supports it. To be sure, the basic artifactual model of teleology is deficient on its own. Teleology presents the basic logical *structure* of truth – conceptual constitution – but it still exhibits the potential separation between ends and means, universal and singular, that prevents the merely teleological object from demonstrating the unity of Concept and objectivity in a concrete manner. In order for the teleological structure to realize the Concept, there must be some form of a *process* in which the singular and the universal are more closely related. I will argue that "life" (in the *Logic*) is a term that is used metaphorically to describe a more abstract and "topic-neutral" kind of process with a specific logical form. I argue resolutely that no reference to nature is needed to understand Hegel's argument in Life.

[1] Karen Ng's (2020) version of Hegelian naturalism consists precisely in her attempt to place life at the center of Hegel's idealism. As she writes, "In presenting the determination of the living individual as the absolute, original subject of judgment, Hegel naturalizes the terms of his idealism" (2020: 265). As this quotation indicates, for Ng, what is central about life is the way it opens up the possibility of *judgment* (cf. also 2020: 234). However, Ng understands "judgment" not to be an activity of thinking but "a form of activity manifest in all living things that enables anything to be presented as an intelligible object of cognition at all" (257). It becomes clear that Ng takes Hegel to think of judgment as something like the "affordances" of living beings (cf. Little 2022). Though Ng rightly denies that Hegel is appealing to the presuppositions of natural science or natural philosophy, it seems undeniable that her use of "life" is a reference to something like that which enables the activity of living organisms *as* natural.

[2] Among more (Aristotelian) naturalistic recent readings of Hegel, see especially Stern 1990, 2017; Pinkard 2012; Sell 2013; Kreines 2015; Khurana 2017; and Ng 2020.

While I do not aim to refute more naturalistic readings point by point, I hope to show how the Life chapter fits in systematically with the account given thus far, and so is no threat to my claim that artifacts provide us with the model or paradigm of Hegelian philosophy. Readings of Life in terms of living nature, just like readings of Mechanism and Chemism as natural scientific categories, fit poorly, at least prima facie, with Hegel's aim of explaining the possible unit of Concept and objectivity, his express goal in the *Concept Logic*. More positively, what I hope to show is that Hegel needs a concept like <life> (understood non-naturally) to explain how an object could be just what its concept says it is. This leads to the constructive side of the chapter. I want to make clear how the Life chapter, especially in combination with "The Idea of Cognition," is strictly relevant to Hegel's logico-metaphysical project in the *Concept Logic*. The concept of life plays an important but transitional role in the development of the concept of *Geist* in the *Logic* itself. I call the domain of *Geist* that of *living artifacts*, for <*Geist*> combines the process-character of <life> with the notion of *cognition*, needed to make a process intentional. The realm of objective spirit, or social ontology, offers the clearest instances of living artifacts, and I contend that the basic logical structure of objective spirit is given in the *Logic* itself. Hence, I argue that the *Logic* itself provides a basis for the philosophical significance of the artifactual domain of human culture. In this domain, our "*Lebenswelt*," it is possible for objects to be, and continue to be, what their concepts say they are, because of the actions of beings like us. This domain stands as the paradigm case of the Idea in its objective form, and thus the paradigmatic site of objective philosophical knowledge.

6.2 A Topic-Neutral Concept of Life

A first difficulty for interpreting Hegel's Life chapter is understanding how it could be a topic in "logic" at all, even in the broad sense in which Hegel uses that term.[3] Though Hegel employs the concept <life> throughout his works, he claims specifically that there is a distinctive treatment of <life> in the domain of Logic. He says that we must differentiate

> the logical view of life from any other scientific view of it, though this is not the place to concern ourselves with how life is treated in non-philosophical sciences but only how to differentiate logical life as idea from natural life as

[3] See, e.g., Düsing 1986; Wolff 1992; Stekeler-Weithofer 2004; Sell 2013; Englert 2016; Lindquist 2018; Pippin 2019; Werner 2019; Ng 2020; and Kabeshkin 2022a.

> treated in the *philosophy of nature*, and from life in so far as it is bound to *spirit*. (*WL* I 470–1/677)

Every interpreter pays lip-service, at least, to this passage, which announces the requirement that the treatment of <life> in the *Logic* be a topic-neutral one: it should not be such an account that has "presuppositions" concerning, for example, matters of empirical fact (471/677). However, when we read further in Hegel's chapter, one begins to wonder if he himself has kept his end of the bargain. Topics mentioned in Life include "body" (*Leib*), "sensibility" (*Sensibilität*), "irritability" (*Irritabilität*), and "pain" (*Schmerz*), among many others. Even if we set aside the question of how these topics could belong in a logic at all, we rightly wonder how they could *not* be discussed in a way that makes them implicitly "natural."

Some readers do not hold fast to the need for topic-neutrality, taking Hegel to be making an argument about nature, apparently despite his protests.[4] Others take the passage I quoted more as evidence that Hegel's Life chapter is offering a kind of a priori vindication of the distinction between living and non-living,[5] or a kind of abstract determination of life as a presupposition of judgment.[6] In either case, this account would count as "logical" rather than empirical because of its abstract or a priori level.[7]

In my view, any account that appeals to something natural in the chapter, even if it avoids explicitly empirical presuppositions, can succeed only by ignoring (or watering down) Hegel's prohibition against reading his logical concept <life> as a quasi-natural one. To be sure, it is not a violation of topic-neutrality merely to say that Hegel's account of logical <life> could be well exemplified in natural life. I have questions about what this exemplification will look like, but that is not the complaint. The violation of topic-neutrality comes from the way naturalistic accounts

[4] Compare Siep 2018: 669–70, 684–5. See also Sell 2013: 191: "On the other hand, it becomes clear that the Idea moves not in an indefinite, empty, or abstract space, but rather its first level is natural, living form (permeated by the Concept)." According to Neuhouser (2022: 283), Hegel uses a "biological prototype" in his concept of life.

[5] Pippin's (2019: 274) framing is striking: "As a consequence of this exploration of logical form alone, we are supposed to know that there must be forms of thought specific to self-organized beings, to perceiving and desiring self-organized beings, and to self-conscious and rational perceiving and desiring self-organized beings, or to plants, animals, and human animals."

[6] For example, Ng (2020: 265) states, "Hegel is not specifying any determinate details concerning what specific instances of living corporeality may entail, but is simply identifying the formal role that is played by corporeality – whatever determinate, empirical shape it takes – with respect to the principle of self-movement. Corporeality is presented here as an a priori condition for the activity of judging in which Concept and objectivity are united in the processual actuality of reason that Hegel calls the Idea."

[7] The latter claim is common to recent interpretations. See, e.g., Kreines 2015: 93–5; Lindquist 2018; Pippin 2019: 273–7; and Kabeshkin 2022a.

implicitly take Hegel's use of "life" to share its reference with some pre-theoretical notion of biological life. This is shown by the common assumption that terms like "species" or "pain" or "reproduction" are tied to their biological meanings. If the reference is fixed in that way, then even if we abstract from empirical details, the account is connected in principle to nature and nature alone.

Rather than starting from any pre-theoretical notion of life, and then asking what a logical version of *that* could be, I contend that we read Hegel's concept <life> in terms of its construction. That is, we should ask: what resources has he developed thus far that enable him to construct the concept that expresses the "immediate Idea" and which he is willing to give the name "life"? The substantive content of this concept will be rooted in its role in developing its predecessors. This leaves room for us to suppose that Hegel has adopted a metaphorically motivated (though not therefore arbitrary) *name* to label this concept ("life"), along with the constellation of concepts that surround it. Yet this strategy will free us to drop the metaphorical connotations of the concept when they become distracting.

The best way to motivate this tactic is to see that, just as elsewhere in the *Concept Logic*, Hegel constructs the concept <life> on the basis of a new development in the logical concepts that have preceded it, most fundamentally <universality>, <particularity>, and <singularity>, but also <purpose> and <object>, which have already been established at this stage. Hegel says that "in the idea of life the moments of its reality do not receive the shape of external actuality but rather *remain enveloped in the form of the concept*" (*WL* II 471/677, my emphasis). I take this to mean that a fully satisfactory account of <life> would show it to be articulable *solely* in the formal-conceptual terms that are given in the account that proceeds it. This can also be seen in one of Hegel's opening remarks on <life>, which seems to offer something like a definition. He writes: "Life, considered now more closely in its idea, is in and for itself absolute *universality*; the objectivity which it possesses is throughout permeated by the concept, and this concept alone it has as substance" (472/678). Rather than reading such a passage as making a substantive claim about life as pre-theoretically conceived (e.g., as that which distinguishes the living from non-living in nature), we are free to take this quotation to be a kind of *stipulative* definition. So that:

> "life/*das Leben*"(logical) $=_{\text{def}}$ the universality that has its objectivity and substance solely in the Concept

Before explaining what such a definition could mean, let me clarify my aim in presenting it thus. I am not saying that Hegel merely stipulates the

meaning of a concept. The complex concept <a universality that has its objectivity and substance solely in the Concept> is one that can be developed on the basis of more basic concepts that are already available in the course of the *Logic*.[8] What is *stipulated* is that such a concept could be given the name "life." If this is the case, the word will be suggestive but (like any metaphor) potentially misleading. The real content of the concept comes from the "logical" terms that make it up. And if the concept <life> is built up of logical terms that are themselves topic-neutral, the resulting concept will be topic-neutral as well. It will not as such serve a purpose like distinguishing the living from non-living in nature.

Now, let us consider this proposal in more detail. What advance stemming from <purpose> could be marked by Hegel's introduction of <life>? Drawing on the definition just provided, this advance can be recognized as involving a subtle but consequential addition to the preceding one. Hegel's development of <purpose> shows the logical form of a purpose to be such that it is a universal that constitutes a singular to be what it is. This concept of a purpose already gives us what Hegel calls above a "universality" that has its "substance" in the Concept. However, the concept <purpose> in Teleology takes it as a starting point that the singularity that comes to constitute the purpose is a "presupposed other" and so is distinct from its purpose. Yet this presupposition is not inherently necessary. Once we have the concept of a singular that is constituted according to a purpose that is initially outside it, we can grasp the concept of a singular for which the purpose is not alien in this way. Whereas the purpose as such was "top-down," as it were, a purpose that is constitutive for a singular is "bottom-up." This modification to <teleology> seems to be what Hegel signals with the turn to <life>. Hence, as Hegel nicely puts it, purpose becomes "life" when there is no longer a distinction between the product and the producing: "The concept produces itself through its drive [*Trieb*] such that the product, since it [the drive] is its essence, is the same as the producing" (*WL* II 477/681–2). In short, in moving on from mere <purpose>, which leaves room for a gap between the singular and the universal, we get a new concept, which I'll call <constitutive purpose>, which is purposive in its singularity. I believe the latter concept is roughly equivalent to Hegel's concept of <life> in the *Logic*. To understand this new concept, the apparent references to nature are irrelevant.

[8] Siep (2018: 685) draws attention to this, though I am not sure that he takes this to mean what I do.

To see this, we can just briefly walk through the main stages of the Life chapter and notice that we can understand each of them through the concept of a constitutive purpose, thereby avoiding the metaphorical connotations of "life." First, the mere notion of a constitutive purpose gives us the idea of the singular something for which the purpose is constitutive: this is the "living individual" (*WL* II 474–80/679–83). Since this singular is something for which the universal purpose is constitutive, we have the idea of something whose substance is the Concept. This was the starting concept of life and requires nothing more than the raw materials of <singularity> and <purposiveness>. Next, since the individual that fulfills a purpose is one that deploys the relevant means, that first notion seems to imply the process of *carrying out* or *working through* the purpose: "the life-process" (480–4/684–6). Though the concept of a process may not seem like a logical one, Hegel says that a process is a kind of inference;[9] carrying out the purpose is akin to reaching a conclusion inferentially that was built in to the premises. Since the process is defined according to purpose, the life-process must involve a discrimination regarding what is *outside* the individual, whether it belongs to the process or not. It must assimilate or not assimilate into it that which is outside it. The process to be *F* must thus have a way of 'saying' to itself whether it is becoming *F* or not. It requires a form of self-reference.[10] In this, the process has a way of representing what does not belong to the purpose: this is lack or deficiency (metaphorically: pain[11]). Finally, since a constitutive purpose must strive toward a universal, the movement toward which makes it what it is, the final stage of a purpose is the achievement of its universality or its *genus* (*Gattung*) (484–7/686–8). It may be especially this last stage that encourages interpreters to think of Hegel's references in Life as essentially natural. But we will see through examples in the next section that the use of "*Gattung*" here is not at all restricted to natural kinds and instead connotes the realized universal more

[9] Hegel says in lectures that "Life exists only as living [*als Lebendiges*]. The living is also a triad of inferences, but which no longer have the name 'inference' but are rather called 'process'" (GW 23,1: 140).

[10] Compare Sandkaulen 2019: 927.

[11] See the use of "pain" as a metaphor for the "negative" side of the realization of a purpose in general at *VÄ* I 113–14/81. Hegel stresses here that a living process requires "negation": "Undergoing this process of opposition, contradiction, and the dissolution of contradiction is the higher privilege of living natures; what is innately [*von Haus aus*] *only* affirmative and remains thus is and remains without life. Life goes on to negation and its pain and is only affirmative for itself by discharging opposition and contradiction" (*VÄ* I 134/96).

generally.[12] The *Gattung* is simply "the concept whose reality has the form of immediate objectivity" (485/687).

All this is abstractly put, and that is part of the point. My aim thus far has been to show that if we treat the concept <life> as essentially the concept <constitutive purpose>, we can understand each stage of the Life chapter without any need to appeal to nature. The concept <life> so determined makes no substantive assumptions about its subject matter. It does not tell us what its domain of application is, or even if there is such a domain. Whether it helps to clarify biological life or not turns out to be irrelevant. What is more important is that it develops a distinctive possibility in the logical relation of singularity and universality, one in which they are more intimately related than teleology as such allows. If this is so, I believe we can legitimately subtract Hegel's metaphorical language in Life to find something like his literal meaning, as rooted in the logical concepts previously developed in his discussion. With some reservations, it is certainly intelligible to see this kind of constitutive purpose as carried out in nature.[13] For that reason, we should not be surprised that Hegel's concept of natural life mirrors precisely his concept of logical life. But it remains the case that, as Hegel develops <life> in the context of his *Logic*, nothing in his account implies a claim about life as naturally understood. Nor is it clear what place such a topic would have in his project. Hegel's aim remains the explanation of the Concept's realization, and for this aim the concept <constitutive purpose> is relevant, as I hope to show.

6.3 Case Study: The "Life" of History

A task for a fuller interpretation of Life, which I will not attempt to carry out here, would be to show how *all* the biological-sounding terms in the chapter can be taken as metaphors for more generic structures that do not require a reference to biological domain.[14] I have only made a gesture in this direction, but it seems a worthy project. One can even think of other abstract purposive structures that have similar features. For example,

[12] For a more detailed account of how an account of the stages of "Life" recounted here can be construed "purely" (i.e., topic-neutrally, in my terms), see Englert 2016: 72 ff.

[13] As for my reservations, I mean Hegel's apparent denial that the "*Gattung*" is fully realized in animal nature. See Sections 6.3, 6.4, and 7.4.2.

[14] Compare Martin (2012: 440): "Thus even such logical determinations as corporeality or procreation, which seem to indicate empirical phenomena do not amount to an intrusion into the Idea section of the extra-logical, but should rather be taken as terminological expressions for a priori stages of the unfolding of self-sustaining self-determining." Though I do not fully agree with Martin, this is a good model for understanding these problematic expressions.

cybernetic theory,[15] or dynamical systems theory, or even the "back-propagation" algorithms of contemporary machine learning might well be taken to exemplify "living" processes, replete with their own *versions* of the metaphorical concepts of "body,"[16] "irritability," and "reproduction."

However, though one can argue that the concept <life> is topic-neutral by showing that it needs no reference to nature, it is perhaps equally useful to see how Hegel uses the concept in a different concrete domain, namely that of spirit.[17] Hegel himself says that the domain of spirit involves a "higher kind of life [*Lebendigkeit*]" (*EPN* § 248 R, 29/18) than nature. And though the *Logic*'s treatment of <life> is not itself the life of spirit, the logical concept of life should be something that can be instantiated in spirit just as well as – or better than – nature.[18]

Perhaps surprisingly, I think Hegel offers us a thoroughly worked-out example of <life>, as defined in the *Logic*, in his popular *Lectures on the Philosophy of World History* (*VPG*).[19] A well-known feature of Hegel's concept of history is his notion of a "ruse of reason." Namely, Hegel thinks that history is a kind of purposive process, but one that achieves its rational results *not* (at least at first) as the result of intentional planning. At the same time, history is unified for Hegel by a single purpose, and indeed one that can be treated as *constitutive*, namely freedom. That is, freedom is the kind of purpose that is involved in its own realization: "[Freedom] is the end

[15] Gotthard Günther (1976) makes a direct connection between "life" as Hegel introduces it in the *Logic* and cybernetic theory (which is essentially a topic-neutral theory of self-organization), emphasizing the self-referential character of cybernetic operations, as well as their neutrality with respect to given substrates (what we would call "multiple realizability" today). See Sachs (2023) for a similar use of cybernetics.

[16] It is not implausible that Hegel's reference to "body" in discussing the Idea as the "soul and body" of the Concept is often metaphorical. See, e.g., *GPR* § 1R. It seems pretty clear here that "body" is standing in, generically, for any form of objectivity suitable to be the 'vehicle' for a constitutive purpose.

[17] An account very congenial to this claim is Sandkaulen 2019. Sandkaulen traces the interest in the concept of "*Leben*" in classical German philosophy to one more like the "*Lebenswelt*" concept of Husserl's phenomenology. Indeed, she argues that the interest in natural life "*presupposes*" this other meaning in the historical context (2019: 915). Accordingly, she agrees that recognizing this more neutral concept of life (she calls it a "meta" concept) tells against naturalistic readings of Hegel (2019: 926 n. 20).

[18] This might seem puzzling. For one way to show that a concept is topic-neutral or "multiply realizable" would be to try to describe it only on a formal or more abstract level, to avoid consideration of its potential instances. But that's not the only way. Someone might think that <computer> is not an abstract or formal concept, thinking that only personal computers and smartphones could count as its instances. This notion could be disabused by a formal theory of computation – but the example of a Turing machine constructed out of wood or LEGOs could serve just as well.

[19] Compare Maraguat's (2023: 223 ff.) similar use of the *Philosophy of Right*, though we seem to draw opposite implications from the presence of logical categories in the "spiritual" domain.

which it itself carries out" (*VPG* 33/67). This is very like the notion of life. But it is not only this seeming coincidence that makes history a relevant example of <life>, defined as constitutive purpose.[20] Hegel makes numerous references to life in the *VPG*,[21] which correspond rather neatly to the stages of <life> in the *Logic*. I believe history exemplifies precisely the structure that Hegel defines as <life> in the *Logic*. In short, history is "life" because it is a process that is moved by a constitutive purpose, which is a necessary precondition for the objective realization of the Concept. History realizes purposes *naively* that will later become the content of explicit conceptual representation.

The main role for <life> in the *VPG* shows up whenever Hegel appeals to the subjective dispositions of individuals and groups of people as they carry out actions that implicitly realize their freedom. Hegel writes:

> Thus would the question arise: what is the material in which the rational end goal [*Endzweck*] is carried out? It is first of all the subject itself again, the needs of the human being, subjectivity in general. In human knowing and willing, the rational comes to its existence as in its material. . . . But the subjective will also has a substantial life, an actuality in which it moves in its essence and has what is essential as the purpose of his existence. What is essential is itself the union of the subjective and rational will: it is the ethical whole – the *state*, which is the actuality in which the individual has his freedom. (*VPG* 55/93, modified)

Hegel uses "life" here to describe the purposive activity of individuals in the state, which *amounts* to a rational will and which constitutes "what is essential" in the state. This passage is particularly useful because it suggests that, unlike an artifact like a statue, in which its "matter" is indifferent to the product, the "matter" of the state is *itself* the subjectivity of human beings who make up the state, including their knowledge and will. A similar idea comes through in the *GPR*: "And since the state is not a mechanism[22] but the rational life [*das vernünftige Leben*] of self-conscious freedom, the system of the ethical world, it follows that an essential moment in the actual state is the *disposition* of the citizens" (*GPR*

[20] It is more usual to see history as an example of teleology or "inner purposiveness" in general. See, recently, Sedgwick 2017; Yang and Yeomans 2023. However, many of the similarities between history and teleology are equally, and sometimes more so, found in life. It should be noted that Yang and Yeomans are also insistent that Hegelian "teleology" is not a specifically natural category.

[21] So numerous, in fact, that there are too many results to display for "*leben**" in the web resource I used to search the *VPG*, the "Past Masters" website: www.nlx.com/home.

[22] Such a reference seems to be further confirmation that we are working within the same conceptual terrain of the *Logic*.

§ 270 R, 422/248). Hegel here says that the state *is* a "rational life,"[23] not that it depends on the living functionality of biological organisms.[24] That would seem immaterial for his point.

The use of "life" found in Hegel's description of history is parallel in numerous ways to the one that we find in his *Logic*. There, Hegel describes a movement from a living individual (*Individuum*) through the "life process" to produce the "genus" (*Gattung*). We find the same outline in history. Hegel emphasizes the importance of the life of "individuals" in his account of history:

> The subjective will, passion, is the activating [principle]; the Idea is the inner; the state is the present, actual ethical life [*sittliche Leben*]. For it is the unity of the universal, essential willing and the subjective [willing], and that is ethicality. The individual [*Individuum*] which lives in this unity has an ethical life, has a value, which consists solely in this substantiality. (*VPG* 56/94, modified)

Readers of Hegel's *Logic* know that it is in the Life chapter that he speaks of the living *individual*, distinguishing it from the merely *singular* (see *WL* II 475/680). The individual seems to be a stronger center of unity than the singular, which could be a fleeting entity. But the individual is only a starting moment in history. The progressive development of freedom in history occurs through the "propagation" of purposes in increasingly collective forms of realization.[25] Hence, the activity of individuals in their historical lives increasingly tends to produce something *universal* or a "*Gattung*," a realization of a purpose that outlives the death of individuals. While one might suppose there is a totally different use of "*Leben*" (and "*Individuum*" with it) in the *VPG* if that term were used on its own, it is the connection with "*Gattung*" that makes the connection to the Life chapter especially plausible. Hegel writes: "[The spirit of a people] dies not a merely natural death, for it is not merely a singular individual, but rather a spiritual, universal life . . . the spirit of the people [*Volksgeist*] exists as a *Gattung*, hence the negative of itself within itself comes to existence in its

[23] See also *VPG* 93 for references to *Staatsleben* and *Zusammenleben* and *rechtlichen Leben*.

[24] See also *EPG* §§ 537–49, where there is a clear connection between the state as "universal work [*Werk*]" and rooted in the "life of the universal substance" of the people.

[25] It would be a nice piece of textual evidence for my view if Hegel used the explicit term "*Fortpflanzung*" ("propagation"; cf. *WL* II 486/688) in the *VPG* to describe the move toward the *Gattung*. Unfortunately, he does not do so there. Still, the way that a purpose spreads from an individual to a collective must be part of his account. See his remarks elsewhere: "Political history considers the acts of willing [reason]; it teaches us how this reason is revealed in the arising, propagation [*Fortpflanzen*], and demise of states" (Hegel 1993: 144).

universality" (*VPG* 100–1).[26] This move from the individual to the *Gattung* is, again, familiar from the *Logic*. But one thing that comes through in this passage is that "*Gattung*" is by no means reserved to describe species or genus concepts in the ordinary sense, not even the "life-form of the subject" (Ng 2020: 259). That is, Hegel is not here describing how the human species is coming to be. In the above passage, he is describing how universal structures – something like their institutions and customs – in a given "people" come about. The use of "*Gattung*" to describe non-biological higher universals is not at all idiosyncratic to this moment in the philosophy of history. In the *GPR*, Hegel speaks of *freedom* itself as a *Gattung*. In the same work, Hegel says that the political state is "the universal Idea as a genus and as an absolute power in relation to individual states" (*GPR* § 259, 405/234). In the *Aesthetics*, he refers back to the state as the "genus of the ethical, legal, and intelligent" (*VÄ* I 90–1/62). Indeed, throughout Hegel's *Concept Logic* and elsewhere, "*Gattung*" is used very frequently and in a wide sense.[27] A *Gattung* for Hegel, it seems to me, is any "concrete universal," of varying levels of generality.[28] What is important here is that, though the movement from individuality to the *Gattung* parallels the movement of <life> in the *Logic*, there is no need to think of this movement in biological terms.[29]

In this sense, history or culture in general establish *numerous* concrete universals or *Gattungen*, not simply that of the human species or life-form: these might include systems of laws, customs, principles of organization, and genres of music. The historical domain thus seems to provide a prime example of what Hegel describes as a "genus process" in the *Logic*. However, what is especially noteworthy about the role of the *Gattung* in the philosophy of history is how it *contrasts* with the philosophy of nature. In the philosophy of nature, Hegel argues that the individual animal attains its *Gattung* only by *dying*.[30] That is, contrary to a popular recent reading according to which Hegel is generally a "realist" about natural kinds,

[26] Several passages of the *VPG* are not translated in the English version I have consulted. These translations are my own.

[27] See Englert (2016: 92) on this point.

[28] "The universality that has thereby arisen is *the genus*, or the universality which is *concrete* in its universality" (*WL* II 333–4/574).

[29] I agree with Englert (2016: 80), when he argues, contra McTaggart, that "there is no indication that Hegel in fact does let his category of thought be taken hostage by a notion of a class-universal derived from the word *genus* as typically associated with classes of animals."

[30] See also the discussion of the role of animal sickness as "inappropriateness to universality" in Khurana 2017: 362–3, 366.

species kinds do not play any determinative role in the lives of animals, according to Hegel:

> But in the animal, the genus [*Gattung*] does not exist as such, but only in principle [*an sich*]; it is only in spirit that it is in and for itself in its eternity. The transition to the existent genus takes place in principle [*an sich*], in the Idea, in the concept, that is to say in the eternal creation; but there the sphere of nature is closed. (*EPN* § 370Z, 520/414)

Hegel insists that thinking – an ability animals do not have, according to him – is necessary for the full existence of a *Gattung* in the *EPG*: "the genus genuinely actualizes itself, on the other hand, in spirit, *in thinking*, in this element which is homogeneous with the genus" (*EPG* §396Z, 76/54, my emphasis). Importantly, this is a break in the correspondence between the logical concept of life and the natural one.[31] For the logical concept of life is one in which the *Gattung* is produced through the activity of "living" individuals.[32] And this is what happens in history, and *not* in nature, or rather only in nature's transition to spirit.[33]

Clearly, then, Hegel's use of "life" in the *VPG* need not be thought of as evincing any kind of naturalistic mentality, but rather as articulating the distinctive way in which history brings about a purpose. A useful precedent here comes from Friedrich Schiller in his *Letters on the Aesthetic Education of Mankind*.[34] He writes in his Third Letter, "When the mechanic has the works of a clock to repair, he lets the wheels run down; but the living clockwork of the State [*das lebendige Uhrwerk des Staats*] must be repaired while it is in motion, and here it is a case of changing the wheels as they revolve" (Schiller 1794, Letter 3/1954, 29–30). Here, Schiller gives an artifactual metaphor ("clockwork") for the state, but points out the important disanalogy to such finite material artifacts. Precisely because it is "living" – in that its product is inseparable from its producing – the state's existence cannot be settled without its own participation in that activity. If we could *only* appeal to the possibility of a teleology rooted

[31] Ng (2020: 273) reads the genus as more akin to a biological species: "The genus determines the specific shape of corporeality and provides the criterion for what constitutes successful reproduction for the individual as it confronts a conformable externality."

[32] See the comparable movement of individual activity to the "universal product" (*ein allgemeines Produkt*) and thus a "substantial life" (*substentiellen Leben*) in *EPG* §§ 515–16. See here Rand 2017.

[33] It seems important, relatedly, that Hegel always signals the transition to *Geist* as a kind of death of the merely living. *EPN* § 376; *EPG* § 432. This confirms in a striking way that life and *Geist* cannot be smoothly continuous, and that if there is a "life of spirit," it cannot be identical to natural life.

[34] See Hegel's appreciative remarks on this work, including its political relevance, in his *Aesthetics*, *VÄ* I 90–1. In an early essay, Schelling also suggestively mentions the "living work of the human spirit [*lebendige Werk des menschlichen Geistes*]." I owe this reference to Sandkaulen 2019: 915.

in the ordinary artifactual model of external purposiveness, we would encounter a serious problem here, for individuals are involved more intimately with the "product" in this instance than in the case of artifacts like clocks. Thus, to account for the different way that individuals cannot be separated from the existence of the state and its purposes, we must appeal to the model of life. If this is analogous to structures in organic life, as found in the plant and animal realm,[35] this can only be because they too exemplify a more similar "logical" structure in the development of a purpose, not because <life> is primarily a natural category.

Indeed, contrary to a biological reading of <life>, what is especially suggestive for my own account is Hegel's use, in the *VPG*, of the artifactual language of the "work" (*Werk*), which we have explored at length in Chapter 2, in combination with his use of the language of life. In a passage that is very congenial to my purpose, Hegel is discussing the culminating stage in the formation of a people, in which its own thoughts and actions become the object of its thought. He writes that "at this point, *Geist* knows its principles, the universal of its actions. But this work of thinking is, as universal, at the same time different in form from the actual work and from the effectual life [*wirksamen Leben*], through which this work [*Werk*] has come about [*zustande kommen*]" (*VPG* 101–2/146). The phrase is crucial: it is *life that brings about a work*, or (in my terms) an artifact; the culminating stage of history is when this work is recognized as a work, even though it is brought about without engineering.[36]

The same language recurs elsewhere. He writes:

> *Geist* essentially *acts*; it makes itself into what it implicitly is, to its deed, to its work [*Werk*]; . . . Thus is the *Geist* of a people: it is the determinate *Geist* which it constructs into a present world. . . . Now, in this its work, its world, the *Geist* of the people enjoys and liberates itself. (*VPG* 99)

[35] Khurana (2017: §§ 69–73) notes the extensive parallels between the self-production or self-determination of human beings in the *EPG* and that of animals in the *EPN*. But he seems to take this to be evidence that the self-determination of human beings is modeled on that of natural animals. If the logical concept of life is a more general one, however, there seems to be no reason to see things this way.

[36] I take this to be key to Hegel's point in the *GPR* that the state's constitution must be regarded *not* as something "made" (*GPR* § 273R, 349/262). Part of the motivation for this statement seems to be political: even if the state *is* something made, if we take the constitution to be our product, we won't feel that we can be subjected to it. In addition, "made" (*Gemachtes*) is in the past tense: to think of the state as finished suggests that it exists independently of what is present (as something being or remaining: *Seiende* in the context). But part of his point is also that the constitution stems from a living history that cannot be ignored (cf. *GPR* § 274Z). Thanks to Markus Gante for raising this passage as a challenge.

And:

> It [a spirit of a people: *Volksgeist*] is only world-historical insofar as in its basic element, in its basic aim there is a *universal* principle; only to that extent is the work [*Werk*] which such a *Geist* brings forth an ethical, political organization [*Organisation*]. (*VPG* 101/145)

Clearly, Hegel does not think that history realizes freedom through a kind of plan or design. That would make its purposiveness external to those living through it, who played no part in the design. But neither does he deny that it has an artifactual structure. For the products of history – and the state in particular – can be finally recognized as something *being made* by fellow-minded actors. The concepts of those products are thus akin to makers' concepts, even if the realization of their products comes about at first blindly. I will call a product that is generated through a purposive process that eventually makes reference to its own universal or concept a *living artifact*. We will examine this concept in the next section.

The example of history has proved to be a useful one for our purposes. It shows how a Hegelian concept of life could be used without any biological reference; only a topic-neutral concept of life could span both the biological and non-biological contexts. However, Hegel's treatment of history also helps show us why the *Logic* itself may have need of a concept like <life> to explain how "truth" or the Idea comes about. For <life> is a concept necessary to describe how a purpose can carry itself out without explicit "guidance" from the universal. History offers a strong example of precisely this. Notice that I have not claimed that the concept <life> in the *Logic* is implicitly historical, or that the treatment of life *needs* the account of history. Quite to the contrary, I have tried to show how the treatment of history (a case in the domain of *Geist*) might make use of the *Logic*'s concept <life>, which is itself determined without reference to concrete history.

6.4 Life's Work: Spirit as Living Artifact

The Life chapter is a stumbling block for almost any interpretation of the *Logic*. Thus far, I have tried to mitigate the offense of that chapter by showing how it expresses a more general logical structure, which can be essentially reduced to that of a process relating some singular to its universal purpose. Articulating this structure is essential for Hegel's aim to explain the unity of Concept and object, and thus does <life> have its credentials as "logical" in his sense. However, though <life> is considered to be a moment of the Idea, and thus of truth, Hegel also says that life "has

shown itself not to be as yet the true presentation or the true mode of [the Idea's] existence" (*WL* II 494/694). This is important. The Idea is meant to express the full unity of the Concept and its objectivity, but Hegel suggests that <life> on its own does not express this unity. It thus does not exhibit truth, or the object of philosophical knowledge, in its paradigmatic sense. Apparently, we are back to the drawing board. In this section, I want to renew my commitment to the artifactual paradigm by showing how the Idea develops into a living artifact.

To see what is missing with <life>, we need to read the whole Idea chapter not as a linear progression but as a kind of analysis or bisection into the extremes found in the notion of <purpose>, which is the concept that transitions to the Idea. Hegel writes: "The Idea is thus at first the one extreme of a syllogism as the Concept, which as purpose has at first subjective reality for itself; the other extreme is the limit [*Schranke*] of the subjective, the objective world" (*WL* II 497/696). One "extreme" of the Idea is the more subjective side. We will see that this is <cognition>. The other extreme is the more objective side. That, of course, is <life>. The full concept <Idea> is supposed to be something like the combined product of these extremes. So it is not as if <life> is the fully formed Idea and <cognition> is a kind of development within <life>. Rather, the separation of <life> and <cognition> is the Idea as analyzed into its two sides or extremes. This is why Hegel speaks of the Idea as undergoing a "judgment," which always refers to the act of breaking up a unity.[37] Here is how he puts it: "The elevation of the concept beyond life consists in this, that its reality is the conceptual form liberated into its universality. Through this judgment the idea is doubled – into the subjective concept, whose reality is the concept itself, and into the objective [concept], which is as life" (*WL* II 487/689, modified).While life is the "objective" side of the Concept, or the purpose of the Concept "sunk in objectivity," cognition is the Concept "distinguished from its external reality and posited *for itself*" (WL II 487/689). Under cognition, Hegel considers the logical content as present in analytic and synthetic methods, definitions, theorems, and more, abstracted from any consideration of what kind of subject could perform these operations.[38] He shows that, though these various cognitive types rely

[37] Here I differ from Ng (2020: 7.3), who appears to take Hegel to be making the *act* of (or capacity for) judgment thematic. By contrast, I think the division of the Idea into its two poles *is* the judgment at issue.

[38] Hegel explicitly says this: "In the logical idea of spirit, therefore, the 'I' is from the start in the way it has emerged from the concept of nature as the truth of nature, the free concept which in its judgment is itself the subject matter confronting it" (*WL* II 496/696). I take this to mean that Hegel

on the form of conceptuality, they do not, initially, determine a concept and object in their identity. As Hegel says in "The Idea of Cognition": "What the idea *seeks* is the *truth*, this identity of the concept itself and reality; but at first it only *seeks* it; for it is here as it is *at first*, still something *subjective*" (497/696). Cognition on its own expresses a failure of the unity of Concept and objectivity from the subjective pole of their relation. Cognition is at first one extreme of the Idea, the one opposed to life.

In terms of logical form, <cognition> represents the pole of *universality*, as it were reaching downwards to objectivity, while <life> represents the pole of *singularity*, beginning as it does with the living individual, reaching upwards to thought or subjectivity (cf. *WL* II 493/694). To understand these terms in their separation, we should think of them as two extremes of a purposive process, since the form of purpose is what leads to the Idea (see the quotation from *WL* II 497/696 above). The purposive process is determined according to its universal moment (present in cognition) but is carried out as singular (as "living"). The two poles would find their concrete unity in a form of cognition that *is* a form of life, and a form of life that *is* a form of cognition. The unity of life and cognition would be a purposive process that is itself guided by thought or the explicit Concept. But this, we shall see, is simply the concept of *Geist*. The treatment of *Geist* in the Cognition chapter shows how the unity of Concept and objectivity can be fully realized.

It is not often emphasized that Hegel provides the logical foundation of the concept of *Geist* in the *Logic*.[39] There is no heading that corresponds to "*Geist*" in the Logic, but it is nevertheless the theme of the introduction to "The Idea Cognition," which says that *Geist* is the "truth of" life (*WL* II 494/694). In terms of its place in the *Encyclopedia*, *Geist* is also the topic of the later *EPG*. But it equally needs a logical treatment because it has a special logical structure: it is constituted by its own self-reference. In the Cognition chapter, Hegel says that self-consciousness – here used as a proxy concept for *Geist* – is "the absolute self-reference that . . . makes itself into an intended object and consists in making itself thereby into a circle" (*WL* II 490/691),[40] and that "*Thinking, spirit, self-consciousness* are

is treating cognition as a kind of logically purified object, pretending that its full abstraction from nature is complete.

[39] Hegel is explicit that there is a purely logical concept of *Geist*, which abstracts from its more concrete determination in the "concrete sciences of spirit"; *WL* II 494/694; 496/695.

[40] Determinations like <*Geist*>, Hegel says, are "determinations of the Idea insofar as it has itself for its object and its *existence*, i.e., the determinacy of its being, is its own distinction from itself" (*WL* II 487/689, modified).

determinations of the idea insofar as it has itself for its object" (*WL* II 487/689). Hence, the logical structure of *Geist* will be one that in some way contains a reference to itself within it.

Now, one could think that the self-referential objects of the Cognition chapter and thus of *Geist* are going to be the concepts of the *Logic* itself. That is, perhaps the *Logic*'s treatment of the pure thought determinations can be seen as something like thought's own self-revelation. Indeed, this *is* a dimension of what Hegel calls the "absolute Idea," for Logic is a moment or "mode" of the absolute Idea (*WL* II 550/736). However, Hegel does not tend to speak of logical knowledge as knowledge of objects or of a *world*. Arguably, merely logical knowledge – knowledge of the "realm of shadows" (*WL* I 55/37) – can only find a circular justification. It does not need a demonstration of its possibility, since any such demonstration will rest on its own proper form. Though Hegel does affirm our pure knowledge of the contents of thought, this is not something that needs justification outside of itself.[41] Instead, the project remaining for the Cognition chapter is to demonstrate the Idea in a concrete shape, suitable to unify <life> and <cognition>. For this purpose, Hegel shows that there is a special logical shape the *world* can take according to which it counts as the realization of the Idea and is thus "true." An essential piece of this account is the inclusion of practical cognition, under "The Idea of the Good" (or simply "The Will" in the *EL*). This inclusion brings the account of truth in the *Logic* near to its completion.

I have claimed throughout this book that Hegel advocates for an artifactual paradigm of truth or the Idea. This model gets its first articulation in the *Logic* in the treatment of teleology, wherein we see the basic form of conceptual constitution. But for conceptual constitution to be implemented, there must be a kind of process that can be governed by its own end. This turns out to be "life." But life, even if it is not restricted to the biological domain, is not in itself artifactual because it is blind. It is not governed by explicit (universal) concepts or thoughtful intentions, which are definitive of anything artifactual. Hence, to make the living artifactual, there must be a new addition of the explicitly intentional or conceptual. And this is what occurs in "The Idea of the Good." The practical dimension of the Idea makes possible a living process that is governed by its own concept. It thus shows how something objective, something worldly, can

[41] Here I differ from McNulty (2023), who understands as a key aim of Hegel's Logic the attempt to justify the laws of logic non-circularly.

be what its concept says it is.[42] The notion of *Geist* delivers a unique logical structure precisely because it is the concept of a living objectivity that is dependent on its conceptuality.

For the explanation of such a concept, an explicitly practical dimension, already implicit in the process of life, is necessary. Hegel says quite specifically that the Idea of the Good is about the "*practical* Idea" or indeed "action" (*Handeln*). Whereas the theoretically cognizing subject brings conceptual universality to bear upon some singularity, attempting to find the "true" in this manner, the acting subject (who is at first singular) has a "drive" (*Trieb*) to actualize some universal purpose, hence "the good" (*das Gute*). There is, as far as I can tell, no necessary *moral* connotation here: the good is just some purpose or other, something that is to be done.[43] Specifically, the realization of a good, or the "activity of the purpose," requires a change in the world outside the subject by "sublating the determinations of the external world, to give itself reality in the form of external actuality" (*WL* II 542–3/730). The acting subject thus bears within herself a "certainty of [one]self" that is also "a certainty of [one's] actuality and the *unactuality* of the world . . . [T]he previous objective world is . . . only still something posited" (542/729). Throughout the section, Hegel alludes constantly to the "world" that is "presupposed" by the acting subject (cf. also 544/731), though this is precisely the world that the subject takes as null. That is, the acting subject does not take the world to have a *given* reality; she takes it that the world can be as she purposes it to be.[44]

As "The Idea of the Good" continues, however, we meet a familiar Hegelian critique of a purely practical standpoint. Practical cognition, in

[42] As Hegel writes in lectures: "Willing is the producing [*Hervorbringen*] of the identity of the subjective and objective Idea" (GW 23,1: 149).

[43] Relatedly, Hegel's discussion of what he calls the "judgment of the concept," which includes judgments of the form "This house is *good*" or "This action is good," does not have a moral connotation. See *WL* II 349–51/585–7.

[44] It is precisely this conviction that Hegel also ascribes (tongue in cheek, to be sure) to *animals*, which he suggestively takes as evidence of their *idealism*: "Animal appetite is the idealism of objectivity, so that the latter is no longer something alien to the animal" (*EPN* § 359Z, 472/388). See also *EPN* § 337Z, 338/274; *GPR* § 44Z. Hegel makes a similar remark about how the ability of the "free will" to make any "thing" into property refutes skepticism about the so-called "thing in itself" (*GPR* § 44R). Again, I think the statement is partly tongue in cheek, but with an important point: our use of things as property, etc., shows that our cognitive relation to the world is not one primarily given in mind-independent terms. Similarly, animals are "idealists" insofar as they look at the world as something that can be *reconstituted*: e.g., raw vegetation is not left as it is but transformed into food. I differ here from Ng (2020: 262), who places more weight on "life as absolute idealism" because of her view that life is a presupposition for cognition, not unlike the role of intuition in Kant. See Pinkard (2012: 18–19) for a different take on these passages.

its Kantian-Fichtean mode (according to Hegel), considers the good to be complete in its very idea. As Kant writes in the *Groundwork*, "A good will is not good because of what it effects or accomplishes . . . but only because of its volition, that is, it is good in itself" (Ak. 4: 394). Because of this, the external existence of the good is merely incidental to the good itself, and any concrete realization of it will be inadequate to the good per se. The realization of the good is at best an "accidental, fragile existence," subject to contingencies and various evils (*WL* II 543–4/730–1). Moreover, since the good is always a *particularization* of some content, it is always finite, dividing up into various "goods," which may conflict among themselves. Hence, purely practical cognition (in this mode) underwrites a dualism of "two worlds," an opposition of practical thought and objective reality. The aim to realize the good becomes internalized, a matter of *mere* intent, divorced from its goal to make actuality fit for its purposes. Hegel specifically refers us to his *Phenomenology* for this dialectic (cf. 544/731), and his challenge to this picture mirrors the development I highlighted with respect to Kant and Fichte earlier (see Section 2.1).

Yet, parallel to his concept of absolute knowing in the *Phenomenology*, Hegel's crucial advance at this stage is to see that practical knowledge must in turn give rise to a quasi-theoretical knowledge of a different kind. Namely, practical knowledge that is expressed in action makes available a new object for theoretical knowledge, for there is conceptual knowledge *of* that which practical knowledge has achieved.[45] Practical knowledge changes the world, and this can be theoretically or speculatively known. As he says, "The idea of the good can therefore find its completion only in the idea of the true" (*WL* II 545/732). His more extensive explanation is worth quoting at some length:

> But what the practical idea still lacks is the moment of real consciousness itself, namely that the moment of actuality in the concept would have attained for itself the determination of *external being*. – This lack can also be regarded in this way, namely that the *practical* idea still lacks the moment of the *theoretical* idea. That is to say, in the latter there still stands on the side of the subject concept – the concept that is in process of being intuited in itself by the concept – only the determination of *universality*; cognition only

[45] Pippin (2019: 90) also remarks on the role that Fichtean practical reason can play in illustrating Hegel's view: "And most suggestively for the entire enterprise of the *Logic*, practical reason can determine the form of a rational will that is also itself a substantive content. . . . [T]he self-legislation of the moral law can serve as a fine example of what it is for a concept to give itself its own content, as it did for Fichte – practical reason determines the content of practical reason as itself, as the form of practical reason." Surprisingly, though Pippin takes this as "a fine example," he does not treat the example as illustrating the general notion of a concept giving itself reality.

> knows itself as apprehension, as the identity of the concept with itself which, for itself, is *indeterminate*; the filling, that is, the objectivity determined in and for itself, is for this identity a *given*; what *truly exits* is for it the actuality present there independently of any subjective positing. (545/731–2)

Hegel says here that practical cognition requires the consciousness that its actions have attained "actuality" or indeed "external being." By itself, this practical cognition is *only* consciousness of the universal; it must proceed to determine the singular. When it does, there results a new form of "immediacy" or indeed a *givenness* – a reality that is *there* because of the practical and can be known non-inferentially in the world.

Hegel explicitly identifies the process through which external reality is determined in accordance with practical cognition as the syllogism of so-called "external" purposiveness, the subject of our previous chapter (see *WL* II 543/730). As he develops the point, he writes:

> But [the idea of the good] makes this transition through itself. In the syllogism of action, one premise is the *immediate reference* of the *good purpose to the actuality* which it appropriates and which, in the second premise, it directs as external *means* against the external actuality. The good is for the subjective concept the objective; . . . [T]he realization of the good in the face of another actuality is the mediation which is essentially necessary for the immediate connection and consummation of the good. (545–56/732)

The structure here is just the same as the relation between the intention to build a house and the actual house, in that simplistic but useful example. The good to be realized is precisely the objective good that results. The intended house is the house that is built. There would not be a house without the practical aim to realize that particular good; but, being thus realized, the house becomes a new object of knowledge.

The difference at this stage in Hegel's account, however, is that the goods produced in and by practical cognition are goods that depend constitutively on conceptual knowledge. That is, they are not artifacts that are finished once and for all (like houses); they are artifacts that continue to be what they are thanks to the contribution of thoughtful action. They are *living* goods. Recall that this is a contribution of practical knowledge to the very reality of such things. It is not a practical knowledge that existed once in the past and is no longer extant. It is a practical knowledge that exists in and through the objects it produces. As a result, if action can carry out such goods, there must be a "world" (or a portion of the world) that is especially transparent to conceptual knowledge. That is,

some part of the world could be recognized conceptually as the very product of the Concept.

This is what Hegel seems to say at the very end of the chapter. His dense remarks become intelligible, I believe, when we see in the background the model of a world that is produced through concepts, or through practical-conceptual knowledge:

> The idea of the concept that is determined in and for itself is thereby posited, no longer just in the active subject but equally as an immediate actuality; and conversely, this actuality is posited as it is in cognition, as an objectivity that truly exists. The singularity of the subject with which the subject was burdened by its presupposition has vanished together with this presupposition. Thus the subject now exists as *free, universal self-identity* for which the objectivity of the concept is a *given* [*eine gegebene*], just as immediately *present* [*vorhandene*] to the subject as the subject immediately knows itself to be the concept determined in and for itself. (*WL* II 548/733–4)

Thus far, we have the picture of an objectivity that comes to be given as the result of the realization of conceptuality. As the passage continues, Hegel is willing to speak of what results as a *world*:

> Accordingly, in this result *cognition* is restored and united with the practical idea; the previously discovered reality is at the same time determined as the realized absolute purpose, no longer, as it is for a seeking kind of cognition, a merely objective world without the subjectivity of the concept, but rather as an objective world whose inner ground and actual subsistence is the concept. (548/733–4)

Now there is a sense in which Hegel *could* be thought to include the *whole* world in this description – if it makes sense to speak of such a whole. This is because what the acting subject here discovers is that there is no region that is a priori disconnected from the reach of the Concept, both in terms of its practical transformation and its own cognition.[46] But it seems clear to me that the description in this passage singles out the *special* status of that part of the world that *actually is* the result of such a nexus of practice and cognition. Elsewhere, Hegel speaks of this domain as that of "living spirit."[47] This is the domain in which the Concept is the "inner ground"

[46] Hegel puts this quite nicely in the *EL*. He writes there, "In this way the Idea is the *certainty* of the *implicit* identity of the objective world with it. – Reason comes to the world with the absolute faith in its ability to posit this identity and to elevate its certainty into *truth*, and with the drive to *posit* as nugatory the antithesis [between itself and the world] which is *in itself* nugatory for it" (*EL* § 224, 378/295, modified).

[47] "It is equally important, on the other hand, that philosophy should be quite clear about the fact that its content is nothing other than the basic import that is originally produced and produces itself in

of the world because it would not exist without conceptually explicit knowledge of itself. In earlier writings, Hegel called precisely this an "intelligible world" because it depends on conceptual knowledge that does not seem to rely (or not directly) on sensory capacities. He writes, "Our knowledge contains in part objects that we cognize through sensory perception, but in part objects that have their ground in the mind itself [*in dem Geist selbst ihren Grund haben*]. The former make up the *sensible*, the latter the *intelligible* world. Legal, ethical, and religious concepts belong to the latter" (W 4: 204).[48] Indeed, "legal, ethical, and religious" concepts are *Zweckbegriffe* that have become *Werkbegriffe* – they are not unrealized moralistic goals but concepts that have "given themselves reality" as real, living artifacts: their objects exist only in being referred to their concepts. They are concepts that have developed into the "present world [*vorhandenen Welt*]" (cf. *GPR* § 142).

Though I think Hegel is describing a part of the world that can be called artifactual, it is not a world of unmoving material objects but the living human world, something like the "*Lebenswelt*" of phenomenological tradition.[49] Closer to his own terms, I believe Hegel is offering a logical foundation for what he would later call objective spirit, or what is today called *social ontology*.[50] Though objective spirit as such does not come under discussion in the *Logic* itself, in my view, the way life and cognition come together in *Geist* precisely lays the logical foundation of objective spirit – demonstrates the conditions of its possibility – because this foundation can be given according to the pure determinations of Logic, rather than in terms of its genesis from prior forms of spirit. That is, objective spirit has *logically* peculiar features, which can be made intelligible independently from

the domain [*im Gebiete*] of living spirit [*lebendigen Geistes*], the content that is made into the *world*, the outer and inner world of consciousness; in other words, the content of philosophy is *actuality*" (*EL* § 6, 47/29).

[48] "Only when actuality is mature does the ideal first appear over against the real and does the *ideal grasp this same real world in its substance and builds it up for itself into the shape of an intellectual realm*" (*GPR* Preface, 28/16, modified, my emphasis).

[49] See, e.g., these remarks from the *Aesthetics*: "Already our physical livingness and more still the world of our spiritual purposes and interests demand that what first exists subjectively and inwardly is carried through to objectivity and only then in this complete existence finds satisfaction" (*VÄ* I 133/96). Cf. Sandkaulen 2019.

[50] For accounts emphasizing social ontology in Hegel's thought, see Thompson 2014, 2018; Testa and Ruggiu 2018: part 1; and Neuhouser 2022. For an older representative of this point of emphasis, see Lukács 1978. The connection of "The Idea of the Good" to objective spirit is also noticed by Ng (2020: 287). See also Pinkard 2003, who frames a similar point in terms of social practices and "norms of judging" (128). This is clearly in the same neighborhood. However, I eschew language of norms and normative statuses, which drives Pinkard's account, because it seems to me that norms follow from concepts rather than the other way around.

anything specifically social or historical. Objective spirit is the Idea because it is the world that is determined by the Concept through the will and thus through action;[51] it is that which exists as a constitutive purpose (logical <life>) that is self-referentially dependent on its concept, or on knowledge of itself. It thus exemplifies the unity of <life> and <cognition> that is necessary to complete the notion of the Idea.[52]

More recent philosophers of social ontology have also recognized precisely this conceptually peculiar status of the human social domain, often fully independent of Hegel's influence (and rather eager to decry it[53]). It may be useful to consider their views in relation to Hegel's. To take a prominent case, John Searle defines the domain of social ontology in terms of *beliefs*, but the connection to concepts is clear, for Searle recognizes certain *kinds* of things (universals) as dependent on beliefs:[54] "In a sense there are things that exist only because we believe them to exist. I am thinking of things like money, property, governments, and marriages" (1995: 1). According to Searle, relatively mind-independent objects, like pieces of paper, become objects of social ontology when a *status function* – something akin to a concept – is imposed upon them. Though we do not need to go into the details of Searle's account, it essentially involves both speech acts of institution ("Let this piece of paper count as money!") *and* acts of belief and recognition ("What you are handing me *is* money"). It is not difficult to extract from this account a marriage of the *practical* use of the concept <money> together with a quasi-theoretical one. We know that money exists, but our knowledge that it exists is in some way contingent on this very "knowing" itself, for the familiar reason that the value of money depends on some kind of belief in or recognition of its value. Money is no *thing* (*Ding*), but it is a *thing at issue* (*Sache*).[55] Recall Hegel's claim in the

[51] In describing objective spirit in the *EPG*, Hegel writes: "But the purposive activity of this will is to realize its concept, freedom, in the externally objective realm, making it a world determined by the will, so that in it the will is at home with itself, joined together with itself, the concept accordingly completed to the Idea" (*EPG* § 484, 303/217).

[52] The description so far does not adequately discriminate between objective spirit and absolute spirit. For the purposes of this chapter, I am more interested in what these two notions have in common than what separates them. For a discussion of their differences, see Section 7.4.3. The introduction of Objective Spirit in *EPG* says, "Objective spirit is the absolute idea, but only as it is *in itself*; since it is here on the soil of finitude, its actual rationality retains the side of external appearing in it" (*EPG* § 483, 303/217).

[53] See Searle 1995: 25; 2010: 9.

[54] "About particular tokens it is possible for people to be systematically mistaken. But where the type of thing is concerned, the belief that the type [e.g.] is a type of money is constitutive of its being money" (Searle 1995: 33).

[55] Money is Searle's example rather than Hegel's. See, however, Hegel's remarks on the status of money as an abstract representation or sign of value: *GPR* § 63Z, § 204, § 299. In particular, money is "the

Phenomenology that the *Sache selbst* is "an essence whose *Being* is the *doing* of the *single* individual and of all individuals, and whose doing is immediately *for others*, or is a *thing at issue* and is only an issue as the *doing of each* and *everyone*; the essence which is the essence of all essences, the *spiritual essence*" (*PhG* ¶ 418, 310/167). This is precisely the structure of the social-ontological object.[56]

Property is another useful example of such a "*Sache*," especially since it is the very first concept that Hegel discusses in the domain of Abstract Right in Objective Spirit. It is especially instructive because the things that become property, in the first instance, are undoubtedly things of nature, things that belong as such to the objective world as it is apart from us.[57] Yet, despite the full mind-independence of these things, they cannot become *property* due merely to any of their mind-independent characteristics. For Hegel, this is part of the difference between the physically definable notion of "possession" (*Besitz*) and the normative notion of "property" (*Eigentum*), the latter of which depends on social recognition (*EPG* §§ 488–90) and the purpose to give "existence" (*Dasein*) to the personality (cf. *GPR* § 45). The true judgment that *there is property* is not quite like the true judgment that *there are trees*. In contrast to the latter, the truth of the former judgment depends equally on the practical institution of the reality in question.

Yet, of course, in the objective social world there are "goods" realized through our actions in ways that involve imposing no status functions on given material things. As Amie Thomasson (2003: 277) writes, "Corporations, laws and governments all seem to depend on the physical world for their existence, and are created by real and intentional acts of writing, voting, etc. Yet none of these abstract social entities is identifiable with some particular physical object or brute fact." For Thomasson, entities that exist in this way, semi-independently from specific, given material substrates, *must* be epistemologically accessible to us because they would cease to exist if we, or someone like us, ceased determining their existence through beliefs, attitudes,

universal element in all resources, insofar as they can be produced in the externality of existence, in which they can be grasped as *things at issue* [*Sache*]" (*GPR* § 299R, 467/286).

[56] Compare Neuhouser 2022: 293: "An ontological implication of [Hegel's conception] is that self-conscious (or potentially self-conscious) meaning is intrinsic to social reality in a way it is not in nonspiritual life. In contrast to the behavior of fish, one cannot capture what humans do within social life without referring to the (more or less explicitly) conscious meanings it has for them." I would only add that Hegel's term for this "meaning" is the Concept; hence the account of this kind of social life depends on Hegel's logical concepts.

[57] In speaking of the "thing" (*Sache*) that becomes property, Hegel defines it first as something "external" and says: "What for free *Geist* . . . is the external is so in and for itself; for this reason, the conceptual determination of *nature* is that of being *external to itself*" (*GPR* § 42R, 103/58).

and practices. We cannot in such instances rely on certain material entities to hang around without us. Facts about social objects of these kinds are "conceptually transparent" (Thomasson's term) because they necessarily involve cognitive states that affirm their existence (Thomasson 2003: 283). In my view, it is a similar philosophical insight that motivates Hegel's appreciation of the logical status of *Geist*, and objective *Geist* in particular. For he recognizes that it is there that cognition can have constitutive status for the existence of the domain. As he writes in an introduction to his 1818 lectures: "The realm of Geist is *the realm of freedom* – everything which holds human life together, what has value and really counts, is *spiritual nature* [*geistiger Natur*]; and this realm of Geist exists only through the *consciousness* of truth and right, through the grasping of the Idea" (W 4: 404).[58] This description suggests precisely what is uniquely possible in the domain of the humanly constructed, our "*Lebenswelt*." It is not just that concepts help us represent this world; this world – or at least part of it – would not be possible without concepts, and thus not without the power of the Concept.[59] To be sure, the constitutive purposes that motivate the activities of natural life precede conceptuality: we have needs and desires before we have the concepts of these needs and desires as such. But conceptuality can transform our purposive activities into objects with a sui generis logical structure. Hegel's final move in "The Idea of Cognition" is to demonstrate precisely this.

I have not argued that Hegel presents a social ontology in the *Science of Logic*. His account is not intended for this purpose, nor is it sufficient for it.[60] What I have argued is that the combination of <life> and <cognition> in the Idea provides a logical foundation for the special status of something like social ontology, not because it presents a *social* structure per se but because it describes a living process that is fully determined by its concept, and thus by a form of practical cognition that yields a new object for

[58] "What the spirit produces as rational out of itself, that *is* – something objective, and this objective is only rational for it insofar as it thinks it" (W 4: 406).

[59] Neuhouser's (2022) account of Hegel's social ontology, though naturalistically inclined, places its emphasis on the way that social reality is something like "objectified mind," in that they have a mind-dependent existence, though not one that is dependent on subjective impressions or occurrent thoughts (see also Neuhouser [2022: 310] on the significance of "thinghood"). There is much for me to agree with in Neuhouser's account, though I am more focused on the logical basis of social ontology than he is.

[60] This is because there can clearly *be* social phenomena that are not concept-dependent, which a more general account of social ontology would have to include. It is also true that Hegel thinks that previous stages of history are not conceptually self-determined, though of course there were objects of social ontology. He is assuming, in particular, that (historically speaking) the modern world signals a moment in which the Concept comes to have constitutive reality. See on this Pinkard (1994: 266) and McDowell (2017: 31–2).

"speculative" truth. It is because Hegel's interest is in determining the case in which Concept and object best agree that something like the skeleton of social ontology emerges at the end of his *Logic*.

6.5 Conclusion

My interest in this chapter has been in the Hegelian explanation of philosophical truth in its paradigmatic instance. The paradigmatic instance of truth is a case in which an object is what it is through its own concept, which is something that can only be instantiated in the objects of *Geist*. What I find compelling about the indirect connection to social ontology (or objective spirit) in the *Logic* is the way it illustrates the peculiar nature of certain philosophical concepts that form the heart of Hegel's inversion of philosophy. For if a certain part of the world is the living result of constitutive concepts, it follows that certain concepts have themselves a special status in our objective knowledge. It has been common in the history of philosophy to single out "formal" concepts – those that pertain especially to mathematics and logic, for example – as especially good cases of the pure or a priori domain of philosophical inquiry. But on my reading of Hegel's <Idea>, he demarcates a different group of concepts that we should find to be, in their own way, even more exemplary as philosophical concepts, since they have a role in determining their own reality. They are not formal concepts. Nor are they empirical concepts, since none of their peculiar content is determined by their sensory content. They are not even "normative" concepts, if that means a concept of something that *should* exist but need not. They are concepts of the world that is made through concepts. And these are concrete as <money>, <property>, <family>, <punishment>, or even <music>, to name just a few. Hegel thinks that we cannot understand the reality these concepts represent if we do not see that such a reality depends finally on concepts.[61] For this reason, these

[61] Since I am only sketching the mere possibility of such concepts, I will not attempt to offer criteria for adjudicating genuine from non-genuine concepts. Consider the phenomenon that Ian Hacking (1996) describes as "looping kinds": e.g., it is undoubtedly true that the universal <witch> could instantiate itself by members of a social practice who believe themselves to be witches. (A vivid portrayal of this is found in Rungano Nyoni's marvelous 2017 film *I Am Not a Witch*.) If we are members of this practice, could we thereby say that we *know* that there are witches because we have *made* it the case that there are? It would be nice if this was not an implication of Hegel's view. The Hegelian response would presumably require showing that <witch> *cannot* be a concept, or more precisely an Idea, because it is impossible to integrate the universal <witch> with the concomitant system of concepts that are required for free human life and thought to exist at all. That is, we cannot really instantiate <witch> without a kind of failure to realize what we are doing. Thus, <witch> cannot be a product of "the" Concept.

concepts require a foundation that stands outside the special philosophical domains and occurs within the *Logic* itself. This account shows, then, how the *Logic* itself could provide the basis for a kind of objective idealism: an idealism that has an object outside the subject, even if it is the kind of object that would not exist without the subject. That is, Hegel's *Logic* shows us what it would mean for there to be a world that is through the Concept itself.

CHAPTER 7

Hegel's Inverted Idealism
The Artifactual Paradigm in Hegel's Realphilosophie

7.1 Introduction

In this final chapter, my aim is to show how the preceding sets up Hegel's approach to philosophy in general, understood as objective conceptual knowledge. I want to begin by laying out the general shape of a Hegelian metaphysics that falls out of what has come before. Then, I wish to show that this interpretation makes the best sense of the shape of Hegel's so-called *Realphilosophie*, his philosophy of the "concrete" domains of *Geist* and nature. As a matter of textual observation, the *Realphilosophie* that results in Hegel's system is an *inverted* one – we find that *Geist* has a clear priority over nature. I explain this priority in terms of the Hegelian conceptuality theory laid out so far. In particular, *Geist* gains priority over nature because the objects of *Geist* are realizations of the Concept, whereas the things of nature are not. This inversion amounts to a humanistic approach to philosophy.

Hegelians tend to be suspicious of anything that looks remotely "one-sided" (*einseitig*). Accordingly, a Hegelian may well be leery of my claim that Hegel is going to invert *anything* without, somehow, doing the opposite as well. However, avoiding one-sidedness does not require universal parity.[1] The textual evidence supporting the philosophical priority of *Geist* to nature is ample and not at all subtle. The same goes for what Hegel says about the respective roles of the Concept in the domains *Geist* and nature. If there is one-sidedness in this picture, I suggest that it is Hegel's, not mine. This inversion belongs to the textual data any reading of Hegel should contend with. Better still, it is an inversion that any reading should try to *explain*. So, while I will certainly show in what follows how I think it

[1] Hegel confronts the "ordinary consciousness" according to which spirit and nature are simply on a level at *VÄ* I 128/92.

is perfectly right that Hegel maintains a philosophy of nature, I see no need to qualify the claim that nature is philosophically subordinate to *Geist*. I also think this claim is so interestingly out of step with contemporary philosophy that it is worth placing at the center of an interpretation. As I mentioned in Chapter 1, interest in Hegel's philosophy of *Geist*, including especially his social philosophy, has been strong in recent years. But what is lacking on many standard accounts of his metaphysics is an explanation of why this dimension of philosophy should take the priority it does.

It is common to think that whatever Hegel's idealism amounts to, it should be a view about the world or reality *as a whole*. For example, a monist reader of Hegel might say that his idealism claims an identity-in-difference of thought and being, or that the structure of mind and the structure of the world are the same. This is evidently a claim about *everything*. Even an interpreter like Robert Pippin, who has at least been taken to offer a more deflationary approach to Hegel, can seem to suggest that Hegel's idealism is a view about what there is, period. He writes: "For Hegel, by contrast . . . the conceptual forms required for the unity of judgment are, at the same time, the forms necessary for *any* object determinacy. The forms of thought are the forms of being" (2019: 276), and that "the structure of reality is conceptual, *is* its intelligibility" (16). Pippin arrives at such a claim, to be sure, on a basis of Kantian considerations about what is necessary for something to be the object of a *judgment*. But for this very reason, the idealist thesis he articulates seems to be completely general and unrestricted: it is about anything whatsoever.

Let us say that both a metaphysical monist and Pippin's judgment-centered view of Hegel's idealism have a *uniform explanation* of Hegelian idealism. For a traditional monist, something belongs to the thought–being nexus just in virtue of existing at all, regardless of what it is; for a judgment-centric interpreter, something belongs to the thought–being nexus just in virtue of being a suitable object of judgment, regardless of what it is otherwise. Hegel's idealism, on such views, covers everything *automatically*, as it were.[2]

The view that I have been defending denies any uniform explanation of Hegelian idealism because it denies the uniformity of the relation of Concept and object. On my reading, there are not only differences of *degree* in the relation between Concept and object; there are *categorical*

[2] See again Pippin (2019: 91): "So, contra Kant on what we might call thought's absolute discursivity, Hegel thinks that thought is always already giving itself its own content." This "always already" is surely *not* the kind of *process* that depends on the unity of teleological constitution and practical cognition, as I argued in the previous chapter. See Pippin 2019: 96–7, 254, 300.

differences. For even if everything (for trivial reasons) "falls under" the Concept in some way, not every object has a constitutive concept as its basis. Instead, I have argued that *only* in the special case of the objects of *Geist*, which I interpret on an artifactual model, is there a constitutive relation of Concept and object. It follows that Hegel's distinction between *Geist* and nature is essential to articulating his idealism.[3] Hegel's idealism cannot be a uniform relation between mind and world, thought and being, because the nature/*Geist* distinction is a direct consequence of his theory of concepts in the *Logic*. While no reader of Hegel would deny that there is a nature/*Geist* distinction, in my view, monism in particular, and uniformist readings more generally, struggle to explain why the distinction is fundamental.[4] For if *everything* is the realization of the Concept, whether it is nature or *Geist*, it seems to follow that nothing special about something's being an object of *Geist* would be needed to explain its special status in the Idea.[5]

Hence, in this chapter I will show how my account, which begins from a starting point in which the Hegelian Concept exists solely in thinking (in a sense of "thinking" that requires no suggestion of the non-human), can nevertheless explain the apparently metaphysical distinction between nature and *Geist*, and thereby the differing prospects for a philosophy of nature and a philosophy of *Geist*. Both nature and *Geist* are expressions of the Idea, but this does not prevent us from making a firm and clear

[3] Robert Brandom (2019: 469) occasionally articulates a suggestive way of describing the distinction between *Geist* and nature: "'Geist' is Hegel's collective term for everything that has a *history* rather than a *nature* – or, put otherwise, everything whose nature is essentially historical" (see also Brandom 2001: 74–6). It looks as if Brandom recognizes a similarly categorical distinction between the two, as do I. However, it does not seem that this distinction plays a general and fundamental role in Brandom's articulation of Hegel's semantics. For example, it is not clear that, for Brandom's Hegel, concepts of social artifacts would have a different semantics than concepts of natural kinds, and thus a greater intelligibility. Indeed, it seems that Brandom wants to make *all concepts* equally exemplify the normative social-perspectival structure of recognition he articulates. Examples like the meaning of "copper" and "hand" abound. Brandom in fact wants to insist that Hegel's idealism is not one of the *reference dependence* of things on our practices but only their *sense dependence*. But the account I have been pushing suggests that the realm of *Geist is* a domain of the *reference dependence on sense* or the Concept. This should surely have fundamental consequences for the intelligibility of this realm.

[4] For example, Brady Bowman (2013) takes Hegel to have independent interest in establishing the "thesis" that mind and world have the same structure, which is independent from his interest in the domain of *Geist*. He writes that "From his arrival in Jena in 1801 until the completion of the *Science of Logic* in 1816, Hegel's main philosophical efforts were directed towards the demonstration of this thesis; it was only in the years after 1817 that he increasingly returned to the themes that had occupied him prior to his arrival in Jena: religion, history, politics, and aesthetics" (2013: 6). The implication here seems to be that his interest in these other topics could only be incidental to his metaphysics.

[5] See Padui (2013) for the idea that monists have a special problem for explaining the privileged status of *Geist*.

distinction between them. I argue that it is the *constitutive* role of the Concept in the domain of *Geist* that distinguishes it from nature, where the Concept is not thus constitutive. I then consider three branches of Hegelian *Realphilosophie* – the philosophy of right, nature, and art – to demonstrate the differential (non-uniform) role of the Concept in each of them. I hope to show that this differential role offers evidence that Hegel's idealism is a lopsided one, since the only instances in which his metaphysical idealism holds "objectively" or "absolutely" are just where we should expect: the human world.

I hope that this chapter helps to clarify the trajectory of my argument in this book. My claim from the outset has been that we should think of the aim of the *Concept Logic* as *forward* looking – *toward* the concrete work of *Realphilosophie*. That is, Hegel's interest in "truth" in the *Logic* is not about the truth *of* the *Logic*; he is providing a foundation to the philosophical project outside the *Logic*. Hence, I have not been arguing that we should suppose that the truth of the concepts *within* the *Logic* has an artifactual explanation (i.e., that they are true because we make them). I have been arguing that the *Logic*'s argument in the *Concept Logic* is meant to justify the paradigmatic status of the humanly made in the remainder of philosophy. This is why, though I fall short of offering a fully systematic reading of the *Realphilosophie* in this chapter, I take the presentation to be important for confirming the interpretation I have offered up to now. This differs from other readings of the *Logic*, which often carefully avoid references to the later moments of the system. In my view, the later use of the concepts of the *Logic* in the *Realphilosophie* is indispensable material for testing any reading of the *Logic* itself. I here hold myself to that test.

7.2 The Idea

We have already considered Hegel's concept of the Idea at some length, in that we have tried to capture its genesis "from below," namely from the teleological form in which the object and Concept are jointly realized. However, it is worth looking at the concept in a more general way as well, since it is perhaps the central term in Hegelian *Realphilosophie*. Much like "the Concept," Hegel's use of "the Idea" is marked by the centrality of its singular usage. He does also speak of various Idea*s* (the Idea of the Good, the Idea of Beauty, etc.), just as he speaks of various concepts, but he clearly wants to emphasize the singularity of the Idea: "The Idea itself is not to be taken as an Idea *of something or other* [*irgend etwas*] . . . The Absolute is the universal [Idea] and *one* Idea, which particularizes itself in the act of *judging*

into the *system* of determine Ideas, but these are [Ideas] only in that they trace their truth to the one Idea" (*EL* § 213, 368/287, modified).

There are two noteworthy, apparently incongruent, features of Hegel's talk of the one Idea that should be addressed. First, Hegel has a tendency to speak of the Idea in a way that makes it suitable to describe *everything* as Idea: the Idea has a comprehensiveness or totality. But, second, the Idea is something that seems to exist in varying *degrees*: not everything is Idea in the same way. These claims seem to be in tension, since one might think that if Idea were a kind of synonym for "all reality," then to belong to reality would be to belong to the Idea *simpliciter*.

I think these two tendencies can be unified by the following definition of the Idea, which I will go on to defend:

<Idea> = that which is, insofar as it conforms to the Concept

On this definition, the source of the Idea's all-comprehensiveness is the *same* as the source of the Concept's all-comprehensiveness. As we have already seen, the Concept's comprehensiveness comes from its inclusion of the form of universality, which applies to everything merely in virtue of that form. That is, it requires no *theory* to say that the world is such that universality holds of it: that follows from the very emptiness of mere universality. Thus, the sense in which "everything" is conceptual (as Hegel says at one point: "the Concept is *all* [*alles*]" [*WL* II 551/737]) turns out to be somewhat trivial as well,[6] because it is rooted in the bare universality of conceptual form. I earlier called this the *Fichtean* moment in Hegel's account. For the universality of the Hegelian Concept has a similar function as the Fichtean I, as capturing everything in its all-encompassing net. This power comes from the Concept's subjectivity alone. For this reason, as Hegel often says, the subjectivity of the Concept "overreaches" objectivity (see *EL* § 20 R; § 215; *WL* II 535/281). It is because the Concept is not constrained to think only of what adequately conforms to it that it can *also* include what *does* thus conform to it. The Concept's objectivity is, as it were, a special case of the Concept's subjectivity.

If this is true, then it follows already from the definition above that everything is in some way Idea. For if the Concept holds of everything, then whatever is will in some way conform to the Concept: for everything will conform to mere universality. This is another way of saying that

[6] By contrast, Kreis (2015: 21, 25) lays tremendous emphasis on this statement, suggesting that Hegel's claim could be paraphrased as "every object is the Concept" (and arguing explicitly that Hegel's claims are compatible with a quantificational theory that would use an unrestricted domain). Against Kreis's interpretation, see Schick 2017.

nothing is intrinsically alien to conceptual form, though this fact depends only on a capacious conception of conceptual form.

The second dimension of the Idea, however, is the more interesting one: that the Idea is not a uniform relation but admits of varying degrees. In my view, the best way to approach this dimension is to pay attention to Hegel's claims about the Idea as a *process*. Hegel writes of the Idea, "It is the process of the Concept, as the universality which is singularity, determines itself into objectivity and in an antithesis [*Gegensatz*] against it, and this externality which the concept has for its substance is brought back through its immanent dialect into *subjectivity*" (*EL* § 215, 372/290; cf. *WL* II 467/674; *EL* § 215). The Idea is a process because the mere "conformity" of the universality and singularity is not the strongest possible relation. The Concept can, as is said here, "determine itself into objectivity" so that something external might have the Concept for its "substance." Hegel says the Idea is "the Concept that *has* carried *itself* out in its objectivity, or the object that is *inner purposiveness*, essential subjectivity" (§ 214 R, 371–2/289). This suggests that realized conceptually articulate purposes are the exemplary instances of the Idea.

If the Idea is a process that depends on the realization of the Concept, it follows that it is complete to varying degrees. Hegel himself directly concludes from this "process" character of the Idea that there cannot be any kind of uniform Concept–world relation: "Because the Idea is (a) is *process*, the expression of the Absolute as 'the *unity* of finite and the infinite, of thinking and being, etc.' is false (as we have often said); for unity expresses an abstract *restfully* persisting unity" (*EL* § 215 R, 372/290, slightly modified). This passage is difficult to explain on a uniformist reading of Hegle's idealism: a uniform idealism does not seem to require a process to make it true. Thus, though there is a sense in which everything is "implicitly" the Idea, because everything conforms in some way to logical form, in the richer meaning of the Idea, there is no "restful" unity of thinking and being. This is a unity that has come about to varying degrees, depending on the extent to which the Concept has been realized in the world.[7] It is a famous (even notorious) feature of Hegel's view that he does not think every era, or period of history, can be credited as having realized rational purposes to the same degree. For that reason, "the Idea" cannot be a synonym for "reality" or "what there is." For reality (or "what there is")

[7] Hegel uses the gradable predicate "ideal" (*das Ideal*) of singular realities that conform to the Concept. He writes in lectures of 1826, "The Idea belongs to thinking, but the Ideal exists" (GW 28,2: 576).

attains the measure in which it is Idea in part by practical and historical processes.

In a way, the radicality of Hegel's concept of the Idea is that it serves as a kind of *successor concept* to <reality> (when the latter is taken in a very loose and general sense). By a successor concept, I do not mean that <Idea> is Hegel's concept *for* reality, as we have just denied. In that case, a statement like "Reality is the Idea" would express something like a theory, in which "reality" expresses a common subject matter for various competing metaphysical theories to correctly describe. Instead, <Idea> is a concept that is supposed to put a concept like <reality> out of its central use. The effect of Hegel's development of the concept <Idea> is to *replace* the question *what is real* with the question *what is true*. The question that Hegel wants to ask is *how* what we think (including what we think of as "real") conforms to the Concept. This new question, rightly understood, puts out of use questions about *whether* reality could be such as to fit with our concepts. For we could not coherently ask whether the Idea is such as to fit with our concepts. This is because <Idea> is Hegel's concept for *that which is, insofar as it conforms to conceptuality*. This concept of the Idea makes it fruitless to look for a *theory* of the reference or objectivity of conceptuality.

Our definition of the Idea thus includes both dimensions mentioned above. It affirms at once that the Idea is everything, insofar as nothing is alien to the Concept; but it also affirms that what is most rational in the world is not simply "always already" there. It is something that must come about precisely through the practical structures described earlier, especially in Chapter 6. And for that reason, the Idea is not a uniform relation of mind (or of conceptual content) to world.

This conception of the Idea as a *graduated* relation of objective conceptual intelligibility permits us to understand the claim that the Idea is the content of *philosophy*.[8] If the Idea were simply everything without distinction, then everything without distinction would be rational and the "truth." It would follow that philosophy could have everything as its object. But when Hegel alludes to the Idea as the content of philosophy,

[8] Sometimes Hegel says that the *absolute* Idea is the content of philosophy. See *WL* II 549/735. I take it that when Hegel speaks of the absolute Idea, he is dealing *solely* with the conceptual content of the concepts of philosophy, including those of Logic, nature, and *Geist*. It is because philosophy concerns concepts and only concepts that it can present something like the absolute truth about the content of those concepts. It is the absolute idea that is perfectly transparent (cf. *WL* II 550/736). But the Idea without the qualification "absolute" tends to concern the actual realities that present or exemplify concepts.

he specifically uses the notion to make a *distinction* between what are proper and improper objects of philosophy. The following passage from the *GPR* makes this especially clear:

> Philosophy has to do with ideas, and therefore not with what are commonly dubbed 'mere concepts.' On the contrary, it exposes such concepts as one-sided and without truth, while showing at the same time that it is the *concept* alone (not the mere abstract category of the understanding which we often here called by that name) which has actuality, and further that it gives itself actuality to itself. All else, apart from this actuality established through the working of the concept itself, is ephemeral existence, external contingency, opinion, unsubstantial appearance, untruth, illusion, and so forth. (*GPR* § 1 R, 29/17)

Here we can see that, to whatever extent philosophy is a thinking of everything, it is not an undifferentiated thinking of everything. For Hegel distinguishes the Idea from "all else, apart from this actuality established through the working of the concept itself."[9] Philosophy thinks of what is *insofar* as it is conceptually intelligible. This means that subject matters ripe for philosophical investigation, or for the "labor of the Concept," will come in degrees or levels. We cannot appeal to a uniform relation of "thought" and "being" to explain Hegel's idealism.

7.3 The Asymmetry of Nature and *Geist*

In the previous section, I defended a definition of the Hegelian Idea, namely that which is, insofar as it conforms to the Concept. This definition makes the concrete content of the Idea dependent on the content of the Concept. Philosophy has the task of dialectically developing conceptual content in a necessary progression; this then makes it possible to distinguish that which does and does not thus conform to conceptuality, and to what extent. We shall see that the primary issue in this "conformity" is the role of universality. Does universality play a kind of necessary and constitutive role? Or is it merely descriptive and explicatory? In my view, these questions yield different answers in the respective domains of nature and *Geist*.

It is from a categorical difference in the mode of conformity with the universal that the distinction between nature and *Geist* can be defined.

[9] Notice also that in discussing the Absolute Idea, Hegel writes, "All the rest [*Alles Übrige*] is error, confusion, opinion, striving, arbitrariness, and transitoriness; the absolute is *being*, imperishable *life*, *self-knowing truth*, and is *all* truth" (*WL* II 549/735). It is clear that there must *be* an "all the rest" for this statement to make sense; hence, not everything is "absolute" Idea.

Both nature and *Geist* belong in some way to the Idea because neither domain is alien to universality. But our previous discussion has enabled us now to distinguish them. Hence:

> <*Geist*> = that which is, insofar as it is *constituted* by the universal[10]

and

> <nature> = that which is, insofar as it is *not* constituted by the universal

One might think that these definitions are obviously too simple to be right. But they are not problematically rigid definitions, thanks to their useful "insofar as," which creates a kind of sliding scale. Nor do they define nature and *Geist* as mutually exclusive domains. They even seem to require overlap between them. Indeed, it would be difficult to make sense of a universal that could constitute something as it is unless there were something *from which* it began, and so as not so constituted. So we need not worry that these definitions will lead to an untenable dualism.

I aim to vindicate these definitions more completely by a consideration of the *Realphilosophie*, but for now it is worth examining their starting textual basis, where I believe they get a surprising degree of purchase. Hegel introduces the concept <nature> in the *Encyclopedia* as follows: "Nature has resulted as the Idea in the form of *otherness* [*Anderssein*]. Since the *Idea* thus is as the negative of itself or *self-external*, nature is not external merely relatively to this Idea (and to its subjective existence, *Geist*), but rather *externality* constitutes the determination in which the Idea is as nature" (*EPN* § 247, 24/13–14). Hegel very frequently speaks of nature as "the Idea in the form of otherness," and this is not readily comprehensible, since he also says that nature is "one of the ways of the Idea manifesting itself" (§ 247Z, 25/15). On the one hand, since (as we saw) the Idea includes the subjectivity of all conceptual thought within it, it is not hard to understand how nature could be included within what is grasped by the Concept, and therewith the Idea. On the other hand, for Hegel, the way that nature is grasped conceptually must be uniquely "external." He writes, "*In itself*, in the Idea, nature is divine, but as it *is*, the being of nature does not correspond to its concept; it is rather the *unresolved contradiction*" (§ 248 R, 27–8/17). Hegel says, quite clearly, that the Concept does not *exist* in nature (except in the limiting case of

[10] For a similar definition, including its rivalry to the Spinozian concept of substance, see Kreines 2008. See also Hegel's direct reference at *GPR* § 66R.

the living human subject who can think).[11] The reason for this absence of the Concept in nature, I believe, is that the *universal* does not exist apart from thinking, and nature is not supposed to be a domain in which the universal constitutes its reality.

Instead, the universal's relation to the natural world is that of striving to know it as a given other and thus in the mode of *theoretical cognition* (*EPN* § 246). That is, the cognition of nature is an instance of the Concept striving to find its objectivity (cf. *WL* II 498–9/697–8). That is, though the Concept does not exist in nature in the sense of constituting it, there are non-empirical philosophical concepts that can be *exemplified* in nature. The philosophical interest in nature is not an investigation of the empirical per se but an investigation of which conceptual universals are necessary for its comprehension. Nature can be judged to be rational because the Idea contains its own internal conceptual standards for rationality, which some (though not all) of what is natural exemplifies.

This makes <nature> *conceptually dependent*[12] on something other than nature, namely the Concept itself, as well as what the Concept constitutes, namely *Geist*. As Hegel writes, "Now the metaphysics of nature, i.e., nature's essential and distinctive characteristic, is to be the idea in the form of otherness, and this implies that the being of nature is essentially ideality, or that, as only relative, nature is essentially related to a first" (*EPN* § 247Z, 25/15). I take Hegel to be saying *not* that the things of nature are relative to something else in their existence, but that <nature> can only be conceived relative to something else; that is, to some other concept. Similarly, if (outside a Hegelian register) we define nature as the mind-independent (insofar as it is mind-independent), we acquire this definition *essentially by reference to* "mind." The same goes for our definition in terms of the Concept. <*Geist*> can be defined by reference to itself; <nature> can only be defined in relation to another.

We have already seen in the previous chapter that *Geist* can also be defined in terms of the Concept, namely as that which is, insofar as it is constituted by the universal, even though this logical definition is not often appreciated. Hegel also frequently defines <*Geist*> by essential reference to its own knowledge: *Geist* is "essentially only that which it knows of itself" (*EPG* § 385Z, 33/21).[13] A clear statement of this comes in the second preface to the *Science of Logic*. He writes, "The most important point for the nature

[11] See Section 7.4.2.

[12] In Brandom's (2019) terms, <nature> is *sense dependent* on <the Concept> or <*Geist*>, though not *reference dependent*.

[13] See also *EPG* § 440Z; *GPR* § 274.

of spirit is the relation, not only of what it implicitly is *in itself* to what it *actually* is, but of what it *knows itself* to be to what it *actually* is; because spirit is essentially consciousness, this self-knowledge is a fundamental determination of its actuality" (*WL* I 27/17). But in many passages, the Concept specifically can be seen to belong to the very definition of *Geist*. *Geist* is the "pure Concept existing for itself, the I, the certainty of itself as infinite universality" (*EPG* § 439, 229/164). Hegel writes in the *Logic*, "It is essentially only *Geist* that can grasp the concept as concept, for the latter is not just the property of *Geist* but its pure self" (*WL* II 295/545). And in the *Encyclopedia*: "The existence of *Geist*, *knowledge* [Wissen], is the *absolute* form, i.e., the form that has content within itself, or [the form] existing *as concept*, the *concept* giving itself its reality" (*EPG* § 442Z, 235/169). *Geist* not only involves knowledge of itself: it is what it is because of its conceptual self-knowledge.

This self-referential constitution by the universal or Concept is true at each stage of *Geist*. Hegel says that subjective *Geist* emerges when "that which is its concept becomes for it and this becomes its being to it, [to be] at home, i.e., to be free" [*das, was sein Begriff ist, für ihn wird und ihm sein Sein dies ist, bei sich, d.i. frei zu sein*]" (*EPG* § 385, 32/20). The suggestion here is that subjective *Geist* only comes on the scene when the mind's own conception of itself becomes determinative of its existence. Hence, Hegel says of subjective *Geist*: "And it is indifferent what is determined as its concept and what as its reality" (§ 441, 232/167). It is precisely because not *everything* about who we are is conceptually determined that *Geist* must "appear" or "emerge" at a later stage of development from our natural characteristics. In particular, a precondition for *Geist*'s appearance is that the soul knows how to subordinate natural desire to itself (see *PhG* ¶190; 196). It is here that the possibility of a *universality* in thinking is present, and so the possibility of more than an immediate form of consciousness. When a consciousness gains the form of universality, it can direct itself even subjectively according to its aims, and so gain the possibility of conceptual constitution.

If subjective spirit is that which is as constituted by the Concept purely individually – that is, only in terms of a kind of internal self-relation – we have already seen that objective spirit is that which is in the world outside the individual mind, insofar as it is conceptually constituted. Absolute spirit could be defined in a similar way, perhaps as that which is fully transparent in its conceptual constitution, but since it raises special questions, I will wait to deal with this topic for our discussion of Hegel's *Aesthetics*.

In the next section, I aim to vindicate these definitions further by considering how the Concept shows up in the various branches of *Realphilosophie*. But I hope to have made clearer how the definitions imply a philosophical *asymmetry* in the domains of nature and spirit. It is not that there is no important conceptual work to be done in the domain of nature for Hegel. But in a way, the conceptual understanding of nature is measured against the conceptual understanding of *Geist*. *Geist* shows us what it means for something to be fully intelligible, on an artifactual model of conceptual constitution; the study of nature may necessarily involve certain conceptual determinations, but this necessity is not a constitutive one. Oddly, it is by apprehending a domain that *is* essentially mind-dependent that we can appreciate that nature is *not*; that it is not up to us what nature is in the way that it is up to us what *Geist* is. The "antirealism" of *Geist* leaves room for a realism of nature.[14]

7.4 The Idea and Concept in the *Realphilosophie*

So, all of philosophy investigates the Idea – it seeks to understand how *what is* corresponds to the Concept. And I have been treating the Concept all throughout as the form of thinking that is especially characteristic of philosophical thought. On this view, the Concept cannot be a term for a hidden structure or essence within things; it can only be an objective existent in the cases where thinking has been carried out in the world, and this is proper to the domain of *Geist*. In other words, the Concept is constitutive only in the humanly made world, where concepts carried out in action are necessary for "things at issue" to be what they are. In the domain of nature, by contrast, we should see the Concept playing something more like a theoretical or explicatory role, in the sense that the concepts investigated there make the objects of nature comprehensible, without being involved in their essence or construction. Since Hegel's idealism is more often taken to imply a claim about the world or reality as a whole, or the nature of "being" per se, such a strong distinction in the role of the Concept in the concrete domains might seem implausible. Hence, in this section, I will put this claim to the test. In what follows, I will compare the Concept's role in three *realphilosophische* domains: the

[14] The technical notion of "antirealism" (especially as introduced by Michael Dummett) is especially apt for describing Hegel's views about *Geist*, on my reading, though this term can be misleading. As Dummett (e.g., 1982) used the term, a theory of a domain is antirealist if it is not in principle knowledge (or verification) transcendent. This is precisely what I claim is unique in the domain of *Geist*.

philosophy of right, the philosophy of nature, and the philosophy of art or aesthetics.

This order of presentation is unusual, as it does not follow the way these domains appear in Hegel's system. My rationale for this order is merely dialectical. I would admit that the philosophy of right presents the "easy case" for my view, for it is in the case of objective spirit that the notion of a constitutive concept makes the clearest sense. Hence, I will consider it first and only briefly. The status of the Concept in nature, by contrast, will presumably become intelligible only against the background of this clear case; hence, it is treated second. Finally, though aesthetics belongs within absolute *Geist* and is thus presumably a more paradigmatic case of the Concept's realization for Hegel himself, it is something of a mixed case for my position. This is partly because of the way that the contrast with nature features so prominently in that domain. Accordingly, it is suitable for my argument to present the role of the Concept in the aesthetics only after nature has been introduced.

7.4.1 Case 1: The Philosophy of Right

Since we have already found the logical basis of objective spirit in the *Logic*, the discussion of the *Philosophy of Right* requires the least defense. Indeed, it is eminently clear that Hegel treats the domain of <right> as the realization of the Concept. The first line of the *GPR*'s introduction states, "The subject matter of the philosophical science of right is the *idea of right*, i.e. the concept together with the actuality of that concept" (*GPR* § 1, 29/17). In the remark to this paragraph, Hegel states that the Concept that is dealt with here is one that "gives itself actuality to itself" (§ 1 R, 29/17). The Concept, in ethical life, "having acquired reality precisely through this positing of its moments, is now present as Idea – as the concept which has developed its determinations to reality and at the same time is present in their identity as their essence in itself" (§ 141 R, 287/152). Thus, the *Philosophy of Right* is not an investigation of an essence or substance that exists independently of its concept, but whose very essence *is* its concept or universal.

The central universal that is at issue in the *GPR*, broadly speaking, is the titular concept <right>, the concept of the "existence of the free will" (*GPR* § 29). The question is how that universal concept of freedom can be particularized in such a way that it comes to have actuality or singularity.

In order to explain this, Hegel appeals to the same language of "translation" as in Teleology:[15]

> (*b*) In so far as the determinations of the will are its *own* or, in general, its particularizations reflected into itself, they are its *content*. This content, as content of the will, is, in accordance with the form described in (*a*), its *purpose*, either its inward or subjective purpose when the will merely represents its object, or else its purpose actualized and achieved by means of its activity of translating its subjective purpose into objectivity. (§ 9, 59/34)

The teleological process is one in which the universal or subjective purpose comes to be realized and thus constitutes its reality. Hegel suggests here that this kind of process is the one we should observe in the domain of <right>. In this case, the universal <right> comes to be realized in the concrete form of the state, which for Hegel is not a dead institutional structure but a living one in which the actual action and will of singular individuals makes it what it is.

Hegel's remarks in the *Logic* on this point are quite helpful. Using the state as a pertinent (and telling) example of the Idea, he writes,

> But if a subject matter, say the state, *did not at all conform* to its idea, that is to say, if it were not rather the idea of the state; if its reality, which is the self-conscious individuals, did not correspond at all to the concept, its soul and body would have come apart; the soul would have taken refuge in the secluded regions of thought, the body been dispersed into singular individualities. But because the concept of the state is essential to the nature of these individualities, it is present in them as so mighty an impulse that they are driven to translate it into reality . . . The worst state, one whose reality least conforms to the concept, in so far as it still has concrete existence, is yet idea; the individuals still obey the power of a concept. (*WL* II 465–6/672–3)

Hegel is claiming here that for a state to exist *at all* depends on its concept governing the individuals that make it up. If the individuals ceased being governed by the aim of producing the state, then it would not be a bad state, it would be no state. When we criticize something as a bad state, we can only do so under the assumption that it is a realization of a concept or universal.

In addition to speaking of the Concept being realized, Hegel also frequently uses the loaded term "substance"[16] in the *GPR* to describe the

[15] The same goes, as we have seen already, for the use of the concept <life>. In the *Lectures on Aesthetics*, Hegel writes: "The will actualizes this reason in the life of the state [*Staatsleben*]. In the truly rationally structured state, all laws and arrangements are nothing but the realization of freedom according to its essential determinations" (*VÄ* I 136/98).

[16] See also *GPR* Preface, 28/16; § 144A, 294/154; § 146, 294–5/155.

reality that is realized by the Concept. However, as we saw in Chapter 4, Hegel's new use of "substance" and related terms is determined precisely by the role he attributes to the forms of thought in a given instance. In particular, something is "substantial" for Hegel precisely when the universal plays a constitutive role in it, just as rationality is constitutive for the nature of human beings. Thus, the "substance" that comes about in the case of the state is precisely one that depends on the thinking subjectivity that brings it about. He writes, "The objective ethical order, which comes on the scene in place of good in the abstract, is substance made *concrete* by subjectivity as *infinite form*" (*GPR* § 144, 293/154). Indeed, it is pure "subjectivity" that makes up the existence of objective spirit or ethical life: "Subjectivity is itself the absolute form and existent actuality of the substantial order, and the distinction between subject, on the one hand, and substance, on the other, as object, end, and controlling power of the subject, is the same as, and has vanished directly along with, the distinction between them in form" (§ 152, 303/160). These references are important, as they suggest that Hegel is *inverting* a conception of substance. For Hegel, <substance> is no longer "nature," a reality that is not the product of the Concept but is rather *Geist*, a domain that decidedly *is* this product.

Accordingly, a major theme in Hegel's political philosophy is that the justification of <right> in terms of the Concept differs from a justification in terms of nature, such as appealing to natural rights or laws of nature. Hegel sees a clear difference between what people are "by nature" and what their "concept" is. He writes in the *EPG* that the proposition

> *all human beings are equal by nature* confuses the natural with the concept; it must be said that the *nature* of human beings is rather only *unequal*. But the *concept* of freedom . . . is abstract subjectivity as *person* . . . But that this equality obtains, that it is the *human being* . . . which is recognized and counts lawfully as person, this is so little by *nature* that it is rather only the product and result of the consciousness of the deepest principle of spirit and of the universality and formation [*Ausbildung*] of this consciousness. (*EPG* § 539, 332–3/237)[17]

This is important because, though in other contexts Hegel is willing to speak of the nature of something as its concept, he is clear here that this use of language should not be supposed to imply a blurry line between nature and Concept.

[17] Hegel also says that right is grounded on "free personality," a "*self-determination*, which is the contrary of *natural determination*" (*EPG* § 502R, 311/223).

Part of the point of an appeal to nature and natural laws in justifying the state is to ground the political constitution by means of something more than human. In contrast, one of the pedagogical tasks of Hegel's political philosophy is to persuade his readers out of this self-undermining position that thought might need to appeal to something outside itself to justify its freedom. He writes of the substance of the ethical (*das Sittliche*) that its power is "more firmly established" than that of nature:

> The substance [*Die Substanz*], in this its *actual self-consciousness*, knows itself and so is an object of knowledge. This ethical substance and its laws and powers are, on the one hand, an object over against the subject, and from the latter's point of view they *are* – 'are' in the highest sense of self-subsistence. This is an absolute authority and power infinitely more firmly established than the being of nature. (*GPR* § 146, 294–5/155, slightly modified)

It is clear that Hegel does not see an ambiguity in the distinction of nature and spirit in the *GPR*. Objective spirit, especially <right>, exists as the realization of a universal or concept, and therefore its "substance" exists *in* the self-consciousness and knowledge of the individuals that make it possible. For Hegel, this is precisely not a substance that exists "anyway" as the structure of the world, but a substance that comes about in and through thinking and acting on its basis.[18]

Hegel's aim in the *GPR* is partly to vindicate the role that philosophy has in understanding the political world. For this task, the role he gives to the Concept is essential. For if Hegel can claim that the very existence of the state depends on concepts being realized in practice, then it seems to follow that it takes conceptual knowledge in particular – that is, philosophy – to understand the essence of the state and modern ethical life.

7.4.2 *Case 2: The Philosophy of Nature*

The references to nature in the *GPR* already show that <nature> plays a subordinate role in Hegel's understanding of philosophy. Nature, as we saw, is the Idea in the form of otherness, which I interpret to mean: *what is*, insofar as the universal does *not* constitute it. Hegel is thus a "realist" about nature: he does not believe that its objects depend on minds or concepts for their existence. But whereas on the contemporary philosophical scene this

[18] Recall from Chapter 4 that, in my view, Hegel's critique of traditional substance metaphysics does not entail that the concept <substance> must be put out of use; rather, its conditions of use depend on the logical form of thought. Here, it is possible to see the state as a substance precisely because it is the realization of the universal.

should mean that nature is more important than the domain of culture and mind, for Hegel this means that it is a less paradigmatic object of philosophical investigation. He writes in lectures: "Nature is the poorest [*schlechteste*] Idea, [it] is the Idea in which the reality is unfitting [*unangemessenen*] to the concept" (GW 25,1: 183). Yet this does not discredit the task of a philosophy of nature. My question here is how the different status of the Concept in the domain of nature affects its philosophical significance for Hegel.[19]

It is first important to be clear that Hegel does indeed claim that the Concept does not have the same status in nature as in the domain of *Geist*, which is precisely what my account would predict. The theme is present Hegel's talk of the "impotence of nature" (*Ohnmacht der Natur*) and its "conceptless" (*begrifflos*) character. It is worth assembling a litany to secure this as an interpretive *datum*:

> This is the impotence of nature, that it cannot abide by and exhibit the rigor of the concept and loses itself in a blind manifoldness void of concept. We can *wonder* at nature, at the manifoldness of its genera and species, in the infinite diversity of its shapes, for wonder is *without concept* and its object is the irrational. It is allowed to nature, since nature is the self-externality [*Außersichsein*] of the concept, to indulge in this diversity. (*WL* II 282/536; cf. 525/717)

> Since nature is the idea in the form of otherness, the idea according to the concept of the idea is not present in nature as it is in and for itself, although nevertheless, nature is one of the ways in which the idea manifests itself, and must occur therein. (*EPN* § 247Z, 25/15, modified)

> On the one hand there is the *necessity* of [nature's] forms which is generated by the concept, and their rational determination in the organic totality; while on the other hand, there is their indifferent *contingency* and indeterminable irregularity. . . . This is the impotence of nature, that it preserves the determinations of the concept only *abstractly*, and leaves their detailed specification to external determination. (*EPN* § 250, 35/22–3)

> Here [sc. in "Physics"] the concept is concealed; it shows itself only as the connecting bond of necessity, while what is manifest is conceptless. (*EPN* § 273Z, 110/86)

> It would be unphilosophical to try to show that a form of the concept *exists universally* in nature in the determinacy in which it is as an abstraction. Nature is rather the idea in the element of mutual externality [*des*

[19] "The idea itself as nature, and nature as the reflection or *Widerschein* of the idea, is obviously what poses the difficulty for any commentator" (Pippin 2019: 321).

> *Außereinander*], so that like the understanding it, too, holds fast to the moments of the concept as *dispersed* [*zerstreut*] and presents them thus in reality. (*EPN* § 312 R, 203/163, modified)

And, finally, he writes candidly in a letter:

> For spirit [or: the mind], in conceptualizing nature, has to change *the very opposite of what is conceptual* into something conceptual, a feat of which thought is capable only when it has grown strong. (Letter to Niethammer, October 23, 1812/Hegel 1984, 278)

There seem to be two central dimensions to Hegel's talk about the impotence of nature. First is a methodological one. For Hegel, the impotence of nature means that the mode of purely conceptual thinking is not sufficient to comprehend or "deduce" the various forms of nature. I take this to be a point of contrast to the *Philosophy of Right*. Hegel wants to show there that there is a conceptual necessity that <right> be determined into specific forms like property, family, civil society, law, and so on. By contrast, the forms of nature seem to be related to each other often with contingency and irregularity. Accordingly, a *philosophy* of nature is going to find limits: "This impotence of nature *sets limits to philosophy*, and it is quite improper to expect the concept to comprehend – or as it said, construe or deduce – these contingent products of nature" (*EPN* § 250 R, 35/23, my emphasis). As far as I know, Hegel never suggests there are similar (in principle) limits in the philosophy of *Geist*. For that reason, he must be referring to something more than the need for empirical knowledge of nature to "fill in the details" – such knowledge is obviously required in the domain of *Geist* as well. The methodological progress of philosophy must find a greater resistance in nature than in *Geist*.

The second dimension of Hegel's talk of the impotence of nature is a more ontological one, and, in my view, it is the explanation of the methodological one. There is a good reason that the philosophical method works so well in the *GPR* – the necessity of conceptual forms that are generated out of the abstract notion of the freedom of the will are all bound to the *universal, conceptually articulate purpose*, which they jointly realize. The Concept "exists" in the domain of right because thought is necessary for the existence of right, and right does not exist without the Concept and thought. But, by contrast, "It would be unphilosophical to try to show that a form of the concept *exists universally* in nature in the determinacy in which it is as an abstraction" (*EPN* § 312 R, 203/163). Or, as he boldly writes in his letter, it is "the very opposite of what is conceptual." If I am correct that the Concept is the form of philosophical thinking, it is very possible

for nature to *exemplify* that form,[20] and thus for there to be a philosophy of nature; but for it to *be* conceptual, it would have to be an inner form of thinking or universality. Yet, in describing the theoretical approach to nature, Hegel writes, "Instead of leaving nature as she is, and taking her as she is in truth . . . we make her into something quite different. In thinking things, we transform them into something universal . . .. We give them the form of something subjective, of something produced by us and belonging to us" (*EPN* § 246Z, 16/7). Nature is not something "conceptual" (and especially not constitutively "universal") in any kind of literal sense; thinking nature conceptually thus requires a kind of cognitive transformation of its object.

Hegel is quite specific about the necessary contribution of thought to the study of nature. Yet, as mentioned, he is utterly "realist" in his consideration of natural things. He elsewhere makes this point by stressing the "authority" that nature and natural objects have for us as thinkers, in a different way than "ethical laws":

> The sun, the moon, the mountains, rivers, and the natural objects of all kinds by which we are surrounded, *are*. For consciousness they have the authority not only of mere being but also of possessing a particular nature which it accepts and to which it adjusts itself in dealing with them, using them, or in being otherwise concerned with them. (*GPR* § 146 R, 295/155)

Despite this realism about natural things, and even the authority they have for us who reflect on them, Hegel clearly believes that the scientific and philosophical use of universals in thinking about nature is *our* contribution: "In thinking things, we transform them into something universal." This point contrasts significantly with his view in the domain of *Geist*. There, universals abound because thinking conceptuality is necessary for things to be what they are. In nature, universals are, if not imposed, nonetheless not something we find but something we need to generate. And if nature lacks the universal, it lacks the conceptual in its full sense. I don't see much room for a more moderate statement of this point: Hegel is not a conceptual realist in the domain of nature.

Instead of positing unthought "concepts" in nature, Hegel's continual references to the relevance of the Concept in the philosophy of nature are a part of his effort to show that the scientific study of nature cannot take

[20] Speaking of natural things in the *GPR*, Hegel writes that "Natural things present [*darstellen*] rationality only in an entirely *external* and *singularized* [vereinzelte] manner, and that under the shape of accidentality" (*GPR* § 146R, 295/155, modified). That natural things "present" rationality (in an adequate form) is what I aim to capture in speaking of exemplification.

a purely empirical shape. The concepts necessary for the comprehension of nature may not be mirroring some real conceptual forms governing natural phenomena, but this does not mean they are theoretically dispensable. In particular, the universal comes to make a genuine contribution to the understanding of nature, even though it does not exist *in res*. He writes of physics:

> The fact is, however, that the principal charge to be brought against physics is that it contains much more thought than it admits and is aware of, and that it is better than it supposes itself to be; or if, perhaps, all thought in physics is to be counted a defect, then it is worse than it supposes itself to be. (*EPN* § 244Z, 11/3)

Hegel does not think it is a defect in physics or natural philosophy to require pure, non-empirical thinking. This comes out especially well in his criticisms of Francis Bacon in the *Lectures on the History of Philosophy*. The reference is not as obscure as it may seem. For it was Bacon, as the father of modern empiricism, who attempted to rid natural philosophy as much as possible of "notions" that merely anticipated sense experience but inevitably misrepresented it.[21] As he writes in the *Great Instauration*: "The primary notions of things which the mind readily and passively imbibes, stores up, and accumulates (and it is from them that all the rest flow) are false, confused, and over hastily abstracted from the facts. Nor are the secondary and subsequent notions less arbitrary and inconstant" (Bacon 1999 [1620]: 66). Depicting Bacon's view, Hegel writes: "Knowledge from experience, reasoning from it, stands in opposition to knowledge from the concept, from the speculative; and the opposition is apprehended in so acute a manner that the knowledge from the concept is ashamed of the knowledge from experience, while the latter is turned against the knowledge through the concept" (*VGP* III 78).

This is not altogether unfair to Bacon. Indeed, Bacon's criticism of the natural philosophy of his day was precisely that it was too conceptual – that it used its abstract notions to "anticipate" phenomena rather than rooting them in the direct observation of nature. The example of thinkers like Copernicus, Newton, and Kepler shows a reader of the history of science like Hegel that Bacon's criticism of theory that goes beyond direct observation of natural phenomena was entirely premature. For Hegel, this means that natural science rests on the Concept. He continues: "The

[21] In the *New Organon* (the main part of the same work), he writes bluntly: "There is no soundness in our notions whether logical or physical. . . . All are fantastical and ill defined" (Bacon 1999 [1620]: 91/ Book I, Aphorism 15).

empirical approach [*Empirie*] is not merely an observing, hearing, feeling, etc., a perception of the singular; for it essentially sets out to find the species, the universal, to discover laws. And since it produces such things, it coincides with the territory of the concept – it generates what belongs to the soil of the idea, of the concept" (*VGP* III 79).[22] Hegel thinks Bacon is wrong to restrict himself in the study of nature to empirical concepts of what is directly observable. Physical science uses a battery of non-empirical concepts that explicate its phenomena and are necessary for the understanding of them. However, Hegel does not seem to conclude from this that there are a corresponding set of theoretical *entities* answering to these non-empirical concepts. A "law of nature," for example, is a conceptual comprehension of a regularity in nature, but *not* (or at least not necessarily) a representation of something that is "in" things. Hegel says here that laws need to be *produced*; they belong to the "soil . . . of the concept."[23]

In short, Hegel is a realist about the things of nature, but he is an antirealist about the conceptual structure that needs to be generated to understand the things of nature.[24] "Antirealism" here is best understood not as the claim that laws and other conceptual structures are *unreal* but rather as a posture for which the question of the "reality" of laws and so on is a kind of category mistake. Since this conceptual structure is not a representation of some hidden entity, it is not clear how it could get things wrong in the same way as an ordinary representation could. It is thus

[22] See also: "In part, all these champions of experience after him [Bacon] who carried out what he longed for, and from observations, experiments, and experiences believed to get at the thing itself [*die Sache selbst*] purely, could do this neither without concepts nor syllogisms; they conceptualized and syllogized so poorly that they thought they had nothing to do with concepts but transcended inference for immanent, true cognition" (*VGP* III 83). Bacon sees syllogisms as only combinations of words, and principles derived from syllogisms as misleading except where they are constructed on the basis of true induction (see *New Organon*, Book I, aphorisms 13, 14, 17).

[23] A full defense of this claim would require a further discussion of Hegel's theory of natural laws. In some contexts, Hegel speaks of the laws of nature in an affirmative way. See *WL* I 45/30; *EPN* § 246; § 270R; § 270Z. But does Hegel accept what is sometimes called a *governing law* conception of laws? That is, does Hegel treat the laws themselves as having a causal or grounding role with respect to the regularities they describe, or is the reality of laws of nature strictly found in the regularities? Since I don't think universals exist for Hegel outside of thinking, I am bound to suggest the latter. I suspect that Hegel would have sympathy with a view like Cartwright's (1999), according to which laws do not apply in their pure generality but only under "ceteris paribus" clauses. See Bowman (2013: 135, 145–8) for a discussion of the possible similarity of Hegel's view to Cartwright's.

[24] For a complementary perspective, see Kabeshkin 2022b. Further textual evidence for Hegel's scientific antirealism comes from the Ground chapter in the *WL*. Speaking of examples like "molecules, empty interstices, centrifugal force, ether, the separate ray of light, electrical and magnetic *matter*," he says that "they are spoken of, and deliberately made use of, as actual things; in good faith one accepts them as such, before one realizes that they are determinations inferred from what they are supposed to ground, hypotheses and fictions derived by an uncritical reflection" (*WL* II 101–2/401). See also *EL* § 126Z.

not clear what it could mean to *want* them to be 'real.' Concern about the reality of something is (in the Hegelian picture) a concern about its *singularity*. The domain of the universal is the domain of thought. And while nature as such exists independently of the mind, the rationality of nature needs the universality of thought for its comprehension. Here again, <nature> is something relative to <*Geist*>. Hegel suggests that this is the truth beyond the religious symbolism of nature being "created": "We therefore have to conceive of nature itself as bearing within itself the absolute Idea, but it is the idea in *the* form through which absolute spirit is posited to be as the other of spirit. In that way, we call it something created [*ein Geschaffenes*]" (*VÄ* I 128/92).

However, what I have said so far may seem to be in conflict with what Hegel says about *life*, and in particular *animal life*, in nature. For he says in introducing the Organic domain, "The Idea has herewith come to existence, though at first to its immediate [form], to *life*" (*EPN* § 337, 337/273). Such statements are quite ambiguous, especially as they use the somewhat technical term "*Existenz*," which is not identical to "*Dasein*."[25] The ambiguity here is this: one could take the Idea to exist "in" life itself by being present in it (whatever that might mean), or one could take life to *be* an existence of the Idea in that it *exemplifies* the Idea. I take the latter course, as I think the former is simply inconsistent with Hegel's many statements about the status of the Concept in nature (and the Idea cannot exist in nature unless the Concept can). The structure of the Concept is such that *purposive concepts* are the most paradigmatic instance of the unity of conceptual form. Hence, if there is a purposive structure in nature, especially in living things, then living things will be the best exemplification of the Concept in nature. This would be the case even if the Concept is not a kind of immanent structure in nature, as conceptual realists believe. For example, though the statement above might seem to suggest otherwise, Hegel also says: "The *immediacy* of the Idea of Life is the fact that the Concept does not as such *ex-ist* in *life*; its existence is thus subjected to the manifold conditions and circumstances of external nature and can appear in the most meager forms" (*EPN* § 368 R, 501/416). Hegel's remarks look to be contradictory, but they are not if we allow that life is the best exemplification of the Concept without being the existence of the Concept *in res*.

The clearest way to see this, once again, is to note the different statuses of universality, particularity, and singularity in the animate organism. One reason that the living organism is more exemplary of the "conceptual" than

[25] See Chapter 4, note 23, on "ex-istence."

the other items of nature is precisely that it maintains its own singularity or individuality in a way that other objects of nature do not. This makes the organism a stable subject of predication; indeed, it makes them "subjects" in a stronger sense as well, being something like agents.[26] By contrast, there are no such subjects in the chemical domain, for example. In a *Zusatz* at the transition to Organic Physics, we read:

> Precisely in the chemical process, the relativity of indifferently appearing determinations of individuality as the essence in this alteration of accidents comes to light; the body shows the fleetingness of its existence, and this its relativity is its being [*sein Sein*]. If the body should be described as what it *is*, then the description could only be completed if the whole circle of alterations in it were indicated. (*EPN* § 336Z, 334–5/270)

It is of course significant here that "body" is the German *Körper* rather than *Leib*. Bodies as mere *Körper* "are" not (in a use of "is" that much invokes Plato). Chemical processes are the kind that make the individuation of bodies as subjects impossible. This helps us see, then, that the "subjectivity" or "Concept" that is found to be in the organic realm is at first simply a genuine form of *singularity* (or a "self-referential *negative* unity": *EPN* § 337), which is only *fleetingly* present in that which is only chemically determined.

Since singularity is of course a moment of conceptual form, it is not surprising that Hegel sees the Concept as exemplified in the organic realm. Animals are singular entities that *particularize* themselves purposively; this makes them act in a way that approximates full conceptual self-determination. But it must be taken as only an approximation because to *be* conceptual requires the universality of the Concept, which does not exist in animal purposiveness. This, as we saw, is why the "genus" does not exist in nature (see Section 6.3). Hegel writes, "Through its process with external nature, the animal gives its certainty of itself, its subjective concept, its truth, objectivity, as a *singular* individual. This *production* of itself is thus self-preservation or *reproduction*" (*EPN* § 366, 497/409).[27] But the animal itself is not a universal:

[26] The sun (e.g.) is an "individual" but not a "subject" (*EPN* § 337Z, 339/274).

[27] "In this relationship [namely, instinct], the animal comports itself *as an immediate singular*, and because it can only overcome single determinations of the outer world in all their variety . . . its self-realization is *not adequate to its concept* and the animal perpetually returns from its satisfaction to a state of need" (*EPN* § 362, 475/390–1). Along these lines, Corti (2023) argues that <organization> rather than <species> is the central concept for Hegel's view of animals.

> In this process of the genus, the merely living only perishes, for it does not as such transcend its naturalness. But the moments of the process of the genus, since they have at their basis the still not subjective universal, which is still not *one* subject, fall apart from each other and exist as several particular processes which culminate, in one way or another, in the *death* of the living. (§ 367, 498/410)

So animal life is something like an approximation of the purposive processes that occur in the domain of *Geist*. However, in the domain of *Geist*, purposive activities produce existing universals because universals exist in the form of thought. We can make our purposes into the forms of explicit intentions and guide our activities to meet them. It seems true to say that we can do this *at all* because we are also animals. Hence, the form of animal life, since it is purposive, is peculiarly appropriate to the realization of our own purposes.[28] But this does not require us to think that there is a kind of real conceptual structure to nature. Our conceptuality may *find* things to be intelligible without requiring that hidden "concepts" are making them intelligible.

There is, for Hegel, a philosophical discipline that takes nature as its object. This discipline concerns itself with the non-empirical concepts that are necessary for the comprehension of nature. Nature thus *exemplifies* the Concept but is not constituted by the Concept and so is the Idea in the form of otherness. Hence, Hegel is not a "conceptual realist" about nature. He does not posit concepts as real structures that make things what they are.[29] In my view, it is important to be unwavering on this point, for only if concepts (and indeed the Concept) exist in thought can we avoid a view in which "concepts" become something like theoretical posits: something we have to assume "behind" what is given in thought or experience. Concepts are ours *directly* because they belong to philosophical thinking. Hence,

[28] On this point, I find much to agree with in Khurana's (2017: 294 ff.) account. See especially: "The concept of life thus takes on a double function: on the one hand, it designates the natural other of spirit; on the other hand, life already prefigures this structure of spirit, since one can already understand life as consisting in its distinguishing itself from inorganic nature and arising out of it. Life carries out unconsciously what spirit does for itself. It is first in life that spirit can comprehend nature in such a way that it can become clear to it [spirit] how it arises out of it [life] and at the same time distinguishes itself from it" (298, my translation).

[29] This implies that, when it comes to the occasional passages (which are, not insignificantly, often found in *Zusätze*, and so not in Hegel's undersigned work) in which Hegel says something like "the Concept is what is truly first [in things]" (*EL* § 163Z_2, 313/241), I take the scope to be implicitly restricted (i.e., "there are some things for which the Concept is first"). Even apart from confusion about how to understand a universal quantification over "things" in Hegel, a universally quantified reading simply won't be consistent with Hegel's many denials about the role of the Concept in nature.

only their efficacy in making nature intelligible, not their existence "in" nature, is at issue in Hegel's philosophy of nature.

7.4.3 Case 3: The Lectures on Aesthetics

One sign of the "inversion of philosophy" that Hegel aims to effect, as I noted in Chapter 1, is his treatment of nature in the *Aesthetics*. Hegel famously defends the view that the beauty of art is "higher" than the beauty of nature: "On the contrary, spirit [or mind] is alone the *true* comprehending of everything in itself, so that everything beautiful is truly beautiful only as sharing in this higher sphere and generated by it. In this sense the beauty of nature appears only as a reflection of the beauty that belongs to spirit" (*VÄ* I 14–15/2). This claim is not, of course, meant to signal Hegel's aesthetic preferences but something important about the respective domains of nature and spirit. It is common to think that nature is more original, more substantial, more fundamental, whereas the constructed domains of mind or *Geist* are merely tacked on. Hegel's *Aesthetics* aims to dismantle this conception. He writes in *EPN*,

> it is the same misunderstanding when the spiritual in general is less respected than natural things, when *human works of art* are thus diminished in comparison to natural things because the material for the former must be taken from outside and because they are not living. As if the spiritual form did not contain a higher livingness and *Geist* were not more valuable than natural form, natural form as such not higher than matter, and [as if] in all the ethical what one can call the 'matter' did not entirely belong to *Geist*, and as if what is higher in nature, the living, did not also take its matter from outside. (*EPN* § 248, 28–9/17–18, modified)

Hegel's hierarchy comes through clearly here. Works of art are higher than natural things, even though they require the "matter" of natural things, because they give "form" to these natural things; spiritual (*geistige*) form in general is higher than natural form; and the "matter" of the *ethical* domain is something hardly material at all. There is no reason for untouched nature to stand as the highest stage, because even nature itself, in the form of the living, does not leave matter alone. Hegel sees the transformation of nature into artifacts as the culmination of nature itself.[30]

There is perhaps no simpler way to defend the view that Hegel accepts an *artifactual* philosophical paradigm than to recall that he gives such

[30] It is worth pointing out that Hegel (drawing from J. F. Blumenbach) recognizes even in the animal domain a "drive to art" (*Kunsttrieb*) (*EPN* § 365Z, 494–7).

singular significance to *art*. However, I have been trying to show that the varying significance of the philosophical disciplines Hegel considers depends on the status of the Concept in the respective domain. The same should be true here. On the one hand, then, we should expect there to be some commonality between the *Aesthetics* and the *Philosophy of Right*, for, since both are disciplines concerning *Geist*, they must be marked out by their concern with the Concept in its realization; both should thus share something of the artifactual form. On the other hand, the *Philosophy of Right* belongs to the domain of "objective *Geist*," whereas the *Aesthetics* belongs to "absolute *Geist*." So we should expect some important difference as well. Can we account for the distinction between these two domains in terms of the respective way in which the Concept is realized in them?

To be sure, we should not expect the domain of art to be one of pure conceptuality. Hegel says that art is absolute *Geist* in the mode of *intuition*, religion is absolute *Geist* in the mode of *representation*, and philosophy is absolute *Geist* in the mode of *conceptuality* (*EPG* § 572). Philosophy is thought thinking itself. So it is clear that philosophy will be something like purely transparent conceptual thought *of* what is conceptually thinkable. Art itself, by contrast, must distinguish itself from pure philosophy by involving sensuous intuition rather than concepts alone.

One might think that the sensuous form of art makes it inappropriate to say that art involves the realization of concepts.[31] Perhaps thinking of art as conceptual in this way is to overintellectualize it. Hegel anticipates the objection that its sensual form should make art immune from philosophical consideration. He writes:

> It is still more likely to seem that even if fine art in general is a proper object of philosophical reflection, it is yet no appropriate topic for *strictly* scientific treatment. For the beauty of art presents itself to *sense*, feeling, intuition, imagination; it has a different sphere from thought, and the apprehension of its activity and its products demands an organ other than scientific thinking. (*VÄ* I 18/5)

However, Hegel sees that this does not follow. Even though art exists in a sensuous form, there would be no actual art without *thought*. In producing a work of art, for Hegel, one is "translating" something from the form of thought or Concept *into* the form of a sensuous reality:

[31] On this theme, including its relation to other aesthetic theories, see Moland 2019: ch. 1.

> In the products of art, the spirit has to do solely with its own. And even if works of art are not thought or the concept, but a development of the concept out of itself, a shift of the concept from its own ground to that of sense, still the power of the thinking spirit lies in being able not only to grasp itself in its proper form as thinking, but to know itself again just as much when it has surrendered its proper form to feeling and sense, to comprehend itself in its opposite, because it changes into thoughts what has been estranged and so reverts to itself. . . . Thus the work of art too, in which thought expresses itself, belongs to the sphere of conceptual thinking. (27–8/12–13)

A similar theme comes in relevant remarks from lectures of 1826. He writes,

> Rather, the Concept is this power of making itself into the object; and the Concept *is* even in its externalization [*Entäusserung*] and also overreaches its other. External nature is something which *is* [Seiendes] and what *is* we oppose to thinking; but the Concept is the universal, it itself is that which overreaches and also grasps the other of itself. Thus, the artwork belongs to its domain as well, is produced out of spirit and in spirit thinking is the most inner, the essential. When spirit produces, makes itself external, establishes external products, it does not become unfaithful to itself, does not abandon itself. (GW 28,2: 527)

Here, Hegel seems to suggest that the work of art is something like a paradigmatic case of the activity of the Concept: the activity of grasping an other and "making" thought into its other. Hegel also speaks of the Concept "indwelling" the reality of the artwork (*VÄ* I 156/115). The artwork begins with natural materials, with the form of sensuous matter; but as an artwork, it is wholly informed by thought. Elsewhere, Hegel describes art as an act of making a *distinction*; and this, as we have seen (see Section 3.3.2), is perhaps the primary way of discerning the activity of conceptual thought: "Only thought, understanding, can make firm distinctions, only spirit, because it is spirit, produces works [*Werke*] which are in accordance with these firm distinctions" (*EPN* § 368Z, 512/424, modified).

Hence, whereas the domain of objective *Geist* involves the realization of concepts through the actions of individuals, the domain of art involves the translation of concepts (or indeed distinctions) into a sensuous form. But this immediately raises a concern, for one could speak of *any* material artifact as the translation of a universal into a sensuous form, and we have seen that Hegel does not want to treat just any such artifact as the

realization of the Concept.[32] Hegel speaks of some objects as exhibiting mere "external" purposiveness, such as tables and chairs; these are not meant to be objects of "absolute *Geist*," higher even than the social world. Yet at first blush, works of art might seem to have more in common with these "external" artifacts than they do with the objective social world, which as we have seen *requires* conceptuality to exist in its proper *rechtlich* form. It is telling that Hegel treats art as having a more "absolute" status than objective spirit, despite the apparent similarity with ordinary material artifacts. What accounts for this?

I think the issue becomes clearer if we take Hegel to think that works of art are set apart by the comprehensiveness of the investment of meaning in them, which involves a proportional requirement for *interpretation* on the part of their appreciators.[33] I *can* encounter a painting as a mindless arrangement of chemical substances. But, in doing so, I precisely do not see it as a work of art. To see a work of art as art is to take it up as belonging within the domain of the intentional. And the intentionality of art exceeds the intentionality attributed to tables and chairs, which is explicable solely in terms of their function. By contrast, with a work of art, for every bit of "matter" we might find in it, there is always a question of *how*, and not just whether, it has been taken up into the intentional content, the meaning, of the work. Since the design of a table or chair (insofar as it is *not* a work of art) is exhausted by its functionality, questions of meaning are not in this way unlimited.

Hegel is clear about the complete saturation or permeation of artwork with its meaning in the following passage:

> If we recall what we have already established about the concept of the beautiful and of art, we found there something double: *firstly* a content, a purpose, a meaning [*Bedeutung*], *then* the expression, the appearance, and reality of this content, and, *thirdly*, both sides so permeated by each other that the outer, the particular appears exclusively as the presentation of the inner. In the art work, there is nothing there but what has essential relation to the content and expresses it. What we called the content, the meaning is the simple within it, the very thing at issue returned to its most simple if also most comprehensive determinations, in the distinctions of the execution. So, for example, the content of a book can be indicated in a few words or propositions. (*VÄ* I 132/95–6)

[32] Some interesting relevant distinctions are drawn with respect to the differing legal status of a work of art and "routine products of craft" in *GPR* §§ 68–9.

[33] On the need for interpretation in art, see Martin 2018: 841–2.

Hegel's view here seems to be that the work of art requires some guiding (even simple) intention or concept. It is due to this concept or content that *everything* in the work of art has some meaning. Hence, we can ask about the meaning or significance of everything in the work of art, not just what is required for it to serve some function. The meaning "permeates" the entire work.

None of this implies that any interpreter (or even the author) has immediate access to the "true" meaning of the work of art. But, in treating art as art, we are always trading meanings with meanings. To step outside an interest in the work's intentionality is just no longer to view the work of art as such. The sensuous element of the work of art is wholly informed by intention, and experiencing art requires, in part, "thinking again" (*Nachdenken*) what the artist has done (or is doing, in the case of performance art). As Christian Martin (2018: 840) writes, "The medium or 'material' which art depends on thus does not arise directly from nature but is rather taken from a world which spiritual activity has already knowingly [*erkennend*] articulated and shaped in action." The need for interpretation or reflection is why the philosophy of art also includes a quasi-theoretical relation to the work, in addition to the prior practical one: "For from the side of the *theoretical* relation, the *object* is taken not merely as an existing [*seiender*] singular object which thus has its subjective concept outside its objectivity . . . but rather the *beautiful* object lets its own concept as realized appear in its existence and shows in itself subjective unity and vitality [*Lebendigkeit*]" (*VÄ* I 154–5/114, modified). The experience of art is theoretical because there is always a question about how the "subjective concept" informs it. The reference to "life" (*Lebendigkeit*) in this passage is also important because it indicates a contrast with the merely external artifacts that are what they are once and for all. Works of art are "living" because their purpose is not a merely useful one that could be completed. The purpose is constantly relived in the experience and interpretation of them.[34]

This constitutive role for interpretation distinguishes works of art from mere tools. How does it distinguish the work of art from social ontology? One might think that social ontology is more purely conceptual because some of its objects (i.e., institutions) do not even find a stable, sensuous material substratum at all. But there is a clear difference between social

[34] "Now to be sure the work of art is not merely a general representation, but rather its determinate embodiment; yet as something which emerges out of *Geist* and its representational element, it must, despite its intuitive livingness, allow this character of the universal to come through" (*VÄ* I 217/164).

ontology and the ontology of artworks with regard to their conceptual basis. My knowledge of the quasi-theoretical judgment "There are laws" or even "The laws are determined by universal interests" is a knowledge that depends on my belief that other thinking subjects are doing something as well. Neither I nor any thinker can make it the case that there are laws. I can look at a written document saying what the laws are, but that document doesn't make it the case that those laws exist either. If the actors in my society ceased to act lawfully en masse, the statement that there are laws would gradually cease to be true. The domain of objective spirit has come into being only with time, history, antagonism, and cooperation; it is *sensitive* to what people have done and continue to do.[35] Indeed, though objective spirit is not a project waiting to be realized (a mere fantasy or moral ideal), it still depends on duties and obligations (see *GPR* § 148), which can appear to conflict with the individual's subjectivity (§ 149). You and I may thus, in failing to uphold our duties, fail to realize collective purposes otherwise possible for us. The claims of objective spirit (and the realization of its concepts) therefore depend, as Brandom (2019) has rightly suggested, on a "spirit of trust." This, I believe, is what makes our knowledge of them a *finite* knowledge. The individual thinker does not have fully transparent "maker's knowledge" of the social world because only *we* are its makers.[36] Conceptual truths about the domain of objective spirit depend on ongoing, cooperative practical achievements.[37]

What can be said about the work of art, on Hegel's view, is that it does not put up *this kind* of resistance to the universal which forms its basis. The given "concept" of a work of art, the thought that would, as it were, open up the work to a special kind of understanding, may be lost on me. A work of art, especially one that is discovered archeologically, might be totally

[35] In other work (Wolf 2020), I connect this to the fact that the concepts of the social world are "essentially contested."

[36] In the *Aesthetics*, Hegel says that the rationality of the state depends too completely on singular occurrences for it to be fully free. See *VÄ* I 136/99: "But this recognition and freedom concern again and again only singular relative sides and their singular objects: this house, this sum of money, this certain right, law, etc. this singular action and actuality. What consciousness has before it are certain singularities."

[37] Christian Martin (2018: 837) makes the basic difference between objective and absolute spirit clear in a similar way, relying on the image of "transparency": "The determinacy of an action [and thus objective spirit] depends thus, on the one hand on the self-relation self-determining of an actor and, on the other hand, on the intra-transparent moves of the person whose actions in the world in which he finds himself, could have unforeseen consequences." See also Gante (2021) for a fuller development of the transparency of the domain of absolute spirit vis-à-vs objective spirit (though Gante places an emphasis on freedom that I, for my purposes, do not). Objective spirit is the realm of the finite not because it is the realm of the human, but because the concept is not there fully self-determining.

opaque. But the conviction that it is art is a conviction that it has some meaning and even fully informed by that meaning. And that meaning can't be taken away from it, as it were, by a failure to cooperate on the part of its maker (not even when the maker is living).[38] Hegel presents art as a kind of mind-to-mind communication through a sensuous medium. Since this communication no longer requires fragile cooperative participation, it can involve a kind of "infinite" self-reflection in the work. It makes art a kind of "absolute" presentation of mind.[39] Art only reveals itself *as* art to the extent that a thinker recognizes it as realized thought.

My aim here has not been to give anything like a comprehensive overview of Hegel's aesthetics, or even to defend philosophically his account as I have sketched it. What I have wanted to show is simply that art is *Geist* because it is something that is insofar as it is conceptually constituted. This fact explains why art gains a more central place in Hegel's philosophy than nature. Philosophy is conceptual thinking; it follows that philosophical thinking *of* what is conceptually constituted is more paradigmatic for philosophy than the philosophical thinking of what is not conceptually constituted. Hence, art is philosophically "higher" than nature, for Hegel, as a direct consequence of his understanding of conceptuality.

7.5 Conclusion: Hegel's Philosophical Humanism

In this final chapter, I have tried to show that Hegel's understanding of the Concept and Idea leads to an inversion of philosophy in the concrete domains of the *Realphilosophie*. While all of philosophy deals with concepts and their development, Hegel accepts a categorical distinction in the way concepts are relevant to the domains of nature and *Geist* respectively. The philosophical study of nature is a conceptual grasp of something other than the conceptual, by means of a rational development of the non-empirical, theoretical concepts needed for the scientific understanding of the physical world; the philosophical study of *Geist* is not the study of an "other" in this way, for it is the study of the kind of "things at issue" that are what they are

[38] Hegel writes of the artwork: "At the same time as well, the unfree relationship of the practical subject has disappeared, since it no longer distinguishes itself in subjective aims, etc., and their material and means . . . but rather has the completely realized concept and purpose before it" (*VÄ* I 155/114).

[39] To be clear, I am not endorsing Hegel's view of art in this work. One can think of many ways in which contemporary art, in particular, has attempted to challenge this viewpoint. My interest here is only making intelligible why Hegel would see an important distinction between absolute and objective spirit.

because of the role of the Concept (specifically the universal) in making them what they are. The Concept, as the form of thought, is active in the understanding of everything, but it is not the essence or substance of everything. The shape of Hegel's philosophy, in my view, falls out of this fact. He does not present an idealism across the board but a partial one: an idealism about the domain of what is conceptually constituted. In a slogan, Hegel's idealism is a humanism.

Though "humanism" is a slippery term, the philosophical humanism that I am attributing to Hegel is one in which the human world – history, culture, politics, and art – has priority in our conception of philosophical knowledge. I have been trying to show that the human world has a role even in the *explanation* of Hegel's idealism. For it is only if there actually are concepts being realized in the world (by us, and thinkers like us) that the kind of reconciliation between thought and reality that Hegel espouses is actually effected. The categorical distinction between nature and *Geist* does not preclude, but even requires, an overlap between these domains. *Geist*, after all, seems to begin according to a transformation of given materials. There was clay before any statue, voices prior to song, and human beings prior to the state. Hence, Hegel's idealism is not a claim about the priority of consciousness or mind in the order of time (or on the level of some deep, more fundamental structure of reality). As I have argued, it is about the conceptual or philosophical priority of the domain of *Geist*. This priority is grounded on the fact that *Geist* can be understood on a positive basis, from thought's own reference to itself, whereas nature must be understood (at least initially) as the other or negation of thought's self-constitution.

This does not exclude the philosophy of nature, but it does exclude any naturalism that takes nature as a paradigm instance of what is real or "true" (in Hegel's sense) and facts about nature as philosophically exemplary for facts in general.[40] Having marginalized the mind-dependent as such, philosophical naturalists have the task of placing human *thought* within this domain of natural facts, showing it to be compatible with the domain. Naturalism as a philosophical position thus has a strange tendency to make philosophical concepts themselves problematic. Facts about morality, art, social institutions, and thought itself (i.e., Logic) can be seen to stand in need of naturalistic justification or explanation. For they are not

[40] Clearly, I cannot be dealing with everything one calls "naturalism" here. My aim in these closing remarks is to consider a common philosophical attitude more than any specific propositional thesis.

paradigmatically natural facts. They have too much of mind about them. Hegel was well aware of this common attitude. He writes,

> Turned against reason, this understanding behaves in the manner of *ordinary common sense*, giving credence to the latter's view that truth rests on sensuous reality, that thoughts are *only* thoughts, that is, that only sense perception gives filling and reality to them; that reason, in so far as it abides in and for itself, generates only mental figments. In this self-renunciation of reason, the concept of truth is lost, is restricted to the knowledge of mere subjective truth, of mere appearances, of only something to which the nature of the fact does not correspond; *knowledge* has lapsed into *opinion*. (*WL* I 38/25)

Hegel realizes that the thinker cannot coherently adopt a position according to which the very form of knowledge and thought is subject to the same demand for justification as is a typical claim about sensuous reality. The thinker is not in a position to say that thought is a mere appearance, in contrast to something else.

For Hegel, this common attitude, crystalized in philosophical naturalism, confuses the order of philosophical explanation. It is in virtue of thinking, in virtue of conceptuality, that the concept <nature>, or any other concept, has any sense for the thinker. The thinker cannot wonder whether <Concept> can be justified in terms of <nature>, for thinking <nature> depends on thinking <Concept>. The thinker cannot suspend commitment to the form of thought itself.[41] This conviction entails that it would be an error to think that the Concept requires justification in the same way a theory does. The Concept is a self-vindicating circle. And it vindicates *Geist* along with itself.

Hegel sometimes expresses his inversion of philosophy using religious language, though put to humanistic ends. He claims that the divine is no longer nature, which he says does not deserve the name "holy" (*EPG* § 441Z, 232/167). Instead, he writes: "By contrast, *Geist* is, according to its *concept* or its *truth*, infinite or eternal in this *concrete* and *real* sense, that it remains absolutely identical with itself in its distinction [*in seinem Unterschiede*]. For this reason *Geist* must be explained as the image of God, for the divinity of the human [*Göttichkeit des Menschen*]" (§ 441Z, 232–3/167, modified). Hegel's philosophy is a humanism not only because the human world is given pride of place but also because he gives to human

[41] Notice that, though this sketched argument shares something in common with a Cartesian one, its emphasis on the *form* of thought (conceptuality) frees it from the potentially egoistic confines of Descartes's (or indeed Fichte's) version.

beings the position within the domain of *Geist* that God had in the traditional view of nature.[42]

Clearly, this view requires a transformation of ourselves as well as philosophy. For we will not be satisfied with a humanistic inversion of philosophy if we think that human thought taints everything it touches. To follow Hegel, we have to abandon the view that the worthiest object of knowledge is necessarily the most distant from us – the freest from the influence of mind. If we think the reality of the mind or the state or a work of art is a meager thing, we will be unimpressed that the Concept can be their essence; this will seem trivial even if true. Hegel thinks this is a mistake. It is from mind's knowledge of itself – not *within* itself, but of its own world – that we gain a model conception of what it is to know. This is something like an ancient philosophical conviction: craft knowledge has often been taken as a model of what it means to know. But this insight is traditionally combined with a view in which nature is the paradigmatic object of philosophical thought, and so leads to a creationist metaphysic. Yet those philosophers who noticed the special mind-to-world dynamic of artifacts tended to use it as a mere *analogy* for philosophical knowledge, not as its first *instance*.[43] Hegel's metaphysics (now, Logic) is a humanism because he sees that the artifactual paradigm can be exhibited non-analogically in the human world. In this world, our concepts are constitutive of the very things we come to know. Hegel's philosophy is in large part a working out of this fact.

[42] More direct attention to Hegel's theological language than I have offered in this book is clearly a *desideratum* for future work. To put my view rather bluntly, Hegel's way of dealing with the language of God is simply to evaporate from its content anything resembling traditional theism (while retaining the tradition as a source of suggestive metaphor). What is left over, in my view, is *only* the divinity of the human and the humanly thought. This rather Promethean implication of his view is not one Hegel is eager to advertise.

[43] Consider the significant role (often analogical) that artifacts and craft play in Plato's epistemology and metaphysics, but especially in Aristotle's work in natural philosophy. See, e.g., Sellars 1967; Sedley 2010; Witt 2015.

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